

BUILDING THE BEAVER AND LAKE ERIE CANAL:
THE POLITICS OF PUBLIC IMPROVEMENTS IN PENNSYLVANIA,
1783-1845

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ABSTRACT

BUILDING THE BEAVER AND LAKE ERIE CANAL: THE POLITICS OF PUBLIC IMPROVEMENTS IN PENNSYLVANIA, 1783-1845

William D. McCarthy

Patterns of commerce and settlement in colonial America were shaped by watercourses and portages. Road building skills were primitive and boating represented the most effective means of moving bulk freight and passengers. Traders and frontiersmen leading the advance of European settlement into the Appalachian Mountains therefore adopted the shortest crossings between watersheds. Natural conditions in Pennsylvania did not promote an orderly advance westward and produced isolated clusters of settlement around Philadelphia and Pittsburgh, with small and widespread settlements in Northwest Pennsylvania. State leaders were hard pressed to define the limits of Pennsylvania until the end of the eighteenth century, and opening roads and canals was viewed as a tool for reinforcing state boundaries in subsequent years. Public policy in Pennsylvania during the early part of the nineteenth century was therefore shaped by concerns for joining these scattered populations into a commercial network under one government. This task was complicated by outside influences and sectional rivalries that reflected the fractured landscape of Pennsylvania. Promoting public improvements therefore became a matter of trading favors and making deals to promote internal improvements between the major settlement clusters in Pennsylvania. Settlements on the fringes of the state economy assumed a heightened role in government because every vote was needed to fund these major constructions. Businessmen and politicians who were trying to build a canal between Philadelphia and Pittsburgh in 1825 were forced to add hundreds of miles of branch lines as a result. Northwest Pennsylvania was rewarded with a system covering that entire part of the state and joining navigation on the Ohio River with the Great Lakes. These commitments overwhelmed any real ability to pay for them. Work sputtered on the minor canals including the French Creek Division, Beaver Division and the Erie Extension Canal in Northwest Pennsylvania. The internal improvements movement in Northwest Pennsylvania therefore illustrates the conflicts and processes of Pennsylvania state government through the first half of the nineteenth century. Canal building is featured as the single largest expenditure of tax dollars in Northwest Pennsylvania during this period.

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INTRODUCTION

Waterways served as the primary avenues of movement and trade in the United States going into the nineteenth century. Trappers and traders of the colonial period adopted native trails along major rivers and sought out portages between watersheds. Early attempts to break free of stream patterns were fraught with difficulties. Contemporary transportation capabilities rapidly broke down after leaving eastern waterways and moving into the rugged interior highlands.

Explorers and traders penetrated the eastern fringe of the Appalachian highlands on several occasions during the second half of the seventeenth century, but the area did not seem to hold much promise. Early reports observed the mountains were too broken up to get across, and no one could say how far they continued toward the interior. After helping to lead an expedition into the highlands with Thomas Batts in 1671, Robert Fallam recounted that his party reached the top of a great peak and then "saw very high Mountains lying to the north and south as far as we could discern."¹

¹ Alan Vance Briceland, Westward from Virginia (Charlottesville, VA: University Press of Virginia, 1997), 126.

Ridges comprising the central portion of the Appalachians from western New York down through Pennsylvania, Maryland and Virginia form an alternating series heights and valleys (which modern day geographers and physical scientists have designated the Ridge and Valley Physiographic Province). Crests for some of the ridges rise 3,000 feet above sea level, which places them 1,000 feet above contiguous valley bottoms. None of the summits is especially high by modern standards, but they proved nearly impenetrable in an era when land transport relied on human porters, pack trains and wagons.² Explorers and traders were awed by the heights, but soon found the greatest hazard was in the multitude of ridge lines.³

Boating remained the most economical means of shifting goods and populations around the eastern half of North America while traders and settlers clawed their way across the mountains.⁴ Road building

² Raymond E. and Marion Murphy, Pennsylvania, A Regional Geography (State College, PA: Penns Valley Publishers, 1937), 11-40; Sylvester K. Stevens, Pennsylvania (New York, NY: Random House, 1964), 8-10; Solon J. and Elizabeth Hawthorne Buck, The Planting of Civilization in Western Pennsylvania (Pittsburgh, PA: University of Pittsburgh Press, 1939), 1-6.

³ Briceland, Westward from Virginia, 126.

⁴ U.B. Phillips noted that in South Carolina through 1818, "two-thirds of the market crops were raised within five miles of some river, and the remainder not more than ten miles from water which could be rendered navigable." Ulrich B. Phillips, A History of Transportation in the Eastern Cotton Belt (New York, NY: Columbia University Press, 1908), 58.

skills in the United States remained primitive through the colonial period into the years of the early republic, and separate economies grew up on either side of the Appalachians. Boating remained the most efficient way of moving people and goods, and merchants started to think about building canals to join waters across the ridgelines.

Building canals in this era relied on technology seen in Europe since the middle of the seventeenth century. Americans were aware of these developments, but they lacked the capital and political stability to try and reproduce the European model until the end of the eighteenth century. Canal building was initiated in the United States at this time through widely scattered projects in parts of New York, Connecticut, Maryland, Virginia, Pennsylvania, and South Carolina. None of these canals was more than a few miles long and all of them suffered from difficulties in funding and actual construction.⁵

A more successful era of building canals was inaugurated when construction started on the Erie Canal of New York in 1817.

New York boasts a natural route through the Appalachians in the Mohawk branch of the Hudson River. This is the single largest

⁵ Frederick A. Cleveland and Fred Wilbur Powell, Railroad Promotion and Capitalization in the United States, (New York: 1909), 39-45,

break in the mountains between New England and northern Alabama. Traders and settlers had used this route for decades, and one of the failed experiments in canal building was geared toward this passage. Businessmen and tax payers in New York were finally in a position to fund major improvements during the first quarter of the nineteenth century. Work on the Erie Canal quickly revived flagging interests in canals on the Potomac River, which itself leads into one of the shortest portages between eastern waters and the upper watershed of the Ohio River.

Pennsylvania was in a difficult position sitting between these competitive projects and boasting a landscape that was peculiarly unsuited for building canals. Because of its geologic underpinnings, the land surface of Pennsylvania is broken and cut up by streams falling into five separate drainage patterns. There is no single passage through the mountains to rival the Hudson-Mohawk route in New York or the Potomac River south of the Mason-Dixon Line; each of the three chief rivers of Pennsylvania (Ohio River, Susquehanna River and the Delaware River) are situated at odds with the patterns of western trade. These rivers and their major tributaries are shallow and broken by bars, ripples, boulders and other obstructions in a natural state. At the same time, many of the state waterways pass through steep walled valleys and are

subjected to intense flooding. Contemporary observers voiced grave doubts that Pennsylvania could ever build a major canal given these conditions.⁶

The simplest and most cost efficient means of building canals called for placing dams in existing stream channels and simply trapping running water in a pool. Locks were installed in the dams to permit navigation between the pools. An artificial channel was more costly and used to bridge gaps between stream beds or carry navigation in search of the natural resources and trade of poorly watered areas. Engineers and surveyors located several possible routes for canals in Pennsylvania, but there was no direct line between opposite ends of the state. Early strategies for opening a canal included numerous twists and shifts that added length and raised costs. Plans for a canal were hampered even further by a rampant sectionalism that characterized state politics.

Pennsylvania entered the nineteenth century as a loose collection of sectional interests. Distinct bunches of counties with shared interests and concerns were observed in Southeast Pennsylvania, Southwest Pennsylvania, Northwest Pennsylvania, and poorly settled districts of the central mountains and the upper

⁶ Murphy, Pennsylvania, A Regional Geography, 41-46; Stevens, Pennsylvania, 10-13.

Susquehanna River watershed. Public policies were shaped by the politicians and merchants from the commercial centers of Pittsburgh and Philadelphia in the lower tier of counties and opposite ends of the state. These rival clusters had developed independently, and their different backgrounds and geographic separation created intense rivalries. Western Pennsylvanians looked to Baltimore as their natural outlet, while Philadelphia demanded their political and financial allegiance; scattered settlements in the upper Ohio system and the northern borderlands shifted their loyalties between all of these larger centers, and even New York. Hopes of building a canal in Pennsylvania to rival the Erie Canal or the Potomac River works were therefore faced with considerable natural and man-made obstacles.

In response, Pennsylvania politicians debated the merits of improved highways and the new technology of railroads in place of canals. Either might have proven more effective for state interests, but the euphoria generated by the Erie Canal in New York clouded serious discussions. Merchants from Philadelphia and Pittsburgh dominated the state legislature and they demanded an imitative work in order to stay competitive. They offered extensions to settlements in all parts of Pennsylvania in order to win broad tax payer support for taking on the massive costs of

construction.

This strategy proved successful and construction started in 1826 on a main stem known as the Pennsylvania Main Line Canal, which spanned a gap almost 400 miles wide between Philadelphia and Pittsburgh.⁷ In following years the state canal network grew to include more 1200 miles of additional canals and slackwater pools. Nearly every mile that was added to this system seemed to incite controversy over expenses and a revival of sectional rivalries. Construction was sometimes pushed ahead of planning to quiet the uproar and maintain voter support. Difficulties in building the Main Line Canal produced a hybrid system of railroads and canals, which suggested to some observers that state authorities had not fully considered all of their options.

Perhaps no part of the state reflects how these issues played out better than Northwest Pennsylvania. This section of Pennsylvania included all of the lands lying north of the Ohio River to Lake Erie, and sandwiched between the Allegheny River and the state boundary with Ohio. Northwest Pennsylvania had not drawn much attention from state leaders in Philadelphia and Pittsburgh during the first quarter of the nineteenth century, but it gained

⁷ This figure includes the various bends and variations in the line through the separate divisions of canals and railroads.

new importance for public figures who were trying to raise support and tax dollars for building canals. Between 1825 and 1838, state leaders authorized work on one hundred and eighty four miles of canals and slackwaters within these geographic boundaries.

A main stem of one hundred and thirty six miles was opened between the mouth of the Beaver River some twenty-five miles below Pittsburgh on the Ohio River, and Lake Erie at the port of Erie. Following this path carried the canal through the western ends of Beaver County, Lawrence County, Mercer County, Crawford County and Erie County. A feeder canal twenty-five miles in length branched off the main stem into central Crawford County at Meadville, and a subsidiary extension called the Franklin Line passed twenty-two miles down French Creek to the Allegheny River port of Franklin in Venango County. This represented nearly one fifth of the canals built with public money in Pennsylvania, but they did not draw much favorable notice outside of the immediate area.

Other parts of Pennsylvania came to regard the local program as a drain on increasingly scarce funds. Some tax payers did not consider these canals as anything but a local improvement, since they were never joined directly with the Pennsylvania Main Line Canal and its contiguous branches. Canal building in Northwest Pennsylvania suffered recurring interruptions while state leaders

tried to work out these criticisms and recurring difficulties in providing funds for the work. State leaders ultimately abandoned the canal program in Northwest Pennsylvania, and some parts of the local system were only opened to navigation by private contractors.

This checkered history of construction has cluttered contemporary records and more recent writings on the canals with a bewildering index of labels to identify the canal and its components; parts of this local system have been identified as the Beaver and Lake Erie Canal, the Pennsylvania and Lake Erie Canal, the Shenango and Erie Canal, the Pittsburgh and Lake Erie Canal, the Beaver Canal, the French Creek Canal, the Franklin Canal, and the Pennsylvania Erie Canal. Alvin Harlow lost track of the actual record in this mix when he tried to compile a history of American canals in the early twentieth century; Harlow mistakenly wrote that the northern half of the canal "was sold to a corporation, which never succeeded in doing anything with them."⁸ Because of this confusion the canals in Northwest Pennsylvania have not drawn much attention from historians.

Early writings on the Pennsylvania canals were descriptive pieces penned by travellers and men who had worked on the canals.

⁸ Alvin F. Harlow, Old Towpaths (New York, NY: D. Appleton and Co., 1925), 134

Most space was devoted to the attractions on the Pennsylvania Main Line Canal between Philadelphia and Pittsburgh. During the industrial era of the later nineteenth century, images of the canals were picked up by romantics and antiquarians as symbols of a simpler and more egalitarian era. Some of the canals in eastern Pennsylvania remained in use into the early twentieth century and the attention generated over canals was drawn in that direction. Components of the state works in Western Pennsylvania had been dismantled by this time and largely forgotten.⁹

After passing out of public memory for sixty years, Lloyd Corkan rediscovered the canals in Northwest Pennsylvania as material for a master's thesis in 1927.¹⁰ Corkan recounted the chronology of building the Beaver and Lake Erie Canal and the costs. Nearly everything written on the Beaver and Lake Erie Canal since that time is derived from this single source, including promotional tourist guides and publications by canal enthusiasts. Corkan's history has also figured into standard works on the state system including William H. Shank's The Amazing Pennsylvania Canals and

⁹ See Philip Holbrooke Nicklin, Pleasant peregrination through the prettier parts of Pennsylvania (York, PA: American Canal and Transportation Center, 1975); Leland D. Baldwin, "Charles Dickens in Pennsylvania," WPHM XIX (1936), 27-46.

¹⁰ Lloyd A.M. Corkan, The Beaver and Lake Erie Canal, (University of Pittsburgh, M.A. thesis: 1927).

The Pennsylvania Main Line Canal by McCullough and Leuba.¹¹ Just a few articles on the Beaver and Lake Erie Canal have appeared in scholarly journals.

These works invariably concentrate on details of construction and boating on the canal. An attempt to expand this view and place the building chronology of the Beaver and Lake Erie Canal into a regional context raises issues about why the canal took so long to finish, and how promoters maintained enthusiasm for the project through repeated delays and disappointments. In answering these queries the nature of the politics and economics of transportation in antebellum Pennsylvania can be more fully comprehended.

That the length of time required to complete the canals in Northwest Pennsylvania had few rivals becomes clear in comparison with other projects. Opening the Pennsylvania Main Line Canal (over a distance of almost 400 miles with its mix of waterways and railroads) took eight years and included work through difficult terrain and high rises in the mountains of Central Pennsylvania. This contrasts sharply to the Beaver and Lake Erie Canal, which took twice as long to cover less than half the distance, while

¹¹ William H. Shank, The Amazing Pennsylvania Canals (York, PA: American Canal & Transportation Center, 1960); Robert McCullough and Walter Leuba, The Pennsylvania Main Line Canal ((York, PA: American Canal & Transportation Center, 1973).

passing through a countryside better suited for building canals. Not many other canals took so long in construction, and most projects that dragged out like this were abandoned before boats ever passed the full length. Cutting a tunnel for the Chesapeake and Ohio at Paw Paw, (West) Virginia required eighteen years but the situations are not fully comparable. Workmen there had to blast and chisel a passage nearly a mile in length through solid rock, although they did suffer from the kinds of financial obstacles seen on the Beaver and Lake Erie line.¹² The most extreme record belongs with the Union Canal in southeastern Pennsylvania, where the work was dragged out by private firms from 1792 through 1828.¹³ But even this record contrasts favorably with how state leaders handled the Beaver and Lake Erie Canal, since the Union Canal was finished in seven years once tax dollars were applied to

¹² Elizabeth Kytle, Home on the Canal (Cabin John, MD: Seven Locks Press, 1983), 53-58. The Tunnel at Paw Paw measured 3,118 feet long when it was completed, and it required a deep cutting 890 feet long and up to 70 feet deep at the northern end to link up with the canal. Pennsylvania actually opened the first tunnel in the United States in 1821 on the Schuylkill Canal. Laborers started cutting the tunnel through a bed red shale in 1818, and when the tunnel was finished three years later it measured 20 feet high, 18 feet wide and about 450 feet long. See Archibald Black, The Story of Tunnels (New York, NY: McGraw-Hill, 1937), 18-19.

¹³ Shank, The Amazing Pennsylvania Canals, 9-12; McCullough and Leuba, Pennsylvania Main Line Canal, 11.

it.

The singular record of the Beaver and Lake Erie Canal has to be explained through other causes than difficulties in terrain or periodic reductions in public funding. Published accounts of the canals tend to pass over any assessment of how public support for the canals was maintained through the difficult years of waiting. There is an unwritten assumption that merchants and farmers anxiously waited while the different segments of the Beaver and Lake Erie system crept toward a union of their waters, but looking at contemporary records reveals a great deal of turmoil.

Northwest Pennsylvania was reduced to a minor role in state politics from an early date, and local tax payers depended on the largesse of the chief commercial centers for public improvements and other benefits from their tax dollars. Economists speak of dependency where the economy of a peripheral region is conditioned by a dominant, outside market. While this does not necessarily prevent development or cause poverty, it curbs independent development by local inhabitants.¹⁴ The politics of economic development in Northwest Pennsylvania therefore blends with classic Appalachian counties through intricate contests between locals and

¹⁴ Paul Salstrom, Appalachia's Path to Dependency: Rethinking a Region's Economic History, 1730-1940 (Lexington, KY: University of Kentucky Press, 1994), xiii-xxxvi.

outside interests.

This pattern was shaped by speculators before the end of the eighteenth century. Promoting canals as public policy only deepened this pattern of conflict, and pitted local communities against one another and larger interests in Philadelphia and Pittsburgh at the same time. Contemporary news reports show how workings at both levels played out in Northwest Pennsylvania. Distinct figures emerge in the high offices of the state government among the delegates serving the bankers and merchants of the large cities. Contending goals were promoted through newspapers and business partners in local communities, leading to anonymous rallies and mob actions.

It seems inconceivable that the public leaders of Pennsylvania would have permitted this situation, and even encouraged it given the increasingly competitive relations with neighboring states. Merchants in New York, Virginia and Maryland talked of opening direct access between eastern ports and the Great Lakes from the middle of the eighteenth century. However, during this same period Pennsylvania looked to secure state boundaries and blunt commercial rivals instead of opening new markets; Philadelphia tried to stem commercial growth in Baltimore, while Pittsburgh carefully watched towns sprouting along the banks of the Ohio River and devised ways

to suppress their growth. Sectionalism in Pennsylvania prevented state leaders from developing a broad outlook.

Interpreting these issues requires treating the canal as part of a region emerging under the influences of state and national political and economic forces. In no way can it be comprehended if viewed as an isolated event or as a purely technical achievement. Although the actual construction of a canal was confined to narrow banks of river and streams or to a fenced path about sixty feet wide cutting through the countryside, canal building was guided by widespread influences in state and local affairs. Studies of the Erie Canal suggest a similar story. In the preface to Erie Water West, Ronald E. Shaw observes that a history of canal building "brings together such varied aspects as its political sponsorship and opposition, construction and operation, travel and commerce, and its social and cultural significance."¹⁵ Carol Sheriff reiterated this theme in the Artificial River by characterizing the Erie Canal as just one part of "the era's ever-growing web of commercial and social networks."¹⁶

The story of building canals Northwest Pennsylvania is revealing

¹⁵ Ronald E. Shaw, Erie Water West (Lexington, KY: University of Kentucky Press, 1966), vii.

¹⁶ Carol Sheriff, The Artificial River, (New York, NY: Hill and Wang, 1997), 6.

in that it leads to none of the bluntly positive achievements of the Erie Canal, even as it was able to command significant resources over a number of years during which it became ever clearer that the possibility of a profitable outcome was fading. Instead of leading a triumphant advance of eastern commerce, the Beaver and Lake Erie Canal and its branches resulted in miles of abandoned cuts filled with polluted waters. The story of this canal, then, furnishes a fuller and more accurate picture of the political culture in Pennsylvania during the early nineteenth century.

Chapter 1:

SQUATTERS AND SPECULATORS, - 1805

Canal building in Northwest Pennsylvania was rooted in the competition between states for trade and new sources of wealth dating to the colonial period and the late eighteenth century. Armed conflicts and political controversies that marked this period helped delineate boundaries for Northwest Pennsylvania, but at the same time these forces left the area outside of the emerging streams of commerce and trade animating the early republican period.

Transportation capabilities in colonial America rapidly broke down as settlers approached the mountains, producing a fragmented and irregular advance toward the interior lands of North America. Early experiences in trying to penetrate the Appalachian highlands forced emigrants to seek out occasional gaps and passes. Much of this activity was concentrated in the Virginia backcountry leading toward Kentucky and Tennessee before settlers began drifting into Western Pennsylvania seeking an easier route to the lands beyond the Ohio River.

This northward inclination brought the colonists into armed conflict with Frenchmen drifting down from Canada as France and

England both claimed all lands lying on the Ohio River and its tributaries. Both sides found it difficult to supply their forces in this area, and the contest was decided by British advantages in manpower and their superior logistics operations. The British authorities then gave the area lying north of the Ohio River back to the Indians in 1768, as a conciliatory gesture for taking lands in Kentucky. Colonists from Virginia, Pennsylvania, Connecticut and New York subsequently claimed this territory for themselves in violation of the British agreement, and each group tried to establish ownership during most of the following two decades.

Leaders of the Pennsylvania state government finally gained the upper hand at the end of the Revolution, but they proved incapable of exercising control over the lands. Attempts to encourage settlement were marked failures. The entire region was then turned over to speculators after 1791 in hopes they could do a better job of promoting settlement (while relieving the state of the burden and providing some badly needed cash). This created a shadow government that enforced land rules and public laws in favor of monied interests.

Settlers accordingly passed by Northwest Pennsylvania, searching out better deals for federal properties in the Old Northwest and on into the Mississippi Valley. Emigrants heading into Northwest

Pennsylvania were largely those without means to travel on, and forced to accept oppressive terms from the land companies. This resulted in the kind of stunted economic development that has characterized the Appalachian highlands into modern times.

The invention of Northwest Pennsylvania

Before the creation of modern state boundaries, Northwest Pennsylvania was part of an anomalous region called the Ohio Country. This larger region included lands resting on the Ohio River and its major tributaries. Boundaries of the Ohio Country were also subject to change over time, but at one time or another the area included lands on the Allegheny River, the Monongahela River and its Youghiogheny feeder, the Kanawha River, the Cumberland, and the Wabash.

European fur trappers and traders entered the region by the second quarter of the eighteenth century in search of new sources of wealth and native trading partners. Frenchmen based in Canada and the more western Illinois Country collided with Anglo-Americans out of Pennsylvania, Maryland and Virginia. Competition between the two sides escalated into violent outbursts, which was legitimized by sporadic warfare between the home governments in Europe.

French authorities in Canada decided to try and end the conflict in the middle of the eighteenth century when their alliances and trade networks on the upper Ohio River exhibited signs of collapse. They planned a sudden strike with overwhelming force that would drive the English back and force them to recognize French rights to the area and its native populations. A mixed force of French regulars, Canadian militia and native allies set out from Montreal in the spring of 1753 and set up a base at Presque Isle (Erie, Pennsylvania) on the southern shore of Lake Erie.¹⁷

Hired laborers and soldiers detailed for fatigue work opened a portage from the lake shore to the head of navigation on French Creek at Lebouef (Waterford, Pennsylvania) by the end of the summer. An advance detachment pushed further downstream to Venango (Franklin, Pennsylvania), where French Creek joins the Alleghany River, but the campaign sputtered to a halt.

Early plans called for building a string of forts from Lake Erie down through the Ohio Valley to the French settlements in the

¹⁷ For the details of this campaign see Donald H. Kent, The French Invasion of Western Pennsylvania, 1753 (Harrisburg, PA: Pennsylvania Historical and Museum Commission, 1954). This was not the only route under consideration, and some effort was placed where the port of Barcelona was founded in western New York; see H.C. Taylor, The Old Portage Road (Fredonia, NY: The Fredonia Censor, 1891).

Illinois Country, but French Canada could not sustain this effort. Because settlers had not moved in ahead of them, the French had to carry everything the expedition required with them. An attempt to revive the campaign the following year only got to the Forks of the Ohio (Pittsburgh, Pennsylvania) where the Allegheny River and the Monongahela River merge to form the Ohio. A band of British traders who had started work on a fort at that location were chased back across the mountains.

In spite of these early successes, the French occupation of the Allegheny River only lasted until 1758. The French lacked the resources and manpower to stem English retaliation, and the fighting quickly spread beyond the Ohio Valley and grew into the larger conflict known as the French and Indian War. The French did not have the resources and manpower to support isolated forts in the Ohio Country and defend Canada at the same time. The garrisons were eventually withdrawn to deal with military situations on other fronts, and each of the forts was burned and abandoned.

French engineers were quite skilled in locating critical locations for maintaining communication and moving goods through the Ohio watershed, and British military planners soon installed their own garrisons near the ruined French works. Small bodies of troops were kept at each fort through 1763 in the unlikely event

the French ever came back; however, French politicians ultimately sacrificed their holdings in North America in order to protect more valued interests overseas. Native tribesmen who had fought with the French were left to make deals for themselves.

Certain British administrators adopted a heavy handed manner in dealing with the natives and failed to stem intrusions on their lands by Anglo-American settlers. These grievances sparked a new round of fighting that is commonly known as Pontiac's War or Pontiac's Uprising. The British finished work on Fort Pitt at the Forks of the Ohio just in time to weather this storm; native warriors could not overrun this massive stone and brick fortress, but the smaller blockhouses and stockades on French Creek and Lake Erie were stormed and burned. British military and political planners did not see any further use for them and none was rebuilt.

Representatives of the British home government and the colonies did not see much use for this entire area in their plans, and it was therefore given back to the aboriginal owners.¹⁸ Anglo-American explorers and traders had discovered paths leading to the rich farmlands of Kentucky and there was no reason to suppose the

¹⁸ See Colonel William Eyre to General Robert Napier, New York, 12 April, 1764; in Stanley Pargellis, Military Affairs in North America, 1748-1765 (New York, NY: Archon Books, 1969), 461-471. This includes a "Memorial Concerning the Back Forts in North America" by Captain Harry Gordon of the Royal Engineers.

hilly woodlands of the upper Ohio could ever prove more useful. Both sides agreed to recognize the Ohio River as a visible demarcation between advancing frontier of European settlement and the native domains. This arrangement was confirmed through the Treaty of Fort Stanwix in 1768.

Establishing a definitive boundary for Pennsylvania in the trans-Appalachian wilderness was complicated because of this treaty and multiple conflicts involving squatters and neighboring states. At times up through the American Revolution it seemed Virginia might gain control over all of the lands resting on the Monongahela River up to the Ohio River, while Connecticut and New York chipped away at Pennsylvania claims in the upper Susquehanna drainage. Pennsylvania finally secured a boundary that included all of these areas, but only after suffering through years of hard negotiations that were interspersed with occasional court challenges and gunfights in the disputed areas.

Tensions between factions from Virginia and Pennsylvania mounted until a state of civil war existed. Mobs on either side of the issue harassed settlers of the rival government for taxes and votes, while civil officers were arrested and imprisoned. Champions of the Pennsylvania state government were chased out of Pittsburgh and forced to relocate thirty miles away at Hannastown.

Pennsylvania's inability to control this conflict was compounded by a similar crisis in the upper reaches of the Susquehanna watershed. Yankee speculators claimed the charter privileges of Connecticut skipped across New York and they organized a company to promote settlement in 1753. Fighting with the French set their plans back a few years, but almost four thousand inhabitants were registered with Connecticut authorities in 1768. Colonists loyal to the government in Philadelphia tried to dislodge the intruders in a series of skirmishes dubbed the Yankee-Pennamite wars, but they could not make any headway.

The start of the American Revolution forced the rival parties into an uneasy truce in both of the contested areas. Virginia finally ended the dispute in Southwest Pennsylvania in 1779 to try and promote cooperation in the war effort. Under the terms of this agreement, the old line drawn between Pennsylvania and Maryland by Mason and Dixon was extended westward five degree of longitude from the Delaware River, and then due north to Lake Erie. Pennsylvania authorities grudgingly accepted land certificates issued by Virginia as part of the accord to get things moving along, although just when the line might be surveyed was anybody's guess. Pennsylvania was heavily engaged in rounding up men and supplies for the war effort, and there were troubles in the Susquehanna that

still had to be dealt with. Settlers from Connecticut refused to make any kind of accord short of their independence from Philadelphia. This matter was finally turned over to the Continental Congress for consideration in 1782. A committee of five delegates sat through forty-one days of testimony and then ruled in favor of Pennsylvania.

Getting these concessions from their rivals on paper did not diminish the sense of urgency in Pennsylvania to establish physical possession. After winning recognition of their land rights, state leaders did not want to see interlopers come in and start arguments over boundaries and land rights again. Surveyors were therefore ordered into the woods as quickly as practical to define the extent of the state's jurisdiction.

A joint commission from Pennsylvania and Virginia started a boundary line from the southwest corner of Pennsylvania to the Ohio River on June 6, 1785. Andrew Ellicott, David Rittenhouse and Andrew Porter formed the Pennsylvania delegation. Their records speak of one difficulty after another from poor weather, biting horse flies, mosquitoes and gnats "numerous beyond conception," and difficult terrain. Moving northward, Ellicott wondered how this area "could ever be an object of contention" given the broken pattern of "very High Hills, narrow at the Top, and only separated

by narrow crevices, or Chinks." Everyone present doubted that this kind of landscape could ever be turned to productive farming.¹⁹

After suffering a mutiny of hired laborers, several injuries and at least one death, the surveyors reached the Ohio River on August 20, 1785. The commissioners from both states drew up an agreement on the banks of the Ohio River and signed it two days later, forever ceding all Virginia claims on the northern and eastern sides of the line. While the Virginians packed up their camp gear and started for home over the following days, the Pennsylvania delegates and their hired hands crossed the Ohio River and continued northward. Every additional mile they passed above the Ohio River was marked by an upright stone inscribed with a "P" on its eastern face; the opposite side was left blank since no one knew what that state might be called. The surveyors had just set the "100 Mile Stone" in place south of "Shenangoe Creek" when changes in the weather forced them to quit for the year.²⁰

Work on marking the western boundary of Pennsylvania resumed at this point on June 19, 1786 under Colonel Porter and Alexander McClean. Entries in McClean's diary show the expedition starting

¹⁹ William A. Russ, Pennsylvania Boundaries: How Pennsylvania Acquired its Present Boundaries (University Park, PA: Pennsylvania Historical Association, 1966), 39.

²⁰ Ibid, 42.

off with the same problems of the previous year, and their miseries increased around the 126th mile stone when the party started wading and slogging through the "infernal bogs" of the great Pymatuning Swamp. On September 14, 1786 McClean reported reaching the shores of Lake Erie at a distance of 155 miles and 266 perches. The surrounding area finally gave hints of promise with "a fertile land" on the bluff overlooking the beach, "well situate for farming and Meadow and [it] doubtless affords every Necessity to Render life agreeable."²¹ After this western boundary was marked on state maps, Andrew Ellicott and David Rittenhouse resumed the unfinished northern boundary of Pennsylvania touching New York.

This division had already been started on the Delaware River and carried west toward the Appalachian wilderness before the Revolution. Ellicott and Porter joined representatives from New York and began carrying the line westward toward the Great Lakes on June 1, 1786. They had mapped ninety additional miles to "the Western side of the South Branch of the Tyoga River and marked the same with substantial milestones" when they decided to quit for the year on October 12, 1786. Ellicott returned with Colonel Porter the following year and carried the line from the ninetieth milestone to Lake Erie, establishing a firm geographic definition

²¹ Russ, Pennsylvania Boundaries, 44.

of Pennsylvania. With maps of the state boundaries in hand, the focus for state government shifted toward peopling the new territories.

Everyone had expected that Pennsylvania would acquire additional western lands after the Revolution and preliminary plans were already made for dealing with this situation. In order to spur sagging enthusiasm for the Revolutionary armies back in 1780, state authorities had traded land bounties or "Donation Lands" for enlistments. Veterans were offered additional "Depreciation Lands" in exchange for nearly worthless pay certificates issued by the Continental Congress. State leaders set aside all tracts lying north of the Ohio River and west of the Allegheny to pay these debts and other expenses related to the American Revolution. However, early hopes for making good on the war debt were abruptly curbed when state legislators realized the standing boundary agreements were not mapped.²²

A bill restricting the sale or disposal of public lands in Western Pennsylvania was accordingly voted into law on April 1, 1784. Only limited sales or awards could be made under the terms of this act until definite boundaries were put in place with

²² John E. Winner, "The Donation and Depreciation Lands," WPHM 8(1), 1-3.

neighboring states. Settlers and land jobbers desiring large quantities right away were directed toward the lands purchased at Fort Stanwix in 1768.

Several months passed while surveyors mapped the new lands and during that time small farmers and speculators proposed several amendments. Lawmakers spent additional weeks trying to strike a balance between these interests. A draft that was adopted on March 24, 1785 finally provided for "the mode of distributing the Donation Lands promised to the troops of this Commonwealth" during the Revolution.

Under the terms of this act, ten horizontal bands were drawn and sequentially numbered from the Ohio River northward. General William Irvine was appointed as the state surveyor-general, and instructed to place an assistant over each district to speed up the work. Surveyors operating in each of the ten districts were ordered to submit written reports of their activities no later than February 1, 1786. The comptroller-general of Pennsylvania was directed at the same time to draw up lists of those veterans eligible for land grants and the corresponding amounts. Awards were based on military rank, ranging from two hundred acres for privates and musicians and growing to two thousand acres for a major general. Lands earmarked for this purpose were located in

the modern boundaries of Lawrence County, Mercer County, the western half of Crawford County, and northern half of Butler County.²³

Careful directions for making the awards were drawn up in hopes of reducing fraud or mismanagement. Guidelines for this procedure specified that tickets representing each 400 acre tract should be placed in a lottery wheel at Philadelphia once the surveyors submitted their reports. Soldiers or their appointed delegates were entitled to draw lots equal to their military rank. State authorities scheduled public drawings from October 1, 1786, through August 31, 1787, but were forced to make periodic extensions for more than a decade. Nearly three thousand veterans or their dependents were awarded lands in the first round of drawings, but relatively few proved willing or able to relocate. Some of the landowners lacked the means or desire to move into northwestern Pennsylvania, and others were not happy about their awards. Using a lottery to dispense titles meant that large grants were broken up

²³ Winner, "The Depreciation and Donation Lands," WPHM 8(1), 5; Stokeley, "Remarks and General Observations on Mercer County, Pennsylvania," in Memoirs of the Historical Society of Pennsylvania, volume IV/part II:: 66-67. Stokeley was named as the deputy surveyor in the 2nd and 3rd districts in 1785, and then held the same position for the 4th and 5th districts in 1792.

over several unrelated tracts.²⁴

Another cause of dissension grew out of a simple fact that some of these grants were made with incomplete or inaccurate information. Surveyors who had been hired to draw definite state boundaries around Pennsylvania were still working their way through the western forests when the initial lots were drawn by veterans in Philadelphia. Certain parts of the Donation and Depreciation tracts were later found to cross these boundaries.²⁵ In other cases state leaders handed out tracts under the mistaken notion that all of the land was of equal value. Some exceptionally bad tracts had already been culled from the lottery, but in other cases the poor quality of the land was not discovered until after an award was made.²⁶

State leaders certainly should have been aware of this situation

²⁴ Tribune Republican, Meadville: 0-13. Alex Moultrip, for instance, was awarded tracts lying several miles east of Meadville for his services in the Revolution. Moultrip took up residence and built a cabin in 1792, but soon departed and gave up all claims on the area. His lands came under ownership of the Holland Land Company and were then sold. A settlement grew up that was initially called Moultrip, before giving way to French Colony and finally Frenchtown. Along the way this settlement lost all of its early connections with the American Revolution and the first landowner.

²⁵ Winner, "The Donation and Depreciation Lands," WPHM 8(1), 7.

²⁶ Day, Historical Collections, 259.

beforehand, since General Irvine observed distinct variations in topography and local conditions across Northwest Pennsylvania in his official report as surveyor-general. Irvine found that lands lying westward of an old Indian trail between Fort Pitt and Venango (around the head of the Beaver River and the Shenango) were "pretty level, well watered with small springs, and of tolerable quality." On the other side of the trail "east to the Allegheny River, which is about 25 miles, there are no lands fit for cultivation, as far as French Creek." Irvine explicitly warned state leaders that "Several of the districts has not 20 lots of good land in them, yet [my] deputies are each instructed to survey upwards of 260."²⁷

Discontent with the grants and the lure of free lands further westward pulled settlers away from Northwest Pennsylvania. With the announcement of a preliminary peace ending the war of the Revolution in 1782, squatters had swarmed across the Ohio River by the thousands and opened a land rush into the Northwest Territory that seemed to have no limits. When federal soldiers entered any given area to establish civil order and regulate settlement, the

²⁷ General William Irvine to John Dickson, August 17, 1785; in Pennsylvania Archives, Series Three, Volume III: 582-583. Another view of the landscape can be found in the writings of John Heckewelder, who travelled the area extensively as a missionary to the native populations. See Paul A. Wallace, Thirty Thousand Miles with John Heckewelder (Pittsburgh, PA: University of Pittsburgh Press, 1958).

squatters simply moved downstream and westward out of their reach. The soldiers burned a few cabins and ordered the residents away, but most of the squatters returned almost immediately and started to rebuild. In the spring of 1785, Colonel Josiah Harmer wrote his superiors about thousands of "banditti whose actions are a disgrace to human nature" on public lands.²⁸ Federal authorities were advised these malcontents had elected their own governor, while claiming "an undoubted right to pass into every vacant country, and there to form their constitution."²⁹ Higher federal authorities were finally forced into action before their hold over the western territories dissolved. On July 13, 1787 Congress adopted the "Ordinance of 1787" or "Northwest Ordinance" to regulate land sales and create civil rule in the western lands.

In Philadelphia, this action raised concerns that squatters who were pushed out of the Northwest Territory might backpedal into the unsettled parts of Pennsylvania. Congress therefore directed

²⁸ Billington, Westward Expansion, 210; Wade, Urban Frontier, 25. Wade notes that the early history of Cincinnati is one of conflict between settlers and the garrison of Fort Washington; William Henry Harrison visited the place as an army ensign in 1791 and "saw more drunken men in forty-eight hours succeeding my arrival at Cincinnati than I had in all my previous life," while another visitor believed it "the most debauched place I ever saw."

²⁹ Billington, Westward Expansion, 210.

military authorities to secure all of the most likely paths for movement between the Great Lakes and the Ohio River. Captain Jonathan Heart was ordered to "proceed with his company" from Fort Harmar on April 10, 1787, "to a place called Venango on the Allegheny river, about one hundred and fifty miles above Pittsburgh, [and] there to erect a suitable work."³⁰ A stockaded blockhouse that was generously characterized as Fort Franklin was then erected near the fading ruins of the old French and English works. Some semblance of a town was provided by the handful of warehouses and sheds erected on the river landing by Indian traders and army contractors.³¹ Few legitimate settlers bothered to visit since federal land sales only commenced at the western edge of Pennsylvania, although there was little doubt that Pennsylvania would eventually have to open general sales to draw settlers.

Pennsylvania state leaders ultimately admitted that granting titles to the Donation and Depreciation Lands had done little to

³⁰ Bell, History of Venango County, 61.

³¹ Rev. Charles Elliott, Life of the Rev. Robert R. Roberts (Cincinnati, OH: J.F. Wright and L. Swormstead, 1844), 37. Roberts and his companions spent a Sunday at Fort Franklin in 1796 and observed the rough character of the settlement. According to Roberts in later years, "there was not much sign of the Sabbath" and an "inconsistency among the professors of religion." A woman purchased a large turkey from an Indian and then scolded him for shooting game on the Holy Day.

promote settlement or secure the rights of veterans and small farmers. Only officers were permitted to sell their grants in advance of the actual drawings, but nothing was said about secondary sales. Enlisted men therefore drew lots, assumed the titles and then sold them to speculators at ridiculously low prices.³² That cluster of sheds growing around Fort Franklin in the summer of 1787 represented the extent of American colonization in Northwest Pennsylvania.

Finishing the border with New York later in the year revealed that over seven million acres had been added to Pennsylvania since the end of the Revolution. Not even the most optimistic politicians had expected this sort of windfall and many began to question limits on public sales. Some 616,500 acres were eventually mapped to satisfy military debts from the Revolution, but this still left the bulk of the new territory unassigned. Politicians from Western Pennsylvania anticipated an outbreak of uncontrolled speculation and they feared disastrous consequences for small farmers. They counselled the administration that before opening any lands for public sale Pennsylvania should settle its remaining debts from the Revolution and prior land controversies.

Warrants issued by Virginia around the Forks of the Ohio were

³² Buck and Buck, Planting of Civilization, 206.

guaranteed by Pennsylvania through the boundary agreement of 1779, but there was still a great deal of confusion surrounding the Connecticut claims in the susquehanna drainage. After winning a favorable boundary from a Congress in 1782, Pennsylvania lawmakers had only ordered local authorities to protect the settlers from harm. Nothing more had been determined about the validity of their claims.³³ Pennsylvania state courts faced years of protracted legal battles trying to sort this mess out. A fairly obvious solution appeared once the full extent of the state lands became known; those politicians who opposed opening public lands to speculators arranged for Pennsylvania to trade any available tracts for judicial relief.³⁴

Several members of the Mead family had been assaulted or chased off their lands in Northumberland County, and they became some of the earliest claimants to take the offer. David Mead reached Fort Franklin with his brother John in the summer of 1787, and then proceeded up French Creek in search of new homes. By all accounts, some of the best land in the region was located in this valley where no one had yet staked a claim. After locating suitable tracts for farming, the pair returned home to file legal notices of

³³ Russ, Pennsylvania Boundaries, 50-51.

³⁴ Day, Historical Collections, 251.

claim and gather their associates. A band of nine men that David Mead later described as "several Adventurers, and some hired hands" departed Northumberland County for their northwestern lands the following April.³⁵ A permanent camp was established on the eastern bank of French Creek near an abandoned Indian village called Cussewago on May 12, 1788.

Land companies and the question of ownership

State leaders sitting in Philadelphia hoped that placing Mead and his companions on French Creek would draw additional settlers into Northwest Pennsylvania, but their plans were defeated by the difficulties of getting into the area and a mounting threat of an Indian war. The primary path into Northwest Pennsylvania consisted of a rude track carved through the mountains by Indians long ago, and now dignified as "Mead's Trail." Settlers who crossed on the lower paths to Fort Pitt were likely to continue down the Ohio River. Heading northward from Fort Pitt meant fighting the currents in the Allegheny River or combing through dense growth on the overland trails.

Some of the settlers who were willing to brave these hardships

³⁵ Cited in John Earle Reynolds, In French Creek Valley (Meadville, PA: Crawford County Historical Society, 1938), 32; Day, Historical Collections, 251.

were put off by fears of the Indians who were still living in Northwest Pennsylvania. Mead and his companions enjoyed fairly good relations with Iroquoian peoples living on French Creek, but with the countryside remaining so open neither group was forced into competition for land or food. Old hands knew that an influx of settlers could rapidly alter this situation.

Even at this date, Northwest Pennsylvania represented a buffer between the Iroquois confederation of the eastern Great Lakes and western tribes including the Shawnee and Delaware. Native populations in this area were never large when compared to some other parts of the frontier, but settlers were easily outnumbered. State authorities in Pennsylvania could only identify a handful of cabins in Northwest Pennsylvania outside of Fort Franklin and Cussewago at the start of 1791.³⁶

State authorities feared they might lose control of the area if this situation persisted, so they finally gave in to the speculators and took up revisions in the land laws. A bill that was introduced in the legislature on January 21, 1791 was styled "An act to open the Land Office, for granting lands in the western

³⁶ Proctor, "Narrative of the Journey of Col. Thomas Proctor;" in Pennsylvania State Archives, Series 2/vol. 4: 480. Proctor mentions an Indian trader named William Wilson who kept a cabin and trading post on Beaver Creek with "the inhabitants resident at Conneyat and French Creek."

part of this State, and for regulating certain proceedings relating to the same." After more than a year of debating the measure, the existing land laws of the Commonwealth were superseded with new regulations on April 3, 1792.

Western politicians had opposed any changes on behalf of actual settlers already on the ground, while Eastern merchants and speculators countered that titles issued from the land office should be the sole criteria for ownership. A compromise opened lands east of the Allegheny in north-central Pennsylvania to speculators and reserved western lands for farmers. Prices in the East Allegheny lands were reduced to thirteen cents an acre with no restrictions on sales. Individual purchases west of the river were limited to four hundred acres at a slightly higher rate and reserved for "persons who will cultivate, improve and settle the same, or cause the same to be cultivated, improved and settled." Western politicians who voted for this measure failed to appreciate the subtle influences of the eastern interests.

A literal interpretation of the revised law enabled landlords or other parties to own the land without taking up residence. Girdling trees, clearing brush and planting seeds or apple cores, or just scattering grain could be advanced as proof of intent to

settle.³⁷ It was a simple matter for land companies to hire an agent or two to perform these tasks, and capitalists in Philadelphia readily took advantage of this loophole. John Nicholson and a band of investors identified as the Pennsylvania Population Company soon acquired half a million acres representing some of the richest lands in the present boundaries of Erie County, Crawford County and the Beaver Valley.³⁸ Their competitors in the North American Land Company gained control of another 250,000 acres in Northwest Pennsylvania with the support of Robert Morris. Later on, they added another 300,000 acres in other parts of Pennsylvania and picked up even larger tracts in New York, Virginia, North Carolina, South Carolina, Kentucky, and Georgia.³⁹

Agents for the different firms were instructed by their superiors to hurry settlement of their Pennsylvania lands in accordance with state wishes. A critical provision in the revised land law stated that settlers or their sponsors had two years to establish residence from the time of purchase, or their warrants lapsed back into the public domain. Surveyors had no sooner taken

³⁷ Winner, "The Donation and Depreciation Lands," WPHM 8(1), 9.

³⁸ Day, Historical Collections, 261-262.

³⁹ North American Land Company, Plan of Association, (Philadelphia, 1795): 22-23.

to the woods laying out individual tracts, when their best efforts were fouled by a series of diplomatic and military disasters in Ohio.

Federal authorities had gravely mismanaged relations between native peoples and settlers on the American frontier since the end of the Revolution, and a series of minor clashes escalated into a full blown war that left a threat of invasion hanging over the frontier for several years. Army regulars and frontier militiamen invaded Indian lands and destroyed villages to try and force the natives to terms, but the campaign collapsed after a stunning defeat for the American forces in 1790. Survivors fled to a string of forts sitting on the Ohio River from Marietta down to Saint Louis, and settlers followed along fearing the inevitable reprisals.⁴⁰ There was a real threat that the entire frontier might be rolled back, and native peoples living near French Creek warned the colonists at Mead's of hearing threats against them.

David Mead later remembered that "At length so great were our apprehensions of Danger, that about the first of May, the entire

⁴⁰ This panic spread up the Ohio River and into Pennsylvania, where settlers "left their houses along the river for some distance and collected in small bodies some miles back" from the southern bank. See James Morrison to General Richard Butler, Pittsburgh, March 17, 1791; cited in "Frontier Defence," Pennsylvania State Archives Series II, Volume IV: 546.

Settlement broke up, and moved to Fort Franklin, at the mouth of French Creek, mostly on rafts of Boards prepared for the purpose." Some of the refugees doubted that Fort Franklin could withstand a determined assault after their arrival, and departed downstream into "the Settled Country."⁴¹ Those settlers staying behind suffered constant alarms and threats to their safety, and their native companions were hardly better off. Western tribesmen were so angered by cooperation between the natives and settlers on French Creek that they threatened to come up the Allegheny and shake the Seneca chief Cornplanter "by the head & sweep this river from end to end."⁴² Northwestern Pennsylvania was not invaded by substantial enemy forces, but small bands of raiders crossed the border once in awhile and made it dangerous to wander anywhere without armed guards.

Word of this crisis did nothing to dampen the ardor of the speculators off in Philadelphia. Instead of coming to the rescue of the garrison and settlers under siege at Fort Franklin, state leaders moved to add more territory to Pennsylvania. Completing the boundary surveys in 1787, had left Pennsylvania without a

⁴¹ Cited in Reynolds, In French Creek Valley, 32-33.

⁴² "Lieut. J. Jeffers on the Situation at Fort Franklin," Pennsylvania State Archives Series II, Volume IV: 569.

decent outlet to the Great Lakes and a beachfront just four miles long. Fortunately for state interests, the natural harbor at Presque Isle had fallen into the federal domain. Mistakes in drawing the different boundaries between the states and sorting out old land claims had left a good stretch of the lake shore outside of any jurisdiction. New York, Pennsylvania and Massachusetts had all asserted rights to the area at one time, but each had ceded its claims. Congress therefore assumed ownership after the Revolution, but with an expressed desire to sell the land.

Pennsylvania emerged as the chief bidder, but a sales agreement had to wait until New York ascertained its western boundary in 1788. A triangular shaped space was revealed between Pennsylvania, New York and Lake Erie. It was determined that this "Erie Triangle" held 202,187 acres, covering most of modern Erie County. Pennsylvania authorities paid the full price of \$151,640.25 in March, 1792, and thereby completed the present state boundaries.⁴³

Speculators instantly demanded that state officials open this acquisition for public sales. Reports from General Irvine and the boundary surveys of 1786 and 1787, had indicated this territory included some of the choicest farmland above the Ohio River. The

⁴³ Buck and Buck, Planting of Civilization in Western Pennsylvania, 174.

speculators were not deterred by threats of fighting with the Indians, and they sent had surveyors to map out choice tracts before the sale was completed. Several of their agents were harassed by the native peoples and warned to leave the area.⁴⁴

While the speculators debated how to regain entry into the area, the refugees at Fort Franklin straggled back and forth between their old settlement and safety inside the stockade. Their hopes of going home were given a boost after Congress named Anthony Wayne to rebuild the United States Army. Wayne informed the War Department on October 12, 1792, that he deemed Mead's settlement of considerable importance "to afford protection to a number of Inhabitants who had abandoned their plantations in the Winter & to cover the extreme frontier of Westmoreland County & to obtain a supply of board &c for the use of the Army."⁴⁵ Mead and his companions went back to Cussewago for good in 1793, when they built a stockade and blockhouse with the assistance of some soldiers sent up by Wayne. This measure of safety allowed the settlers to hang on until the troubles all along the frontier were brought to a

⁴⁴ Day, Historcal Collections, 317; Tribune Republican, Meadville, 0-6.

⁴⁵ Wayne to Knox, Pittsburgh, October 12, 1792; in Richard C. Knopf, Anthony Wayne, A Name In Arms (Pittsburgh, PA: University of Pittsburgh Press, 1960): 118.

close.

With the speculators discretely shaping public policy, militiamen from the western counties were called into service and dispatched northward to secure the Erie Triangle. There was no fighting to speak of, but records of the campaign vividly show the difficulties of moving men and supplies up the Allegheny River and French Creek. Members of the expedition dragged their supplies to LeBouef, where they erected a fort near the old French works. Governor Mifflin then ordered a halt at the urging of President Washington, who was trying to gauge the intentions of British leaders in Canada. Indians prowled around the works and insulted the garrisons at LeBouef and Meadville, but they did not attack.

Resistance from the native peoples had already collapsed by 1795, when Secretary of War Timothy Pickering wrote Governor Thomas Mifflin (of Pennsylvania) that "the temporary obstacles to the establishment formerly contemplated by the State of Pennsylvania at Presqu'Isle are removed."⁴⁶ Wayne was instructed to assist the Pennsylvania state forces in establishing control of the area. Wayne therefore dispatched 200 men from his army under Captain Bissell to Presque Isle while the Pennsylvania forces resumed

⁴⁶ Harry Marlin Tinkcom, Republicans and Federalists (Harrisburg, PA: Pennsylvania Historical and Museum Commission, 1950), 132.

cutting trees and brush north of LeBouef to open the old French Portage again. When the two forces finally united on the lake shore, Bissell had already started construction of two strong blockhouses on the high bluff overlooking the beach. Settlers appeared close by within weeks, before the works were finished.⁴⁷

Any hopes for fair and orderly sales respecting the rights of both small buyers and large investors in Northwest Pennsylvania collapsed when applicants deluged the state land offices with appeals for warrants and land rights. At least part of this frenzy was related to the appearance of the Holland Land Company, which would play a critical role in shaping subsequent development of the area.

After hearing of the troubles with Indians in the Northwest Territories, the chief investors in the North American Land Company decided to try and dispose of their holdings in New York and Pennsylvania. Before joining this partnership Robert Morris had negotiated loans from Holland as the United States superintendent

⁴⁷ Tradition credits Colonel Seth Reed as the first permanent settler. Reed was sailing westward in search of lands and stopped on the outer side of the Presque Isle Peninsula. Soldiers who spotted smoke from his campfire and went to investigate invited Reed to stay on. He subsequently built a shack near the garrison and divided it as a residence and tavern. M.P. Sargent, Pioneer Sketches (Erie, PA: Herald Printing and Publishing company, 1891), 87; Elise Lathrap, Early American Inns and Taverns (New York, NY: Tudor Publishing Company, 1926).

of finance in 1784. He was aware these notes were scheduled for payment and suggested this might work in favor of the North American Land Company. Representatives for Morris and his associates visited the Dutch bankers with advice how they might make a killing in the American land market.

A handful of Dutchmen and their English partners organized the Holland Land Company to purchase lands after hearing these reports. Americans who were hired to represent the Holland Land Company in Philadelphia eventually purchased several million acres in Northwest Pennsylvania and western New York. Almost all of modern Crawford County was included in the purchase, along with sizable tracts in Erie County, Warren County, and Venango County.

Provisions in the land law of 1792 had directed settlers or their sponsors to establish physical occupation within two years or forfeit their warrants. Exceptions might be granted if the landholder was prevented from doing so by some natural calamity or enemies of the state. Agents of the land companies seized the Indian war as an excuse to avoid compliance, and took out additional warrants without mustering any pretext of trying to colonize the land.

Calls for reform by western politicians in the Pennsylvania legislature were brushed aside in the rush to enhance state

finances. A token measure of relief was provided on April 18, 1795, when the legislature set aside some of the best lands for public use at Presque Isle, LeBouef, the mouth of French Creek near Fort Franklin, and the mouth of Conewango Creek where Warren was founded.⁴⁸ Afterwards, all remaining parts of the Erie Triangle and even some of the left over Donation Lands were thrown out for public sale in a new round of speculation.⁴⁹

Wild trading and competition between the largest land companies only increased the furor. Small scale investors hoped to take advantage of the situation by buying claims in hopes of forcing the land companies to make an arrangement. One firm called the Harrisburg and Presque Isle Company purchased tracts when the state reserve at Presque Isle was opened in 1796, and passed these to the Pennsylvania Population Company at a healthy profit. Down along the Beaver river, the Pennsylvania Population Company was forced to make an agreement with the McNair brothers of Pittsburgh over competing claims. As part of the sales agreement, the McNairs

⁴⁸ Since rivers served as highways on the frontier, setting aside choice tracts at these important junctions of the major rivers and streams was a severe blow to the speculators (and a clear warning where the state legislature stood on this issue). Speculation in cities and towns proceeded right along with investments rural farmsteads; see Richard C. Wade, Urban Frontier (Chicago, IL: University of Chicago Press, 1959), 29-35.

⁴⁹ Ferguson, Early Western Pennsylvania Politics, 141.

agreed to help sell off the lands and sweep squatters from the area.⁵⁰

Since the land companies and the state had claimed such huge tracts, it was inevitable that conflicts would arise over ownership. Judge Alexander Addison of the state court complained of an illegal house on public lands near the Beaver River during the first week of February, 1795 and warned of other settlers who had stated their intention to build close by. Their activities were reportedly making "havock" of the timbers on the unsold lands, and Addison feared widespread destruction and seizures could only interfere with legal sales.⁵¹

Homesteaders were inclined to dismiss any challenges through ignorance of the law, or a common belief that the warrants issued earlier had expired. Certain politicians who were still angry about changes to the land law back in 1792, and the more recent failures to provide relief, urged squatters to take lands in hopes of restoring the old rules. Legal warrant holders appealed to state authorities for relief and warned of grave disorders if some

⁵⁰ Buck and Buck, The Planting of Civilization in Western Pennsylvania, 210.

⁵¹ Judge Addison to Governor Mifflin, Washington, February 3, 1795; in "Frontier Defence," Pennsylvania State Archives, Series 2/volume 4: 650.

measures were not taken to stem illegal settlement. The Board of Property, which controlled public lands, indulged the biggest landholders by declaring that settlement requirements dating from the land act of 1792 could be postponed. Other states and local governments had done the same when faced with similar circumstances.⁵²

Pennsylvania state officials followed suit and started to issue "prevention certificates" that extended the time requirements for settlement. Landholders were given two years to establish settlement rights from the conclusion of the Indian war, instead of the original date on warrants. Board members tamely accepted arguments that the only Indian troubles had prevented the land companies from meeting their mandate. Frontiersmen and homeseekers

⁵² Samuel T. Wiley, History of Monongalia County (Kingwood, WV: Preston Publishing company, 1883), 575. Virginia state leaders faced a similar situation. They had incorporated "Morgans-Town" on the Monongahela in 1785, with fixed schedules for making improvements. After purchasing a town lot at auction, each new landholder was required to erect a house counting eighteen square feet and equipped "with a brick or stone chimney" within four years. Failure to meet this requirement would result in forfeiture of the tract with all land rights reverting to the state. On December 4, 1798, the General Assembly of Virginia upheld the rights of landholders in the face of unforeseen difficulties and granted a stay of all forfeiture cases on grounds "That Indian hostilities and other causes" were to blame for the settlers' failure to build houses. These modest requirements for gaining title are nearly repeated in a claim from Northwest Pennsylvania cited by Winner, "The Depreciation and Donation Lands," WPHM 8(1), 9.

protested that fighting and threats of violence were endemic to the frontier, and did not pose a just cause for continuing the warrants. Squatters began taking tracts in open defiance, while the land companies raced to place their own people on the ground.

Competition between the two groups was heightened by mistakes in drawing maps and locating lands. Surveyors were not licensed by any civil authority, and anyone holding a compass and chains could pass himself off as a skilled tradesman.⁵³ One so called surveyor who was hired to lead emigrants to their tracts around New Castle and the Shenango River, dumped his charges on the Mahoning River in Ohio where Youngstown was founded.⁵⁴ Josiah Tannehill of Allegheny County built a new home on the road between LeBouef and Preque Isle in 1795, and then found out his grant was mistakenly placed in the state reserve lands.⁵⁵

Repeated stories of comparable misdeeds and mistakes reinforced desires to continue past Northwest Pennsylvania. In order to draw settlers the land companies offered bounties in land, tools, and provisions, or some combination. Company lands were advertised in newspapers up and down the Atlantic coast while agents scoured

⁵³ Erie Weekly Gazette, December 29, 1870: p3c5.

⁵⁴ Hazen, History of New Castle and Lawrence County, 59.

⁵⁵ Ferguson, Early Western Pennsylvania Politics, 141.

Pennsylvania, New Jersey, Maryland and Virginia in search of prospective settlers. Discounted supplies and easy credit were used as additional inducements, but the early results were not promising.⁵⁶

Major Howe of the Holland Land Company enlisted one hundred immigrants in New York City with promises of one hundred acres and provisions for six months. After reaching eastern Pennsylvania, Howe deposited his charges at Easton while searching for wagons to cross the mountains. Rumors of bad lands and poor provisions swept the ranks and spurred the immigrants into fleeing. Howe eventually reached French Creek "with but a corporal's guard behind him."⁵⁷ In another instance, recruiters for the Holland Land had just started to place between fifty and one hundred settlers on their tracts when the weather turned dark and cold. Most of the newcomers then returned home or took boats downstream for the warmer climate of Kentucky.⁵⁸

Still another attempt to enlist settlers for the Holland Land Company in 1796, was only partially successful. Two hundred

⁵⁶ See Pittsburgh Gazette, August 20, 1796:p3c3.

⁵⁷ Paul Demund Evans, The Holland Land Company (Buffalo, NY: Buffalo Historical Society, 1924), 115.

⁵⁸ *Ibid*, 115.

settlers and families agreed to serve as tenants for five years, in exchange for a partial tracts. Traders at Pittsburgh told them of more lucrative deals that others had negotiated, and most of the new arrivals scattered to make for better arrangements. Part of this group proceeded down the Ohio, and others contracted with rival companies. Just a fragment of the original gathering agreed to stay on with the Holland Land Company, but they demanded additional concessions.⁵⁹

Settlers had been placed on five hundred thirty tracts belonging to the Holland Land Company at the end of 1799, but this represented only about half of the warrants the Dutchmen claimed to own. None of the other companies could boast of even this modest success. There was little reason for settlers to submit to the harsh terms offered by speculators when land could be had for almost nothing up and down the frontier. Old hands in the jagged hill country of Southwest Pennsylvania were constantly leaving to seek better tracts out West and willing to strike any kind of deal to make something from their clearings. One entire farm was traded for just a rifle, and a former soldier from Fort Pitt acquired

⁵⁹ Ibid, 116-117.

another in exchange for his old army coat.⁶⁰ With land being traded so freely, the agents for the land companies in Northwest Pennsylvania found they could only force terms on poverty stricken emigrants from eastern ports and farmers who had lost their fortunes to taxes or debt.

Manipulation of these unfortunates fostered resentment against the land companies, and a fair number of tenants abandoned their contracts after establishing residence. Once they had taken possession of the land, homesteaders were highly susceptible to gossip that any extensions of the original land warrants after 1794 were illegal. A spirit of rebellion was furthered by the lack of any civil authority and an influx of squatters. Frontiersmen placed their views of natural rights above any contracts and sales agreements made in eastern cities. By their reckoning, any man could stake a claim by clearing land and putting up shelter.⁶¹ They were inclined to settle questions of ownership between themselves without outside interference or circumspection.

One representative and well known case from Northwest

⁶⁰ Howard L. Leckey, Tenmile Country (Waynesburg, PA: Greene County Historical Society), 12.

⁶¹ Elliott, Life of the Rev. Robert Roberts, 41. When Roberts and five companions staked out their claims along the Shenango River in 1796 "they were guided in their division lines by some that had been run by a company a year or two before."

Pennsylvania makes this point. According to the legend, William Gill spent the summer of 1793 or 1794 building a cabin and reaping a crop of corn and potatoes. In the fall he repaired to Pittsburgh to secure supplies and gather his family, but postponed his return because of weather. His home was viewed as open and when Gill finally came back the next spring Jenny (or Janet) Finney was living there. Locals celebrated tales of how Finney stood in the doorway with rifle in hand and warned Gill away. David Mead was so impressed that he took Finney as his second wife.⁶²

Settlers called on longstanding traditions and pulled together for common defense when confronted by the land companies. Proximity to civil authorities may have tempered violent tendencies in a few cases. Settlers living on the Beaver River near Pittsburgh organized themselves as the "Pennsylvania United Settlers" and sought legal advice from Hugh Brackenridge of Pittsburgh. Brackenridge was known for his opposition policies, and already pressed claims against eastern landholders including George Washington back in 1784. In more remote locations, the squatters loosely styled themselves "improvers" or "actual

⁶² John Dick, "Recollections of an Early Settler," in Centennial Edition Tribune-Republican: 12; Sargent, Pioneer Sketches, 52-53; Reynolds, In French Creek Valley, 118.

settlers" and offered a show of arms.⁶³

Agents for the land companies and any of their friends holding tracts were warned to leave matters alone or leave the area. Civil unrest in a few localities bordered on civil war. Jacob Colt of the Pennsylvania Population Company felt compelled to keep a band of between forty and one hundred men under arms up in Erie County.⁶⁴ Harm Jan Huidekoper wrote his employers in the Holland Land Company of meetings held near Meadville in which "plans of opposition were organized, assessments made, counsel appointed, and every step taken that would insure success to their lawless plans."⁶⁵ Unknown persons started setting fires on company tracts and went unpunished even after Huidekoper offered fifty dollars in reward for information.⁶⁶

Democratic politicians who had opposed any changes in state land laws back in 1792, were delighted by this turn of events and warned of further disorders and increased violence unless some sort of remedial action was taken. Their landholding rivals in the

⁶³ Day, Historical Collections, 316.

⁶⁴ Laura G. Sanford, History of Erie County (Erie, PA: published by the author, 1894), 162.

⁶⁵ Buck and Buck, The Planting of Civilization in Western Pennsylvania, 211.

⁶⁶ Crawford Weekly Messenger, May 1, 1805: p3c3.

Federalist ranks vigorously opposed any additional changes in the state land code, so a compromise was worked to provide civil jurisdictions in the affected areas. At this time, all of Pennsylvania above the Ohio River and west of the Allegheny was included in Allegheny County. Since all court business and voting was conducted at the county seat in Pittsburgh, settlers in the northwest were excluded from most government functions. Western politicians projected several new units into the county map to correct this imbalance. Creating new governments increased their ability to appoint local officials, while raising the number of polling stations for their rural followers.⁶⁷

Centre County was therefore carved out of Allegheny County on February 13, 1800. Wrangling in the legislature produced additional jurisdictions exactly one month later on March 13, 1800, including Armstrong, Beaver, Butler, Crawford, Mercer, Erie, Venango and Warren counties. Boundaries for the different counties were based on anticipated future needs, since there were not enough settlers to justify separate organizations at this time. Only Crawford was organized for judicial purposes, and this was

⁶⁷ Ferguson, Early Western Pennsylvania Politics, 159-160.

predicated on a promise to erect suitable public buildings.⁶⁸

This success ushered a wave of support for the small landholders and republican values in state offices. Public authorities who might have wavered in favor of the land companies started to criticize their monopoly over state land warrants. A reconstituted Board of Property refused to extend the time limits for settlement on account of the Indian war, and began to issue "vacating warrants" to Actual Settlers. Protests from the land companies were answered with hints the board might revoke the warrants already issued for any unsettled lands. A series of court challenges were filed on behalf of the different land companies, but they faced increasing opposition as from the state courts. A final appeal to the Pennsylvania Supreme Court was denied in 1802. Governor Thomas McKean was inclined to make some sort of arrangement and pay the companies for their troubles, but the legislature voiced almost no support for the measure. McKean then abandoned the large landholders in an attempt to shore up his position in his own party.⁶⁹

During their efforts to negotiate a settlement with the

⁶⁸ Buck and Buck, The Planting of Civilization in Western Pennsylvania, 214.

⁶⁹ Ferguson, Early Western Pennsylvania Politics, 172-173, 182-185; Evans, Holland Land Company: 142-143.

governor, one faction of the speculators had urged their colleagues to seek federal intervention. After this split with the governor, they did not have any choice. Most of the companies had exhausted their legal rights to appeal in state courts, but members of the Holland Land Company still retained certain privileges. Under the Constitution of the United States, the Dutch bankers could argue their case in federal court as foreign nationals. Since any decision was certain to affect the rights of the Pennsylvania Population Company and the other large landholders, and there was concern that they should gain legal standing in the case. Six tracts claimed by the Pennsylvania Population Company and "occupied by the usurpers" were transferred over to the Holland Land Company so that suits could be filed in their name.⁷⁰ Several ejectment suits were filed against the squatters, and one was eventually forwarded to the Supreme Court of the United States as a test case.

State leaders in Pennsylvania vigorously protested this intrusion in their affairs, and consistently questioned the limits of federal authority. A bill that was adopted by the state senate in 1803, declared that the "mode of settling and disposing of the territory exclusively belonging to each state respectively in respect whereof each state is and ought to be sovrein and

⁷⁰ Evans, Holland Land Company, 145.

independent." Citizens of Pennsylvania were advised to oppose any preliminary ejectments issued by the federal authorities, and the legislature authorized the governor to hire one or more "able counsel" at public expense to defend their interests.⁷¹

In spite of the mounting urgency surrounding the case, a full hearing was postponed several times due to legal wrangling and an epidemic of yellow fever. Chief Justice John Marshall and two associates finally heard the case during the spring term of the United States Circuit Court of Pennsylvania in 1805. After considering the arguments, the court handed down a unanimous decision favoring the land companies. Marshall pointed to that clause in the state land act of 1792, that stated if hostilities prevented settlement then the grantee or his heirs "shall be entitled to have and to hold the said lands, in the same manner as if the actual settlement had been made and continued." All of the preemption certificates and replacement warrants issued since 1795, were therefore dismissed out of hand.⁷²

Actual settlers and most of their patrons in state government were stunned by this decision. Members in both houses of the state

⁷¹ Ferguson, Early Western Pennsylvania Politics, 128-129; Buck and Buck, The Planting of Civilization in Western Pennsylvania, 211.

⁷² Ferguson, Early Western Pennsylvania Politics, 183.

legislature protested the outcome, but failed to mount an effective challenge. A bill questioning federal intervention in state affairs was only passed two years later, and there was little comment when it was vetoed by the governor. State courts maintained their freedom from federal interference in wordy pronouncements, but failed to sustain any challenges to the federal ruling that were brought before them.⁷³

A small group of state leaders had predicted this outcome all along. William McArthur who represented the district including Crawford, Erie and Venango in the state senate, and had already introduced a measure for the relief of actual settlers. McArthur proposed financial assistance to allow the inhabitants of the disputed lands to keep any tracts on which they built homes and cleared fields. This scheme collapsed once the federal court ruling became known. Actual Settlers were advised instead, to negotiate the best deals they could make for themselves with the land companies.⁷⁴ Local newspapers began running advertisements for the land companies by the start of the summer, warning the Actual Settlers they must come to terms or face severe consequences.

⁷³ Buck and Buck, The Planting of Civilization in Western Pennsylvania, 211-212.

⁷⁴ Ibid.

James Gibson directed occupants of the Pennsylvania Population Company lands in Beaver and Mercer counties to settle their differences by September 14, 1805, or face eviction.⁷⁵

Some of the squatters refused to make any kind of arrangement, and clung to their tracts with hopes that friends in the state legislature might still intervene on their behalf. Huidekoper reported on June 7, 1805, that the Intruders in one district near the western state line had organized and "voted funds for the purchase of powder and balls."⁷⁶ Others gave up the struggle and fled, but a sizable number tried to strike a deal with the speculators. Huidekoper had expected as much back on March 20, 1805 when he wrote "The late decision [by the Supreme Court] will contribute considerably to the population of Canada or Louisiana." A canoe was stolen and taken downriver from Meadville the same night that news of the court ruling arrived.⁷⁷ Barely two months later, Huidekoper observed that "our country is clearing very fast and explained that "Arks full [of squatters] go down the river to the land of promise." It was expected this migration out of the

⁷⁵ Ferguson, Early Western Pennsylvania Politics, 184.

⁷⁶ Evans, Holland Land Company, 167.

⁷⁷ Nina Moore Tiffany, Harm Jan Huidekoper (Cambridge, MA: Riverside Press, 1904), 119.

region would continue for some months, and that the numbers of refugees would increase once the court began serving ejectments.⁷⁸

Opposition crumbled when settlers were served with court orders and called to account for their actions. Huidekoper notified his superiors on August 13, 1806 that "As to intruders that is over, on the Holland Company's lands ... Those amongst them that had any industry have chiefly agreed to purchase. Of the rest, a part have been so good as to leave the country, and a few more will run away this fall or next spring as soon as the water rises."⁷⁹

Conclusion

Competition between speculators and settlers was an inherent part of advancing the frontier, but in Northwest Pennsylvania the conflict was exaggerated by wars and the desires of certain politicians to create a republican haven for small farmers.

Early explorations of the Appalachian Mountains and the lands lying behind the western slopes drew attention to the rich farmlands of Kentucky and Tennessee. Settlers drifted through the mountain gaps in this direction, and settlement in that area came closest to fulfilling the Turnerian model of an expanding frontier.

⁷⁸ Evans, Holland Land Company, 167.

⁷⁹ Tiffany, Harm Jan Huidekoper, 123.

Western Pennsylvania drew attention as a gateway into this region. Settlers streamed through this area in their search for western lands, although some stayed and crafted small farms out of the narrow floodplains and plateaus of the upper Ohio Country leading into the higher Appalachians. Leaders in the Pennsylvania state government developed interests in promoting settlement in order to establish ownership. Several states had voiced rival claims over lands around the head the Ohio River and Pennsylvania leaders were forced to negotiate for their rights to the area. They decided that placing a loyal population in the area was the best way to enforce these agreements once definite state boundaries were established. In order to further this end, lands in Northwest Pennsylvania were freely offered in settlement of war claims and other debts against the state. This policy failed to provide a resident population, and in desperation the lands were opened to speculators. Pennsylvania state leaders hoped private concerns might succeed in promoting where they had failed. Settlers vehemently opposed this shift in policy and called it a violation of their natural rights. Plans for encouraging additional settlement and promoting economic development bogged down in conflict between the two sides.

Chapter 2:
STATE CAPITALISM AND INTERNAL IMPROVEMENTS,
1805 - 1815

Settlement patterns in Northwest Pennsylvania during the early part of the nineteenth century placed impoverished tenants of the land companies next to independent landholders and successful farmers. This stunning contrast in fortunes provided public officials with a strong impetus for promoting internal improvements during the next quarter of a century.

State leaders in Pennsylvania had invested heavily in building roads and canals since the late eighteenth century, but few of the benefits had spread up across the Ohio River and the Allegheny. Agents for the different land companies holding claims in Northwest Pennsylvania had only occasionally opened roads or built mills, and only in locations that served their benefactors. More money was spent on legal fees trying to evict squatters than making improvements. Elected officials had not stepped in to make up the shortfall, since the land had already been sold and was no longer part of the public domain.

Politicians and business leaders in the northwestern counties tried to better their lot, but lacked the financial and political

resources required for any major improvements. Settlers took advantage of their surroundings and started shipping lumber and agricultural produce of their farms down French Creek and the Allegheny River, and then adding salt from western New York. Settlers expressed hopes they could improve navigation on these streams and add better road connections to develop a corridor for commerce, but money for promoting the work was scarce and hopes for outside assistance were stonewalled by a divisive rise of sectional politics in Pennsylvania. Any thoughts that state legislators might have harbored over aiding Northwest Pennsylvania were pushed aside by feuds drawing in Philadelphia, Pittsburgh, and their commercial rivals outside the state boundaries. While their concerns sometimes overlapped, each section sought to shape legislation and public spending for its own particular interests.

Business promoters and state government

Capabilities for building decent roads or improving navigation had hardly advanced in Pennsylvania and neighboring states since the earliest settlers landed on the Atlantic shore. Trained engineers seldom marked the trails or channels used for boating, and this fostered a belief that making improvements did not require

special skills.¹ Where government agencies stepped in to open a road or clear a stream, subsequent repairs and maintenance were left to the local authorities.² Most improvements therefore assumed a temporary character outside of a few well used paths.

Roads were opened by slashing brush and cutting back the timber so that a wagon could pass; trees were cut low to the ground, but drivers had to guide their wheels between the stumps. These paths were choked with dust during dry spells, and wet weather turned them into nearly impassable quagmires. Drainage ditches rapidly filled in low lying areas, and paths cut into hillsides were commonly choked with debris that washed down from higher elevations. Piles of stones or loose planks and felled logs sufficed for bridges.³

Public figures were hard pressed to keep the roads open and even stretches of major highways suffered.⁴ Settlers living on the old Forbes road petitioned state leaders to view its ruined condition in 1773, in hopes of getting it fixed. This was one of the major

¹ Durrenberger, Turnpikes, 88.

² Sanford, History of Erie County, 277; Phillips, History of Transportation in the Eastern Cotton Belt, 61.

³ Parke Rouse, jr., The Great Wagon Road, from Philadelphia to the South (New York, NY: McGraw-Hill Book Company, 1973), 216-217; Sanford, History of Erie County, 108.

⁴ Rouse, Great Wagon Road, 93-94.

trails crossing the Appalachian Mountains, but vehicular traffic had nearly ceased since the end of the French and Indian War because countless trees were laying in the roadway and deep morasses were worn into the surface. It was so chewed up in some places that two hacks could not pass at once; when teams met from opposite directions, one driver had to brush against the trees so that the other could pass. The few teamsters still trying to make a living on the path complained they had to drag branches behind their carts to serve as brakes and keep from sliding around.⁵

Apologists for the state government might have excused these conditions in poorly settled districts of the mountains in central Pennsylvania or the western frontier, but roads were no better in more populated localities with a longer history of settlement. Elizabeth Drinker of Philadelphia made a trip to Lancaster in 1778 and complained that "In our journey today we found the roads so bad, that we walked part of ye way, and climbed 3 fences, to get clear of ye mud..."⁶

This situation did not improve with an increase in trade after

⁵ George Dallas Albert, History of the County of Westmoreland (Philadelphia, PA: L.H. Everts & Co., 1882), 180, 183.

⁶ George Shumway, Conestoga Wagon (York, PA: Early American Industries Association and George Shumway), 71.

the American Revolution. One eyewitness wrote that long stretches of roads near the suburban village of Rising Sun were quagmires of black mud where horses were seen floundering up to their bellies. Close by on the York Road, long lines of wagons backed up every day at a local landmark named Logan's Hill where wagon drivers had to unhitch their teams and assist one another in dragging their vehicles up the grade. Some spots of the roads were so bad that drivers tore down fences and made new paths; stakes were set in the ground to mark off sections of the old course that were likened to quicksand. This assault on fence lines and private property was repeated as wagons churned up each new passage.⁷

Complaints from travellers and property owners did not arouse much sympathy in the state government, since Pennsylvania was no better or worse than other states in allowing these kinds of conditions.

Real concern for building better roads was fostered by competitive pressures for trade and new lands. Settlers heading westward at the close of the Revolution began hacking trails through the brush along the Mohawk River into western New York, and widening old traders' paths down the Great Valley toward the mountain gaps leading into Kentucky and Tennessee. Pennsylvania authorities responded in 1785 by voting \$10,000 to build a road

⁷ Cleveland and Powell, Railroad Promotion, 5.

from the mouth of the Juniata River to Pittsburgh. After this modest start, more than \$150,000 was committed to building new roads in different parts of the state over the next six years. Unfortunately, most of these undertakings were never completed and others were badly mismanaged.

Hugh H. Brackenridge of Pittsburgh published a piece on the difficulties in getting across Pennsylvania on April 26, 1789. Despite the thousands of dollars spent on improving roads to that point, Brackenridge wondered if "Perhaps it might be well that the road from Philadelphia to Pittsburgh should remain as it is, because in that case it would resemble the way to Heaven, rough, rugged, and difficult to pass."⁸

Funds for the different road projects had been entrusted to county commissioners with no mechanisms to guarantee fair and proper spending. This omission generated uneven results across the state, and emphasized sectional rivalries. One newspaper editor in Philadelphia had already blamed western settlers for this condition in 1787, and wondered how "happy it would be for Pennsylvania if

⁸ Shumway, Conestoga Wagon, 123. Another view is found in the observations of New England emigrants going West in 1788, who found that roads through the Pennsylvania mountains "were cut into deep gullies on one side [of the mountain] by mountain rains, while the other side was filled with blocks of sandstone;" cited in Lathrap, Early American Inns and Taverns, 243.

her boundaries were comprised by the Susquehanna; [since] we should then be more compact and more united." Inhabitants of the western counties were just "dead weight" on the state government according to this author, who accused them of making demands on the public treasury while offering little in return. Thomas Paine added that Westerners "come here to legislate," but head to Baltimore to trade.⁹

Newspaper editors from both ends of the state hurled charges of ingratitude and complaints of the other across the mountains. While this battle raged in print, merchants and speculators from Philadelphia and surrounding counties organized "A Society for Promoting the Improvement of Roads and Inland Navigation" with Robert Morris acting as president. Members convened once a week and devised schemes for making additional improvements or bettering existing facilities. Promotional handbills and newspaper accounts of their activities drew a great deal of notice in coffeehouses and shops around city, but failed to generate much excitement in the far corners of Pennsylvania.¹⁰ Inhabitants of the western counties wanted to see tangible measures of their tax dollars creeping

⁹ James Weston Livingood, Philadelphia-Baltimore Trade Rivalry (Harrisburg, PA: Pennsylvania Historical and Museum Commission, 1947), 8.

¹⁰ Livingood, Philadelphia-Baltimore Trade Rivalry, 9.

across the mountains, while Philadelphians increasingly pushed the Susquehanna as their natural frontier.

In order to promote improvements and stay in the good graces of voters, members of the state legislature crafted a compromise approach. They agreed to empower private firms with rights to build and operate roads, bridges and canals, while the state set rates of tolls to safeguard public interests. One of the earliest and more successful ventures was the Lancaster Turnpike that was started in 1792, to connect Philadelphia with the interior counties. A proper road was constructed over the following two years, boasting a bed of crushed stone that prevented vehicles from sinking in the mud. It included accessories unheard of on most public roads, like culverts, bridges and drainage features.

Businessmen and politicians from Philadelphia hastened to trumpet the benefits of their new road, but its geographic reach was severely limited. With a length of just 62 miles, it barely reached the external limits of the greater Philadelphia community. Teamsters refused to use the road at first because paying tolls cut into their profits, but they relented once the advantages became known. Waggoning over an improved surface saved a great deal of time and money otherwise wasted on rutted dirt tracks from broken wheels and overturned wagons.

Plans were soon drawn up for surfaced roads leading from Philadelphia into the Delaware Valley and over to the Susquehanna. There was talk of eventually extending these benefits into every part of Pennsylvania, but there were serious political and financial obstacles stood in the way. Politicians were not likely to spread their favors into far corners of the state unless power brokers from Philadelphia and the neighboring counties approved. An overwhelming majority of Pennsylvania tax payers lived in these southeastern counties, and Philadelphia served dual roles as the capital and chief business center of the state. Few would argue against the benefits of expanding political and commercial relations through the state, but Philadelphia placed its growing trade rivalry with Baltimore above everything else.

Merchants and mill owners from that port had pushed roads through western Maryland up to the Pennsylvania state line since the middle part of the eighteenth century. Farmers from the western districts of Pennsylvania out past York (including Bedford County and Somerset County) started hauling their goods and produce over the mountains toward Baltimore as a result.¹¹ When settlers began flocking over the mountains after the Revolution, the merchants in Baltimore drew up plans to tighten their grip in

¹¹ Livingood, Philadelphia-Baltimore Trade Rivalry, 29-30.

Western Pennsylvania.

Legislators in Virginia and Maryland eagerly agreed to help, and jointly commissioned the Potomac Company to extend navigation the full length of the Potomac River to Cumberland. Farmers in Western Pennsylvania were promised substantial reductions in real transportation costs and their time on the road once this improvement was opened for use. Promoters behind this scheme hoped to someday extend their services over the heights into the Monongahela River and its tributaries, and reach the Great Lakes.¹²

Merchants in Philadelphia complained of intrusions in their affairs, but hoped to make up their losses in Western Pennsylvania by promoting settlement and trade in the Susquehanna drainage. Public figures had already talked of extending navigation through Pennsylvania, but the haphazard arrangement of rivers and mountains inside the state boundaries raised cost estimates and technical obstacles beyond an acceptable level. Each of the three major drainage systems in Pennsylvania ran counter to the patterns of western trade. Philadelphia interests therefore looked northward where the Susquehanna fans out toward New York.

Settlers had begun taking lands on the main river and its

¹² George Washington "to Robert Morris, Mount Vernon, February, 1, 1785;" in Writings of Washington, volume 28: 50.

tributaries at the end of the Revolution.¹³ After clearing their fields and erecting homes and barns, settlers branded any excess lumber with their marks and floated the pieces downstream with the current. Cut boards and scantling were seen mixed in by 1789, while the farmers improved their lot. Around 150,000 bushels of wheat arrived by canoes and flatboats two years later along with the lumber, some if it coming all the way from the rich Genessee Country of western New York.¹⁴

Merchants at Baltimore readily grasped the economic potential of this region, and tried to reach up over the state line and wrest it from Philadelphia. Maryland authorities passed several acts to clear their end of the Susquehanna River and make it safe for boating, but the Pennsylvania Assembly consistently blocked any improvements on their side of the boundary. Boating effectively ceased between the Conewago Falls at Middletown and the state line. Boat skippers who decided to try and run the falls going downstream usually changed their minds at Middletown after viewing the wrecks of boats that had tried to go through before them, and bringing

¹³ See James Arthur Frost, Life in the Upper Susquehanna, 1783-1860 (New York, NY: King Crown's Press, 1951), for a survey of the early settlement and patterns of economic development in the upper parts of the Susquehanna watershed in New York.

¹⁴ Livingood, Philadelphia-Baltimore Trade Rivalry, 28.

cargoes up against the falls required costly and time consuming transfers.¹⁵

Baltimore responded to this blockade by building branches from its western turnpikes up along the Susquehanna.¹⁶ Business partnerships were crafted with local merchants so that Pennsylvania state leaders could not reject their charter petitions out of hand. Rival ports subsequently grew up across Conewago Falls, with Middletown on the East Bank expressing loyalty to Philadelphia and York Haven on the opposite shore tied to Baltimore. Besides the usual collection of dockside warehouses, both communities built extensive mills for grinding grain before it was carted off over local roads. Since Philadelphia or Baltimore was about one hundred miles away over bad roads, there was no real advantage in choosing one port over the other. Merchants from Philadelphia therefore

¹⁵ Livingood, Philadelphia-Baltimore Trade Rivalry, 30. According to one eyewitness, getting a single load through the falls meant hiring 30 or 40 men who were "obliged to perch and scatter themselves (as it has been humorously expressed) like black-birds on the rocks, and to drag their burden shifting from rock to rock through the whole length of the falls."

¹⁶ Some of the chief investors in the Potomac Company visited Philadelphia at times to seek technical advice for their own canals, or to view likely connctions. See George Washington "to Tobias Lear, Philadelphia, December 21, 1794," in Writings of George Washington, volume 34 (Washington, D.C.: U.S. Government Printing Office): 66-67; Lathrap, Early American Inns and Taverns, 155,

crafted an ambitious plan to extend boating in Pennsylvania and break the deadlock.

Early plans of the Potomac Company in Maryland called for opening five short canals around troublesome obstacles and merging these into a comprehensive system at some later date. Prominent Philadelphians including Thomas Gilpin, David Rittenhouse, William Smith, Benjamin Franklin and Thomas Mifflin, decided to trump this effort with a canal of their own. Mifflin was serving as the governor of Pennsylvania and promised favorable action in the Pennsylvania legislature.

Plans were hurriedly drawn up for opening a channel between the Schuylkil River near Philadelphia and the Susquehanna River near the Conewango Falls. Boats coming down the Susquehanna could then pass around the falls and continue on to Philadelphia without stopping to unload. One of the few drawbacks on paper was trying to sell this plan across the state.

Tax payers were growing critical of free spending after repeated failures in the state road program, and the canal easily fell outside the realm of "public highways" because of its limited range. Thomas Mifflin dismantled some of the opposition by launching surveys for roads and canals in every settled part of Pennsylvania. Surveyors were dispatched up the West Branch of the

Susquehanna and over into the Allegheny watershed, while contracts were signed for clearing and making other improvements in the Monongahela River and its Youghiogheny branch. In order to cement the deal, all of the work around Philadelphia was turned over to private contractors acting under state authorities. This was the same procedure taken to open new roads, and gave tax payers the illusion that all of the risks had passed into private hands.

State authorities created the Schuylkill and Susquehanna Navigation Company for "opening a canal and lock navigation" between the two rivers along Swatara Creek and Tulpehocken Creek on September 29, 1791. Work had barely started on this line before April 10, 1792 when state leaders vested the Delaware and Schuylkil Navigation Company with rights to extend navigation into Philadelphia. After waiting a few more months for work to start on this line, they released additional contracts for work around Conewago Falls on July 3, 1792.¹⁷

Successful bidders for the work at Conewago Falls were instructed to open a ditch one mile long according to the prevailing standards of at least forty feet wide and four feet

¹⁷ Corkan, Beaver and Lake Erie Canal, 3; McCullough and Leuba, Pennsylvania Main Line Canal, 11.

deep, and include two "safe and commodius" locks.¹⁸ This modest undertaking soon taxed the capabilities of its builders.

Philadelphia promoters had gleefully written off problems encountered in finishing the Potomac works as the result of poor planning and inadequate funding, instead of seeing the limits of contemporary excavation and building capabilities. The work around Conewango Falls was finally dedicated to public use in a freezing rain on November 22, 1797, more than five years after the first spade was turned on it. Nearly five hundred citizens braved the weather to hear Governor Mifflin's predictions of success. Neither of the other two lines had gotten anywhere near completion. Work on the canal coming out of Philadelphia had started at Third and Vine Streets, but it had not gone any further than the bridge at Columbia Avenue several blocks away.¹⁹

Boatmen from the upper waters had already grown tired of waiting. With thoughts of running the rapids in mind, they started building heavy boats around strong keels that could absorb the hard shocks from smashing into rocks and other obstructions. While work on the canals lagged in 1794, a German miller from the Juniata Branch plunged through the Conewango Falls aboard a vessel "in the

¹⁸ Livingood, Philadelphia-Baltimore Trade Rivalry, 32.

¹⁹ McCullough and Leuba, Pennsylvania Main Line Canal, 11.

shape of an ark" and carried a load of flour to Havre de Grace. At that point the flour was easily placed on shallops bound for Baltimore.²⁰

News that a vessel had successfully gone through the rapids in one piece unnerved the merchants and state leaders sitting in Philadelphia. They instantly doubted the wisdom of building canals and redoubled their efforts in roadbuilding. Dozens of companies were organized to open new roads in the following months and years, and existing firms were offered incentives to improve their facilities. In a bid to push commerce back on to state roads the legislature adopted strict measures to check further improvements on the Susquehanna. A law from 1799 provided that "any individual or company, who shall without proper authority from the governor of the commonwealth, remove or attempt to remove, the obstructions in the river Susquehanna, between Wright's ferry and the Maryland line, shall be fined in a sum not less than two hundred dollars, nor more than two thousand dollars, with such imprisonment as the court before whom they are prosecuted in their discretion may direct, not exceeding six months."²¹

²⁰ Livingood, Philadelphia-Baltimore Trade Rivalry, 32; Frost, Life in the Upper Susquehanna, 26.

²¹ Livingood, Philadelphia-Baltimore Trade Rivalry, 33.

Pittsburgh and the western river trade

With their plans for improving navigation collapsing around them, state leaders fell back on road building as their chief tool for economic development. Newspapers from around Philadelphia were spiked with glowing accounts of the Lancaster and Philadelphia Turnpike, and readers in far corners of Pennsylvania were fed broad hints that it might still reach across the mountains. One traveller who passed over the road after its completion observed that "There is, at present, but one turnpike road on the continent, which is between Lancaster and Philadelphia, a distance of sixty one miles, and it is a masterpiece of its kind; it is paved with stone the whole way, and overlaid with gravel, so that it is never obstructed during the most severe weather."²²

Opponents of public spending noted that it cost investors nearly half a million dollars for this modest improvement, and charged that it did not enhance economic prospects outside of a few counties in southeastern Pennsylvania. During these same years when road and canal projects sputtered around Philadelphia, a broad network of roads was opened westward from the settled parts of New York, Maryland, Virginia, and the Carolinas. At least 13,000 emigrants toiled over the old Forbes Road every year, but this

²² Ibid, 43.

figure quickly fell short of the tally on rival paths.²³

This unceasing migration to the western territories and the prospects for trade it created made Ohio a state in 1803 and forced federal authorities to consider their responsibilities to that region. Several bills had been introduced in Congress since the end of the Revolution for improving roads and waterways through the Appalachians. An alliance of Western delegates and eastern merchants rekindled this effort in response to the increasing exchange of people and goods across the mountains. A Congressional committee that was charged with looking into this matter submitted a report to President Jefferson in 1805. Members of the committee discovered that network of roads Maryland had already staked out leading westward from Baltimore and Washington and decided to start there.

Handing this bonus to their chief rival brought howls of protest

²³ Billington, Westward Expansion, 248-250; Stewart Holbrook, Yankee Exodus (New York, NY: The Macmillan Company, 1950), 17. Traffic on the Walton Road out of North Carolina was so dense in 1795 that wagons and horses pushed pedestrian traffic off the track and into the woodline. Contemporary observers guessed that 26,000 people passed over the rival Cumberland Road during just two months of good weather; near the end of 1795, Moses Austin encountered hundreds or even thousands of destitute travellers on the Cumberland Road during the worst parts of the year. Holbrook noted that more than 500 sleds passed through Albany for western New York in a single day during the winter of 1795-96.

and outrage from Pennsylvania. Jefferson was warned that slighting Pennsylvania would cost his party dearly in any coming elections and that some sort of accommodation was in order. Early plans showed a direct route to the Ohio River at Wheeling through Maryland and Virginia; these sketches were hurriedly altered so that the road curved up through the boroughs of Brownsville and Washington in southwestern Pennsylvania. Secretary of the Treasury Albert Gallatin voiced displeasure at the change, but admitted this was the best deal that could be made given "the conflict of local interests and the silent opposition of Philadelphia."²⁴

The merchants and politicians who ruled state affairs from Philadelphia were even less satisfied. This solution did not approach meeting their goals for improving western commerce and a rival state program of building roads was inaugurated. In order to win broad support and forestall old charges of favoritism, state leaders authorized the Uniontown and Cumberland Turnpike Company to carry the old Braddock Road from the Maryland line into southwestern Pennsylvania. Another firm was chartered at the request of Pittsburgh merchants to restore the old French Portage

²⁴ Durrenberger, Turnpikes, 48; Ferguson, Early Western Pennsylvania Politics, 255-56. Ferguson adds that opponents of the administration noted how this change brought the road close to Gallatin's own estates on the Monongahela, near Brownsville.

between Waterford and Lake Erie in the northwestern counties.²⁵ State leaders in Philadelphia were satisfied that projects fulfilled obligations to the western counties, and they hurriedly turned their attention back to the opposite end of the state. Several new roads were authorized between the Susquehanna and the Delaware through the remainder of 1804 and into the following year.²⁶

Plans for additional roads soon outstripped any genuine abilities to pay for them. To remedy this shortfall the legislature expanded their definition of "the public interest." A measure enacted in 1806 authorized the governor to purchase up to one fifth of all the stock in any given road company with public funds. Similar measures had already been enacted to aid the state banking industry in 1793, and again in 1803. With this precedent on the books, it was a short stretch to extend the policy into fields like transportation. In return for its largesse toward road companies, the state maintained rights to "participate in the profit and controul" of any highways completed with public funds.²⁷

A committee that was charged with drawing up these rules

²⁵ Durrenberger, Turnpikes, 54.

²⁶ Ibid, 54.

²⁷ Ibid, 97-98.

recommended against providing any additional funds for roads that were already finished or nearly done. Committee members wrote that too many of these roads had been drawn up without due regard for public needs, and only those "great leading roads" of general use should be aided."²⁸ By drifting toward a policy of selective funding, the Legislature virtually guaranteed that remote and poorly settled parts of Pennsylvania would stay on the margins of the state's commercial network.

One unforeseen consequence of this policy was that road building took off in Maryland. Farmers in southern and western counties of Pennsylvania had sent their produce to Baltimore for years, and the new roads were easily tapped into existing networks. One turnpike leading up to Conewago Falls was backed with funds from Maryland, and one of the chief merchants of Baltimore openly served as president of the company. Other lines were opened up through Hanover and Carlisle into the rich Cumberland Valley, and additional paths were improved around Gettysburg and westward toward Bedford and Somerset.²⁹ The chief road leading westward from Philadelphia boasted one tavern for wagon drivers and stage coach

²⁸ Louis Hartz, Economic Policy and Democratic Thought (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1948), 83.

²⁹ Livingood, Philadelphia-Baltimore Trade Rivalry, 49.

passengers on each mile out to Lancaster, but then branch lines drew traffic southward and business on the highway dropped off.³⁰ Loyal citizens of Philadelphia failed to realize the dilemma they had created for themselves until the new turnpikes were in use.

Road building in Pennsylvania suffered a temporary setback while Philadelphia merchants and their allies in the state government plotted how to respond. The ensuing round of spending on state highways was tacitly guided by progress on the National Road. In 1811, federal pursers released contracts for the first ten miles of the highway west of Cumberland, Maryland, and Pennsylvania answered with an appropriation of \$825,000 for state roads.³¹ Improving the old Forbes Road as the Philadelphia and Pittsburgh Turnpike (called the Pittsburgh and Philadelphia in Western Pennsylvania) was a centerpiece of the bill. Communities all over southwestern Pennsylvania welcomed the measure after fighting for years to secure what they considered their fair share of tax dollars.

Business promoters in Pittsburgh had suffered the same kinds of setbacks that plagued Philadelphia, but without the financial and political resources of that metropolis to fight back. Difficulties in getting passengers and freight over the Allegheny ridges to the

³⁰ Rouse, Great Wagon Road, 215.

³¹ Shank, Three Hundred Years, 50.

Forks of the Ohio had at once aided local development and cursed it. Pittsburgh had started on a course separate from either Philadelphia or the frontier counties in northwestern counties.

Traders and fortune hunters had drifted toward the Forks of the Ohio almost as soon as General Forbes bestowed the name of his patron on the ruined French works. The Philadelphia firm of Baynton, Wharton and Morgan had opened a boatyard by 1765, and sent hundreds of carpenters and laborers over the mountains to open trade with the British garrisons that were installed in the old French settlements along the Mississippi.³²

Settlers largely left the place to businessmen and the rough sorts of frontiersmen. Pittsburgh did not draw a resident population for several decades, and George Washington counted just two log houses besides traders' cabins and sheds during a visit in 1770.³³ John Wilkins, Sr., arrived more than a decade afterwards and found that "all sorts of wickedness were carried on to excess, and there was no appearance of morality or regular order." Wilkins added that "Presbyterian ministers were afraid to come to the

³² Leland Baldwin, Keelboat Age on Western Waters (Pittsburgh, PA: University of Pittsburgh Press, 1941), 8; Leland R. Johnson, Headwaters District (Pittsburgh, PA: United States Army Corps of Engineers, n.d.), 11.

³³ Wade, Urban Frontier, 10.

place, lest they should be mocked or mistreated." Another visitor in this era found Pittsburgh was infested with a "combination of pensioned Scoundrels" who made cheating visitors their business.³⁴

Pittsburgh labored under its rough frontier image for years, but at least one visitor in 1783 suggested that "However little to be regarded this place is now, from its advantageous site it must be that Pittsburgh will in the future become an important depot for the inland trade."³⁵ Settlers finally started building homes in discernible numbers when the threat of raids by the British and their Indian allies on the frontier subsided. According to one resident, the new arrivals "of 1785 and '86 were what was then considered rich." This appraisal was based on how they "introduced into the country large stocks of cattle, sheep and hogs, cleared large farms, built grist and saw mills, and gave employment to many poor settlers."³⁶ Census records from 1790 showed just 376 permanent residents, but within a decade the population increased fourfold to 1,565.³⁷

Commerce remained the staple economic activity of the town

³⁴ Leland Baldwin, Pittsburgh, Story of a City (Pittsburgh, PA: University of Pittsburgh Press, 1937), 104.

³⁵ Wade, Urban Frontier, 11.

³⁶ American Pioneer, volume II: 162.

³⁷ Wade, Urban Frontier, 11.

during this period of expansion. Traders based in Pittsburgh followed the United States Army through Indian negotiations and campaigns to open the western lands. Some went off on their own in search of additional customers. The firm of Duncan and Wilson started sending agents with canoes and pack trains loaded with trade goods up the Beaver River and on through the Mahoning toward the Cuyahoga and Detroit in 1786, years before the British turned that place over to the United States.³⁸

Opening the Northwest Territory and the far ends of the Ohio River out toward the Mississippi for settlement sparked boom conditions at Pittsburgh. Military garrisons and settlers from all over this great region became customers for all of the flour, bacon and whiskey that Pittsburgh could send out, besides trinkets from eastern ports. Old hands who faced hunger and hard times in Southwest Pennsylvania in 1784, were exporting a substantial agricultural surplus six years later. Competition became fierce, and marginal producers soon joined the emigrants heading downstream to seek better lands and new opportunities on crest of the frontier.³⁹

Because of the difficulties in getting over the Appalachians,

³⁸ Howe, Historical Collections of Ohio, volume II: 175-176.

³⁹ American Pioneer, volume II: 163.

western emigrants usually turned their disposable goods into cash back in the eastern counties before starting out.⁴⁰ Pittsburgh merchants discovered a lucrative market replacing these goods and forwarding any excess they could lay their hands on. Heavy freight was hauled up the old Braddock Road from Baltimore or over the Forbes Road from Philadelphia, and sold in local shops or started downstream. Boatbuilding flourished at Pittsburgh and its satellite towns, where rafts, flatboats and keelboats were turned out in support of this trade.⁴¹ Schooners and deep water craft were occasionally turned out after 1792, then started down the Ohio River toward the Mississippi and the Gulf of Mexico. Some of these vessels were observed in Philadelphia, New York, and several European ports.⁴²

These growing signs of success rapidly raised expectations. Most Pittsburgh merchants had started out as junior partners or contractors of firms based in Philadelphia, Baltimore, or some

⁴⁰ American Pioneer, volume II: 163.

⁴¹ Charles Henry Ambler, Transportation in the Ohio Valley (Glendale, CA: The Arthur H. Clark Company, 1932), 34; Johnson, Headwaters District, 33.

⁴² Baldwin, Keelboat Age on Western Waters, 161-174.

other eastern port.⁴³ With signs of new wealth in hand, they began making plans to increase profits and establish commercial independence. Hauling goods over the mountains was expensive, and there was almost nothing to send back the other way. It was cheaper to send most goods down the western rivers and out around Florida to eastern ports, than freight it back over the heights. Western businessmen soon realized the surest way to cut costs was through domestic manufacturing.⁴⁴

Local production stood to cut shipping costs, while bringing down the rates that eastern merchants demanded for comparable goods. Pittsburghers had already engaged in ventures like boatbuilding and barrel making in support of their commercial dealings. Cheap and seemingly limitless sources of coal and water power in the area easily suggested that greater efforts should prove profitable. Small manufactories were therefore turning out goods in iron, glass, paper, cloth and leather before the end of the century. An early attempt to open an iron furnace failed when

⁴³ James B. Walker, Experiences of Pioneer Life (Chicago, IL: Sumner & Co., 1881), 28. Walker mentioned that his grandfather worked in an early rolling mill and nailery in Pittsburgh that had been set up by Boston capitalists. Skilled positions were held by workmen who were sent from New England, while local men and boys served as apprentices and laborers.

⁴⁴ Baldwin, Pittsburgh, 138.

local supplies of ore gave out, but Pittsburgh easily slipped into the role of a secondary producer.⁴⁵ Furnaces proved more successful in isolated spots up the Monongahela River and tributaries of the Allegheny, and these shipped a steady supply of bars and ingots. By the time the War of 1812 erupted, Pittsburgh boasted dozens of different kinds of manufacturing plants and businesses."⁴⁶

That this kind of growth was achieved with local capital made it all the more remarkable. Manufacturing capabilities in Pittsburgh rapidly overshadowed expectations, although the good times were tempered with a certain uneasiness. What kept local merchants looking over their shoulders were myriad signs of growth and

⁴⁵ James M. Swank, History of the Manufacture of Iron in All Ages (Philadelphia, PA: American Iron and Steel Institute, 1892), 225-232.

⁴⁶ Buck and Buck, Planting of Civilization in Western Pennsylvania, 310-311; Wade, Urban Frontier, 43-48; Swank, History of the Manufacture of Iron, 213-224. Buck and Buck compiled a fairly lengthy list of the kinds of industries found in Pittsburgh at that time, including "brick yards, quarries, marble yards, potteries, and coal mines; sawmills, cooper shops, cabinet shops, and chair factories; tailor shops, hatteries, boot and shoe shops, stocking factories, glove shops, button factories, and comb factories; bakeries, breweries, distilleries, tobacco mills, and soap and candle factories; tanneries, saddlery shops, saddle-tree factories, wagon and carriage shops, and ropewalks; gold and silver smitheries, copper, brass, and tin works, and shot factories; printing presses, book binderies, and a playing card factory; white-lead factories, and flaxseed-oil mills;" along with a "chemical manufactory" and heavy industries relating to coal, iron and glass.

prosperity in rival communities. The inhabitants of Pittsburgh were not unique in pushing toward industrialization and self sufficiency.

Settlers pouring into Kentucky had likewise called for domestic manufacturing to reduce their own costs. Tax rolls for Kentucky listed dozens of flouring mills and distilleries for tax purposes by the end of the century, along with boatbuilders and establishments for making nails, shot, shoes, leather, cordage, linen, cigars and snuff, furniture, clocks, hats, stoves, mill-irons and kettles.⁴⁷ Tradesmen and merchants calling themselves the "Bourbon Association" magnified their push for self-determination in 1800, by calling for limits on imported goods. Items like woollens, linens, cotton fabrics, hats, shoes and saddles were not to be brought into the state, unless they were exchanged for other local products. Liquors were excused if intended for medicinal or religious uses. Supporters observing these guidelines were asked

⁴⁷ Harry Toulmin, The Western Country in 1793 (San Marino, CA: The Castle Press, 1948), 89-129; Arthur Preston Whitaker, The Mississippi Question, 1795-1803 (Gloucester, MA: Peter Smith, 1962), 18. Toulmin provides a first hand account of the earliest industrial development in Kentucky, while Whitaker picks up this theme in more recent times and expands it into surrounding areas. Whitaker observed that Tennessee was not far behind Kentucky in the drive for local manufacturing and boasted of several substantial iron works in this period. Five boats left Sumner County for the lower river markets in 1795 with loads of bacon, flour, cast iron and bars.

to attend "the raising of sheep, the cultivation of cotton, hemp, and flax, and home manufactures of all kinds."⁴⁸

Merchants at Pittsburgh had grown dependent on shipping goods and agricultural surplus downstream, and this kind of competition could only force prices down. Their best hope seemed to lay in drawing trade back the other way, and becoming a port of deposit for the lower Ohio Valley shipping goods eastward. River vessels known as keelboats were largely developed to meet this need.

Commerce on western rivers drew on a dazzling variety of craft including native canoes, larger European versions styled bateaux, rafts, and bulky floating boxes called flatboats.⁴⁹ Rafts and flatboats were used for a single trip downstream and then broken up for materials, where bateaux were intended for repeated trips. This label was indiscriminately applied to any type of small craft at times, although the vessels were broadly characterized as "ribbed and planked flatbottom boats" lacking a keel, and tapering in to a point at both ends. Some of the largest samples measuring up to 40 or 50 feet in length were outfitted with shelters, and could carry up to fifty tons of cargo with eighteen or twenty

⁴⁸ Whitaker, Mississippi Question, 19.

⁴⁹ Timothy Flint, Recollections of the Last Ten Years (Boston, MA: Hilliard and Company, 1826), 14-15; Wade, Urban Frontier, 41.

handlers.⁵⁰ Extra hands were carried when possible, since it was necessary to drag the boats through low waters or push against opposing currents with long oaken poles.⁵¹

Bateaux took a rough beating from the snags and obstructions that littered western waters on most trips, and boatbuilders began nailing keels on their bateaux sometime after the Revolution in response. This produced a new classification of river vessels called "keelboats," which was characterized by strong keels and heavy construction in which flat-bottomed hulls were ribbed and planked over. Sharp points rose up out of the water at either end to absorb the shock from collisions and break oncoming currents. Details were left to the boatbuilders, but most samples ranged between 40 and 80 feet in length, from 7 to 10 feet wide, and drew just 2 feet of water when fully loaded with up to 40 tons of freight. Distinctive styles of emerged that reflected their uses and point of origin. Boats from the upper Allegheny River were called "French Creekers, while miners working along the Monongahela River spoke of keelboats as coal boats and barges; across the

⁵⁰ Baldwin, Keelboat Age, 42; Johnson, Headwaters District, 9. Thirty bateaux that were launched at Fort Pitt during the American Revolution measured 40 feet long, 9 feet wide and 32 inches deep.

⁵¹ Flint, Recollections of the Last Ten Years, 16, 26.

mountains on the Susquehanna River they were called "arks."⁵²

Keelboats were launched from dozens of locations in Western Pennsylvania and adapted to every conceivable use for hauling freight or passengers. By 1805, some 50 keelboats were engaged in regular runs to Cincinnati and back, with an average capacity of 30 tons apiece. Three times this many boats were engaged over the full length of the Ohio River. A few were even placed in round trip service between Pittsburgh and New Orleans, covering 1,950 miles on each voyage.⁵³

Factories for manufacturing cotton goods, tobacco, rope, and baggage sprang up in Pittsburgh when the boats began dropping off

⁵² Wiley, Monongahela, the River and its Region, 180; Frost, Life in the Upper Susquehanna, 26. Frost describes a loose hull weighted with lumber as "half raft, half boat;" the term "ark" was probably a sweeping label applied to any bulky craft on the Susquehanna, much as open boats on the western waters were called bateaux.

⁵³ Baldwin, Keelboat Age, 178-179; Baldwin, Pittsburgh, 135, 139. Most of the boats were used for transporting freight, but passenger services were inaugurated in October, 1793 by Jacob Myers of Pittsburgh. Myers placed a pair of keelboats in operation between Pittsburgh and Cincinnati on a two week rotation, and later he added two more boats to provide weekly service. Passengers were offered room and board with liquor, sanitary facilities on board, and high bulwarks and arms to protect them from the threat of Indians lurking on the river banks. This scheme proved more ambitious than practical and it was abandoned about a year later. Emigrants stayed with their rafts and flatboats, and occasional travellers preferred making arrangements with individual boat owners.

raw materials up the western territories and the South.⁵⁴ All signs had pointed toward a prosperous future for Pittsburgh, so most inhabitants of the borough were shocked when they heard of proposals for the National Road. Concessions by national leaders to push the road through Southwestern Pennsylvania were bitterly denounced in Pittsburgh, since the planned route was still thirty miles away. Merchants who had declared their independence from Philadelphia just a few years back beseeched that city for help.

Politicians from Philadelphia and the southeastern counties finally looked across the mountains because it aided their battle against Baltimore. This unfolding spirit of cooperation between the sections emboldened western politicians and frontiersmen to press for a greater share in state government. They asked for a visible symbol of change, and overpowered Philadelphia with a decision to move the seat of government to a central location. Concerns for Pennsylvania roads were muted by a slow rate of construction on the National Road and a new eruption of sectional fighting in Pennsylvania.

Both houses of the state legislature had taken up residence outside of Philadelphia in 1799, at Lancaster. Given repeated calls to move the state capital every few years, Philadelphians

⁵⁴ Baldwin, Keelboat Age, 178; Baldwin, Pittsburgh, 139.

expected they would eventually reclaim this particular honor.⁵⁵ This desire accounts for at least a part of their free spending on roads in that direction. Most inhabitants of the city were therefore shocked when calls went up to move state government even further away to Harrisburg on the Susquehanna.

Newspaper editors and citizens in Philadelphia bitterly denounced the plan, and added charges that Baltimore merchants had engineered the vote in small towns across southern and western Pennsylvania. Critics of the move observed that Harrisburg was twenty-four miles closer to Baltimore than Philadelphia, and had certainly forged links with that city. Some believed that enemies of Philadelphia in the Pennsylvania legislature had deliberately embarked on a ruinous path "so as to promote the interests of another state" over their own. One newspaper columnist glumly noted that "About ten years ago, Philadelphia paid the highest amount of revenue into the treasury of the United States; but by the adoption of the present mistaken line of policy, which commenced about that time, New York exceeds her by some hundreds of thousands of dollars, and Baltimore is fast approaching to an

⁵⁵ William Henry Egle, History of the Counties of Dauphin and Lebanon (Philadelphia, PA: Everts & Peck, 1883), 312.

equality."⁵⁶

Calls to uphold tradition did not win much support outside of Philadelphia, and commissioners were named to secure a new home for the state government. Laws relating to this transfer were passed up through March 10, 1812, when clerks in the two houses of the legislature were instructed to start gathering up "all the papers, records, books, and documents belonging to each House, as aforesaid, together with whatever furniture may be thought for removal."⁵⁷

While Philadelphia tried to figure out how to respond to its disgrace and fading fortunes, Pittsburgh took off on another round of industrial expansion. When fighting erupted in the Old Northwest during the War of 1812, Pittsburgh was the nearest point where supplies and stores could be obtained. Purchasing agents for the army awarded dozens of contracts to local firms instead of their customary suppliers from eastern cities in order to reduce the time in transit and the costs of shipping.⁵⁸ Finding workers

⁵⁶ Livingood, Philadelphia-Baltimore Trade Rivalry, 51.

⁵⁷ Egle, History of the Counties of Dauphin and Lebanon, 315.

⁵⁸ Catherine Elizabeth Reiser, Pittsburgh's Commercial Development (Harrisburg, PA: Pennsylvania Historical and Museum Commission, 1951), 18.

to fill these contracts was not a problem. Hundreds of emigrants who had planned to go down the Ohio River and westward, halted at Pittsburgh when they heard of the fighting and began looking for work.

Manufacturing in Pittsburgh exceeded any reasonable expectations of growth, while other parts of the state fell behind. Northwest Pennsylvania and Philadelphia were diverted from thoughts of commerce and internal improvements by real threats of invasion. Commodore Perry's victory in the battle of Lake Erie did not stem British raids across Lake Erie, and the United States Navy was nearly swept from American shores by superior numbers of British warships. An increased presence of enemy ships off the eastern shores during the late months of the war and the burning of Washington ultimately forced Philadelphia to spend tens of thousands of dollars for defense.⁵⁹

Merchants who had relied on coastal shipping before the war started, were forced to seek safer if more expensive routes for moving their goods on interior waterways. Cargoes were packed overland to New Orleans and other ports on the lower Mississippi, where they were loaded on keelboats for the long trip upstream.

⁵⁹ James A. Kehl, Ill Feeling in the Era of Good Feeling (Pittsburgh, PA: University of Pittsburgh Press, 1956), 3.

Pittsburgh served as a major point for redistributing these products to eastern ports that were under blockade.⁶⁰

Goods valued up to four million dollars passed through Pittsburgh in 1813, and wagonmasters recorded more than four thousand trips over the mountains toward eastern ports closed by the war. In the next year, the Pittsburgh firm of Bosler and Company handled 275 tons of merchandise from New Orleans during the shipping season between April 1 and September 1, 1814.⁶¹ More than 5,800 wagons still started out of the city with western goods in 1815, but the boom times were clearly drawing to a close. Businesses all over the city scaled back their operations as work orders for the government dried up, and some ceased their activities entirely.⁶²

Pittsburgh civic leaders and businessmen had revelled in the

⁶⁰ Wade, Urban Frontier, 40.

⁶¹ Bosler and Company is mentioned by Baldwin, Pittsburgh: the Story of A City, 141; and Keelboat Age on Western Waters, 184. Reference to the full volume of trade through Pittsburgh in this period is found in Flint, History and Geography of the Mississippi Valley (Cincinnati, OH: E.H. Flint and L.R. Lincoln, 1832), 427-428. Flint visited Pittsburgh in later years and wrote that "So long ago as 1814, 4,055 wagons of four and six horses, employed, as transport wagons, passed between this place and Philadelphia."

⁶² Walker, Experiences of Pioneer Life, 32; Reiser, Pittsburgh's Commercial Development, 20.

high profits and good times that came their way during the war, and common hands in the factories saw their paychecks rise at an unprecedented rate. Community boosters talked of becoming the chief city in Pennsylvania and insisted on nothing less than reciprocal trade agreements with eastern ports.⁶³

Philadelphia businessmen were still smarting over losses to Baltimore in the western territories and a drop in foreign trade during the War of 1812. They refused to make any arrangement that appeared to diminish their status even further. Chances for building a unified state government in Pennsylvania fell apart when the fighting ended and eastern merchants refused to add tariff protections to the "war born" industries of the western counties.⁶⁴

Failure to develop a market economy

This conflict between the major political and market centers of Pennsylvania was a crushing blow for hopes of development in the northwestern counties. Concern for securing land titles had consumed the squatters and land agents in Northwest Pennsylvania, diverting attention and resources from matters of public improvements and economic development. Neither side had been

⁶³ Reiser, Pittsburgh's Commercial Development, 20.

⁶⁴ Kehl, Ill Feeling in the Era of Good Feeling, 66.

willing to invest in questionable titles that the courts might strip away from them.⁶⁵

Promises that were made to lure tenants toward company owned lands were carefully worded to avoid making firm guarantees. The directors of the North American Land Company only allocated their field agents in Pennsylvania \$600 to open roads, "if necessary and useful to settlers;" up to seven workmen might also be hired to cut timber and aid settlers in erecting houses and barns.⁶⁴ This measure was adopted by business managers for the Holland Land Company and the Pennsylvania Population Company, who added \$250 for encouraging "useful Mechanics to Settle" on company lands. However, agents overseeing work in the new settlements were warned to carefully weigh these amounts against real need.

Everyone connected with the offices of the Holland Land Company agreed it was better to spend their funds in western New York where their claims were more certain. Depositions filed in state courts eventually claimed expenses of \$400,000 in Northwest Pennsylvania, but extant records indicate only a minor share went toward material improvements. Just \$5,000 was spent in 1794 and 1795 to build a storehouse at Mead's settlement (and this structure was then used

⁶⁵ Tiffany, Harm Jan Huidekoper, 113.

⁶⁴ North American Land Company, Plan of Association, 3-5.

as an office and depot to advance \$22,000 worth of tools and supplies to settlers on credit). Nearly \$60,000 marked for "improvements" in 1797 was actually used to pay legal fees relating to court cases over land rights. Expenditures were cut in half the following year when the company finally authorized building mills and roads for the settlers.⁶⁵ These improvements were of course located where the speculators wanted to promote sales.⁶⁶

One settler who took lands on the fringe of Northwest Pennsylvania in Potter County was forced to cross the mountains into the Susquehanna watershed for basic amenities. Flour was obtained at Jersey Shore in Lycoming County. By his reckoning, this settler "crossed Pine Creek eighty times going to, and eighty times coming from mill, was gone eighteen days, broke two axle-trees to my wagon, upset twice, and one wheel came off in crossing the creek."⁶⁷

⁶⁵ Evans, Harm Jan Huidekoper, 107. Officials of the Holland Land Company eventually claimed expenses of \$400,000 in Northwest Pennsylvania through the first decade of the nineteenth century. The majority of funds were only released in later years when company officials were desperate to dispose of their holdings.

⁶⁶ Sanford, History of Erie County, 107-108.

⁶⁷ Buck and Buck, Planting of Civilization in Western Pennsylvania, 216-217. The primitive conditions in this part of Northwest Pennsylvania during this period are depicted in Philip Tome, Pioneer Life, or Thirty Years a Hunter (Harrisburg, PA:

Harm Jan Huidekoper wrote his superiors in the Holland Land Company that "everyone seemed determined to have as little at stake as possible" until the courts decided who really owned the land. As a result, he observed "The West Allegheny country, with a soil which in point of quality is inferior [to] no body of land of the same dimension in the state, offers a picture of wretchedness which I have never seen equalled in America." Log cabins on the company lands were "shabby" and surrounded by fields that were smaller and more slovenly than any he had seen in other parts of Pennsylvania and neighboring states.⁶⁸

Close observations revealed it was not just the aesthetics of the frontier settlements that was suffering. Settlers were found in tatters and half-starved for want of decent food. Few oxen or horses were found to till the soil, leaving farmers on the company lands around Meadville to scratch at the surface of their fields with hoes. The resulting crops barely lasted half the year and pushed prices past a tolerable level for the remaining six months. Wheat sold in Meadville at double the going rate in western New York just two months after the harvest.

Some of these inflationary pressures might have been reduced if

Aurand Press, 1928; Salem, NH: Ayer Company, 1989).

⁶⁸ Tiffany, Harm Jan Huidekoper, 113.

farmers in outlying areas had been able to get their crops into town. Small clusters of settlement that began cropping up across Northwest Pennsylvania were characterized by weak markets with "no buyers." Cash starved settlers were selling agricultural products at half their cost in labor when they were able to do so. One early pioneer in Crawford County raised a crop of potatoes, but could not find anyone willing to take them for either cash or trade.⁶⁹

Settlers on parts of Northwest Pennsylvania saw their situation worsen by the day while the land companies and politicians argued over who owned the deeds. Agents for the land companies were not authorized to mount relief efforts by their superior officers or stockholders until this matter was settled. Officials in the fledgling county governments on the other side of the battle appeared uncertain about dispensing public funds for the same reason; public law in Pennsylvania was clear that public funds should not be used to fund private developments.

Settlers were growing desperate and tried to force either side into action without much success. Seven separate petitions were filed at the first session of the Beaver County court in February,

⁶⁹ Riesenman, History of Northwestern Pennsylvania, 282; Sanford, History of Erie County, 274.

1804, asking for better roads. Public figures politely reviewed the appeals, but postponed any decision until question of land ownership was resolved.⁷⁰ A public highway that was eventually opened between New Castle and the Shenango River was so cluttered with rocks and precipitous drops that it was hardly passable for pedestrians until after the War of 1812. Wagonmasters knew better than to even try it.⁷¹

Numerous tracts were given up by disgusted and hungry tenants while legal proceedings dragged along. Old hands in Northwest Pennsylvania watched their new neighbors start down French Creek and the Allegheny River toward the Ohio, while others skipped across the state line toward Moses Cleaveland's settlement on the Cuyahoga. These refugees spread wild tales of their ill treatment at every stop, and the high prices quoted for land seemed to confirm some of the worst excesses. Newspapers were rife with notices of ejectment proceedings and sheriff's sales all across the region.

Hard times were only aggravated by the Supreme Court decision favoring the land companies in 1805. Speculators saw little reason

⁷⁰ Warner & Co., History of Beaver County, 146.

⁷¹ Hazen, 20th Century History of New Castle and Lawrence County, 60.

to try and accommodate their tenants with this ruling behind them, and all of their efforts turned toward increasing profits. Huidekoper wrote his employers that he would treat the intruders like "any other strangers that applied to me for land," but wondered if they should pay a higher price to reflect the illegal improvements they had made on their tracts.⁷²

Squatters who came to the land companies with hopes of a lenient settlement were sorely disappointed. Huidekoper argued that their resistance should not be rewarded with gratuities and lower rates than those given to loyal company settlers. Any arrangements made in 1805 and after, held more oppressive terms than could have been had a year earlier. Land prices went up to three dollars an acre in some localities, and Huidekoper tallied \$13,500 in new sales agreements within a month of getting news of the Supreme Court's decision from Washington.⁷³

Politicians from the western counties could not rescue the settlers from this dilemma, but they did take steps to check the influence of the speculators. Beaver County, Mercer County and Erie County were all organized in 1803, providing a slew of public office holders sympathetic to settlers and loyal to the state

⁷² Tiffany, Huidekoper, 120.

⁷³ Evans, Holland Land Company, 166.

authorities. McKean and Potter counties were created on the fringes of Northwest Pennsylvania in 1804, followed by Armstrong County and Venango County the following year.⁷⁴ Most lands still held in the public trust were opened for sale at discounted prices once these new county governments were in place. Public officials in each jurisdiction were given full authority to make the arrangements and agents representing the speculators found they could not enlist enough loyal settlers to counter this threat. Small farmers often found it cheaper to buy new lands from civil authorities than keep up one sided arrangements with the speculators. The biggest landholders found there just were not enough settlers to make up the losses.

Some 210,000 people lived in Western Pennsylvania according to the Census of 1810. At least sixty percent of these people lived in the five southwestern counties, with another fourteen percent in the mountain districts further eastward. Just over a quarter of the total population was therefore scattered across Northwest Pennsylvania and into the mountains reaching up to the northern state line.

Beaver County headed the list with 12,168 residents, but the

⁷⁴ Buck and Buck, Planting of Civilization in Western Pennsylvania, 214.

numbers trailed off with distance from the Ohio River. Mercer came in next with 8,000 inhabitants, and Butler followed with a thousand less; Crawford, Armstrong and Indiana counted about six thousand settlers apiece, while Erie tallied four thousand. Comparative figures showed further reductions in the higher elevations on the eastern edges of the region. Venango County had just three thousand residents, while Warren and Clearfield had between eight and nine hundred each. Jefferson and McKean trailed with about two hundred inhabitants in each county, and Potter County came in last with the diminutive total of just twenty-nine permanent settlers.⁷⁵

Their inability to control these settlers or promote economic development finally spelled the end for the speculators. The directors of the North American Land Company assembled in Philadelphia on New Year's eve in 1806, and determined that business in this region "cannot be conducted in the manner marked out in the articles of agreement and association." A board of five managers was then vested with "full unlimited, and uncontrolled powers to barter, sell, or convey all or any part of the land or property of the said company, on whatever terms and conditions they

⁷⁵ Buck and Buck, Planting of Civilization in Western Pennsylvania, 215.

may judge fit."⁷⁶

The governing body of the Holland Land Company reached a similar conclusion within three years and decided to cease operations in Northwest Pennsylvania. Harm Jan Huidekoper was ordered to close the land office at Meadville and visit Philadelphia to help arrange the terms of sale. With their two chief competitors bailing out of the region, share holders in the Pennsylvania Population Company saw little reason they should fight on. Although they claimed certain rights for decades afterwards, the three chief land companies ceased operations by the time the War of 1812 erupted. Their retreat from active affairs in Northwest Pennsylvania did not alter the picture of wretchedness. Courtroom victories for the speculators had not loosened their purse strings for public projects and no one appeared to pick up the difference. Meadville did not see a boom in real estate or new constructions for more than a century.⁷⁷

Boating on French Creek provided one of the few bright spots in this depressed economy. Soldiers from French Canada, Britain, and

⁷⁶ Memo of James Greenleaf, Secretary of the North American Land Company, December 31, 1806; attached to Plan of Association of the North American Land Company, Crawford County Historical Society.

⁷⁷ Tribune Republican, Meadville, G-35.

the United states had successively cleared passages through the debris and driftwood that perennially choked the stream. Public figures in Pennsylvania had lent their support by declaring French Creek a public highway in 1791, and allowing \$400 for improvements. Not much real work was accomplished, but seasonal flooding usually rose over the obstructions. General Mead and his followers had been drawn to the area through a combination of the good bottomlands along French Creek and access to that stream. These families were building crude barges on the banks of French Creek for the downstream trade before the end of the eighteenth century.⁷⁸

Poor farmers lacking spare produce to send along could still make a few extra dollars by shipping the trees they cut down clearing new farmland. Northwest Pennsylvania was rich in valuable building timbers, and logs bound for the sawmills at Pittsburgh made up a heavy share of the early traffic downstream.⁷⁹ Michael McKinney of Warren claimed in later years that he had inaugurated the lumber trade in Northwest Pennsylvania back in 1787, by taking a raft of logs down to Pittsburgh. Other claimants for this honor

⁷⁸ Tribune Republican, Meadville, 0-8.

⁷⁹ Sargent, Pioneer Sketches, 72-73, 285; Sanford, History of Erie County, 342-343.

include Seneca Indians from the Cornplanter reservation who signed a contract to supply the garrison at Fort Franklin with building timber in the same year.⁸⁰

No matter who started this boom, families and individuals began swarming up the Allegheny River to stake out timber lands. Others came over through the Holland Land Company grants in western New York. Rafts of felled trees and single trunks started drifting down from the upper end of the Allegheny in ever increasing numbers. Because of their similar circumstances on the upper waters, communities in New York like Olean and Jamestown began forging ties with Northwest Pennsylvania.

Besides increasing the volume of timber moving downstream, opening this avenue of commerce introduced salt into the local economy. Salt was vital for storing meat and other commodities before the advent of modern preservatives and refrigeration. After taking in their harvest in the fall, western settlers formed companies to travel over the mountains and procure this commodity. Opening western New York for settlement and trade introduced sources of salt closer to home. When federal troops moved into the Great Lakes country after 1795, General James O'Hara of Pittsburgh

⁸⁰ Serepta Kussart, Allegheny River (Pittsburgh, PA: Burgum Printing Company, 1938), 91.

won the government contract to supply the garrison at Oswego. Military contractors had always bought their supplies in eastern markets, but O'Hara hoped to develop local sources and reduce transportation costs since the Onondaga Saline was located just forty miles from the fort. Salt had been produced at a small and steady level here since 1788, but the works were significantly expanded under O'Hara. Several furnaces were installed for boiling brine, and a town named Salinas (Syracuse) was expressly founded to support the operations.⁸¹

Once the garrison at Oswego was fully supplied each year, any excess production was placed in barrels and started on a laborious trip toward the western settlements. After passing down Lake Ontario, each shipment was unloaded and carried in ox carts around Niagara Falls to Chippewa on the Canadian side, and then shipped over Lake Erie to Presque Isle. Once back ashore, the salt barrels were hauled over the old French Portage to LeBouef, then shipped down French Creek and the Allegheny River to Pittsburgh and the Ohio Valley. Waterford, Pennsylvania, grew up around the old Fort at LeBouef as a point for transferring barrels of salt from wagons to boats. The first large structures ever erected in Waterford

⁸¹ John Allais Jakle, Salt and the Initial Settlement of the Ohio Valley, (Indiana University, Ph.D. dissertation: 1967), 136-137.

were warehouses to store the salt until French Creek rose enough for boating.⁸²

Inhabitants of Meadville were treated to the spectacle of "Eleven flat bottomed and six keel boats loaded with salt" passing down French Creek near the end of 1803. Each of the flatboats was packed with 170 barrels, while the keelboats carried 60 barrels apiece, for a total of 2,230 barrels in this one shipment. According to the records of the federal revenue collector at Presque Isle, "it appears that the quantity of salt imported in 1800 was 714 barrels, 329 in 1801, 854 in 1802, 2,743 in 1803, 3,600 in 1804, and 6,659 in 1805."⁸³

These large increases in volume quickly overwhelmed local capabilities for moving it on. Presque Isle lacked the most rudimentary dock or harbor facilities, and every barrel had to be rowed in to the beach from the lake carriers. Once ashore, they were carted up over the bluffs and sent on the old French Portage toward the head of navigation at LeBouef. Teamsters complained of delays and damages to their wagons and cargoes because of the poor condition of the road. Most of the salt was destined for

⁸² Day, Historical Collections, 86; cited in Sanford, History of Erie County, 108-110, 252.

⁸³ Sanford, History of Erie County, 108-109; Jakle, Salt and the Initial Settlement of the Ohio Valley, 139.

warehouses at Pittsburgh, where merchants were saddled with surcharges for damaged wagons and time in transit. In a bid to bring their own costs down, Pittsburgh businessmen used their influence in the state legislature to enact a bill for the construction of the Erie and Waterford Turnpike.⁸⁴ Subscription books were opened at Pittsburgh and Meadville, but the year passed and full funding was not secured. Investors fretted that the salt industry had peaked, and there would not be enough additional trade to justify the expenses. Increased production at the salines was balanced by additional settlers moving into western New York.

Officers for the Waterford and Erie Turnpike Company were finally elected in the summer of 1806, but this action failed to stir up much enthusiasm or new subscribers. Much of the initial stock offering had been taken in the belief that the state would lend its support to the project, and stockholders began to back away once it became clear they would have to bear the full cost of the turnpike. On October 2, 1806, the governing board of the company served public notice "THAT suits will be commenced against all stockholders in Erie and Waterford turnpike road company, who shall not have made the first payment of six dollars on each share before the first day of November next." Contractors holding work

⁸⁴ Crawford Weekly Messenger, January 2, 1805: p4c3.

orders for the roadway were advised they would be paid out of these funds.⁸⁵

Prospects for finishing the roadway buoyed hopes of commercial development in the upper counties. This was one of the chief concerns behind the organization of the Meadville Society for the Encouragement of Domestic Manufactures and the Useful Arts in 1807. Members of that body warned their fellow citizens against uneasiness over "the scarcity of money, as if it were the cause, and not the effect, of our condition," and proposed industrialization as a remedy. In their eyes, the any hopes for drawing capital into the region were doomed to failure "if industry and public spirit be wanting; for it is upon the internal industry and improvement of the country that our wealth and independence must rest."⁸⁶

The local business climate had not materially changed since the end of the Northwest Indian wars more than a decade earlier.

⁸⁵ Reynolds, In French Creek Valley, 265.

⁸⁶ Crawford Messenger, February 5, 1807: p3c1; Reynolds, In French Creek Valley, 85. Residents of Crawford County relied on a barter economy into the 1830s owing to a scarcity of cash. The owners of the Jackson and Wolf Foundry indicated they "Mostly bartered for country produce" in responding to a federal survey of industrial development in 1832; see Documents Relative to the Manufactures in the United States (New York: Burt Franklin, 1969), 268.

Business leaders at Meadville in 1807, found it "melancholy to relate, that except the manufacture of whiskey, a few hats, a little coarse linen and leather, we are entirely without manufactures." Metal goods, paper, clothing, "hemp, oil, beer, porter, with numbers of other articles" still had to be carried into the region, and there were few signs that anything would change soon.⁸⁷ According to the census of 1810, Crawford County had just 6,150 inhabitants scattered in farms and hamlets over its entire territory. Most residents gave their primary occupation as farming, and figures for taxable goods seems to confirm this. Public records for the year list 2,142 horses and 5,389 cows, with 4,120 sheep.⁸⁸

Manufacturing cloth represented the single largest pursuit outside of farming. There were 934 spinning wheels in Crawford County at this time (or one for every 6.5 inhabitants), and 313 looms. Out of the county residents listing an occupation in 1810, there were 347 weavers (166 males and 181 females) or one weaver for every 18 people. The total production of textiles for the year worked out to 12 yards of linen, wool or cotton cloth for every

⁸⁷ Ibid.

⁸⁸ Ferguson, Early Western Pennsylvania Politics, 218.

single county resident.⁸⁹

Craftsmen and home industry provided a basis for cultivating manufacturing interests, but there was still a nagging question of developing ties to larger markets. Subscribers to the Meadville Society for the Encouragement of Domestic Manufactures and the Useful Arts predicted that: "being Remotely situated from a market for our produce and bulky materials, the price of carriage would diminish the value of labour, and create a competition which we could not withstand, if even we were in a situation to attempt it."⁹⁰

State figures stepped in with a modest appropriation for roadwork during the winter of 1806-07, but only to cover charges of sectional favoritism while they channelled thousands of dollars into highway improvements around Philadelphia. The amounts set aside for the northwestern counties were barely adequate to clear old trails of fresh vegetation. Just \$400 was provided for improving the road from Pittsburgh to Butler, with \$600 to continue on Meadville, and another \$400 to reach the shores of Lake Erie. An additional \$400 was slated for work between Meadville and

⁸⁹ Ibid; Reynolds, In French Creek Valley, 97.

⁹⁰ Crawford Weekly Messenger, December 5, 1807: Reynolds, In French Creek Valley: 85-86.

Franklin.⁹¹ Since French Creek supplied a valuable link between several of these points during the boating season, state authorities added another \$500 from land sales in Erie County to improve navigation.⁹²

Finishing the Waterford and Erie turnpike in 1809, seemed to clear the state of charges that it had neglected Northwest Pennsylvania. Unfortunately, the regional economic problems had grown beyond the simple remedy of one decent road. Bringing goods up the Allegheny River to Franklin usually took four or five days, with the return trip taking about half as long. Bringing wagons into the region did not materially alter this time schedule. A round trip by wagon might only take four days under the best of circumstances, but it usually required at least double that time.⁹³

Dozens of roadways had been added to the map of Northwest Pennsylvania, but without any practical effect. Few of them were anything more than the primitive trails that had troubled the earliest settlers.⁹⁴ State authorities recognized how difficult it

⁹¹ Sanford, History of Erie County, 181; Reynolds, In French Creek Valley, 267.

⁹² Sanford, Histry of Erie County, 181; Johnson, Headwaters District, 45.

⁹³ Riesenman, History of Northwestern Pennsylvania, 282.

⁹⁴ Sanford, History of Erie County, 108.

was getting around Northwest Pennsylvania in 1810 when they allocated another \$2,000 for freeing French Creek from its latest collection of driftwood and snags.⁹⁵

Meaningful chances of expanding the regional economy soon faltered along with the fortunes of the Waterford and Erie Turnpike. Investors earned modest profits during the first few years of operations, but then repairs and maintenance costs began to absorb an increasingly larger share of revenues. Local farmers objected to paying tolls all along, and sought ways around the toll gates. A parallel path that became known as the "Shunpike" was then carved out of the forest and held out for free use.

Competition and complaints against the toll road were compounded by a decline in the regional salt trade. New sources of brine were being tapped along the Kiskiminetas River in Western Pennsylvania and the Kanawha River in western Virginia before the War of 1812, reducing the need to haul large amounts of processed salt down from the Great Lakes.⁹⁶ Production increased at the Onondaga works during this decade, but freight haulers in Northwest Pennsylvania

⁹⁵ Johnson, Headwaters District, 45.

⁹⁶ Day, Historical Collections, 376; Flint, Recollections of the Last Ten Years: 25-26. Salt works were also started in Kentucky at an early date; see Toulmin, The Western Country in 1793: 104.

did not reap an increase in their business. Their declining profits reflected an ominous trend settling over the entire area.⁹⁷

Merchants and farmers all across Northwestern Pennsylvania began feeling the pinch from increased competition, not just in the salt trade. As the edge of settlement shifted ever westward, new towns cropped up. Each of these settlements began drawing in its own regional produce, and sending it downstream toward pioneer settlements. Nearly any small run or tributary joining the Monongahela, Kanawha, Cumberland, or half a dozen other major rivers became points launching trips toward western markets.⁹⁸ This pattern left the inhabitants of Northwest Pennsylvania at the tail end of an expanding base of supplies going into the second decade of the nineteenth century. Shippers from the Allegheny watershed had to send their raw materials and manufactured goods further and at greater cost than their competition, just to reach a glutted market. Trips downstream became longer and longer in search of customers. In 1806, Samuel B. Magaw of Meadville steered into New Orleans with four flat boats carrying one hundred tons of flour,

⁹⁷ Sanford, History of Erie County, 182. Sanford cites a final shipment of 400 barrels sent over the Portage in 1819.

⁹⁸ Flint, Recollections of the Last Ten Years, 23.

lumber and butter.⁹⁹

Unloading cargoes at New Orleans might have been a plan worked out ahead of time, but for many shippers it proved a last (and desperate) resort. Boat captains just could not sell their cargoes anywhere else, and took any price at this last port of call.

Disposable goods on the boats like blankets and cookware were sold off to raise additional funds, and the deck hands were discharged and paid off as quick as possible.¹⁰⁰ In order to save something of their meager pay, the boatmen often walked home. While some of their companions took passage around Florida to Atlantic ports, most waited in the lower ports until enough bodies had gathered to ensure a degree of safety and assistance in the event of sickness or injury. They elected officers when the time to start home arrived, passed out arms, and tramped off in loose military order. Men dropped off the march at their homes all the way up the rivers, until only a few souls were left going up trails along the

⁹⁹ Johnson, Headwaters District, 45.

¹⁰⁰ See the letters of C.W. Thomas Thompson, Crawford County Historical Society. This small collection of 5 letters includes letters of introduction and instructions for Thompson from Edward Work and Dr. T.R. Kennedy of Meadville. Thompson took a load of lumber down to Natchez and New Orleans on their behalf and found it difficult make a sale because of the saturated market.

Allegheny River to places like Meadville and Warren.¹⁰¹

Profits from these trips did not do much to alter the financial climate in Northwest Pennsylvania. A few families increased their personal fortunes, but they lagged behind other parts of Pennsylvania in raising their political influence or any abilities to draw tax dollars for improvements. When federal naval contractors who were dispatched to Presque Isle during the War of 1812, they wrote how backward and isolated the area appeared. Nearly everything they needed to build ships outside of timber had to be hauled in from Pittsburgh or Buffalo, and more distant points. When shipments of iron failed to arrive on time, blacksmiths had to fashion spikes and nails from any scraps that could be rounded up between the lake shore and Pittsburgh. One of the chief builders wrote that "The government was to send iron ... but the roads were so bad that I had almost finished the fleet before any arrived at Erie."¹⁰²

Conclusion

¹⁰¹ American Pioneer, volume II: 163-164; Sanford, History of Erie County, 343-344.

¹⁰² Max Rosenberg, The Building of Perry's Fleet on Lake Erie (Harrisburg, PA: Pennsylvania Historical and Museum Commission, 1974): 38.

Pennsylvania had entered the nineteenth century as a discordant collection of geographic provinces, and counties lying in each section actively pursued their own interests. On those occasions when politicians talked of making statewide improvements, the proposal was always geared toward their home section. Settlers in Northwest Pennsylvania were too far removed from these battles to garner much interest from their state leaders, and they lacked the clout to call on them for favors. Northwest Pennsylvania stayed in the grip of speculators who had found friends and business partners in the state government. Economic development subsequently lagged behind other parts of Pennsylvania by several years.

Philadelphia stood alone as the dominant city of Pennsylvania and seized the initiative in promoting public policy for its own ends. Baltimore was exerting a growing influence in regional affairs and the business leaders who dominated the city government of Philadelphia (and the state government of Pennsylvania) were consumed with maintaining a competitive edge. This produced unequal distributions of tax dollars for public improvements in Pennsylvania and fueled rivalries with Pittsburgh. Counties sitting across the Appalachians retaliated in any manner they could, which hampered additional spending and any real hopes of crafting a unified system of roads or canals benefitting the entire

state. Pittsburgh merchants crafted their own identity during these political battles and sought to find advantages over their rivals in the eastern end of Pennsylvania. Contemporary transportation capabilities directed Pittsburgh interests down the Ohio River and westward.

Chapter 3:

SECTIONAL POLITICS AND THE TRANSPORTATION QUESTION IN

PENNSYLVANIA, 1815 - 1827

Sectional bias was an established element of Pennsylvania politics when the greater western territories were thrown open for settlement after the War of 1812. Speculators and settlers swarmed westward, but Pennsylvania merchants and shippers found they could not compete for their business. State politicians answered their cries for assistance with a hurried campaign to extend roads into all parts of Pennsylvania and rebuild old highways that suffered from neglect. This effort was largely guided by the merchants and politicians from Philadelphia, so the lion's share of funds were directed into the southeastern counties. Thousands of tax dollars were spent trying to check the ambitions of speculators and merchants from Maryland and northern Virginia. They enlisted federal support for building public roads and freely talked of gaining control over the Ohio River and expanding their interests into the Northwest Territory and the Great Lakes.

Pennsylvania appeared to gain the upper hand in this struggle by opening competitive works, but state leaders failed to contain the sectional conflict inside their own boundaries. Cooperation

toward extending better roads into all parts of Pennsylvania fell apart and each section of the state fell back on its own local concerns. Pennsylvania politicians were finally forced to acknowledge their lack of discipline when New York opened the Erie Canal and inaugurated a new era of regional competition for trade. Virginia, Maryland and Ohio. Enthusiasm for building canals swept over state boundaries and Virginia, Maryland and Ohio launched imitative programs.

Politicians and business leaders in Philadelphia and Pittsburgh decided to follow along in spite of questions whether this was appropriate for a state where the terrain was so broken by mountains and haphazard stream patterns. Policy makers in these commercial centers of Pennsylvania set aside their rivalries and asked broad support for what was certain to be a costly undertaking. Northwest Pennsylvania and marginal sections of Pennsylvania were accorded a new sense of importance by state leaders from Philadelphia and Pittsburgh in their bid to gain support for a canal.

Tax dollars and sectional rivalries

Merchants in Pittsburgh and Philadelphia temporarily put their feud aside after the War of 1812 in order to meet their common

enemy. Work on the National Road had slowed during the fighting, but that project was finally closing on the Ohio River at Wheeling. Every mile that was finished jeopardized commercial activities in both ends of Pennsylvania. Philadelphia could not afford to let Baltimore steal any more of its western trade, and Pittsburgh started suffering from the kinds of defections that had plagued Philadelphia for decades.¹

Communities in Southwestern Pennsylvania that had relied on Pittsburgh for guidance began charting their own fortunes once they had access to the National Road. Down at Brownsville where the National Road crossed the Monongahela River, merchants and politicians began promoting their town as the head of navigation instead of Pittsburgh.² Further westward on the National Road, the borough of Washington anticipated great profits through the "wonderful magic of the Cumberland Road." Landlords talked of selling individual lots along the highway for \$5,000 or \$6,000, while farmers and tradesmen expected up to twenty-five percent more for their farm produce and other goods. Complaints of ingratitude

¹ Wade, Urban Frontier, 178-179.

² William Cooper Howell, Recollections of Life in Ohio (Cincinnati, OH: The Robert Clarke Company, 1895), 9-11; Kehl, Ill Feeling in the Era of Good Feeling: 67-68. Howell described his family's passage over the National Road to Brownsville in 1813, where his family took boats for the West.

from Pittsburgh were dismissed as "local jealousy."³

Communities on the Ohio River below Pittsburgh added smug voices to this chorus as work on the National Road continued. Westerners had complained for years they were mistreated at the head of the Ohio River, and they welcomed any chance to get even. Many frontiersmen believed a rumor that Pittsburgh was peopled at an early date by shady sorts who only took up residence to take advantage of the emigrants coming behind them.⁴ Newspapers from Wheeling down through Cincinnati reported every complaint out of Pittsburgh with the same enthusiasm they used to promote local achievements.⁵ One editor in Wheeling openly warned Pittsburgh that "Your day is over, the scepter of influence and wealth is to travel to us."⁶

Talk in the streets and taverns around Pittsburgh placed much of the blame for this distressing shift of fortune on other parts of

³ Kehl, Ill Feeling in the Era of Good Feeling, 67-68.

⁴ Flint, Recollections of the Last Ten Years, 18-19; History and Geography of the Mississippi Valley: 428. When this second work was published in 1832, Flint had only softened his views a bit from his earlier visit to Pittsburgh. He wrote that "The habits of the people of the place are those of persevering industry, calculating carefulness, distrust of strangers, and a fixed purpose to look to their individual interests."

⁵ Kehl, Ill Feeling in the Era of Good Feeling, 43.

⁶ Baldwin, Pittsburgh, 184.

Pennsylvania. Settlers in Ohio and other Westerners could hardly be blamed for trying to better their lot, but Pittsburghers believed their ambitions might have been curbed by concerted action in their own state. Philadelphia seemed to abandon the rest of Pennsylvania trying to win concessions from Baltimore. Citizens of Pittsburgh readily believed gossip that a businessman in Philadelphia had declared it "much better for us to trust Baltimore, than the whole country west of the mountains."⁷ Over in Philadelphia, newspaper editor and publisher Zachariah Poulson had to admit that his city was "rich in means, but poor in spirit" when it came to statewide concerns.⁸

Much of the funding that was promised for improving public roads in 1811 had been dumped on local authorities without any oversight. Philadelphia added miles of decent roads to its local network with its share of the money and again left the remainder of the state wanting. Work on the turnpike between Philadelphia and Pittsburgh had proceeded in an uneven and haphazard manner outside of those two localities.⁹ One traveller going over the Allegheny Mountains

⁷ Kehl, Ill Feeling in the Era of Good Feeling, 66.

⁸ Kehl, Ill Feeling in the Era of Good Feeling, 68.

⁹ John S. Ritenour, "Over the Old Roads to Pittsburgh," WPHM 4, (April, 1921): 78.

to Ohio in 1817 found the path so "rude, steep, and perilous" that "some of the more precipitous slopes were consequently strewn with the carcasses of wagons, carts, horses, oxen, which had made shipwreck in their perilous descent."¹⁰

These conditions were not unusual, but they were suddenly deemed intolerable with the National Road pressing ever westward. Public authorities in Pennsylvania dispatched contractors to some of the worst spots with orders to bring the trail up to prevailing standards. Some stretches were still crude and even dangerous when state authorities declared the work finished at the end of 1817, but the highway still represented a major improvement over the old trails. Costs for transporting goods plummeted by more than half since smoothing and widening the road surfaces allowed the use of larger wagons with heavier loads. Estimates held that 30,000 tons of goods were shipped to Pittsburgh in 1818.¹¹ Within three years, the volume of goods moving across Pennsylvania was guessed at three times that passing along the National Road.¹²

¹⁰ Hatcher, The Western Reserve, 73.

¹¹ Reiser, Pittsburgh's Commercial Development, 75-77.

¹² Julius Rubin, "An Imitative Public improvement: The Pennsylvania Mainline;" in Carter m. Goodrich, Canals and American Economic Development (New York, NY: Columbia University Press, 1961), 68.

Having bested Baltimore and the National Road, leaders in Philadelphia and Pittsburgh called for stronger controls over public expenditures. The boom climate generated by the War of 1812 had faltered and the merchants who dominated politics at either end of the state fell back into their old routines of promoting local interests. However, state leaders could not openly abandon their policy of assisting private firms after spending hundreds of thousands of dollars on pet projects. They got around this by making sure the conditions for securing aid were stringent enough to favor primary markets.¹³

No less than 146 firms were authorized to build 2,521 miles of new roads through 1821, but only 84 companies received letters of patent. Many failed because promoters could not raise enough capital to win state aid and get started, or else state figures turned their charter privileges over to some other group they owed a favor.¹⁴ Public records indicate that 1,807 miles were finished out of that total authorized in the legislature, and a majority tapped into existing highways serving Philadelphia and Pittsburgh. Frontier communities in Northwest Pennsylvania and the upper

¹³ Ritenour, "Over the Old Roads to Pittsburgh," WPHM 4(2), 78.

¹⁴ Durrenberger, Turnpikes, 55.

Susquehanna drainage lagged far behind in their abilities to secure funding.

Business promoters at Meadville discovered just how difficult it was getting state funds after they decided to rebuild Mead's old trail from the Susquehanna. State authorities had talked about repairing this path since 1794, but their interest in the work lagged after an initial survey was completed. Those plans were resurrected in February, 1812 when the legislature extended charter privileges for the Susquehanna & Waterford Turnpike. There was talk of war around the Great Lakes, and this highway was seen as a vital link joining the old French Portage Road from Lake Erie with roads radiating out of Philadelphia. Investors in the company were promised up to \$125,000 in public funds to help them along, provided they sold 2000 shares of stock within three years. A little more than half that amount was sold during the War of 1812 and officers of the company had to trick the legislature into releasing funds so they could get work on the highway started. Another two years passed before workers began grading the highway and making other improvements. Wagons could not travel the full distance from Philadelphia to Erie until 1824, and toll receipts quickly fell behind the costs of keeping the road open.¹⁵ By that

¹⁵ Reynolds, In French Creek Valley, 267-268.

time, every part of Pennsylvania was debating the merits of spending additional funds on road traffic or opening new avenues of navigation.

Merchants from Philadelphia had never given up their dream of opening direct navigation with the Susquehanna despite repeated delays and rising costs. They had worded the road bill of 1811 to cover the costs of all general improvements including canals. State legislators created the Union Canal company under the provisions of this act and granted the firm all rights to the old works that had been started with public funds in 1792. There was some concern how other tax payers in Pennsylvania might feel about giving more money and privileges to Philadelphia, so the directors of the Union Canal Company were granted permission to hold a lottery to raise private funds for starting work.¹⁶

Looking at the Union Canal Company as a model spurred ideas for improving navigation soon spread through Pennsylvania alongside plans for building roads. State leaders eventually granted 41 separate charters for canal companies up through 1821, although southeastern counties once again drew the greatest share of funds.¹⁷ Far corners of Pennsylvania were occasionally granted trifling sums

¹⁶ Corkan, Beaver and Lake Erie Canal, 3.

¹⁷ Ibid, 4.

for making river improvements in order to stem charges of sectional bias.

For instance, state leaders declared French Creek a public highway for the northwestern counties in 1794 and intermittently voted funds for clearing the stream of boulders and debris. In 1807, \$500 derived from land sales in Erie County was applied to that purpose; legislators voted another \$2,000 for clearing French Creek in 1810, but by the time the Pittsburgh and Philadelphia turnpike was finished in 1818 the stream was in need of attention again. Richard Patch of Meadville and a flatboat captain named John Martin were subsequently given contracts worth \$800 to oversee the work.¹⁸

This kind of work that had been going on in other parts of the state for years. Crews were kept busy blasting boulders and dragging driftwood out of the Monongahela and the Youghiogheny below Pittsburgh since 1792.¹⁹ Business and civic leaders in Pittsburgh only voiced their support for diverting public funds up the Allegheny River when they needed broad support for their own

¹⁸ Johnson, Headwaters District, 45. Farmhands and transient laborers were placed in French Creek with axes, picks and shovels during spells of low water to clear obstructions and debris, and a shipping channel was carved up to Waterford behind big, horse-drawn scrapers.

¹⁹ Johnson, Headwaters District, 48.

business deals. Work aimed at opening navigation on French Creek coincided with a rise in land speculation and the Indian war in 1794, and then federal approval for the National Road in 1807. This latest episode of clearing French Creek in 1818 was sparked by the emergence of steamboats on the Ohio River.

Some of the earliest steamers had been launched at Pittsburgh and satellite communities on the Monongahela River in the early nineteenth century, but their appearance did not spark instant changes in the carrying trade on the western rivers. Some of these vessels suffered from problems in their design and propulsion systems.²⁰ Others were held up by legal challenges; Robert Fulton and his associates from New York City claimed to hold a monopoly on building steamboats and their uses. Western boatmen eventually

²⁰ Observations concerning early steamboats are legion, and include Flint, Recollections of the Last Ten Years, 26, and Howell, Life in Ohio, 74-75. John H. Morrison, History of American Steam Navigation (New York, NY: Argosy-Antiquarian, 1967), 204, recounts the maiden voyage of the "Enterprize" out of Brownsville and its difficulties. This steamboat dropped down the Mississippi River in 1814 with arms and ammunition for the army defending New Orleans under General Andrew Jackson; the vessel made good time going back home because floodwaters covered obstructions near Louisville and spread out the current. Many observers dismissed this successful run as a fluke because of unnatural and highly favorable conditions. Walker, Experiences of Pioneer Life, 59, recounts the tale of another steamboat that took a party of sightseers from Pittsburgh to Steubenville; the vessel did not have enough power to get back upstream and passengers were invited to take a pole and help push against the current or take a stagecoach home.

broke the Fulton monopoly through court action and launching boats in defiance of their objections.²¹

This surrender opened the way for steamers up and down the Ohio River and its branches, which spelled new troubles for Pittsburgh since Wheeling was the natural head of navigation during dry spells.²² Where keelboats might try to push on with their shallow draft, steamers were prone to drop cargoes on the National Road at Wheeling. Clearing the Ohio River for use through the entire year became an obsession at Pittsburgh.²³

Droughts in 1818 and 1819 extended the normal schedule of low waters and exacerbated tensions in the city. Neville Craig of the Gazette reported nearly one million dollars worth of merchandise

²¹ Morrison, History of American Steam Navigation, 208-214; Johnson, Headwaters District, 56-59.

²² Flint, Recollections of the Last Ten Years, 26; Flint, History and Geography of the Mississippi Valley, 428. Captain Meriweather Lewis and William Clark discovered the difficulties of the navigating upper Ohio River at the start of their famed expedition in 1803. Clark found the river was littered with "many obstructions to it's navigation formed by bars of small stones which in some instances are intermixed with, and partially cover large quantities of driftwood;" his men had to cut channles for their keelboats with oars and tools, and on some occasions farmers were hired to bring teams of horses and oxen to drag the vessels along. See "Lewis to Jefferson, Wheeling, September 8, 1803," in Reuben Thwaites, Original Journals of the Lewis and Clark Expedition, 1804-1806, volume 7 (New York, NY: Antiquarian Press, 1959), 269-270; Johnson, Headwaters District, 36-37.

²³ Wade, Urban Frontier, 179.

sitting on the river banks at Pittsburgh during the worst of the crisis. Craig moaned the authorities had put off meaningful improvements for twenty years, and "it now becomes a task that can no longer be dispensed with."²⁴ Businessmen and civic promoters formed a committee to raise funds and direct laborers in clearing the Ohio River for navigation down to Wheeling. Crews of hired laborers were placed in the river to blast channels through ripples and drag boulders out of the way.²⁵ Members of the committee wrote letters to neighboring states seeking aid but they failed to garner much enthusiasm. All of the early improvements were carried out with funds raised in the local business community at Pittsburgh. Petitions that were sent to Harrisburg asking for assistance did not fare any better than those letters sent to other states.²⁶

Pennsylvania was caught up in a general economic downturn that was sweeping the nation. Politicians and businessmen from Philadelphia opposed any additional spending in far corners of the state while they struggled to finish the Union Canal and keep

²⁴ Johnson, Headwaters District, 51. A boat drawing just fourteen inches of water took thirty-five days going from Pittsburgh to Cincinnati and the skipper complained that he had grounded at least fifty times.

²⁵ Wade, Urban Frontier, 180.

²⁶ Johnson, Headwaters District, 52.

Baltimore in check. State legislators finally voted funds for making permanent improvements in the Ohio River during their session of March 26, 1821; an appropriation of \$15,000 was allocated for deepening the channel and removing fish dams, rocks and timber.²⁷

This change in attitudes was spurred by a sudden realization that the competition for western trade was entering a new and highly competitive phase. While Philadelphia tried to contain Baltimore and draw trade through Pittsburgh during the preceding decade, New York pushed its own network of improvements westward and behind Pennsylvania. Helping Pittsburgh to bring trade up the Ohio River seemed like a reasonable step in checking this latest threat.²⁸

Canals and regional competition

Ending hostilities with England in 1815 had lifted restraints on western settlement and sparked a frenzy of economic activities on the prairies lying out beyond Pennsylvania. Western land sales accelerated at a phenomenal rate while prices soared and banking credit expanded to meet demand. Farmers who had supplied

²⁷ Johnson, Headwaters District, 54.

²⁸ Kehl, Ill Feeling in the Era of Good Feeling, 242-243.

agricultural produce to army contractors during the war avidly encouraged settlement in hopes of winning new customers without regards for competition. New settlers quickly started producing their own surplus and forced prices down, throwing the local economy into turmoil. Two decades of inflated wartime prices at home and abroad had spoiled the farmers and encouraged extensive borrowing. The economic depression lasting from 1819 to 1822 was largely blamed on speculation in western lands, generous credit and low prices. An abundance of agricultural produce forced prices down, and left farmers unable to meet their credit obligations.²⁹

Westerners responded by launching a campaign for improved transportation facilities that would provide access to eastern markets while reducing costs. Governor Ethan Allen Brown of Ohio complained that "Our productions, which form our only great resource, are generally of that bulky and ponderous description, as to need every easement in conveyance, that we can afford."³⁰

National figures in Washington took the requests under consideration out of fears that ignoring the frontiersmen would encourage movements for independence. In 1817, John C. Calhoun

²⁹ David H. Mould, Dividing Lines (Dayton, OH: Wright State University Press, 1994), 11.

³⁰ Ibid, 15.

warned his listeners in Congress to consider that geographic expansion of the United States "is our pride, our danger, our weakness and our strength" all at once. Calhoun urged fellow legislators to resolve questions attending to growth by establishing "a perfect system of roads and canals" to bind the nation together.³¹

Nationalist politicians had warned of a growing rift for decades and issued similar calls to combat it. Albert Gallatin offered several solutions through his Report of the Secretary of Treasury on the Subject of Roads and Canals in 1808, calling for an extensive system of internal improvements. Authorities from the different states had then deluged Congress with petitions for additional local improvements. Members of Congress deferred a decision on these expenditures, pending a full discussion on the propriety of using federal tax dollars for local improvements. Calls out of Ohio and the western territories for federally funded improvements brought the matter up for debate again.

Interpretations of the Constitution permitted federal spending on projects of a national scope so long as tolls were not collected for local benefits. Constitutionlists argued the government was fully empowered to fund public works, but local and sectional

³¹ Stover, American Railroads, 2.

interests objected to any works that could not be justified for the common good of all. States that had already funded their own projects supported this drive, and as a result government funding of postal roads and defenses was not extended to a broad infrastructure for economic growth. James Madison emphasized the federal position with a presidential veto of federal public works in 1816. Public demand for improvements at the same time forced state legislators to consider the burden of funding.³²

New York ushered in a new era of public improvements by starting work on the Erie Canal with public money. A former mayor of New York City named DeWitt Clinton revived his sagging political fortunes by seizing this issue as his own. Clinton penned a memorial to the state legislature in Albany explaining the benefits of a canal for all tax payers including large landholders, small farmers in the west, and merchants in eastern cities. The resultant groundswell of support for the Erie Canal forced state authorities to accept the financial risk involved.³³

To cross the full width of New York from the Hudson River to the

³² Forest G. Hill. Roads, Rails & Waterways (Norman, OK: University of Oklahoma Press, 1957), 44.

³³ Rubin, "An Innovating Public improvement: the Erie Canal;" in Goodrich, Canals and American Economic Development, 52-54.

Great Lakes required a canal three hundred and sixty four miles long, with a difficult crossing over a mountain chain.³⁴ Federal agencies had seen prospects for the line as completely unrealistic and denied funding. Experience to that point offered a dismal record of failed canals across the nation, and none of these schemes had been as ambitious. An attempt to improve the Mohawk River in western New York for navigation before the turn of the century was viewed outside that area as a failed enterprise.³⁵ By 1816, the United States still counted just one hundred miles or so of operating canals. Only three lines were more than two miles in length, and the longest was just twenty-seven miles.³⁶

Promoters in New York were painfully aware of previous failures, and carefully staged news releases and public events to make a favorable impression. Groundbreaking ceremonies were planned to coincide with the anniversary of national independence on July 4, 1817, just three days after Clinton took his oath as governor. Visiting dignitaries and local residents assembled in the early morning haze so they could turn dirt with the rising sun and

³⁴ Shaw, Erie Water West, 40-45.

³⁵ Shaw, Canals For A Nation, 10.

³⁶ Cleveland and Powell, Railroad Promotion and Capitalization in the United States, 39-41.

symbolically begin a new day. Newspapers were regularly fed this sort of news during the years of construction, and readers were already commenting on the economic benefits of the canal when the first section of seventy-five miles length was opened for traffic in 1819. Canal building provided jobs and a market for raw materials that helped New York through the financial disasters that buffeted the nation. Some complained that the only way to stay afloat in New York was "by getting a job on the canal" where wages were low, but at least there was work.³⁷

While others groaned and questioned how to escape these hard times, politicians in Ohio increasingly looked to New York as a model of sound reasoning. Governor Thomas Worthington had already linked prosperity with a comprehensive transportation program,

³⁷ Shaw, Erie Water West, 119-120. This situation was not unusual for the times and was echoed in several states and numerous localities; see Howell, Life in Ohio: 139. Howell lived between the Ohio River and the path of the Ohio Canal, and wrote: "That part of it nearest to us was in [the] process of building in 1826-7, and this afforded work and money to the men who could do it during the winter, at prices they seemed glad to get and thought they were doing well to take. Hands were paid eight to ten dollars a month for chopping, digging, etc., receiving board and lodgings in addition; but every wet day was counted out, the laborer losing his time and the contractor the board. In this way, it would take all winter to make about two months time. It was hard earned money, but it was esteemed worth the labor. There were certain things for which money was required to be raised, the chief of which were taxes; and to these the ready money was applied."

after viewing logistics problems in the War of 1812. When the New York assembly started serious discussions on the Erie Canal, Worthington urged Ohio to contribute financial support. Ohio could hardly offer more than good wishes at the time, but raised canals for public consideration.³⁸

Counties in Northwest Pennsylvania proved more susceptible to the lure of canals. Residents despaired of ever getting their share of attention or state funding from Harrisburg and jumped at the chance to forge new ties. Local politicians sought permission to extend the Erie Canal into Northwest Pennsylvania in 1818, although the idea was quickly brushed aside and forgotten in Harrisburg. One commentator in the Pennsylvania state capitol correctly guessed that the "proposed canal from lake Erie to French creek by the way of Conniott lake, had better be underway" before other parts of the state joined together in opposition.³⁹

Hardly anybody outside of Northwest Pennsylvania took the idea seriously, since there was doubt the Erie Canal would ever handle any traffic. Favorable reports of the work were applauded as a mark of American ingenuity, but each finished mile of the Erie

³⁸ George E. Condon, Stars in the Water (Garden City, NY: Doubleday & Company, 1974), 122; Scheiber, Ohio Canal Era, 15-17.

³⁹ Crawford Weekly Messenger, December 25, 1818: p3c1.

Canal was estimated to cost around \$15,000. Adding on the costs for masonry structures like locks and aqueducts seemed to doom the effort. Pennsylvania authorities sitting in Harrisburg believed that total costs would exceed seven million dollars and ultimately bankrupt New York.

Most inhabitants of the Keystone state agreed, and looked to their own record of failed canal companies as evidence. Most of these ventures failed to secure adequate funds and collapsed before a spade of earth was turned. Workmen were still carving out a channel for the Union Canal, which state leaders hoped to merge into the Schuylkill Navigation Company in hopes of finally turning a profit. Parts of this latter work had been completed into the coal fields around Pottsville and Port Carbon, and at least one commentator hoped this merger might "stimulate us to exertions which will secure to this city the immense trade to the North and West of which Baltimore and New York are now making every exertion to deprive us."⁴⁰

In spite of these proposed benefits, funding was becoming difficult as costs for the Union Canal escalated beyond the most pessimistic expectations and work lagged. Fearful of placing their own fortunes at risk, the powerful merchants who were backing the

⁴⁰ Pittsburgh Gazette, June 26, 1818: p3c3.

company called on the city of Philadelphia for aid in 1820. When this added source of funding failed to stem the crisis, they turned to their friends and colleagues in the state assembly. State authorities obliged and on March 26, 1821 they guaranteed interest payments on a new series of bonds to raise the required sums.⁴¹ This was the same day the legislature voted money to clear the Ohio River for navigation near Pittsburgh.

Conservatives expressed outrage that the state would abuse the public trust for private interests. Citizens with commercial ties to Baltimore complained that Philadelphia was trying to circumvent the premise of free trade. One embittered editor from the York Gazette complained that "the people of York county will have to contribute the payment of interest for a project which is to wrest the Susquehanna trade from their shores and carry it through Reading to Philadelphia." He then added that if there was "one consolation left to the people" of York County, it was "that the project will be a fruitless one, and that the attempt to monopolize the Susquehanna trade, and turn it out of its natural channel, will result in an abortion, and consequently the only injury that can result to them, will be the loss of their money they will have to pay towards an experiment engendered by the avaricious spirit, and

⁴¹ Livingood, Philadelphia-Baltimore Trade Rivalry, 106-107.

blind and grasping zeal of the Philadelphians."⁴²

Anger over the manipulation of state authority in Pennsylvania had hardly subsided when Ohio legislators cast their lot with canals. For four straight years after taking office in 1818, Governor Ethan Allen Brown proposed building a canal between the Ohio River and Lake Erie to meet the Erie Canal. Sectional fighting in the Ohio state legislature undermined his initial efforts, but Brown doggedly refused to quit. Friends of the project promised manifold benefits for their mostly rural electorate that included direct access to coastal markets, while reducing costs and breaking the New Orleans monopoly over shipping. Powerful merchants of New York offered their support in hopes of breaking the natural boundaries of the Great Lakes and reaching into the Ohio Valley and the far West. After bringing the measure to a vote four years in a row, Governor Brown finally won legislative approval in January 1822, when the benefits of the Erie Canal were becoming apparent. A board of canal commissioners was authorized to immediately begin surveying potential routes.⁴³

When Ohio joined forces with New York to build canals,

⁴² York Gazette, April 17, 1821; cited in Livingood, Philadelphia-Baltimore Trade Rivalry, 107.

⁴³ Harry N. Scheiber, Ohio Canal Era (Athens, OH: Ohio University Press, 1969), 15-17.

Pennsylvania was suddenly faced with prospects of being isolated and cut off from interstate trade patterns. New York merchants and their western partners could trade through canals and the Great Lakes without costly transfers to wagons. Roads leading across Northwest Pennsylvania were abysmal, and even dangerous in places. Merchants based in Buffalo already preferred shipping goods and passengers bound for northern Ohio to Sandusky or Detroit and carting them back, instead of risking a direct trip overland. Steamboats were introduced on this route in 1818 to speed up traffic, and they could easily take canal boats drifting out of Cleveland in tow.⁴⁴ Cargo shippers could therefore be expected to forgo further uses of Pennsylvania roads and waterways except for local deliveries once the canals were opened.⁴⁵ Settlements in the

⁴⁴ The "Walk in Water" was launched at Black Rock near Buffalo in 1818, and became the first successful application of steam on the Great Lakes. There were several earlier attempts to launch steamboats, and all of them were saddled with the same difficulties seen in the early boats used on the Ohio River. The "Walk in Water" and its immediate successors had to be towed out of Black Rock and Buffalo by several teams of oxen to overcome currents in the Niagara River. See George A. Cuthbertson, Freshwater: A History and Narrative of the Great Lakes (New York, NY: The Macmillan Company, 1931), 214-218.

⁴⁵ Despite boasting one of the finest harbors on the Great Lakes, the settlement at Erie hardly showed signs of growth after the War of 1812. Federal authorities surveyed Presque Isle Bay for harbor improvements, but nothing was done. A detailed description of Erie in this period is found in Isaac Moorhead, The Occasional Writings of Isaac Moorhead (Erie, PA: A.H.

upper Susquehanna basin and counties on the western edge of Pennsylvania might even be drawn into this network of exchange.

Influential businessmen representing Philadelphia and Pittsburgh in the state government pulled together in a common cause and called for consideration of a rival system. A special committee of the Pennsylvania legislature was appointed at their urging to deliberate the question of possible routes and likely objections to canals in December 1822. After considering the reports from expeditions that had been dispatched throughout the state in preceding years, the committee recommended a canal connection between the Susquehanna River and the Allegheny watershed.

Opponents naturally charged that the preliminary surveys were a farce, and only undertaken to mask collusion between the legislature and its favored sons in Philadelphia. A canal bill that was introduced in February 1823 was quietly shelved in hopes that the controversy would blow over.⁴⁶ Events in neighboring states foiled this strategy within months, and forced Pennsylvania to respond before the end of the year.

Parts of the Erie Canal that had been opened were proving more

Caughey, 1882).

⁴⁶ Rubin, "An Imitative Improvement;" in Canals and American Economic Development: 72.

valuable to New York than expected. Trade picked up on every section that was opened for navigation, and new towns rapidly appeared as depots and distribution centers.⁴⁷ Sources from Rochester reported that 10,450 barrels of flour had been shipped in just ten days that spring, and even more would have been sent if the canal had not broken open near Albany.⁴⁸ Repairs were made and the Erie Canal was running at record levels again before the end of the year. A report from this period showed that merchants at Utica shipped 3500 pounds of fresh salmon for New York City and received 24 tons of oysters and clams in return.⁴⁹

Word of this success quickly spread across the state line. Merchants from New York had advised farmers in Northwest Pennsylvania to prepare a heavy crop in 1823 so they could enjoy the benefits of a steady market along the canal and regular transportation.⁵⁰

Even worse for Pennsylvania than the northern shift in trade was

⁴⁷ Frances Trollope of England commented on the rough appearance some of these towns still displayed in the late 1820s, with business overtaking architectural or artistic concerns. See Frances Trollope, Domestic Manners of the Americans (London, England: Century Publishing Company, 1984), 333-334, 344-346.

⁴⁸ Crawford Weekly Messenger, May 27, 1823: p3c2.

⁴⁹ Crawford Weekly Messenger, December 9, 1823: p2c2.

⁵⁰ Crawford Weekly Messenger, March 23, 1823: p2c3.

the way the Erie Canal generated a groundswell of support for building canals in Maryland and Virginia. Boats had stumbled through the short stretches of canal opened by the Potomac Company at the turn of the century, and the success of the Erie Canal prompted discussions of crafting these into a larger and unified system. One group of merchants from northern Virginia sponsored a convention in 1823 and took on the work as the Chesapeake and Ohio Canal. They had hoped to call it the Union Canal in a bid for federal aid, but that name was already being used in Pennsylvania. Their initial plans called for carrying navigation up to the head of the Potomac River at Cumberland, and crossing the heights into the Ohio drainage through the Youghiogheny or the Monongahela in Southwest Pennsylvania.⁵¹

Years of delay in Pennsylvania gave way to months of frenzied activity, as surveyors and politicians drafted reports and memorials discussing canals. Panic stricken merchants resurrected the bill from February 1823, just as quickly as state legislators convened for their end of year session. After considering the materials at hand, the assembly decided in favor of a canal on March 27, 1824. Governor J. Andrew Schulze was instructed to name three members to an exploratory committee that was charged with

⁵¹ Kytte, Home on the Canal, 18.

locating a line of improvement from "the great valley of Chester and Lancaster Counties along one or another set of natural waterways westward to Pittsburgh."⁵²

Teamsters and tavern owners fronting highways across the state drafted petitions against this threat to their livelihood. They assembled on February 4, 1825 and drew up five separate resolutions for the state legislation opposing canals. One of these petitions unabashedly declared that teamsters had paid tolls "with unexampled good faith (except when they could cheat a little!)" and deserved some consideration for it. Another one declared that teamsters were not opposed to public improvements, but simple justice and common sense demanded they oppose "canals and water communications calculated to drive them from the honourable pursuits" of their occupation.⁵³

To mollify these objections, the legislature adopted a second canal bill on April 11, 1825, that considerably expanded the scope of improvements. This amended version replaced the canal committee with a five member board of canal commissioners and proposed no less than seven different routes for opening a "navigable communication between the eastern and western waters of the state

⁵² Shank, Amazing Pennsylvania Canals, 14.

⁵³ Reiser, Pittsburgh's Commercial Development, 82.

and Lake Erie." By bowing to the northwestern counties and opening a junction with Lake Erie, the merchants from Philadelphia and Pittsburgh hoped to counter vehement opposition in the southeastern part of the state.

What the canal crowd had not counted on was protest that crossed the lines of customary sectional rivalries. People from all across the state complained that building a canal was wasteful after throwing hundreds of thousands of dollars into state road building. Teamsters and tavern owners who depended on these highways were leading a determined campaign to destroy the canal bills.

The board of canal commissioners tried to soothe their anger by pointing out that waggoning cost about \$8,000 in start up costs and \$60 a day thereafter, while boating on the canal reduced these costs to "but \$260, and the daily expense but \$3" thereafter.⁵⁴ Spokesmen for the canal bill predicted a relatively easy and profitable transition in the hauling trade from roads to canals, but again miscalculated sectional interests.

Uniontown and the surrounding parts of Southwest Pennsylvania served by the National Road were not swayed. Citizens from this area vehemently opposed the Pennsylvania Canal and called for a mass protest on August 27, 1825. Local dignitaries took the podium

⁵⁴ Reiser, Pittsburgh's Commercial Development, 87.

at the appointed time, but they surprisingly threw their support behind the Chesapeake and Ohio Canal. Federal officials had decided to fund this canal in a partnership with the state governments of Virginia and Maryland. after weighing the benefits, local drivers felt this "union of the eastern and western waters across the Allegheny" should be accepted as a "national object." This would permit them to roughly maintain their current routes, while reaping the improved conditions of travel and higher profits predicted by the board of canal commissioners.⁵⁵

Other parts of Pennsylvania naturally objected to this open display of self interest, and banded together to prevent the Chesapeake and Ohio from crossing the state line. News editors in Crawford County indignantly pointed out that Uniontown already had the National Road and now wanted additional benefits that it was unwilling to extend through the rest of Pennsylvania.⁵⁶ Sectional rivalries and local jealousies overpowered business in the state capitol and reduced discussions on any piece of legislation to a battle over canals and road building.

A minority faction tried to break the stalemate by advancing railroads as a compromise, but this only worsened the situation by

⁵⁵ Crawford Messenger, September 15, 1825: p3c3.

⁵⁶ Ibid.

creating a third special interest group. Railroad promoters tackled canals by explaining that tracks could be laid just about anywhere and operated the full year, while canal uses were limited by water supplies and seasonal weather conditions. Trains were capable of reaching speeds of fifteen miles an hour, while boats crept along at just four miles an hour and suffered frequent delays passing through canal locks.

Canal men were hardly convinced and argued that rails could not be kept free of ice throughout the entire year; they predicted tragedies would result from machines skidding off tracks. Steam engines of the period were said to be as susceptible to cold as canals, with frequent mechanical failures as a result. Since Pennsylvania canals were being planned to move heavy freight including timber and iron, speed was of limited value. Railroad men grudgingly conceded that locomotives run at low speeds were little better than horses, which only boosted arguments in favor of staying with canals and roads.⁵⁷

Experience with state politics engendered a combative spirit, and the once conciliatory railroad men engaged in heated defense of their project. After agreeing that horses were cheaper than locomotives, they suggested building tram railways. This line of

⁵⁷ Crawford Messenger, September 15, 1823: p3c3.

reasoning held that motive power was less important than establishing procedures for maintenance and traffic control under any circumstances of weather and terrain. Road building had scarcely advanced in several decades and poor road surfaces were the norm. Railroad promoters pointedly commented that increased spending on the National Road had not changed this pattern. In 1824, David Shriver of Wheeling reported that farmers owning lands next to the National Road were hauling off the gravel and stone cover for their own uses. Several hundred miles eastward, John Davis complained that the stretch of highway across Allegheny County in Western Maryland was a near ruin and in need of constant maintenance. Long distance travellers reported these conditions had spread over large segments of the highway. Lucius W. Stockton made three trips over the National Road by the spring of 1826, and recorded an unending path of devastation. Surfaces were cracked and washed out, and the stone cover was sinking where it had not been carted off.⁵⁸

While teamsters struggled to get their wagons over local roads, rail promoters observed that English businessmen successfully operated horse railways for heavy traffic that included mining and quarry ventures. English models consisted of iron rails laid on

⁵⁸ Jordan, National Road, 98-99.

stone foundations, but an abundance of wood in America meant wood ties could replace the stone blocks at substantial savings.

Merchants in Philadelphia and other parts of the state that favored canals grudgingly weakened their resistance to railroads as the debate dragged on month after month with no end in sight. Building canals through the mountains of Central Pennsylvania certainly raised formidable technical questions, and any solution was likely to substantially increase cost estimates. One railroad enthusiast warned that "should the advocates of canals gain a victory," it would prove "one they will never boast of." Partisans on all sides of the issue conceded that "some of our enterprising capitalists" would eventually open a railroad between Philadelphia and Pittsburgh.⁵⁹

Railroads were certain to compete with canals in the near future, and most legislators agreed that "An error committed at present will have the most serious consequences on the future destinies of this state." Members of the Pennsylvania Society had already determined that the "railroads which are about to be made in England, will furnish the best data upon which to reason and act in this country," and dispatched William Strickland overseas to

⁵⁹ Rubin "An Imitative Improvement: The Pennsylvania Mainline;" in Goodrich, Canals and American Economic Development. 92.

gather information.

Leaders of state government concurred and postponed further discussions of internal improvements until Strickland's report could be reviewed. Mention of railroads virtually disappeared from Philadelphia newspapers during the summer of 1825, except for scattered references to experiments in England. This gesture of good faith on the part of railroad promoters belied a widespread belief that the question of internal improvements had been settled. Public officials gave ready assurances that Pennsylvania was capable of answering any challenge when Ohio broke ground for its canal on July 4, 1825, and hinted that canals were already outmoded.

Pennsylvanians waiting for an official announcement were shocked out of their apparent stupor when New York celebrated its completion of the Erie Canal during the last week of October, 1825. Panic stricken merchants in the assembly and cities across the state feared that further delay would prove fatal to their interests, and demanded immediate action.

New York had already slipped ahead of Philadelphia in the ranking of American commercial cities since the end of the Revolution, and the canal could only widen the gap. Exports out of Philadelphia had fallen from eighteen million dollars in 1796, to

a little more than seven million dollars in 1821. While this still represented a substantial volume of trade, the total amount was barely half of that passing through New York. Three years earlier, a visitor to Philadelphia had recorded his disappointment "in seeing the shipping so very inferior to that at New York; and the houses fronting the river are old and irregularly placed, so that the idea of a port declining in trade immediately occurred."⁶⁰

Criticisms of this nature gained new momentum as the Erie Canal neared completion in 1825, and broke the lethargy that had settled over political process in Pennsylvania.

After gradually shifting their favor toward railroads, the merchant community in Philadelphia and their allies across the Pennsylvania reversed course and decided that canals were a better investment. Railroads were yet unproven, while the Erie Canal was an unqualified success. Proponents of a canal in the state legislature traded political favors at a furious pace in order to gather a majority for the end of year session and claimed that public opinion was clearly in their favor.

One hundred and thirteen of the leading citizens from forty-six counties assembled at Harrisburg on August 4, 1825, to discuss canals. Most of the delegates had been hand picked because of

⁶⁰ Livingood, Philadelphia-Baltimore Trade Rivalry, 18.

their support for canals, so it was no surprise when resolutions confirming the canal bill of February 4, 1825, were adopted by a vote of 87 to 26. Opposing votes predictably came from Bedford, Cumberland, Franklin, Lancaster, Northampton, Tioga and York counties, while delegations from Berks, Chester, Lebanon and Lehigh counties were divided on the question.

Delegates voting in favor of canals deluged newspapers and their representatives in the state legislature with these results. Nearly all of them agreed there was no time to lose. Teamsters had their own convention scheduled to promote improved highways near the end of the month, and many people were still waiting for news on railroads before making a decision. While railroads made sense on paper, politicians in Pennsylvania felt they could not risk their fortunes on an unproven technology, and the commission empowered to survey possible rail lines was still three weeks away from issuing its final report.

Given a general air of confusion and the different charges flying around the state capitol, opponents bowed to the most vocal group and tamely authorized construction of the Pennsylvania Canal on February 22, 1826. Newspapers across the state joined in singing their praises of the measures, and at least one editor predicted that February 22 would become as celebrated for the canal

as for the anniversary of George Washington's birthday.⁶¹

Pennsylvania embarks on a statewide system of canals

Public officials decided that Pennsylvania should openly imitate New York, drawing on building skills practiced in Europe for hundreds of years and common through the United States. Engineers hired to supervise the work followed the same dimensions used on the Erie Canal and the early Pennsylvania canals, which were designed for passing along river boats. Sketches of the ditch (properly termed the "prism") showed a surface width of 40 feet, narrowing to 28 feet at the bottom, and a minimum depth of 4 feet.

Mechanical excavators were still several years in the future, and the work proceeded with gangs of hired laborers shovelling dirt and breaking up rock with picks and crowbars. Beasts were used to haul dirt and rock, or pull large scrapers in the work areas. Once the ditch was cleared, it was turned over to "puddlers" who coated the insides with clay to prevent leakage. Masons and carpenters took charge where locks and other features had to be installed. Costs were contained whenever possible by drawing natural features into the work. Placing dams across a river bed proved the cheapest and most expedient means of construction, creating slackwater pools

⁶¹ Klein, Pennsylvania Politics, 197.

and negating any need to cut a new channel. When the engineers were forced to cross between watersheds in rugged landscapes, they guided the work along hills so the builders could just throw up an embankment and trap water. Cutting artificial channels was expensive, and this practice was relegated to levels between streams or specific localities that did not allow for other methods.⁶²

State leaders in Pennsylvania hoped to span the entire distance between Philadelphia and Pittsburgh by drawing on these simple techniques, with methods of financing and organization that had been pioneered in New York. Early attempts to open canals had failed because a single builder was entrusted with the complete project; on the Erie Canal, separate contracts were signed for excavation, puddling, procuring materials, or construction on short

⁶² Contracts released by state figures represent the basic source for understanding the requirements of work and pay rates. Hundreds of surviving documents are maintained in Record Group 17 (RG 17), Records of the Bureau of Land Management, in the Pennsylvania State Archives at Harrisburg. Hubertis M. Cumming has compiled a guide for sorting through this extensive collection that includes divisional records, superintendent reports, maps of route surveys and finished projects, with the individual contracts. Descriptions of the actual construction are included in most secondary works on canals. For details on building the Erie Canal, see Shaw, Erie Water West, and Condon, Stars in the Water. One descriptive piece for the western end of Pennsylvania is Robert Ilisevich and Carl K. Burkett, "The Canal Through Pittsburgh: Its Development and Physical Character," WPHM LXVII (1985).

sections that were keyed to local conditions and the capabilities of the builders. Plans for the Pennsylvania Main Line Canal included roughly 400 miles of continuous slackwater pools and canals. Five separate divisions were therefore created to oversee the hundreds of contracts relating to construction and material procurement.

Work on the Pennsylvania Main Line Canal commenced with appropriate ceremonies at Harrisburg on July 4, 1826. Construction was then picked up around the terminals at Philadelphia and Pittsburgh. With gangs of laborers scattered up and down the Main Line Canal, state authorities turned their attention to promises they had made to Northwest Pennsylvania.

State leaders had not foreseen any great difficulty in opening navigation between the Ohio watershed and Lake Erie. Boating traditions on French Creek and the Allegheny River went back decades and readily drew notice in Philadelphia and across state lines in Virginia, Maryland and New York. Under good conditions all sorts of watercraft could ascend French Creek up to Waterford, only fifteen miles from Lake Erie over the old French Portage. Opening navigation through this short gap or just improving the land carriage was not seen as a difficult undertaking. Pennsylvania legislators funded several studies to determine how

the route could be put to the best use, starting in 1790.

Federal figures furthered interest in these streams by looking at their usefulness for commerce and national defense. Early successes in opening parts of the Erie Canal in New York led federal authorities to consider the possibility of building an interlocking system across state lines. A Board of Engineers for Internal Improvements was created within the Corps of Engineers for this purpose in 1824, and up to twenty-four officers were attached to this command at one time. Surveyors and engineers were hurriedly detached from this command to examine some of the more promising routes including links between the Potomac River and the Youghiogheny River in southwestern Pennsylvania, and the Ohio River and Lake Erie in the northwestern corner of the state.⁶³ One party passed along the west bank of French Creek near Meadville and set up camp where the Mercer Street bridge was erected in later years. Their presence created a stir in the town and residents visited with questions and advice. William Reynolds was taken along by his father while still a small boy, and when he was compiling accounts of local history in his later years Reynolds remembered Colonel Joseph Totten, Major D.B. Douglass, General Samuel Bernard and Captain William Tell Poussin being present. Totten was chief

⁶³ Hill, Roads, Rails & Waterways, 47-51.

engineer of the United States Army, while Bernard and Poussin were French exiles who had served under Napoleon.⁶⁴

State officials in Pennsylvania eagerly reviewed the findings and reports of progress from these surveys, although they hoped to disrupt plans for building an integrated system across state lines. Politicians and business promoters from the southeastern parts of Pennsylvania feared repeating their mistakes when they opened roads too freely near the southern state line and boosted fortunes in Baltimore. Farmers in northwest Pennsylvania had already threatened an economic secession from Pittsburgh and Philadelphia when work started on the Erie Canal in 1818. Members of the state legislature in New York revived this threat when Pennsylvania voted to build its own canal system.

Several possible routes were sketched out across the common state line from the Erie Canal, including a passage along the old French route from Barcelona down to Conewango Creek. Merchants and civic leaders at Buffalo favored this particular route and urged the residents of Chataqua County to join with them in promoting it to state leaders.⁵⁷ An engineer employed by state agencies was

⁶⁴ William Reynolds, "Reminiscences of the Old Canal," manuscript, Crawford County Historical Society, 1-2.

⁵⁷ Crawford Messenger, August 3, 1826: p3c3-4.

asked to look into the matter, and he reported favorably on a cut of 96 miles between the Allegheny River and the Genessee branch of the Erie Canal. After building the Erie Canal, placing the estimated costs of building this line at \$633,000 seemed a comparative bargain. According to newspaper accounts, "Mr. Jones, the Canal Engineer" advised New York legislators in Albany that this "will open a navigable communication between the 2 extremes of the Union."⁵⁸

Pennsylvania state leaders answered by drafting plans to draw the trade of Northwest Pennsylvania and the upper Allegheny drainage down toward Pittsburgh and the Main Line, while leaving streams near New York in a primitive state. A broad plan was adopted in Harrisburg for improving navigation on the Allegheny River from Pittsburgh up to Franklin, and then shifting traffic off the main stream into French Creek. Boats from the upper waters could still pass downstream on seasonal freshets, but ascending traffic would be effectively barred from continuing toward the state line. Financial benefits from increasing commerce in this area could be applied toward continuing the canal to Lake Erie and westward into the Beaver watershed of the larger Ohio River drainage. There was still some question how these two lines might

⁵⁸ Crawford Messenger, February 15, 1827: p3c1.

be joined or where they would reach Lake Erie, since the bills authorizing construction of the Main Line Canal only called for opening navigation between the Ohio River and Lake Erie.⁵⁹

Subsequent action in the state legislature on February 25, 1826 required the canal commissioners to construct a navigable feeder from French Creek to Conneaut Lake. Common opinion held a pool was necessary at this point for getting boats over the northwestern highlands during dry seasonal conditions. Conneaut Lake rests in a shallow divide between French Creek, Conneaut Creek, and the Shenango River, and seemed certain to figure in any future plans. This was also in the heart of the most populated and sensitive political district in that section of Pennsylvania.

Major D.B. Douglass of the United States Corps of Engineers was hired to oversee this effort because he had already viewed the region with the survey party that passed through Meadville in 1824. Douglass hired W.E. Felton of Meadville as his chief surveyor and took charge of the levelling party. After considering several possible routes, a primary path for the French Creek Feeder Canal was sketched out along the northern fringe of the Conneaut Marsh between French Creek and the southern end of Conneaut Lake. A

⁵⁹ "Report of the Canal Commissioners of Pennsylvania, to the Legislature," JHR 1828, appendix, 18-19; Crawford Weekly Messenger, March 3, 1827: p3c2-3.

westward extension of the canal was added later, from a point about one third of the way up the west side of the Conneaut Lake to a high ground that locals knew as the Beaver Dam Summit. This extension was designed to feed traffic toward French Creek, and it could be joined to the canal system that was planned for the Beaver River and its tributaries. Conneaut Lake had to be raised eight feet under this plan in order to sustain sufficient water level for navigation in the feeder canal and its extension. One final issue for consideration was just where to tap into French Creek and start construction. In his report to the state authorities, Douglass observed that after laying out the canal along the Conneaut Marsh "the question presented itself, whether its continuation should be carried up the eastern or western shore" of French Creek.⁶⁰

All of the available evidence suggested the western bank was better suited for building a canal, but the residents of Meadville attached great importance to drawing the canal through their town. As elected officials, the canal commissioners and members of the state assembly did not lose sight of how this might translate into votes during upcoming elections. Work on the French Creek Feeder

⁶⁰ See D.B. Douglass, "A report on the French creek feeder by Major D.B. Douglass," JHR 1827, appendix: 3-47; William Reynolds, "Reminiscences of the Old Canal," manuscript, Crawford County Historical Society: 2.

Canal was therefore authorized by the legislature on April 9, 1827.

Parts of the canal near Meadville were opened for bidding under the terms of this act, even though the overall plan for a larger system between Pittsburgh and Lake Erie was not completed. Major Douglas was hired again during the following summer to remedy this omission by plotting a route for the canal from the western side of Conneaut Lake to Lake Erie.⁶¹ Since Douglass was only under contract for a few months, Charles C. Whippo was instructed to locate a line from Pittsburgh to Conneaut Lake during the same period. Whippo had trained as a civil engineer on the Erie Canal and was hired as chief engineer on the more westerly "Beaver and Chenango [sic]" system.⁶² Before embarking on those duties, he was charged with finishing all of the surveys connected with the French Creek route of the state canals including the summit levels near Waterford and Conneaut.⁶³

⁶¹ Erie Gazette, August 23, 1827: p3c3. Douglas proceeded northward along Conneaut Creek from the western side of Conneaut Lake, before crossing overland into Hall's Run, and skirting the shore of Lake Erie to the harbor at Presque Isle. Douglas reported that this path was more favorable for construction than believed, despite passing over the deep gorge cut by Elk Creek (above Hall's Run) and a fairly broad divide surrounding Walnut Creek near Erie.

⁶² Erie Gazette, June 14, 1827: p3c1.

⁶³ Erie Gazette, September 20, 1827: p3c1.

While the surveyors and their assistants examined these routes, other workmen were staking off sections of the canal for construction near Meadville. "Mr. [James] Ferguson, the Engineer" had arrived in town before June 27, 1827 with instructions to lay out the canal on the east bank of French Creek and mark off some of sections for construction.⁶⁴ Contracts covering more than nine miles of the canal were awarded through open bidding over the following weeks. This carried the canal downstream from Meadville toward the mouth of the Conneaut Marsh, where an aqueduct was going to be built across French Creek. Once the contracts were signed, the citizens of Meadville formed a committee to adopt rules for breaking ground.⁶⁵

Work on the canal was kicked off with a ritual demonstration of civic pride. A crowd from Meadville and surrounding communities was milling in the streets on August 27, 1827 when they were called to order by the booming discharge of a cannon and bells ringing in church steeples and the courthouse. A procession formed up following a strict order worked out ahead of time, with local dignitaries in the lead. Records of the event show those falling

⁶⁴ Erie Gazette, June 28, 1827: p3c1.

⁶⁵ This meeting was held on August 21, 1827. Another gathering was called three days later to arrange proper ceremonies.

in behind included the militia, a band of music, a president of the ceremonies, secretaries, persons designated to break the ground, laborers, a couple of vice-presidents, and even "a team of seven yoke of oxen, with a plough." After reaching the designated section of the canal, a hollow square was formed around a podium. Invocations and speeches followed until the time arrived for turning the first shovel load of dirt. According to the local press the following moments proved "in the highest degree interesting" when "Robert Fitz Randolph and Cornelius VanHorne, the one nearly 90 and the other 80 years of age, performed this duty with as much alacrity as if the light of but 20 summers only had shone, upon their heads."⁶⁶

Next the oxen pulled a plough through the entire section, and laborers carted off the upturned dirt and clay in wheelbarrows. Thirteen cannon thundered a salute to their efforts, and the town turned to "a cold collation prepared by the committee while "the head of a barrel of fine old whiskey was staved in." After partaking of these entertainments, the procession reformed and marched to the public square, where the marshal and committee

⁶⁶ Reynolds, "Reminiscences of the Old Canal," manuscript, Crawford County Historical Society: 3-6; Reynolds, In French Creek Valley, 274-275.

thanked the crowd for a proper deportment, and dismissed them.⁶⁷

Public enthusiasm ebbed over the following two years until November 28, 1829, when another round of ceremonies was held to inaugurate navigation on the feeder. Construction had not progressed beyond those sections let to bidders two years earlier, and the two boats engaged on this maiden voyage only travelled between three and four miles downstream. However, state and local leaders had determined that some show of support for the canal was required to revive enthusiasm for the project.

In their hurry to get construction underway, state leaders and their engineers failed to adequately consider the influences of the Allegheny Mountains in central Pennsylvania. From Pittsburgh, the Western Division of the Canal was projected up the Allegheny River to the mouth of Conemaugh, and then eastward to Johnstown in front of the western slopes of the Allegheny Mountains. Construction coming from the opposite end of the state drew in the old Union Canal and continued through the Eastern Division and Juniata Division to Hollidaysburg, across the heights from Johnstown. None of the promoters was unduly concerned about getting a canal through the intervening heights, until several years after work was started.

⁶⁷ Ibid.

One early proposal called for opening a tunnel through the mountains, though this was clearly beyond the engineering and construction capabilities of the time. Workmen would have to chisel through nearly four miles of rock to join the opposing ports. Substituting a wagon portage was not likely to succeed either, because of the great heights and steep slopes in the area. The most probable solution was to alter the path of the main line, but politicians who had pushed this program through the legislature feared breaking promises and adding costs for new surveys. Spending thousands of tax dollars to promote a flawed design could not be explained away without consequences.

Adapting railroads to local conditions offered a face-saving solution. Railroads had found new favor in Pennsylvania after their hurried dismissal during prior debates over the Main Line Canal. While workmen for the Chesapeake and Ohio Canal carved out a ditch along the Potomac River, merchants sitting in Baltimore had decided to hedge their chances for success with a horse-drawn railroad on a parallel path. Following their customary pattern in responding to competition, Philadelphia merchants embraced this idea as a model of progress.

Some of the business leaders in that city were already frustrated with plans for using the old Union Canal as the eastern

end of the Main Line. Excavations for forerunners of the Union Canal had struck nearly solid bedrock, and barely fifteen miles of that improvement had been finished in thirty years.⁶⁸ Railroads appeared eminently more practical, given this solid footing and cost projections for cutting the ditch any further. State leaders responded in their own typical fashion, by continuing work on both projects. While work on the Union Canal neared completion on March 24, 1828, both houses of the state legislature approved construction of a railroad between Columbia and Philadelphia.

A local rail boom unfolded as citizens living outside of Philadelphia and away from the canal demanded rail service. Lateral lines were being built before the main stem of the Columbia Railroad was even finished. This new-found favor with railroads eased questions of how to cross the Allegheny Mountains. On March 21, 1831, Governor Wolf signed into law "An Act to Continue the Improvement of the State by Canal and Railroads."⁶⁹ Early supporters of railroads took this as a tacit admission they had been right all along. Most tax payers were content that work was going forward on a unified system and waited for the benefits of

⁶⁸ Shank, Amazing Pennsylvania Canals, 40.

⁶⁹ Roberts, Reminiscences, 372; McCullough and Leuba, Pennsylvania Main Line Canal, 62; Shank, Amazing Pennsylvania Canals, 32.

their tax dollars to come home to them.⁷⁰ Others grumbled about poor planning and the rising costs of the public works and called for changes in public spending policies.

Conclusion

Politics in Pennsylvania had always been guided by the major market centers. This produced gross inequities in how public funds were spent, and canal building did not greatly change this situation. Mounting competition for trade had sometimes forced state leaders to adopt a conciliatory attitude between the different sections of Pennsylvania; tax payers they had ignored for years were courted for funds and votes, but this spirit of cooperation did not last.

Philadelphia and Pittsburgh looked at Baltimore as their chief rival through 1817, when New York started work on the Erie Canal. Merchants from Baltimore had adopted an aggressive policy of opening roads and river improvements to capture new sources of trade, and they showed scant regard for political boundaries.

⁷⁰ Pennsylvania Reporter, February 10, 1832: p3c3. Western counties in Pennsylvania threw their support behind Wolf, expecting a solid return for their votes. James Duncan of Mercer declined to run on the opposition ticket, and declared the government in Harrisburg "have sadly mistaken the politics of the West."

Pennsylvania state leaders responded with a dual campaign to open their own roads and close their common boundaries.

This deadlock was broken in 1804 when federal authorities started building a public highway through the Appalachians from western Maryland. The National Road was intended to promote unity and forge ties between states on both sides of the mountains, but Pennsylvania merchants only saw disaster for themselves. Federal authorities tried to reduce resentment in Pennsylvania by looping part of the highway up into Southwestern Pennsylvania on the way to the Ohio River. This was not enough to reduce the advantages handed to Baltimore, so state authorities promoted a rival building program inside Pennsylvania boundaries.

Pennsylvania politicians and business leaders had already set a pattern of imitating their competitors (going back to the middle of the eighteenth century). During each crisis the separate sections of the state pulled together in common cause, but old rivalries surfaced once the situation was under control. Pennsylvania successfully met the challenge of the National Road by building a turnpike between Pittsburgh and Philadelphia and opening branch lines through the state. However, the benefits of improved highways were soon discounted by the appearance of steamboats on western rivers and improved methods of building canals. Merchants

from New York successfully used these tools to fashion a commercial network spanning their state from the Hudson River at Albany to the Great Lakes, with extensions reaching across Ohio into the Mississippi watershed.

Sectional politics in Pennsylvania was again eclipsed by the need to forge a common response. Business and political leaders in Pennsylvania developed their own version of that work that was styled the Pennsylvania Main Line Canal, but it faced strong opposition because of costs and doubts it could ever be finished. Politicians and businessmen from Philadelphia and Pittsburgh forged new relations to try and push the issue forward against strong opposition.

Settlers in Northwest Pennsylvania were thrilled that for once they had been included in state policy decisions. They failed to realize this did not presage a rising sense of fairness over how to distribute tax dollars in the state legislature or business offices in Philadelphia and Pittsburgh. Instead, it reflected a simple truth that every vote was needed to get the canal program underway and keep it running at public expense.

Chapter 4:

CANAL BUILDING AND THE EMERGENCE OF SECTIONAL INTERESTS IN NORTHWEST PENNSYLVANIA, 1827-1835

Waterways still served as the primary highways of the United States in the early nineteenth century. Proponents of the Main Line system had promised extensions and branch lines to all parts of Pennsylvania in exchange for votes to fund their projects. Inhabitants of Northwest Pennsylvania had eagerly agreed to support the Main Line project as a result, but they failed to get concrete guarantees of what they might expect in return. This oversight proved costly in later years since state leaders had not thought that far ahead. State leaders started work on the French Creek Feeder Canal near Meadville in 1827 in a bid to demonstrate the widespread benefits of spending tax dollars on canals. However, there was no clear consensus on how to proceed from there or even where the canal might go.

Anxious citizens submitted dozens of proposals for possible routes to the Board of Canal Commissioners once public resources were committed to building canals. State legislators who had agreed to fund multiple branch lines gingerly accepted the reports, but an overwhelming majority of these petitions did not survive

their first reading. Only those branch lines serving politically sensitive regions were addressed.

Settlement had spread through Northwest Pennsylvania using the streams and portages between them. Cabins and villages were scattered all over Northwest Pennsylvania by the 1820s with the heaviest concentrations on French Creek, the Beaver River and the shore of Lake Erie around the harbor at Presque Isle. Construction was started near Meadville because at that time it was the most populated locality in Northwest Pennsylvania. However, merchants and tax payers in every settlement of Northwest Pennsylvania felt the canal should pass through their area in return for their political support and tax dollars.

State leaders accommodated this outcry with rough plans for extending the canal above Meadville and westward to cover the entire northwestern corner of the state. A separate extension of the Main Line Canal was sketched down the Ohio River from Pittsburgh to the Beaver River, and up into its Shenango and Mahoning feeders. This design was calculated to tap the resources of counties on the western state line and the old Firelands of northeastern Ohio up to the shores of Lake Erie. An expanded view of the state canal program called for eventually merging these two systems into a broad network completely covering Northwest

Pennsylvania.

Work started on the canals with a view of meeting this goal, but a looming budget crisis called for checks on spending. State leaders reacted by combining the different lines into a single program and paring back their plans, which generated competition between localities hoping to draw the canal in their direction. Any sense of common purpose faltered, and the political landscape of Northwest Pennsylvania began breaking down into local interests. State leaders grew fearful of offending voters and let the matter drift aimlessly in hopes that it would somehow work itself out. This indecision had devastating consequences for the canal program when voters from other parts of Pennsylvania protested against these added costs.

Construction is pushed on French Creek

Hopes for developing new channels of movement and commerce in Northwest Pennsylvania were heightened by the introduction of steamboats on the Allegheny River in 1829, but this development generated conflicts with other parts of the state.

The earliest steamboats used on the western rivers had displayed deep drafts with twin paddle wheels hanging over both sides. It was difficult and dangerous to take them on shallow rivers like the

Allegheny, where the hulls and wheels were chipped and broken on rocks and other obstructions. Several steamboats had gone up the Allegheny River to Kittaning under normal conditions, but each turned back before reaching Franklin. Surveys on this stretch between Kittaning and Franklin revealed no less than 35 shoals covering an aggregate distance of three miles. A steamer called the "William B. Duncan" made it up to Franklin during a rise in 1828, but excitement lagged when the waters fell back to normal levels. Managing the "Duncan" proved difficult under these conditions and boat owners at Pittsburgh said that the upper part of the river was simply not suited for steamers.¹ Merchants and farmers based on the upper Allegheny and its branches argued that regular service was possible if another type of craft was introduced.

Thomas Blanchard of Massachusetts had reconfigured the standard Fulton design for use on the shallow rivers of New England, incorporating a low hull and a single paddle wheel in the stern. These modifications stood up to some of the worst conditions, and in 1829 Blanchard embarked on a tour of the western waters to promote his invention. David Dick of Meadville organized a

¹ The "William B. Duncan" was pulled off the Allegheny River and sold out the area during the following year. It later turned up running passengers on the Missouri River.

company of investors to fund the construction of a steamboat on the Blanchard plan.² Shipwrights at Pittsburgh launched this vessel as the "Allegheny" in time for the next boating season, on March 20, 1830.

After issuing bold promises of success, the owners and investors meekly started the "Allegheny" upstream on April 13, 1830 "in rather an unprepared state, being desirous of trying the boat before the water got too low."³ After passing Kittanning, the Allegheny encountered unexpected swift currents, and had to be warped about thirty feet through a narrow and swift running channel before reaching Franklin. Operators blamed the difficulty on the poor quality of the wood taken aboard as fuel, which kept the steam pressure to two-thirds of its expected level.⁴ This faulty performance did not diminish the excitement in communities up and down the river where the steamer passed.

Public acclaim for this route was reinforced by two more voyages up the river in the following month. After securing a new supply of fuel, the "Allegheny" departed Pittsburgh again on May 2, 1830.

² Pittsburgh Gazette, October 9, 1829: p3c2.

³ Pittsburgh Gazette, April 27, 1830: p3c1.

⁴ Pittsburgh Gazette, April 30, 1830: p3c2; May 4, 1830: p3c1.

Improved performance brought the craft home within a week, after reaching "the mouth of Kenjua, fourteen miles above Warren, a distance of 200 miles" and taking on freight and passengers. Steam operators commented that this same trip would take at least eighteen days by keelboat.⁵ The steamship operators predicted they could easily increase their speed and reach up the river with experience. A third voyage that was intended to test the limits of the craft set off on May 14, 1830 with 64 passengers and 25 tons of freight. Within a week the vessel pulled alongside the wharf at Olean, New York.

Reports of this successful outcome for the steamer propelled the Pennsylvania legislature into action. While the "Allegheny" was being prepared for its trial run that spring, the seasonal navigation from the upper waters descended on Pittsburgh. From "90 to 100 flat bottomed boats" were launched on French Creek between Waterford and Bemus Mills, with an "equal, if not greater" number between Meadville and the mouth of French Creek. Reports coming from Pittsburgh valued the boats and produce at no less than one hundred thousand dollars.⁶ State figures called for immediate measures to protect this trade and keep it from seeking out other

⁵ Pittsburgh Gazette, May 11, 1830: p3c1.

⁶ Pittsburgh Gazette, March 30, 1830: p3c1.

paths. Inaugurating steam navigation on the Allegheny River meant some of the boats could be towed up toward Olean and the Erie Canal.

State authorities considered their options and decided to start work on twenty-two miles of slackwater pools and canals between the French Creek Aqueduct of the Feeder Canal (below Meadville) and the Allegheny River at Franklin. This new work was designated the Franklin Line, and it was combined with the French Creek Feeder Canal for administrative purposes. State leaders planned to eventually join the Franklin Line with improvements on the lower Allegheny River, while leaving the waters above Franklin in a rough state to discourage use.

Proponents of this work were so anxious to get started that contracts and engineering specifications for the Franklin Line were already drawn up when the legislature approved funding on May 31, 1831. This bill also authorized work on the Beaver River near the Ohio state boundary in order to maintain broad support for building branch lines.⁷ However, plans for a quick start on French Creek faded when the engineer who was nominated to direct the work declined the appointment. The canal commissioners then expressed their hopes that a suitable replacement might still be found in

⁷ "General Trade," JS 1827, volume I: 433.

time for letting the work on July 8, 1831.⁸

Alonzo Livermore was consequently brought back into state service on this division, after resigning from the Main Line in 1829. By the first week in June, a survey party including assistants and hired hands had been organized and dispatched to the woods along French Creek. While they had started late, Livermore gave assurances that the entire line from the aqueduct to Franklin would be surveyed in time.⁹

Specifications for the Franklin Line included 17 locks and 12 dams, with a little more than eight miles of canal, and seventeen miles of slackwater. Contracts for the work were released, but the canal commissioners were apparently second guessing decisions to start the work. Over eleven thousand dollars was diverted from the Franklin Line to other projects, from a base appropriation of sixty thousand dollars. Other allocations had to be shared with the feeder.¹⁰

Inadequate funds for the Franklin Line were quickly exhausted, with the inevitable result that the workmen became discouraged, and

⁸ Crawford Messenger, May 5, 1831: p3c1.

⁹ Crawford Messenger, June 9, 1831: p3c1.

¹⁰ "French Creek Feeder. Report of John Anderson, Superintendent," JHR 1832-33, appendix: 157-158.

sought employment elsewhere. Word of emergency funding arrived too late to help. Alonzo Livermore reported that when construction resumed "laborers could not be had at any price, sufficient to carry on the work with that degree of rapidity requisite, until late in the season."¹¹

While state authorities scrambled to provide funding, local residents used the delay to examine the works for themselves. A committee of boatmen and lumbermen discovered the outlet locks at Franklin were too small for their liking, and petitioned for changes. Officials sitting in Harrisburg happily obliged their constituents and increased the dimensions of the locks during the coming season, ignoring any work already done.¹²

Locks on the state canals followed a standard pattern 90 feet long and 15 feet wide in the chamber. Locks on the upper part of the Franklin Line were widened by three feet. The outlet lock at the mouth of French Creek was completely revamped to measure 122 feet long, by 22 feet wide, permitting small steamers to pass. Alonzo Livermore estimated the added costs at more than twenty-two

¹¹ "Report of Alonzo Livermore," JHR 1832-33, appendix: 160.

¹² Crawford Messenger, February 4, 1832: p2c5.

thousand dollars.¹³

Officials concerned with the Franklin Line could hardly add these costs to their budget. By 1832, escalating costs and free spending of this sort through the entire state program called for a policy of financial retrenchment in Harrisburg. Already scant funding for the Franklin Line dried up as funds were shifted to finish the Main Line. Complaints heard in the Beaver Valley and other parts of the state echoed along French Creek.

Alonzo Livermore complained "the doubtful course pursued by the Legislature during the session of 1831-2 came near ruining many of those concerned in heavy jobs." After purchasing tools, provisions and supplies on credit, miserly appropriations for the line "proved an illusive hope" to the contractors. Some abandoned their contracts, while others held on in hopes of recovering something of their losses.¹⁴

Funding difficulties for the Franklin Line was compounded by its administrative connections with the feeder. This particular work was proving to be one of the most wasteful drains of the state's financial resources. Alonzo Livermore protested at the end of 1832

¹³ "Report of Alonzo Livermore," JHR 1832-3, appendix: 160; Crawford Messenger, February 4, 1832: p3c1.

¹⁴ "Report of Alonzo Livermore, Engineer," JHR 1833-4, appendix: 118.

that the French Creek Feeder was yet to be put to any productive use, "owing to want of connection to French Creek."¹⁵

Residents of the area may have wistfully remembered prediction of a "tub" at the groundbreaking ceremonies five years earlier. Even though the feeder had been extended across French Creek, no connections with open waters had been made at either end. The French Creek Feeder was simply a costly trough, filled by minor streams and rainfalls.

Work on the feeder dam above Meadville was interrupted by the budget crisis in 1831, reducing chances of opening an outlet at that end in the foreseeable future. Before work could resume in 1832, floodwaters battered parts of the dam that were in place. An ice jam in French Creek tore down the valley in January 1832, wrecking public and private property. Bridges were torn down over a distance of twenty miles to the Allegheny River, and the dam at McCalmont and Hays ironworks near Franklin was swept away.¹⁶ Faced with reduced funding for the year, there was little supervisors on the line could do to repair the damage. Instead, Superintendent John Anderson advertised for bids on two bridges and abutments in

¹⁵ "Report of Alonzo Livermore, Engineer," JHR 1832-3, appendix: 159.

¹⁶ Crawford Messenger, January 28, 1832: p3c1.

Meadville.¹⁷

State officials revived their expectations for the coming season when news of the Girard donation reached Meadville. Bidding was immediately opened for nearly four miles of canal to join the feeder with Conneaut Lake, with a new dam and a pair of locks. Residents of that area reserved judgement after suffering years of postponements and delays, although some of the opinions expressed in local newspapers exposed bitterness toward the state program and questioned why it had taken so long to reach this point.¹⁸ Damage was still evident from floods and ice earlier in the year. In June 1832, Jacob Shattuck advertised that he had relocated his "celebrated Carding and Picking machine" away from the state dam at Bemus Mills for want of water power.¹⁹

Laborers were again in short supply when funds became available on the division, repeating what had become an annoying and tiresome pattern for local residents. Like the year before, the season for canal work had largely passed by the time workers drifted back to the state improvements. Construction had barely resumed when

¹⁷ Crawford Messenger, May 12, 1832: p3c5.

¹⁸ Crawford Messenger, June 16, 1832: p3c3; June 23, 1832: p3c4.

¹⁹ Crawford Messenger, June 2, 1832: p3c4.

summer turned to fall with six weeks of unusually wet weather, forcing an early end to work for the year. The critical dam and outlet lock at Franklin had to be abandoned until the following year.

After an initial focus on the feeder, attention drifted back downstream when local farmers tried to run the seasonal rise to Pittsburgh. The supervisor and engineer of the division had foreseen this event, and advertised that French Creek was perfectly safe for navigation and free of any obstructions to boating.²⁰ Twelve out of sixteen boats trying to get down French Creek were destroyed or severely damaged afterwards trying to pass the dam at Franklin. Boatmen complained that dangerous conditions for navigation were masked by a misleading press release, leaving them to suffer the consequences.²¹

Boatmen learned their lesson and waited for especially high waters before making another attempt. When heavy snow melt raised the creek during the first two weeks in April 1833, between 150 and 200 boats started downstream for Pittsburgh before the waters fell close to normal levels.²² When two days of heavy rain raised water

²⁰ Meadville Courier, November 21, 1832: p2c4.

²¹ Crawford Messenger, December 8, 1832: p2c4.

²² Crawford Messenger, April 17, 1833: p3c2.

levels in May, boatmen who missed the first run took advantage of the opportunity presented to them.²³ Their anger at state officials remained even after all of the boats got safely downstream.

Outraged citizens called for a new assembly at the courthouse in Meadville on May 22, 1833 to voice their concerns. Speakers reviewed the construction history of the French Creek Division and demanded tangible progress. Over nineteen and a half miles of the feeder had been finished without any benefit to communities along its path and navigation on French Creek was again reduced to a seasonal occupation with added dangers from the ruined state works. Farmers and entrepreneurs failed to see any benefits or increased opportunities for reaching new markets. Frustration with state officials was compounded by news from Harrisburg that no new constructions were authorized on the feeder. State leaders mistakenly concluded the line was finished after reading the optimistic reports submitted by Superintendent John Anderson and Alonzo Livermore.²⁴

Emergency funds were released to rectify this situation, but the bulk of the canal budget was already tied up in other projects. Contractors were pushed hard to speed up their efforts and reduce

²³ Meadville Courier, May 14, 1833: p2c6.

²⁴ Crawford Messenger, May 29, 1833: p3c3.

payments for the hours worked, but funding dwindled and construction was suspended again "on those jobs that would be least calculated to affect the public interest."²⁵ Men and money were diverted from the French Creek Feeder Canal so boats could use French Creek during the fall rise. Almost every contract on the feeder canal was suspended, including work on the dam and an attached guard lock. If these were finished before the Franklin Line, then no boats from the upper creek could pass downstream.²⁶ All parties apparently hoped to avoid a repetition of the boating disaster in the preceding December.

Alonzo Livermore reported "adding expense to our works to ensure their permanence." Protective walls and guard banks were increased in size, and additional work was authorized to protect the foundations and abutments of the dams.²⁷ This course paid dividends later in the year, when autumn floodwaters crashed down the valley. Nearly all of the locks and dams escaped major damage. Alonzo Livermore surveyed the effects of the flood and reported that only

²⁵ "French Creek division. Report of John Anderson, Superintendent," JHR 1833-4, appendix: 115.

²⁶ "French Creek division. Report of John Anderson, Superintendent," JHR 1833-4, appendix: 115.

²⁷ "Report of Alonzo Livermore, Engineer," JHR 1833-34, appendix: 118.

Dam No. 4 was "considerably injured by the first rise of water this fall, on account of being in an unfinished state."²⁸

Congratulations on this turn of events were almost immediately countered by another budget crisis. Work had barely resumed on the Franklin Line when the inadequate appropriation from the spring was depleted. With no contingency fund at hand, Superintendent Anderson ordered a halt to all constructions except for "those jobs which interfere with the navigation of French Creek."²⁹ Contractors on other parts of the line were advised that "should they think proper to complete, they may do so, at their own risque."³⁰

Critics charged that the line might have been finished if state authorities had acted responsibly toward Northwest Pennsylvania. Divisional officials had not only failed to open French Creek for navigation, but diverting their meager appropriation to the Franklin Line guaranteed the feeder would remain useless for some time to come. Opening a junction with French Creek had been postponed when the canal commissioners moved the location of the

²⁸ "Report of Alonzo Livermore, Engineer," JHR 1833-4, appendix: 119.

²⁹ "Report of Alonzo Livermore, Engineer," JHR 1833-4, appendix: 119.

³⁰ "Report of John Anderson, Superintendent," JHR 1833-4, appendix: 117.

feeder dam a short distance up stream. Materials had been gathered on site, but went unused when the job had to be bid again. By the time contracts were released for construction, all funding had been diverted to the Franklin Line.³¹

State figures answered the public clamor with an aggressive building campaign the following year. Funds were earmarked for finishing the Franklin Line, and opening either end of the feeder canal. Once work was underway for the year, engineers staked out the pool of the feeder dam for additional improvements.³²

The customary shortage of labor during the harvest season temporarily slowed the work, and contractors were urged to push ahead with any means at hand. Almost as quickly as workers returned to the canal, jobs were reported finished and ready for final estimates and payment. Water was let into the canal through Meadville during the last week in October, 1834.³³

A mob jostled for vantage points on the Chestnut Street bridge

³¹ "Report of Alonzo Livermore," JHR 1833-34, appendix: 119-120.

³² "French Creek Division. Report of J. Anderson, Superintendent," JS 1834/5, appendix: 98, 100; "French Creek Division. Report of Alonzo Livermore, Engineer," JS 1834/5, appendix: 101.

³³ "French Creek Division. Report of J. Anderson, Superintendent," JS 1834/5, appendix: 98, 100; "French Creek Division. Report of Alonzo Livermore, Engineer," JS 1834/5, appendix: 101.

in Meadville to witness the first boats passing by. As bystanders joined the fray, five or six craft descended the feeder toward the Franklin Line and the Allegheny River.³⁴ A small breach opened during the night and drained the canal south of Meadville, but it was immediately closed and twenty boats passed down within the week.³⁵ Traffic from the opposite direction finally appeared near dark between 7-8 P.M., on November 13, 1834. A boat called the "French Creek Pioneer" reached Meadville from Franklin behind three horses and loaded with passengers.³⁶ Boating on the new works continued into the first week of December, when "Messrs. Dick of Meadville" sent a large boat loaded with pearl ash and scorched salts for Pittsburgh. Another craft reached Meadville carrying the household furniture of Alonzo Livermore. Five more craft headed downstream in quick succession, while two came up from Franklin as

³⁴ Crawford Messenger, October 31, 1834: p3c2, p3c3.

³⁵ Crawford Messenger, October 31, 1834: p3c2; p3c3. "Tribune Republican," Meadville, 0-16. This latter source places the first voyage on the canal on November 14, 1834, leading some writers to cite that date. This pair of sources reflects traffic going in opposite directions two weeks apart. The latter date marks the first successful voyage against the current, but boats had certainly gone down the canal before then.

³⁶ Crawford Messenger, November 14, 1834: p3c1; Beaver Argus, November 28, 1834: p2c6; Reynolds, "Remiscences of the Old Canal," manuscript, Crawford County Historical Society: 7.

far as the aqueduct.³⁷

Local sources that had vilified state authorities in the past reversed their course and congratulated John Anderson and Alonzo Livermore for the "workmanlike appearance of everything connected with this field of their operation."³⁸ Longstanding complaints about the French Creek Feeder Canal were overshadowed by celebrations stretching down the valley from Meadville. Additional praise was heaped on the Franklin Line when the works survived the spring freshet. French Creek was "running high" with ice and spring melt in 1835 when observers noted the dams "appear to stand the racket very well."³⁹

During a single week in April 1835, more than forty boats passed along the canal through Meadville with cargoes of hay, oats, whiskey, potatoes and lumber for the Pittsburgh market. About one hundred more were reported on French Creek and ready to descend.⁴⁰

Public officials were so pleased with this outcome that they started talking about extending the line. Alonzo Livermore had already examined French Creek up to Waterford in 1833 and declared

³⁷ Crawford Messenger, December 6, 1833: p3c1.

³⁸ Crawford Messenger, December 13, 1834: p3c3.

³⁹ Franklin Intelligencer, March 17, 1835: p3c3.

⁴⁰ Crawford Messenger, April 4, 1835: p3c2.

that French Creek was fully capable of supporting slackwater navigation to that point, even during the dry months of summer.

Opponents of spending additional state funds questioned whether Livermore's calculations of water volumes in French Creek and its tributaries were correct. Some writers have repeated claims to the present day that French Creek just could not support slackwater navigation. This argument was blunted in dramatic fashion when excess water decided the fate of the Franklin Line.

The fall rains arrived on October 18, 1835 and continued in torrents through the following day. French Creek reached heights not seen for thirty years or more, and several persons were nearly drowned in this gurgling onslaught. A stagecoach was pushed off the Mercer Turnpike where it crossed the Conneaut Marsh between Mercer and Meadville. Lands bordering French Creek disappeared beneath a widening and increasingly violent lake.

Eyewitness reported lumber, fences, hay stacks, and "pumpkins innumerable" were swept away, and even whole structures; at one point, a small frame house was seen floating downstream. A farmer named Peter Houser lost a small log stable with 50 bushels of oats, and was likely to lose his home in the same manner. Rising waters at the lower end of the valley forced residents to abandon their homes or "betake themselves to the second floor and peep out, Noah

like, at the beautiful sheet of water around them."⁴¹ Water completely covered the locks and dams at the lower end of French Creek, and their locations were only identified by ripples in the water passing over.

Falling waters in subsequent days revealed how badly the Franklin Line had been damaged. Several locks and dams had been undermined and were in danger of collapse, and lock gates were battered and torn loose. The lower lock at Franklin could not be opened for fears of draining the entire slackwater pool. One observer wrote "As it is now, it presents one of the most sickening wrecks imaginable." Lumbermen were notified they could not run their logs past the big dam, and would be advised when it was passable again.⁴² Laborers were instantly hired to mitigate this disaster, but they were released within a week for lack of funds to pay them. Citizens of Venango County, Crawford County and Erie County calculated that spending \$1,000 in the next few weeks could save the state from \$50,000 to \$75,000 later on, and they proposed raising this modest sum to get the work started.⁴³ State

⁴¹ Franklin Intelligencer, October 27, 1835: p3c2-3; Erie Gazette, November 5, 1835: p3c2-3.

⁴² Franklin Intelligencer, October 27, 1835: p3c2-3; Erie Gazette, November 5, 1835: p3c2-3.

⁴³ Franklin Intelligencer, November 24, 1835: p3c4.

authorities declined all offers for loans or donations outside of proper bureaucratic channels and waited for an appropriation from Harrisburg. Damaged parts of the Franklin Line went unattended for weeks as a result. Officials connected with the French Creek Division finally advertised for 300 laborers just before the start of the following boating season to try and make the works passable.⁴⁴

Newspaper accounts of their early efforts predicted a favorable outcome for the boating season. The lock and dam at Franklin were said to be finished by the middle of April except for hanging the lock gates, and this operation was to commence shortly.⁴⁵ Navigation was scheduled to resume on April 22, 1836 but boatmen trying to use the line quickly discovered the works were in a miserable condition. Two locks had collapsed above Franklin, Dam No. 4 was entirely carried away, the feeder dam was in ruins, and several other dams were so injured that boats could not pass without serious risk of loss and injury.⁴⁶ Bids were opened in June for work on Dam No. 7 and some smaller jobs, but funding for the

⁴⁴ Franklin Intelligencer, March 8, 1836: p3c5.

⁴⁵ Franklin Intelligencer, April 19, 1836: p3c1.

⁴⁶ JHR 1838, volume III: 114.

division could not cover the full costs of extensive repairs.⁴⁷ The Franklin Line was reported in a "dilapidated and ruinous condition" near the end of the year. Superintendent John Anderson meekly suggested the line should be repaired to take advantage of the increasing steamship traffic on the Allegheny River.⁴⁸ There was a real chance the Franklin Line would be abandoned in favor of the Beaver Division.

A rival system takes shape on the Beaver River

Preliminary work on the Beaver Division had commenced in 1831 at the head of the Beaver River near New Castle, where Neshannock Creek and the Shenango River merge. State legislators voted more than \$100,000 for starting work, and the canal commissioners pushed ahead at a frantic pace. There was a real fear that funding could be reduced or withdrawn for other uses.

Engineers assigned to plot the canal started down the east bank of the Beaver River toward the Ohio River on May 4, 1831, and within a week they had progressed two and a half miles. They were properly charged with investigating both banks to determine the best means of construction, but the canal commissioners were

⁴⁷ Franklin Intelligencer, May 31, 1836: p3c5.

⁴⁸ JHR 1838, volume III: 114.

already seeking bids for the work. This course was later justified as necessary for protecting this valuable line of commerce.⁴⁹ Certain parts of line were therefore advertised from April 15, 1831 through July 20, 1831 while the engineers worked out the final details. Engineers who looked at this problem suggested a series of locks and dams, but deferred to the canal commissioners in making a final determination.⁵⁰ Parts of the Beaver River were characterized by sharp drops which provided ample water power for industry. This circumstance made the Beaver Valley one of the most heavily industrialized parts of Pennsylvania and raised talk that it might eventually rival Pittsburgh. Any modification of normal stream patterns was therefore bound to effect the local and regional economy, and the engineers who were laying out the Beaver division did not press their authority. Their reports and any suggestions how to proceed were hurriedly forwarded to the canal commissioners, and then to the highest levels of state government.

Governor Wolfe finally decided to view this setting for himself before making any decision.

Proponents of the Beaver Division saw the opportunity they were

⁴⁹ Beaver Argus, May 13, 1831: p2c4; Crawford Messenger, May 26, 1831: p3c3.

⁵⁰ Beaver Argus, July 15, 1831, p2c3.

given and welcomed his presence, proposing that "Should the Governor pass through our county, and view the unequalled advantages we possess, the facility of improvement, and the benefit that the State will derive from such improvement, he will no longer doubt the propriety of extending the Pennsylvania canal to Lake Erie."⁵¹ Their enthusiasm was rewarded when the governor and his aides toured the area on June 11, 1831. According to the local press, Governor Wolfe was "suitably astonished and delighted" at the extent of the water power and the adjacent manufacturing plants.⁵² This approbation encouraged the canal commissioners and their engineers to push ahead with their plans. Six miles of canal were consequently located from New Castle to Clark's Mills, where the Beaver Division entered a series of slackwater pools and short canals leading down to the Ohio River.

At this point some of the businessmen who had plants on the lower part of the Beaver River grew nervous over possible interruptions in their trades. After his visit in June, they expected the governor would somehow give them a canal while making

⁵¹ Beaver Argus, June 10, 1831: p2c3.

⁵² Beaver Argus, June 17, 1831: p2c3. One reporter who observed these proceedings commented that the governor "like most of the eastern people, had very mistaken notions of the great and increasing prosperity and natural advantages of the west."

accommodations to protect local manufacturing. Industrial leaders from Fallston (on the western bank) urged workers and citizens to attend a rally planned for July 6, 1831. Fallston and adjacent communities were fully represented on this occasion, with a large contingent from East Beaver and West Brighton on the opposite shore. Officers who were elected to guide this meeting declared their purpose was to provide benefits for the entire valley with as little injury as possible. Those in attendance drew up a resolution calling on state leaders to adopt a slackwater construction with canals around the falls. Copies were dispatched throughout the valley with a call for joint action. Residents of Beaver, Sharon and Bridgewater considered the matter and added their support a week later.⁵³ In the meantime, state officials proceeded with work on the upper line while they considered this request.

Plans of the locks, dams, and other structures on the upper parts of the division were on public display, and contractors were reported "coming in from all quarters" to submit bids. Contracts for the full six miles of canal on the upper end of the line and sixteen miles of slackwater, with seventeen locks and six dams were released on July 20, 1831 nearly as soon as the deadline for

⁵³ Beaver Argus, July 8, 1831: p2c4; July 15, 1831: p2c2.

accepting bids had passed. A committee was already in place to arrange proper ceremonies for starting the work.

A procession was formed on the east bank opposite Fallston in the early afternoon of July 26, 1831. Committee members arranged the dignitaries according to the prescribed manner. A marshal of ceremonies led the procession, trailed in order by a music band, the orator of the day, president of the committee, vice-presidents, secretaries, veterans of the Revolution, canal engineers, members of the legislature, half the committee of arrangement, a yoke of oxen with plough, the other half of the committee with picks and shovels, and as many citizens as cared to join in marching two by two, with an assistant marshal bringing up the rear. After a short tramp East Brighton, the marchers formed a hollow square around the ground staked out for building lock no. 12 on the Beaver Division. The site was then "broken by the revolutionary Soldiers with Oxen, Plough, shovels and Picks, followed by the firing of cannon, and the shouts of the citizens." The entire body then returned to a grove opposite Fallston for the usual speeches and dinner.⁵⁴ Work started on some of the other sections the following day.

Under the terms of successful bids, contractors were required to come forward and sign an agreement with the state no later than

⁵⁴ Beaver Argus, July 29, 1831: p2c3.

August 15, 1831. By this time, state authorities had made their decision how to proceed with the lower part of the Beaver Division leading down into the Ohio River and opened bidding through October 19, 1831.

A canal just over a mile in length was marked out on opposite Fallston, leaving the mill dams intact. At its lower end, the canal opened on a slackwater pool that reached to the Ohio River three miles away. Thoughts of continuing a canal over this distance were discounted over fears it would disrupt local trade and isolate the west bank. State officials were also deeply concerned that the Beaver Division should accommodate traffic from the Ohio River. Stone's Point at the confluence of the Beaver and the Ohio was already regarded as the safest and most commodious landing between Pittsburgh and Cincinnati, and much of the trade coming out of the Western Reserve in Ohio passed through this landing. A pair of unusually large locks was therefore designed to pass steamboats from the Ohio River into the lower pool of the Beaver Division up to Fallston and New Brighton.⁵⁵ Opening the line to river trade increased its value to the state even if a connection to the Main Line was not effected.

⁵⁵ "Beaver Division. Report of W. Milnor Roberts-relative to repairs," JS 1838-9, volume III: 418; Corkan, The Beaver and Lake Erie Canal, 28-29.

Optimistic forecasts from the canal commissioners predicted the entire Beaver Division would be finished by December 1832. Arguments about mounting costs in the state legislature during the following winter eroded these hopes. Funding for all branch lines was stricken from the appropriations bill in response to a growing budget crisis, and the canal commissioners warned subordinates to guard against increasing their debts. Contractors on the Beaver Division were notified on March 5, 1832 that funding for this part of the public works was exhausted and that any additional work "would not be considered as incurring a debt against the commonwealth." Construction almost instantly ceased along the entire line.⁵⁶ Inhabitants of Beaver County and adjacent areas feared construction might never resume and they assembled in protest. Officials sitting in Harrisburg were called on to meet their moral obligations and prevent an economic disaster. Laborers would seek other work if nothing was done, while contractors were ruined by debt; mill owners were afraid to make improvements or revive old works on the canal because they wondered if the state had relinquished the property.⁵⁷

⁵⁶ "Report of John Dickey, Superintendent," JHR 1832-33, appendix: 161.

⁵⁷ Western Argus, April 6, 1832: p3c4.

Work on the Beaver Division had stalled a full month when an emergency appropriation was passed on April 5, 1832. News that the legislature passed this bill was hurriedly dispatched westward from Harrisburg, with the advice that contractors were free to resume work or relinquish their contracts for any money owed to them. Most contractors picked up where they had left off, but a pair of locks, two sections of towpath, and a handful of bridges were abandoned. Everyone who resumed work was promised payment no later than September 15, 1832; however, another budget crisis unhinged these plans and dissolved much of the goodwill generated by the emergency appropriations bill. A few contractors continued work "Relying upon their contracts, and what they conceive to be the pledged faith of the state," but a larger number quit with expressed regrets "that the most favorable season of the year should be lost to them for want of funds to complete their jobs."⁵⁸ While administrators struggled to locate funds for resuming work, their costs increased because of damage to the existing work.

Seasonal floodwaters came crashing down the Beaver River during this work stoppage. Long time residents of the area said the river was higher and more ferocious than they had ever seen it, and

⁵⁸ "Report of John Dickey, Superintendent," JHR 1832-33, volume II: 162.

objective measures placed the rise at least twenty feet above normal levels for that time of year. Charles Whippo watched the flood while serving as the chief engineer on the Beaver Division, and afterwards he wrote "that our structures, though some of them have been very substantially built, are nevertheless too weak to resist the fury of our mountain streams."⁵⁹

Specifications for the locks and dams were revised to increase their mass and height. According to Whippo, "the additional height requires a corresponding additional thickness of the walls, in order to sustain the pressure of the earth against them." When work resumed on the sections between the locks, some were found to pass through quicksand. Contractors on these sections were forced "to the necessity of driving piles, which is a slow and expensive operation."⁶⁰

Financial disaster was only averted at this critical juncture through an unexpected bequest from Stephen Girard of Philadelphia. Girard had opened a banking house in 1812, and had used his money and influence for promoting internal improvements as an aide to business. Perhaps this stand explains why state regulators

⁵⁹ "Report and Estimate of C.T. Whippo, Engineer," JHR 1832-33, appendix: 165.

⁶⁰ *Ibid.*

overlooked repeated violations of Pennsylvania banking laws; but for whatever cause, when Girard died in 1832 his last will endowed the state with \$300,000 for making internal improvements.⁶¹

Governor Wolfe gratefully acknowledged the "Girard Legacy" (as the grant was called) and a major share of the fund was turned over to Superintendent John Dickey on the Beaver Division. In honor of their benefactor, local officials christened the massive outlet locks on the Ohio River the "Girard Locks;" a commemorative stone explaining all this was installed on the inner face of the locks where passing boatmen could see it. With this additional funding in hand, the canal commissioners warned contractors to resume any unfinished contracts on the Beaver Division by April 2, 1833 or face another round of competitive bidding. Superintendent Dickey was also instructed to advertise for bids on an additional six miles of slackwater above New Castle. This new work was released in half mile increments on May 4, 1833 and several contracts showing insufficient progress were reassigned at the same time.⁶²

According to local reports, the contractors on every part of the

⁶¹ Hartz, Economic Policy and Democratic Thought, 21.

⁶² "Report of John Dickey, Superintendent," JS 1833-4, appendix: 107; Western Argus, May 10, 1833: p3c2.

Beaver division launched the work season "with a vigor and energy that promises an early completion." State agents specified that work in the coming year was to be done by October 15, 1833, but few expected it would take that long.⁶³ Field surveys showed consistent progress all summer, until a scarcity of laborers and heavy rains in September forced a temporary postponement of the work. A sudden rise in the Beaver River on September 20, 1833 damaged several dams and set the schedule back several more weeks. After consulting with his engineers, Superintendent Dickey hired contractors on the spot to effect repairs. Water was let into several sections of the canal before the end of the year as a result, but the entire line required additional time and funds. Lock No. 17 and the dam at Stone's Point were covered for nearly a month after the September flood, canceling any chance they might be finished before the following year.⁶⁴ At the other end of the line, laying timbers for the Shenango Dam had been postponed so that workers could reinforce and crib the towpath upstream.⁶⁵ Workmen were put on the line as early as possible the following

⁶³ Western Argus, April 12, 1833: p2c3.

⁶⁴ "Report of John Dickey, Superintendent," JS 1833-4, appendix: 108.

⁶⁵ Ibid, 107; "Report of C.T. Whippo, Engineer," JS 1833-4, appendix: 114.

year to make up for these delays. While the entire Beaver Division required modifications and repairs, twenty-five miles between Bridgewater and New Castle were opened for navigation by the end of the May, 1834. James D. White of New Castle placed his boat "Alpha" in service with plans for making three trips every trips every week and state officials gave assurances of finishing the remaining work before the end of summer.⁶⁶

Trade picked up moderately during the summer, and by November there were four or five boats making daily runs along the line. Owners of the steamer "Beaver" had worked an arrangement to connect with the boat "Alpha." By using this combination, passengers and freight could cover the distance between Pittsburgh and New Castle in twelve hours. The operators also offered to carry freight from Beaver all the way through to Philadelphia in fourteen days.⁶⁷ Proponents of the Western Route advised the public that "The produce and merchandise that has heretofore been waggoned to and from the Western Reserve, now find a cheaper and more expeditious means of transportation."⁶⁸ Improvements on the Beaver Division were reported to compare favorably with any in the state.

⁶⁶ Western Argus, May 30, 1834: p2c3.

⁶⁷ Corkan, The Beaver and Lake Erie Canal, 33-34.

⁶⁸ Western Argus, November 7, 1834: p2c3.

Only a few minor improvements were still needed at the end of the building season in November, 1834, when the line was said to be "about completed."⁶⁹ Seasonal rises in the river resulted in comparatively minor damage, but that was repaired in time for the following boating season. Residents of the Beaver Valley took umbrage at reports that "their" canal would not be ready for traffic in 1835. Officials of the Beaver Division resumed operations on March 16, 1835, in concert with the opening of navigation on the Main Line between Pittsburgh and Philadelphia.⁷⁰ Tolls for the preceding year on the Beaver Division had only added up to \$550.00, and state officials hoped this start would produce a substantial increase. Work resumed on the six mile extension above New Castle in expectation of these additional funds.

Tolls through the summer of 1835 increased fourfold and gave every promise of relieving the financial stresses plaguing the line, but then a devastating series of floods and severe storms wrecked the Beaver Division. Three days of heavy rains near the end of October raised the Beaver River to record levels and caused severe damage to public and private property. Several dams and nearly the entire length of the towpath were damaged to some

⁶⁹ Ibid.

⁷⁰ Western Argus, March 25, 1835: p2c2.

extent. The most serious breach occurred at the head of the falls, where the embankment between the dam and the lock gave way. The dam owned by the Fallston Water Company was heavily damaged, and the headgates to the raceway on the west bank were torn away. Floodwaters rolled through the raceway and stripped over two hundred feet of embankment, leaving bare rock behind and stopping all the machinery. Observers expected quick repairs would be made to the water works, but the schedule for the public improvements was uncertain. Nothing could be done before ice appeared on the river, bringing navigation to a premature halt by several weeks.⁷¹

Political fragmentation and the emergence of outside interests

Inhabitants of Northwest Pennsylvania were getting worried over these kinds of delays and the unceasing reports of damages to the local works. Taxpayers from those parts of Pennsylvania served by the Main Line were grumbling about the tax dollars and the opportunities that had been wasted in the northwest corner of the state. While the Main Line was beginning to show increases in toll collections, the Beaver Division and the French Creek works were in shambles. These conflicting fortunes helped revive sectional interests in state politics that dissolved a sense of common

⁷¹ Beaver Argus, October 28, 1835: p2c3.

purpose in Northwest Pennsylvania.

Genuine political parties were only emerging in Pennsylvania during the 1830s after several decades of Democratic-Republican hegemony. Democratic leaders had brushed Federalism aside at the turn of the century and seized control of state affairs. Dissent through the 1830s appeared in the form of party factions.⁷² Meaningful breaks with the Democratic-Republican ranks finally appeared in opposition to perceptions of secrecy and privileges in public life. This latent hostility was galvanized into political action in 1828 by news that Masons in New York had committed murder to protect their secrets. Candidates who had been denied offices by the party monopoly on public life adopted this cause as their own and formed the opposition Antimason party.

Experienced politicians were wary of a party founded on this questionable principle. Antimasons only drew thirty-five delegates from fourteen widely scattered counties at their first state convention in 1829, leading into statewide elections. Joseph Ritner of Washington County was named as their candidate for the state's highest office. Democrats placed George Wolf in the governor's chair as expected, but Antimasons produced a surprising majority in seventeen counties. Returns favored the fledgling

⁷² Snyder, The Jacksonian Heritage: 22-23.

movement in the extreme northwest, Washington County in the Southwest, the southern tier of counties, and southeastern counties outside of Philadelphia.⁷³

Antimasonry flourished in those areas where voters saw little gain in the public works or felt they had not gotten their fair share of funding. German farmers of southeastern Pennsylvania and the border counties had already enjoyed access to Philadelphia and Baltimore markets, and soundly resented taxes to support state canals. At the other end of the state, Antimasonry drew voters who felt abandoned by Harrisburg after years of delays in building a canal. This limited focus hampered its chances in state elections and Governor Wolf was returned to office in 1832; however, the election was decided by less than three thousand votes and both sides adjusted their strategy for the next contest.⁷⁴

Wolf hoped to become the first chief executive in two decades to lead the state for three consecutive terms, but factions of the party did not believe this was possible. Spending on canals and his defense of an unpopular education bill made Wolf a liability for the Democratic party in some parts of Pennsylvania. Newspaper

⁷³ Snyder, The Jacksonian Heritage: 30.

⁷⁴ Snyder, Jacksonian Heritage, 30-31. Antimasons polled majorities in twenty counties and tallied more than 88,000 votes.

editors in Philadelphia started to promote Henry Muhlenburg as a viable alternative in 1834. Any semblance of Democratic unity disappeared as the rival factions battled for the party nomination. Antimasonry had nearly expired in Pennsylvania when this feud resurrected chances of toppling the Democrats. Antimasons assembled in Philadelphia on March 4, 1835 and placed Joseph Ritner on the ballot as the opposition candidate for the third consecutive time. His longstanding nemesis was placed on the ballot against him two days later.

Democrats assembled in Harrisburg on March 3, 1835 amid palpable hostility. Factions supporting Wolf and Muhlenburg had already tried to wrestle control of their county conventions through any means. Competing sets of delegates appeared from eleven counties and senatorial districts, with neither body recognizing the authority of the other; victory depended on gaining control of procedural matters to seat delegates. Standing governor George Wolf was finally declared the official candidate of the party on March 6, 1835 after three days of plots and shouting. Muhlenberg men dismissed the "Wolf Caucus" as a fraud and called for a separate assembly at Lewistown two months later. Results of the state election were sealed when the Muhlenberg camp refused to back down. Democrats drew their customary majority in the fall contest,

but they were forced to give up their hold on the governor's chair. Election returns showed Ritner with 28,000 votes over Wolf, who then led Muhlenberg by 25,000. Ritner had carried his usual strongholds, but failed to show significant gains in any single county. Democrats gave away the contest by dividing their vote, which might have combined for a comfortable margin of 12,000 votes.⁷⁵

Antimasons increasingly used public works as a central issue in reaching this plateau. Ritner preached that branch lines were acceptable, but only after the Main Line was finished. Profits from this undertaking might then be used to fund additional constructions. Proponents of this approach believed they could keep voters satisfied by meeting their demands for canals and other improvements while eliminating onerous taxes. Antimasons called for a broad approach to complete the branch lines with any remaining work on the Main Line. This appealed to merchants and taxpayers who recognized the opportunities that had been squandered through the chaotic handling of the state works.

Newspapers reported on advances made in neighboring states whereas Pennsylvania dawdled about where and how to spend its own tax dollars. While floods dashed the Franklin Line to pieces, New

⁷⁵ Snyder, The Jacksonian Heritage: 67.

York voted to rebuild locks on the Erie Canal and allow larger vessels to pass through.⁷⁶ The Erie Canal and other improvements around the Great Lakes were nearly overwhelmed by phenomenal rates of growth in regional commerce.⁷⁷ Boats pushed through the Great Lakes until forced to quit by ice and cold weather.⁷⁸

Boating resumed the following year just days after the ice retreated and suitable weather conditions arrived. Within weeks, public authorities were guessing that up to 200,000 emigrants might pass along the lakes before the close of the boating season.⁷⁹ Officers on the Welland Canal reported a heavy business passing freighters around Niagara Falls, and offered every facility and assistance to American shippers. Merchants at Buffalo complained of the trade they lost to the Canadians, but agreed there was enough to go around for everybody.⁸⁰

This frantic pace was maintained all through the summer and beyond without any signs of letting up. Winter conditions were marking their return at Buffalo, but "the jaded warehousemen and

⁷⁶ Crawford Messenger, May 23, 1835: p3c3; Erie Gazette, November 5, 1835: p2c2.

⁷⁷ Crawford Messenger, April 11, 1835: p3c4.

⁷⁸ Western Argus, November 28, 1834: p2c6.

⁷⁹ Western Argus, June 3, 1835: p1c6.

⁸⁰ Pittsburgh Daily Gazette, April 20, 1835: p2c4.

the sturdy boatmen and mariners alike pursue their various toils without cessation."⁸¹ Traffic was so heavy that one group of Buffalo merchants had pressed the old "Queen Charlotte" from the War of 1812 into service. This vessel was one of the prizes taken by Perry in the battle of Lake Erie in 1813. After serving out the war, it was sunk in Misery Bay near Erie. After negotiating their rights to the craft, it was raised and towed to Buffalo for fitting out.⁸²

Salvage operations were conducted within site of the docks at Erie, but this port was hardly deemed suitable for further work. Basic amenities for promoting navigation and commerce were missing and ships experienced difficulty getting in and out of the harbor. Passengers and freight were dumped on a pier extending into the bay a full mile and a half from town.

One party travelling on the steamship "Michigan" in 1835 was landed at dusk and told a packet would pick them up in about fifteen minutes. According to a member of this group, a steam scow described as a "crazy kind of boat" appeared about an hour later with a single candle for light. Its crew of two or three rough

⁸¹ Erie Gazette, October 29, 1835: p2c6.

⁸² Western Argus, January 28, 1835: p1c6; June 24, 1835: p3c1.

characters did nothing but curse and swear at one another until reaching shore, and on the way over a heavy downpour put out the candle and nearly sank the boat. Since there was no light at the pier, there was no hope of separating luggage and freight. Any items at hand were tossed aboard a wagon in a confused pile and hauled to the closest hotel.⁸³

Merchants and innkeepers at Erie watched in anguish as emigration to the West picked up again the following year at even greater levels. Groups of families were seeking passage at Buffalo where the docks were overflowing with passengers and freight. One observer suggested the West would soon be filled at this rate. Pennsylvanians were advised to hurry their works along before the exodus ended.⁸⁴

Citizens of the Northwest Pennsylvania and Antimasons in other parts of the state eagerly disseminated these kinds of items, but Democratic loyalists tended to discount their optimistic tone. Many taxpayers in Pennsylvania brushed aside any ideas that they

⁸³ Crawford Messenger, June 6, 1835: p3c1-3. This reflects conditions found a decade earlier when John James Audubon visited and Erie was still regarded as a frontier settlement; see John James Audubon, Delineations of American Scenery and Character (New York, NY: G.A. Baker & Co., 1926; Arno & the New York Times, 1970), 36-37.

⁸⁴ Erie Gazette, May 26, 1836: p3c1.

should still expand the state system. Critics of expansion suggested that building a line from Pittsburgh to Erie would only benefit a few small communities along its path and that tolls would hardly justify the expense. Businessmen at Pittsburgh and Philadelphia had quickly lost interest in branch lines once the Main Line Canal was finished. One newspaper in Pittsburgh urged its readers to consider Cleveland a Pennsylvania city and their "true port" on the lakes.⁸⁵ Much of the state proved willing to accept this solution to stave off a menacing debt crisis.

Interest payments on the state debt had already climbed to \$650,000 a year back in 1831, when work started on the Beaver division and the Franklin Line. When construction on the Pennsylvania Main Line ended in 1835 this figure had risen to \$1,169,455.00 with no end in sight. Combined disbursements for construction, maintenance and salaries since 1826 exceeded twenty-two million dollars. Predictions that the canals would pay for themselves proved a bitter memory when tolls for 1835 added up to just \$684,357.⁸⁶ Critics charged that widows and orphans were being robbed of their inheritance and some form of retrenchment was

⁸⁵ Pittsburgh Daily Gazette, May 3, 1835: p2c2.

⁸⁶ Hartz, Economic Policy and Democratic Thought: 149.

clearly necessary.⁸⁷

One solution called for scaling back the works in Northwest Pennsylvania. State leaders made it clear they could not fund two parallel lines in this area and urged voters to decide for themselves between the Beaver Division and French Creek. Talk of a "route controversy" emerged with communities on either line fighting to secure political support and continued funding. Some of the inhabitants of this area had foreseen this outcome several years earlier.

Meadville had already hosted a public assembly on the evening of October 29, 1833 at which local leaders called for an open convention to resolve the looming dispute.⁸⁸ Counties all over Northwest Pennsylvania were urged to make a good showing to placate the charges of apathy and ill will that were already coming out of other parts of Pennsylvania.⁸⁹ Residents of Beaver County were pointedly invited to send delegates in union with the northern and eastern counties on Lake Erie and the Allegheny watershed.

Local meetings were scheduled all over Northwest Pennsylvania over the following weeks to discuss the merits of this convention

⁸⁷ Western Argus, September 24, 1830: p1c5.

⁸⁸ Crawford Democrat, November 1, 1833: p3c1.

⁸⁹ Western Argus, November 8, 1833: p2c3.

and name representatives if this was deemed appropriate. When the delegates assembled at Meadville on November 20, 1833, they primarily represented communities favoring the Allegheny River and French Creek route. They decided to hold another convention at Mercer following the end of year holidays to promote wider interest and better attendance.

Early indications suggested this would not be easy. Residents of western Crawford County met at the home of Alfred Strong near Conneaut Lake, on December 31, 1833 to consider the invitation. Delegates were only named if they agreed that the canal bill of 1825 obliged state figures to open navigation on a direct line between terminals at Pittsburgh and Erie. This struck a discrete blow at the Eastern route since that path sprang up at Freeport and avoided going in to Pittsburgh. Five representatives were selected for the area around Conneaut Lake based on their promise to press this interpretation.⁹⁰

Delegates were eventually drawn to Mercer from parts of Beaver County, Butler County, Mercer County, Crawford County, Erie County, Venango County, Jefferson County, and Armstrong County. Discussions of the canal program produced agreement that an extension of the Main Line was legally mandated, but still left the

⁹⁰ Crawford Messenger, January 5, 1833: p3c4.

specific route open to question. A memorial was then forwarded to Harrisburg weakly reminding state legislators of this promise and questioning rumors that funding for the canals was in trouble.⁹¹

Merchants and tax payers in Northwest Pennsylvania started breaking into local interest groups with the sole purpose of pushing their favorite route for the canal while they waited for a decision from Harrisburg. Discussions and criticisms of route proposals, engineer reports and funding became a mainstay of local newspaper reporting. Erie favored the Elk Creek path of the Western Route, while Meadville supported the Eastern Route up French Creek; Beaver and Mercer fell in line with Erie against Venango County and Armstrong County.⁹²

A writer signing himself "Meadville" called for another convention during these debates with a warning that state authorities would not act favorably if citizens were divided; "Meadville" supposed that "Our public men are not in the habit of risking their popularity," and the legislators and canal commissioners might simply deny funding and blame the people for

⁹¹ Crawford Messenger, January 19, 1833: p2c2-3.

⁹² Western Argus, June 14, 1833: p2c5; Crawford Messenger, November 22, 1834: p3c1-2; p3c3.

their loss."⁹³

Public opinion at Erie seconded this belief and another assembly was called for November 18, 1834 to consider a response.

Those in attendance issued a call for another convention of the northwest counties, to prod the legislature into action. Butler was chosen as a neutral site to host the convention, which was tentatively scheduled for December 24, 1834.⁹⁴ Proponents of the Western Route seized this opportunity for their own use, and acknowledged their invitation with calls on "Friends of the extension and completion of the Canal to Lake Erie" to appoint suitable representatives.⁹⁵

The promoters sponsoring this event left little doubt the upcoming assembly was intended to sustain the Western Route since they lambasted the Eastern route in speeches and in newspaper columns.⁹⁶ Critics in Meadville countered with warnings about the costs of building aqueducts and culverts over the deep stream cuts in western Erie County; they proposed carrying the works up French Creek to Lake Erie through Waterford instead, and joining the

⁹³ Crawford Messenger, November 22, 1834: p3c1-2.

⁹⁴ Western Argus, November 28, 1834: p1c4.

⁹⁵ Western Argus, November 22, 1834: p2c3.

⁹⁶ Crawford Messenger, November 22, 1834: p3c1-2; p3c3.

competing routes through Conneaut Lake.⁹⁷ None of the southern counties or eastern counties bothered to voice an opinion.

All of the eighty delegates who attended the gathering at Butler were drawn from Allegheny, Armstrong, Butler, Beaver, Crawford, Erie, Indiana, Mercer and Venango counties.⁹⁸ Such meetings assumed a social function for many of the delegates, and two days of meetings produced little more than "Resolutions expressive of the views of the counties represented, on the subject of the Canal to Erie," and "a memorial to the legislature, urging completion of the work."⁹⁹

State leaders finally stepped in and warned the northwest counties that the rest of the Pennsylvania was losing patience with their squabbling and indecision. Powerful merchants from Philadelphia suggested that the whole route controversy was a sham to improperly draw funds toward northwest Pennsylvania, and hinted they might promote corrective measures in the state legislature. Governor Ritner agreed that something had to be done one way or another, and warned the matter had better be settled soon.¹⁰⁰

⁹⁷ Crawford Messenger, November 22, 1834: p3c3.

⁹⁸ Western Argus, January 16, 1835: p1c6.

⁹⁹ Daily Pittsburgh Gazette, January 2, 1835: p2c2.

¹⁰⁰ Western Argus, January 2, 1835: p2c2.

Pennsylvania was running out of time if neighboring states were to be kept in check and prevented from drawing trade away. Baltimore was courting Bedford County and Somerset County with additional connections to the National Road, and there was loose talk from directors of the Chesapeake and Ohio Canal about making a western extension toward Fayette County and on into Washington County.¹⁰¹ Expenses already outraced tolls derived from the finished parts of the system, and there was no chance of securing federal funds since the Pennsylvania Main Line and its branches were designed to check free trade across state lines. Pittsburgh merchants offered their own solution to this impasse by asking "If Pennsylvania is already in advance of her greatest rival, what will be her situation when her public works are pushed out to the Lake and Ohio Canal ?"¹⁰²

Businessmen from Allegheny County, Beaver County, and Mercer County were already involved with their own schemes for improvements when the canal convention assembled at Butler. Some of the plans under consideration called for extending the Chesapeake and Ohio Canal up to Pittsburgh or carrying a lateral extension of the National Road to Erie. Another plan that enjoyed

¹⁰¹ Daily Pittsburgh Gazette, March 31, 1834: p2c2.

¹⁰² Western Argus, November 7, 1834: p2c???

broad support in Pittsburgh called for joining the Pennsylvania Main Line Canal with the Beaver Division, and extending navigation through the Mahoning River toward the Ohio and Erie Canal with its terminus at Cleveland. Spokesmen for the plan liked to point out this would reduce the costs of building a canal to Lake Erie, but there were other considerations.

Financial restraints and construction capabilities both dictated that any union of the Eastern Route with the Main Line Canal should be placed near Freeport, thirty miles up the Allegheny River and eastward from Pittsburgh. After all of the years they had spent fighting with Philadelphia for recognition and public funds, Pittsburgh merchants were adamantly opposed to any design that might let traffic pass around their city. Philadelphia was easily won over since eastern Ohio represented a developed economy and lucrative market.

Pioneers in the old Firelands of eastern Ohio had opened commercial relations with Pittsburgh from an early date. Produce and manufactured goods from Southwest Pennsylvania flowed into the area, until the settlers were able to produce a surplus of their own. Isaac McCord of Youngstown started a return trade in 1823, when he launched two flatboats loaded with wheat and flour down the Mahoning River. After passing numerous snags and obstructions,

the boats drifted into the Beaver River on their way out into the Ohio river. Speculators and merchants from eastern Ohio instantly started to talk of the potential benefits from improved navigation on the Mahoning River.¹⁰³

State legislators in Ohio voiced support for the scheme and predicted the Mahoning Canal would pay for itself in the long term, but funds to start construction were just not available. Officials sitting in Columbus had already committed public resources to the Ohio and Erie Canal and, unlike their counterparts in Harrisburg, they feared extending the state credit to unmanageable levels. A compromise was amicably reached on January 10, 1827 when the Mahoning Canal was licensed as a private enterprise. Since there was no added cost for their own taxpayers, Pennsylvania authorities approved an extension across the common border to New Castle on April 14, 1827. Merchants in Pittsburgh and Philadelphia wholeheartedly backed this decision, and it certainly played a role in shaping plans for the Beaver Division of the Pennsylvania public works. Terms of the Pennsylvania charter lapsed in 1831 before construction started, but investors in Ohio pursued the canal as

¹⁰³ Reid, The Canal Heritage of Youngstown, Ohio: 2. Engineers assigned to this project located a suitable route starting at Akron and passing through Ravenna, Warren and Youngstown, before crossing the state line and meeting the Beaver River in Pennsylvania near New Castle.

best they could.

Navigation opened on 21 miles of the canal between Kent and Akron in 1832, and goods from the Western Reserve started flowing toward Cleveland and Lake Erie. Pittsburgh merchants lamented this loss of trade and called for action several times during the following years. Merchants from the city and county of Philadelphia named delegates to a convention at Warren in 1833 to help promote completion of the canal.¹⁰⁴ Pittsburgh and Allegheny County followed suit two weeks without any apparent difficulty.¹⁰⁵

Pennsylvania counties lying closer to the project area faced a political and moral dilemma; other counties in Northwest Pennsylvania charged this betrayed their common interests. Butler County declined to attend on matters of principle while urging protections for the Main Line Canal and its branches.¹⁰⁶ Beaver County appointed delegates to Warren, but countered criticism by offering equal support for a rival meeting at Meadville.¹⁰⁷

Mercer also scheduled delegates to attend, with the same divisions in opinion. After poorly publicized proceedings named

¹⁰⁴ Western Argus, November 8, 1833: p2c1,3.

¹⁰⁵ Western Argus, November 1, 1833: p2c3.

¹⁰⁶ Western Argus, November 22, 1833: p2c3.

¹⁰⁷ Western Argus, November 8, 1833: p2c3.

representatives to the Warren Convention, another meeting was held in favor of the Meadville convention. After stating they held no objection to the Pennsylvania and Ohio Line, citizens at the meeting "most decidedly" rejected any attempt to "induce the Legislature to prefer that route to the one through from Pittsburgh to the borough of Erie."¹⁰⁸

Northwestern Counties had every reason to fear this development. Besides being almost free, the prospects for the Mahoning Canal were apparent to any critical observer. Another group of promoters designed the Sandy and Beaver Canal on a parallel course and were actively courting recognition and aid. Philadelphia and Pittsburgh avoided any involvement since plans for the Sandy and Beaver Canal barely crossed the Pennsylvania line before meeting the Ohio River along the Little Beaver.¹⁰⁹

Counties that stood to benefit the most actively promoted the Warren Convention on both sides of the state line and suggested that it would "be very numerously attended," and "quite respectable

¹⁰⁸ Western Argus, November 15, 1833: p2c1.

¹⁰⁹ This canal did not generate great support off the proposed line of the canal. The Sandy and Beaver Canal was eventually opened for navigation, but the tolls never repaid the construction costs. A detailed history of this canal is found in R. Max Gard and William H. Vodrey, The Sandy and Beaver Canal (East Liverpool, OH: East Liverpool Historical Society, 1952).

as to intelligence and talents."¹¹⁰ Drawing delegates from Philadelphia and Pittsburgh heightened the sense of legitimacy and guaranteed that authorities in Harrisburg would carefully review the outcome. The Pennsylvania Canal bill of 1825 had only called for opening a canal from the Delaware to Lake Erie without naming a specific route. A broad interpretation of the law did not ban links to neighboring states.¹¹¹

Glowing reports and memorials were sent to the respective state governments when the convention broke up after three days of meetings. Pennsylvania legislators named a state committee to investigate the matter and its members eagerly gave their assent to the project after visiting "the most favorable ground, along the whole route, for constructing a canal that they have ever seen."¹¹² Businessmen from Beaver County started to distance themselves from Northwest Pennsylvania after reviewing the reports for themselves. One newspaper editor from Beaver took offense when his counterparts from Erie wrote of the "hot headed zealots" who were promoting the Ohio in the area of Pittsburgh.¹¹³ Exchanges between the

¹¹⁰ Ibid.

¹¹¹ Western Argus, November 28, 1834: p2c5.

¹¹² Reid, "The Canal Heritage of Youngstown": 3.

¹¹³ Western Argus, January 2, 1835: p2c4.

newspapermen sharpened over the following days, and the editor at Beaver started to openly call on local counties to look after their own interests.¹¹⁴

Ohio state legislators authorized additional work on the Mahoning Canal just a few weeks afterwards on February 11, 1835. Under the terms of this act the Mahoning Canal Company was empowered to adjust local toll rates, and certain restrictions placed on the state canals were voided.¹¹⁵ This preferential treatment rapidly translated into sales when the company opened its books for subscriptions. Investors from Allegheny County took \$50,000 worth of shares in a single afternoon, reportedly as fast as the names could be written down. Trumbull County and Portage County in Ohio promised to take \$80,000 apiece, and the canal's promoters were so confident of selling all available stocks that they scheduled a meeting at New Castle on May 21, 1835 to elect company officers.¹¹⁶

Antimason leaders in Pennsylvania buckled under this pressure. Even though Antimasons had seized control of the governor's office, they were still a minority in the Pennsylvania state government and

¹¹⁴ Western Argus, January 16, 1835: p2c4.

¹¹⁵ Western Argus, February 11, 1835: p2c4.

¹¹⁶ Western Argus, May 13, 1835: p2c3.

they could not easily dictate policy to the powerful Democrats who controlled Philadelphia and Pittsburgh or withstand their demands. The Mahoning Canal was therefore granted the same privileges on the near side of the state line. Contracts for that portion of the canal in Pennsylvania were handed out to contractors at New Castle on August 10, 1835. Work was underway by the end of the month with completion scheduled for September 1836, at which time the canal was to be opened as far as Youngstown or Warren.¹¹⁷

Conclusion

Communities along the projected path of the canal from Akron through Warren, Youngstown, and over to New Castle voiced support for the pace at which construction had started. This theme echoed down through the Beaver Division of the Pennsylvania state works and up the Ohio River to Pittsburgh, before travelling over the Pennsylvania Main Line Canal to Philadelphia; support for the Mahoning Canal fanned out from the opposite end of the line through

¹¹⁷ Western Argus, August 26, 1835: p1c5. These awards covered thirteen miles of canal in 25 sections, with 6 locks and 8 culverts, an aqueduct over the Shenango below New Castle, and a dam at Mahoningtown. Plans for the entire line spanned 90 miles from a junction with the Beaver Division below New Castle to the highlands at Akron. At this point the Mahoning Canal tapped into the Ohio and Erie Canal, just 36 miles from Lake Erie at Cleveland.

the Western Reserve and into Cleveland. One author using the alias "Mahoning" proposed that anyone connected with this "important work" should congratulate themselves that construction had commenced. When it was finished, the Mahoning Canal was predicted to hold "striking and obvious" benefits for Pennsylvania."¹¹⁸ Of course, not everyone agreed with this glowing synopsis.

Inhabitants of the Pennsylvania residing above the head of the Beaver River at New Castle and eastward toward the Allegheny River wholeheartedly disagreed; they felt betrayed by every article in print or public pronouncement of this sort. They had provided crucial votes for getting construction of the Pennsylvania Main Line underway; in return they heard promises that improvements would be extended into all parts of the state. Breaking ground on the French Creek Feeder in 1827 seemed to herald a quick return on their investment, but their hopes were soon dashed. When navigation opened over the full extent of the Pennsylvania Main Line Canal and its railroad divisions in 1835, the public improvements program in Northwest Pennsylvania was in shambles.

The French Creek Feeder Canal was not joined to open waters at either end and only provided a spur for the Franklin Line leading into Meadville. Below this point French Creek was littered with

¹¹⁸ Western Argus, August 19, 1835: p4c1.

debris from ruined locks and dams. Navigation had been opened for a brief period, but severe storms revealed flaws in the planning and construction of the Franklin Line. Components of the Beaver Division had withstood these challenges in a better state, but this line of the public works was not well suited to benefit Northwest Pennsylvania. The Beaver Division was an isolated slice of the public works at the far western edge of Pennsylvania. It was not directly connected to any of the other public improvements and chancy connections with Pittsburgh depended on steamboats and adequate water levels for these vessels in the Ohio River. When public authorities in Pennsylvania finally decided to connect the Beaver Division with existing works, they looked across the state line to Ohio.

This may have been the most damning blow to Northwest Pennsylvania. State leaders had courted local politicians and civic leaders from Northwest Pennsylvania for over a decade in order to win support for the canal program. With the completion of the Main Line Canal, state leaders gave every indication this relationship was over. By 1835, state policies were again being shaped by Philadelphia and Pittsburgh again for their own benefit. Northwest Pennsylvania was returned to a dependent status, subject to the whims of outsiders with different concerns.

Inhabitants of the area had responded in earlier times by joining in common cause, as when they fought the land companies. In this new era of trading favors for votes, this sense of unity collapsed. Residents of Beaver County threw their lot with the Main Line counties and separated their interests from tax payers living closer to the shores of Lake Erie. The remaining parts of Northwest Pennsylvania started breaking into distinct camps that were based on support or oppositon for likely canal routes.

Chapter 5:
CANALS, RAILROADS AND THE POLITICS OF PUBLIC IMPROVEMENTS,
1836-1838

Dissension in the northwestern counties played into the hands of Democratic party leaders in Pennsylvania. They came out of the statewide elections of 1835 divided into two hostile camps, blaming one another for the surprising victory by the Antimasons and their allies in that contest. One common theme that still bound the Democratic factions together in spite of the uproar was a determination to restore their dominance in state affairs. Northwest Pennsylvania had gone heavily for Joseph Ritner in 1835, and the Democratic party leaders decided that gaining votes in this area was crucial for their plans.

Funding for the canals therefore emerged as a critical issue to recruit voters for the next round of statewide elections in 1838. The sorry condition of the state works in Northwest Pennsylvania provided plenty of material to attack Ritner and his policies, even if the problems were rooted in earlier Democratic administrations. Antimason legislators pushed work on the canals to offset charges of neglect.

Communities in Northwest Pennsylvania despaired of ever seeing the canals finished and briefly gave their attentions to railroads and improved toll roads, but they ultimately fell back on canals as their best hope for promoting economic development. After fully considering the matter, the taxpayers in this corner of Pennsylvania rejected notions of spending their own money out of pocket when other sections of the state received benefits from public funds. This decision pitted Northwest Pennsylvania against other sections of the state that had grown tired of the ceaseless expenditures on public improvements.

Taxpayers from the counties resting on the Main Line Canal expressed grave concerns about the public debt and did not see grounds for following plans drawn up a decade earlier. Patterns of commerce had changed since that time, and the politicians and business leaders from these areas found an audience for guiding the public works in new directions. Private investors were applauded for offering to open interstate connections on the southern and western borders of the state at their own expense. The gubernatorial contest scheduled for 1838 in Pennsylvania consequently took shape as a referendum on spending additional tax dollars for canals.

From hope to despair on the Erie Extension

Shipping and trade on the Great Lakes in 1835 appeared to justify the faith politicians and taxpayers placed in the Erie Extension Canal. Thirty-four steamers followed the retreating ice out of harbors from Buffalo to Detroit, besides dozens of schooners and brigs. Over one million dollars was invested in steamship companies and there were almost a thousand hands on their payrolls.¹ Anything that floated was hurriedly pressed into service, and more than two hundred vessels of all types were observed in use when the shipping season fully got underway. Emigrants were "literally jabbed" aboard every vessel, with larger craft carrying between four hundred and eight hundred passengers apiece.²

Shippers and merchants at Buffalo were nearly overwhelmed by the traffic and public meetings were called to bring a sense of order to the public docks. One proposal called for diverting the excess trade to satellite ports in return for a share of the profits. Some of the chief merchants and shippers at Buffalo supported the idea, but then they thought about it and decided to continue as

¹ Erie Gazette, April 7, 1836: p2c3.

² Crawford Messenger, June 6, 1835: p3c2; Erie Gazette, June 9, 1836: p2c2.

before.³ The Pennsylvania port of Erie was one of the most likely points for deflecting surplus freight and passengers, but the power brokers at Buffalo had second thoughts about encouraging competition. Business prospects at Erie took a dramatic swing upwards in the early weeks of 1836 without any help from across the state lines.

Antimasons and their Whig allies did not waste any time in trying to implement their promises to the electorate after gaining control over Pennsylvania. On January 19, 1836 Thaddeus Stevens introduced a bill in the state house that was titled "An Act to Repeal the State Tax and to Continue the Improvement of the State by Railroads and Canals, and for Other Purposes." The Improvements committee of the lower house held up passage just long enough to change the name and more accurately reflect its true aims as "An Act to Repeal the State Tax on Real and Personal Property and to continue and Extend the Improvements of the State by Railroads and Canals, and to Charter a State Bank to be Called the United States Bank." Governor Ritner willingly signed the measure into law on February 18, 1836.⁴

Erie exploded in celebration when this news reached the lake

³ Erie Gazette, March 17, 1836: p3c2.

⁴ Snyder, The Jacksonian Heritage, 78-79.

shore and the entire town was illuminated with candles and lanterns for revellers in the streets. Friends of the administration looked forward to good times and proclaimed that passage of this bill guaranteed a "prompt and speedy" completion of the canal.⁵ Even commercial rivals of Erie conceded there was cause for optimism. A Baltimore newspaper proposed that not even the fractious partisan politics of Pennsylvania could delay growth now.⁶

Speculators showed their agreement by stampeding toward the lake front in a desperate race to acquire property. Sales of over half a million dollars were recorded during the second and third weeks of February, and prices were rising every day.⁷ Speculators based in New York City were reportedly bidding for lots out of fears that Erie might overtake Buffalo as the favorite port for lake skippers.⁸ This news sparked another rush out of Philadelphia, where newspapers picked up notices of lots for sale.⁹

The excitement hanging over Erie was furthered in the first week of April, 1836 with word that the canal commissioners had hired

⁵ Erie Gazette, February 23, 1836: p3c1.

⁶ Erie Gazette, March 10, 1836: p2c5.

⁷ Erie Gazette, February 23, 1836: p3c1.

⁸ Erie Gazette, March 17, 1836: p3c2-3.

⁹ Erie Gazette, May 5, 1836: p2c6.

Charles C. Whippo as chief engineer for the northwestern lines. Local news sources declared they could not have made a better choice.¹⁰ Whippo had learned his trade during the initial construction of the Erie Canal in New York before accepting an assignment on the Pennsylvania state works. More recently, he had worked on the Wabash and Erie Canal in Indiana.¹¹

Whippo was advised there was no time to waste and he started work at the head of the Beaver Division near New Castle on April 26, 1836.¹² Over the following weeks the canal was marked out along the Shenango River up to Greenville, and then taken through the Little Shenango to the mouth of Crooked Creek; from this point the surveyors drifted along the margins of the Pymatuning Swamp and up over the Beaver Dam Summit toward Conneaut Lake.¹³

Local hopes for economic development were bolstered by regular reports of the progress made on this survey and accounts of increasing traffic on the Main Line Canal. Newspapers from Harrisburg reported that 1200 to 1500 passengers were passing over

¹⁰ Erie Gazette, April 7, 1836: p3c1.

¹¹ Western Argus, August 5, 1835: p2c3.

¹² Whippo aided by bringing along a skilled staff from his previous jobs. Henry C. Moore was named chief of the locating party after working on the Erie and Wabash Canal with Whippo. See Report of the Canal Commissioners, 1836/7, 70.

¹³ Report of the Canal Commissioners, 1836/7: 67.

the state works in any given week, and at least a dozen transportation companies and independent operators had pressed four hundred boats into service to accommodate them; somewhere between nine hundred and one thousand rail cars were being used on the adjoining Philadelphia and Columbia Railroad in the eastern part of the state.¹⁴ Four steamship operators on the Great Lakes added regular stops at Erie to their summer schedules to get a foot into this booming market.¹⁵

This rising sense of importance attached to Northwest Pennsylvania was bolstered even further when state figures approved spending \$200,000 to get work started on the canal to Lake Erie. Rumors swirling through the taverns and shops of Erie held that the canal commissioners were expected to visit the area soon, and some members of that body appeared in New Castle on August 6, 1836.¹⁶

They hurriedly reviewed the survey reports of the Shenango River and announced their intentions to receive bids for the work, which was now being called the Erie Extension Canal. All parts of the Erie Extension Canal between the Beaver Division and Greenville were then opened for competitive bidding through September 6, 1836.

¹⁴ Erie Gazette, April 16, 1836: p3c3.

¹⁵ Erie Gazette, June 9, 1836: p2c2.

¹⁶ Meadville Courier, June 28, 1836: p3c4.

Parties of engineers were ordered to begin staking out the work in a week. Residents of New Castle voiced approval for this eruption of activity on the canals, but many doubted it would produce lasting results; critics were already complaining of the "the snails pace of Dr. Whippo."¹⁷

State authorities answered their foes by releasing detailed plans for the new work and inviting bids for forty-five and a half miles of canals and slackwater pools, five dams, twenty-six locks, eighteen weirs, eleven culverts, three aqueducts, bridges, and fencing. This represented the bulk of the Shenango Division, which was created as an administrative unit for public works spanning sixty miles between the Beaver Division and Conneaut Lake. However, work had only been authorized on three quarters of the line at this time pending possible changes.

It was still not clear if the canal would continue toward Lake Erie from the head of the Shenango River or cross Conneaut Lake into the French Creek Feeder Canal. The engineers laying out the Shenango Division were therefore instructed by the canal commissioners to finish that line and head to Erie; from this point, they were charged with surveying a line from the public dock to the head of navigation in French Creek at Waterford. Popular

¹⁷ Erie Gazette, August 11, 1835: p3c1.

opinion held the canal commissioners would finally declare their support for a route when this report was finished.¹⁸

Several of the canal commissioners were sighted with Dr. Whippo in Erie near the end of July, 1836 and into August. Their secretary and the remaining members of that body were expected at any time, and a final decision on the route for the canal was expected once they had all assembled at Erie.¹⁹ The engineers and surveyors who were assigned to this line rode into town on October 18, 1836 and announced their intentions to start working immediately.²⁰

Optimistic forecasts guessed that contracts for the new work would be signed by the start of the new year, leaving plenty of time to get ready for the building season. More careful observers might have noticed the canal board had not released a decision and only called for letting fourteen and a half miles from Erie; this was the distance of the old portage to Waterford and a length that would have to surveyed and built in either case.²¹

Speculators ignored these details and descended on Erie again

¹⁸ Erie Gazette, September 1, 1836: p3c1.

¹⁹ Erie Gazette, August 4, 1836: p3c1.

²⁰ Erie Gazette, October 20, 1836: p3c1.

²¹ Erie Gazette, August 11, 1835: p3c1.

with heightened expectations. Prices for land quickly rose above the prohibitive levels of the preceding spring. Investors from New York City paid \$50,000 for a forty-five acre tract, and there were reports of negotiations for sales involving greater sums.²² Competition for these plots increased even further after the Pennsylvania state government met the semi-annual interest payment on the public debt without resorting to special taxes. Nearly \$100,000 remained in state coffers after paying this obligation, and this might be used to finish the canal.²³ The engineers who had been tasked with locating a suitable canal route to Erie added to the frenzy by submitting their long overdue report to the Board of Canal Commissioners.

Whippo and his staff recommended the Western Route, which was 25 miles shorter than the Allegheny and French Creek passage. Following this line promised to reduce the necessary lockage and save taxpayers up to \$171,000.²⁴ This news naturally excited citizens living along the projected path of the canal. The inhabitants of Brightstown at the northern end of Conneaut Lake assembled on January 12, 1837 and adopted a resolution supporting

²² Erie Gazette, August 4, 1836: p3c1.

²³ Erie Gazette, August 18, 1836: p3c1.

²⁴ Erie Gazette, December 22, 1836: p2c6.

the report and condemning any further delays.

Promoters of the rival path on French Creek refused to surrender their dreams so easily. Merchants at Meadville called their own meeting and threatened to build a railroad if they did not get the canal. Colonel Joseph Cochran lived near Meadville and lobbied state legislators with a threat that citizens from that area had "kept back the extension canal for the last five years" and would double that record to keep the Western Route from being built.²⁵ None of the canal commissioners appeared willing to enter the fray and so there was no official response to the engineer's report.

Their inaction only exacerbated tensions in the area. Boosters from Conneaut, Ohio, stepped in and offered that place as an outlet for Pennsylvania on Lake Erie. They suggested that Conneaut might soon rival Cleveland with the right kind of backing, and then pointed out the Shenango Division could easily continue down Conneaut Creek and directly into Lake Erie from the western end of Conneaut Lake. Following this plan could reduce the number of locks and the overall costs for construction below all previous estimates.

Carrying a canal across the state line was not an extraordinary proposal given the Mahoning Canal was already completed and in

²⁵ Meadville Courier, January 17, 1837: p2c3.

operation, but the response from the northwest corner of Pennsylvania was predictable. One newspaper from Erie advised its readers on both sides of the state line "that withstanding the harbor at Conneaut is sufficiently capacious to hold as many Geese as there are vessels on the lake, they will find that when Pennsylvania spends her money it will be to enrich herself and citizens."²⁶ Pennsylvania state leaders quickly expressed their agreement with this stand.

The appropriations bill introduced in February, 1837 included over three million dollars for the public works. Approximately one half of this amount was set aside to subsidize corporations, and all of the remaining funds were dedicated to the state canals and railroads. More than \$600,000 was set aside for finishing the Erie Extension Canal.

Opponents of the administration, and even some supporters, questioned these amounts when the bill was read for the first time. The figures seemed too outlandish given past difficulties in raising funds, and every project was subsequently scaled back. Funding for the Erie Extension Canal was reduced by a full third; but this was still not enough to stem charges of wild spending, and

²⁶ Erie Gazette, February 23, 1837: p3c2.

even Governor Ritner started to express misgivings.²⁷

Friends of the canal in the state legislature responded to these fears by revising the appropriations bill to guarantee favorable treatment from bankers. One provision of the amended act therefore permitted state leaders to invest public money in private firms including the Bank of Pennsylvania.²⁸ Opponents of the administration instantly warned Ritner that easy credit only encouraged speculation and monopolies while taking power from the working class.

Overturing the governor at this point was not likely since Antimason politicians in the General Assembly were forging a broad coalition with Whigs and even Conservative Democrats. However, friends of the bank were caught somewhat by surprise and scrambled to secure their own interests.²⁹ A compromise was arranged that protected the United States Bank, but prohibited state branches of that institution from speculating or investing in public improvements.³⁰ This defection by the bankers left state authorities holding full responsibility for funding the public

²⁷ Erie Gazette, February 23, 1837: p3c1.

²⁸ McFarlane, "The Pennsylvania Canals," WPHM 22(1), 41-42.

²⁹ Snyder, The Jacksonian Heritage, 89-90.

³⁰ Erie Gazette, March 2, 1837: p2c1.

works.

Every single project suffered additional reductions by the time the appropriations bill was sent to Ritner, and the Erie Extension lost another \$100,000. Antimasons could not afford this snub to one of their strongholds and at the last minute they tacked on an amendment that restored \$100,000 for this canal "if necessary."³¹ Funding for private companies finally proved the decisive issue of this budget proposal. Governor Ritner strongly opposed funding private concerns while the canals went unfinished. Since limited resources made it impossible to have it both ways, Ritner vetoed the Improvement Bill rather than risk state bankruptcy.³² This action was not unduly upsetting or completely unexpected since everyone realized that some accommodation would be made.

Disappointment at Erie over another delay in starting work on the canal was tempered by the survival of the bank. A cashier had just arrived at Erie to commence operations near the start of the month. Local newspapers advised their readers that combining the presence of this bank with a canal or railroad would ultimately make the port of Erie second to none on the lakes. One editor

³¹ Erie Gazette, April 6, 1837: p3c1.

³² Erie Gazette, April 13, 1837: p3c1; April 20, 1837: p2c1-4.

surmised that with these combined facilities not even Cleveland and Pittsburgh, or "little" Conneaut, could stand in the way.³³

Competition and criticism from these rival centers was becoming an increasingly sensitive subject at Erie. Years of delay in extending the public works to the Great Lakes had provided more than enough bad publicity. Support for the Mahoning Canal at Pittsburgh was an especially sore point. Any real or imagined slight instantly launched a round of rebuttals and outright slander.

A promotional piece that ran at Pittsburgh in the spring of 1837, for instance, advised western shippers that the Ohio River and the Main Line Canal were opened for shipping several weeks before the Great Lakes and the Erie Canal. While this was intended to draw trade through Pennsylvania from New York, inhabitants of Erie took it as derogatory to their interests. An editor caustically commented "how wonderful" it was that dim-witted Pittsburghers had discovered ice melts sooner in the south. Western shippers were then warned that the Ohio River suffered from low water levels during much of the summer, and navigation was accordingly suspended.³⁴ Politicians and businessmen at Erie even

³³ Erie Gazette, March 2, 1837: p2c6.

³⁴ Erie Gazette, March 9, 1837: p3c1; March 23, 1837: p3c2.

welcomed news of a downswing in the economic climate at Pittsburgh. The inhabitants of Erie saw this as just retribution for betraying their own interest, and failed to realize this presaged larger problems.

Investors and residents at Erie were expecting another banner year for business. Promotional pieces pointed out no less than five large warehouses were being built on the wharf on Lake Erie by the start of the boating season in 1837. A local shipbuilding industry was taking off, and the keels for a brig and steamboat had just been laid near the shoreline. Improvements on the waterfront were matched in residential neighborhoods where houses were "springing up" while streets were being levelled and filled, and sidewalks were being extended or repaired.³⁵

A few merchants expressed fears that a "spring recession" fueled by speculation and wild investments might spread outside of Pittsburgh, but they were widely discounted as alarmists. Most residents of Northwest Pennsylvania preferred thinking that any difficulties at Pittsburgh would stay confined to the Forks of the Ohio. Politicians, merchants and citizens alike were therefore shocked by news that New York banks had suspended specie payments on May 9, 1837.

³⁵ Erie Gazette, May 4, 1837: p3c1.

Banks had already closed in New York, Baltimore and Philadelphia when news of the panic reached Pittsburgh four days later. After a hurried meeting to discuss the crisis, Pittsburgh bankers decided they had no alternative to following suit.³⁶ Signs of this unfolding crisis were carried into Northwest Pennsylvania when contractors on the public works were once again warned to suspend operations. Work on the Shenango Division and the older lines all but ceased pending an emergency appropriation.³⁷

This decision by state authorities to suspend operations only reinforced the division between the upper and lower halves of Western Pennsylvania. Public figures in Ohio refused to buckle under and found \$450,000 to keep construction of the Mahoning Canal on schedule. Officials of Trumbull County chipped in with a loan for \$35,000 and called on their counterparts from Portage County and Cuyahoga County to match it. Pittsburgh newspapers cheerfully reported this project was "especially favored" and that hard times worked to its advantage "both by the reduction of prices and the abundance of hands."³⁸

³⁶ Reiser, Pittsburgh's Commercial Development, 168.

³⁷ Corkan, Beaver and Lake Erie Canal, 52.

³⁸ Daily Pittsburgh Gazette, May 24, 1837: p2c1; Reiser, Pittsburgh's Commercial Development, 118.

Laborers were turned out of factories and shops by the hundreds and then thousands in other parts of the nation as the crisis mounted. In Pittsburgh nearly two thousand people were thrown into the streets by the end of May. A major firm that specialized in supplying goods for the public works discharged 175 hands, keeping just one or two foremen and some apprentices on the payroll. Other businesses across the city reported equally dramatic reductions; one company with 37 employees released 30 of them, and another trimmed its normal roster of 34 down to just 2 or 3 hands. Shop managers savagely targeted women, children and widows at the lower end of the pay scale and warned men to move into these lower paying positions or starve.³⁹

Every business based in the city suffered these kinds of reductions over the following weeks. One of the leading transportation lines at Pittsburgh suspended operations on the Main Line and others curtailed their operations.⁴⁰ Between fifty and sixty steamers were laid up at Pittsburgh with nothing to do. A comparable number that visited the city in better times were stalled at Saint Louis, while others sat at Cincinnati and Louisville. The few steamboats still in service were said to "have

³⁹ Erie Gazette, June 22, 1837: p3c1.

⁴⁰ Western Argus, May 31, 1837: p2c3-4.

very little freight and are not overburdened with passengers."⁴¹ Business leaders in Pittsburgh predicted "dark and gloomy" times through the coming summer, but then the shipping industry started to show signs of revival.⁴²

Displaced workers who had suffered at a subsistence level when times were good now begged charity in the streets or drifted elsewhere. The shipping industry started to show signs of life again when passenger lines were deluged with people seeking to escape. Three stage lines running between Philadelphia and Pittsburgh expanded their operations going into the summer to include daily arrivals and departures at both points. The Pioneer Line announced plans to expand its packet services on the canal "besides the numerous wagons, which are constantly employed in conveying families to the interior."⁴³

This movement magnified the opportunities that Erie was missing because it lacked suitable port facilities and connections with interior routes. Shipping clerks who made arrangements for moving passengers between canals and steamboats in Cleveland and Buffalo soon had more work than they could handle. Some of the steamers

⁴¹ Western Argus, June 28, 1837: p2c5.

⁴² Erie Gazette, June 22, 1837: p3c1.

⁴³ Western Argus, June 28, 1837: p2c5.

based in Buffalo started out earlier than usual in a bid to ease the crush on the city wharves, and at least one steamer was trapped in ice on Lake Erie. Two more steamers from Buffalo stopped at Erie before the ice had fully lifted, each "crowded with passengers, families, goods, &c., &c., for this city, the west, and the region round about." Any open space on the steamboats was held at a premium, and the few passengers taking their leave at Erie were quickly replaced.⁴⁴

Inhabitants of Erie were stunned when these signs of revival passed them by and Pennsylvania state leaders did not seem to take notice of their plight. Counties sitting north and west of Pittsburgh had generally applauded Ritner's veto in the spring in the belief this would save Pennsylvania millions of dollars in interest payments and place the state in a better situation to overcome its difficulties.⁴⁵ Plaudits turned to worry when the legislature recessed without passing an amended version of the bill. Weeks passed without further action, and erstwhile supporters of the administration joined a general clamor for some measure of relief. Ritner was urged to call a special session of

⁴⁴ Daily Pittsburgh Gazette, May 23, 1837: p2c3.

⁴⁵ Erie Gazette, April 20, 1837: p3c2; Western Argus, June 28, 1837: p2c4.

the legislature, but he declined on grounds that racing ahead without due thought for consequences would be ill calculated and "mischievous" to the state.⁴⁶

Ritner, of course, had not ignored the crisis. At the end of May, 1837 the governor called for state banks to take corrective measures on their own. A moderate issue of bills was suggested, if released in a true spirit of cooperation with those in need.⁴⁷ Ritner announced that he had secured a loan of \$200,000 near the end of June, 1837 for resuming work on the Erie Extension Canal and the West Branch Canal on the Susquehanna.⁴⁸ To assuage complaints of favoritism from other parts of the state, the canal commissioners released news that the Main Line had brought in upwards of \$550,000 in tolls and suggested the benefits of increased revenues would soon spread through the entire state.⁴⁹

Northwestern counties expressed delight that the governor had provided for their relief, but failed to notice the amount slated for the Erie Extension Canal was just a third of what the amount the canal commissioners had asked for in the spring and would have

⁴⁶ Reiser, Pittsburgh's Commercial Development, 169.

⁴⁷ Western Argus, May 31, 1837: p2c4.

⁴⁸ Western Argus, June 28, 1837: p2c5-6, p3c1.

⁴⁹ Western Argus, July 5, 1837: p2c2.

to be shared between two separate lines. The reality of this scant funding was made clear shortly afterwards when heavy rains and floods struck the area.

Erie County was hit by a severe downpour that started on June 8, 1837 and continued for three days. Roads and bridges were damaged throughout the county, including important structures over Elk Creek and Walnut Creek.⁵⁰ Recovery efforts drew attention away from the canal and postponed the start of any new work on the canals. This situation deteriorated even further when Crawford County was devastated by storms just weeks later.

Torrents of rain accompanied by severe thunder and lightning struck during the night of July 4, 1837. By 11 A.M. the following morning, French Creek and neighboring streams had reached levels not seen since the "great flood of 1805." Islands and low banks near Meadville disappeared when Cussewago Creek and French Creek merged half a mile west of their usual meeting place. Several homes on Dock Street were hastily abandoned with "their inhabitants leaving their untenable abodes, on horses, in wagons, and in boats." Some horses were trapped on high ground close by and several men braved dangerous waters leading them to safety.⁵¹

⁵⁰ Erie Gazette, June 23, 1837: p3c1.

⁵¹ Erie Gazette, July 13, 1837: p2c5.

Rescue operations and evacuations were rendered extremely dangerous by the volume of drift and timber coming downstream. Mill dams along the creek were washed out and added to the downed trees and limbs cascading downstream. Every farm and mill for ten miles around Meadville reported damages and sawmills on Woodcock Creek were especially hard hit. Public properties near Bemus Mills and points further down French Creek were devastated; one abutment of the French Creek Feeder Dam was swept away and a new channel was cut around the opposite end of the dam. Early reports placed losses in the area at \$100,000 with warnings this total was likely to rise.⁵²

Any benefits of the governor's loan evaporated almost overnight. Streams across the region were cluttered with wreckage through the summer and fall boating season and laborers were diverted from working on the canals to try and open these channels. Ritner had exhausted his credit in securing the loan and there was little chance he could find additional funds to cover these unexpected costs. Members of the legislature had ended their session and were only scheduled to convene again in December.

The promise of railroads

⁵² Erie Gazette, July 13, 1837: p2c5.

Inhabitants of Northwest Pennsylvania openly talked of their betrayal in Harrisburg after this disaster, but it did not appear they could do much but wait. Private citizens had tried on several occasions to promote improvements while work on the canals lagged, but none of these attempts had succeeded in accomplishing much.

Farmers living around Conneaut Lake had complained about the sluggish pace of construction since ground was broken at Meadville. After waiting five years for the French Creek Feeder to open with no clear end in sight, neighbors were called to consider "the expediency of opening the out-let marsh for boat navigation between Konneycutt [sic] Lake and French-creek."⁵³ Proponents of opening this passage believed they could provide an alternative for the canal by simply clearing vegetation from a channel through the marshlands. This proved impractical for a handful of farmers, and the scheme wilted.

Other settlements called for a renewed emphasis on building roads in Northwest Pennsylvania, but they were no better suited for this venture. Construction was still expensive and based on the Macadam techniques used on the Lancaster and Philadelphia Turnpike and the National Road in the earlier part of the century. Keeping the roads in a useful state presented a sizable problem and a

⁵³ Crawford Weekly Messenger, May 12, 1832: p3c5.

constant expense.

Travellers taking stagecoaches over the turnpike between Philadelphia and Pittsburgh were severely jostled about, and commonly complained of banging their heads on the carriage roofs.⁵⁴ Conditions on the National Road had gotten so bad that public authorities from Ohio seized control over their segment of the highway in 1831, and erected toll booths to collect maintenance costs. National leaders offered to relinquish control to the other states it passed through, but Maryland and Pennsylvania both refused until they were provided with toll booths and necessary repairs were made.⁵⁵ Local roads were often in worse shape having less funding for repairs or popular support for keeping them open. Problems with roads and the slow pace of building canals ultimately sparked new consideration of railroads.

Railroads exploded across the United States while laborers carved out waterways in Pennsylvania. Railroaders had greatly

⁵⁴ Durrenberger, Turnpikes,

⁵⁵ See Searight, Old Pike, 52-56, 357-358. An Act of April 11, 1831, noted "Whereas, that part of the Cumberland Road lying in Pennsylvania is in many parts in bad condition for want of repairs, and as many doubts have been entertained whether the United States have authority to erect toll gates on said road and collect toll," leaving Pennsylvania authorities with no choice but to step in and arrange terms for "its constant continuance and preservation."

improved their equipment and building capabilities since the debates over roads, canals and railroads in the 1820s. Finding adequate funds to start construction was the most obvious hindrance to building railroads in Pennsylvania, where state leaders had invested so heavily in canals with taxes and political favors.

Construction on the Baltimore and Ohio line was pushed ever westward from Baltimore after 1827, sparking proposals for dozens of similar works. After watching the tracks creep up the Potomac along with the Chesapeake and Ohio Canal, New York authorities decided to build a similar line. Lawmakers sitting in Albany did not foresee destructive competition between the two modes of transport, and suggested that railroads might serve as feeders for the Erie Canal and ease congestion on this prized waterway.

Business was so good on the Erie Canal that construction of the Mohawk and Hudson Railroad was started on a parallel course in 1830. Track laying crews were hurried up the Mohawk River and westward at a hectic pace during the building season and about one thousand hands were employed by the end of summer.⁵⁶ An exhibition train passed the full distance between Albany and Schenectady on April 9, 1831, and one official voiced hopes this might relieve the

⁵⁶ Pittsburgh Gazette, October 1, 1830: p3c4.

canal of its "onerous" passenger trade.⁵⁷

Rail building suffered a temporary setback in New York when rail promoters talked of opening a long distance carrier after their success with the Hudson and Mohawk. Elected officials in New York proved as slavish to toll receipts and job appointments on the canal as Pennsylvania politicians. When the New York and Erie Railroad Company was organized to expand rail services in 1832, the "canal ring" in the state legislature steered their tracks away from the canal. Any approved routes for the line were kept near the state boundary with Pennsylvania, and relegated by law to some unmentioned port west of Buffalo. Dunkirk was the only harbor that met this description, but it lacked port facilities. Investors holding stock the company were tacitly advised they should look further afield for connections.⁵⁸

Promoters took the hint and started looking at projects in Pennsylvania and Ohio. One group proposed building a rail alternative to the Mahoning Canal in 1832, a full three years before ground was broken for that canal. Exploratory surveys that were carried over thirty-eight miles between New Lisbon and Canton

⁵⁷ Shaw, Erie Water West, 287; Condon, Stars in the Water, 305.

⁵⁸ Hungerford, Men of Erie, 19.

found ground well suited for building railroads and reducing the expensive deep cutting and embankments needed for a canal. Investors who looked at this report proposed extending the railroad to the mouth of the Beaver River and Pittsburgh; another scheme called for laying tracks from eastern Ohio all the way to New York City.⁵⁹

Railroad promoters captured public support with these kinds of proposals. More than two hundred separate rail companies won state charters around the United States by the middle 1830s, and one thousand miles of tracks were in use through eleven different states. With few exceptions, these early railroads were poorly funded, of short length, and designed to satisfy local cravings for improvements; one source has stated they "began anywhere and ended anywhere." There was no hint of a unified system, but growing interest in railroads foretold a healthy future. The monthly "American Railroad Journal" answered public demands for information by switching to a weekly format starting on January 2, 1832.⁶⁰

States that had invested heavily in canals naturally tried to control construction and enthusiasm for railroads. Lawmakers in

⁵⁹ Western Argus, March 23, 1832: p3c3; August 16, 1833: p1c2-3; Pittsburgh Gazette, October 1, 1832: p2c1.

⁶⁰ Burgess, Pennsylvania Railroad, 15.

the state of New York incorporated the Utica and Schenectady line on April 29, 1834 with restrictions to preserve the canal trade. One clause bound the railroad to refuse "property of any description except the ordinary baggage of the passengers." Other lines were bound by similar conditions regarding their services, track rights and the kinds of equipment they could use. Passengers trying to cross New York between Albany and Buffalo by rail in the middle 1830s faced sixteen different transfers including several connections by stage or wagons through gaps in the rails.⁶¹ Boating down the Erie Canal seemed to present a picture of stability in contrast, and even the Pennsylvania Main Line compared favorably to this chaotic situation.

Businessmen in western states were angered at how the eastern states disregarded their concerns in adopting these rules. Every transfer added to their costs in time and hard money while placing their freight at increased risks of damages. Hundreds turned out at Cincinnati in 1835 when local merchants called for public discussions about building railroads. Plans were floated for building direct connections between Cincinnati and major ports including New York City, Philadelphia, Charleston and New Orleans. Talk of building railroads subsequently swept through the western

⁶¹ Durrenberger, Turnpikes, 136-137.

states and territories and skipped up over national boundaries.

Canadian authorities considered making a railroad around Niagara Falls in 1832, but they had repaired the old Welland Canal to compete with the Erie Canal instead. Public authorities in Canada feared the competition with railroads could prove fatal for the canal, but public sentiment overrode protections for pet expenditures. A railroad was then planned along the border from the area near Buffalo and Black Rock all the way to Detroit in 1835.⁶² There was also discussion of carrying a railroad over the border in Maine, where a small army of 35 surveyors was already charting a right-of-way between Belfast and Portland.⁶³ Filling in the gap between the two lines at some later date would leave the Canadians with a continuous line from the upper Great Lakes to the Atlantic.

After enjoying the phenomenal success of the Erie Canal for a decade, public figures in New York were suddenly buffeted on every side by demands for railroads, and even people who made their living from the canal were not immune to the mounting frenzy. Inhabitants of Lockport petitioned the state assembly for a

⁶² Erie Gazette, April 6, 1836: p2c6; Glazebrooke, History of Transportation in Canada, 150-151.

⁶³ Erie Gazette, August 11, 1835: p3c3.

railroad in hopes of improving services, or at least reducing tolls on the canal.⁶⁴ New York leaders in Albany determined they would not surrender any of the gains they had made, but they bowed to public demands for additional services. Charter privileges for the New York and Erie Railroad raced through legislative committees, and groundbreaking ceremonies were held on November 7, 1835.⁶⁵

Pennsylvania authorities were still uncertain how to proceed in railroad matters and continued to question their purported benefits over canals. Exchanging freight and passengers between short lines and wagons replicated the transfers on the Main Line, and railroads had not mastered severe weather; locomotives were idled on the Saratoga and Schenectady line in New York from January 10, 1836 through the first week of April because of heavy snow. One frustrated newspaper columnist at Fredonia warned his readers that railroads were not always "navigable."⁶⁶

Problems with keeping the trains on schedule left the canals holding a favorable place in the public eye. Pennsylvania authorities could therefore limit rail building without stirring up too much trouble for themselves. Increased toll revenues on the

⁶⁴ Shaw, Erie Water West, 288.

⁶⁵ Hungerford, Men of Erie, 23.

⁶⁶ Erie Gazette, April 21, 1836: p3c2.

Main Line greatly aided this effort, and the system finally gave signs of at least covering maintenance and operating costs. Most Pennsylvanians would not argue with protectionist policies after shouldering the costs for building the Main Line Canal.

Rail building in Pennsylvania was therefore relegated to a role in support of the Main Line Canal and its branches. Permission to lay tracks inside Pennsylvania or across the state boundaries was based on this premise. Rail speculators from Ohio and New York saw several plans dashed when they failed to consult Pennsylvania authorities before starting work. One of their more ambitious schemes called for opening a continuous line between Buffalo and the Maumee River. Construction started at either end and rapidly progressed toward the old Erie Triangle, where Pennsylvania state leaders halted any further work at making a connection.⁶⁷

Folks living in the area were angered that any improvements were halted, while they watched years go by without any real progress on the canal. Landowners and businessmen in the area saw how quickly rails had been laid and talked of building their own railroad.

Pittsburgh merchants had already raised this idea back when they loaned support to the Mahoning Canal. Newspapers from Pittsburgh called on "friends of the Erie Canal, to Pittsburgh" with cost

⁶⁷ Erie Gazette, March 10, 1836: p3c1.

estimates and instructions on how to lay tracks, and advice that a railroad built on this plan "could be got into active operation before ground could be broken for a canal."⁶⁸

Northwest Pennsylvania had opposed the idea back then, sensing the merchants at Pittsburgh were only trying to save tax dollars and get out of longstanding promises to the area. Opposition faded over the next two years, when the local canals were battered by storms and any assistance from across state lines was blunted by officials sitting in Harrisburg.

Broad discussions about railroads in Northwest Pennsylvania eventually crystallized into concrete plans for a serpentine line running from Pittsburgh through commercial depots at Butler, Mercer, Meadville and Erie. Interested parties followed a familiar routine, and called for a general convention to discuss the matter at Mercer on June 22, 1836.⁶⁹ Every county in Western Pennsylvania was invited to send delegates, but only those representing stops on the line bothered to send delegates.

County governments and sparsely populated districts lying northward and east of the proposed railroad only gave this call passing notice because they were promoting a separate line.

⁶⁸ Daily Pittsburgh Gazette, December 31, 1834: p2c3.

⁶⁹ Erie Gazette, May 26, 1836: p3c1; p3c2.

Inhabitants from the area around Wattsburg in Erie County had complained for years about their inability to reach markets with local products. Their lumber and cut boards were in great demand with builders at Erie, but the only decent road in the area went in an opposite direction toward the New York state line near Jamestown.⁷⁰ Representatives from Wattsburg therefore joined rail enthusiasts who assembled in March, 1836 at Jersey Shore (in Lycoming County) to promote railroads. Delegates to the convention called on elected leaders to consider "the propriety and practicability" of opening a direct communication between the Philadelphia and the Great Lakes along the West Branch of the Susquehanna River.⁷¹

State authorities tried to wrest control of this situation. On April 21, 1836 the Pennsylvania canal commissioners hired Benjamin Aycrigg to undertake surveys for either a canal or railroad over the mountains from Erie and the West Branch of the Susquehanna.⁷² However, this action failed to sway public opinion and certain merchants from Philadelphia expressed interest in the railroad.

News drifting down from New York included a bold plan for

⁷⁰ Erie Gazette, April 21, 1836: p3c1.

⁷¹ Erie Gazette, March 31, 1836: p3c1.

⁷² Erie Gazette, April 21, 1836: p3c2.

opening a system of short lines and inclined planes covering 510 miles between Albany and Dunkirk. Speculators in Philadelphia pointed out that opening a comparable line through Pennsylvania shaved off 113 miles and eliminated any need for mechanical lifts with their repeated transfers of cargoes and passengers.⁷³ This convenience would clearly render the Main Line obsolete, so promoters added a branch line to Pittsburgh from somewhere in Jefferson County or Clearfield County to placate Southwest Pennsylvania. Citizens from Erie wholeheartedly adopted the proposal. Not only did it promise access to outside markets, there was a chance to get even with Pittsburgh for past wrongs; if the railroad was finished, Erie would become a major hub of commerce while Pittsburgh fell behind.⁷⁴

Desires for railroads swept through parts of Northwest Pennsylvania in the way proposals for canals had a decade earlier. Loose plans for railroads increased in value before tracks were laid. When state officials hedged on promises to Wattsburg, a handful of local men had organized to try and lay tracks over to Erie. Once plans for the Northumberland and Erie line became public, people flocked into Wattsburg trying to buy shares in their

⁷³ Erie Gazette, March 31, 1836: p3c1.

⁷⁴ Erie Gazette, March 31, 1836: p3c1.

project.⁷⁵

State leaders sitting in Harrisburg were stunned by the chaos breaking out around them, and the grave threats it posed for the Main Line. Surveys were quietly initiated that summer "with a view to avoid, if possible, the inclined planes on the Portage Railroad" with canals or railroads. Funding for the work was capped at a modest two thousand dollars to mask any hints of retreat from the Main Line system.⁷⁶ Several weeks later, state leaders confirmed Charles Whippo as chief engineer on the Erie Extension Canal and broadened his duties to include work on railroads. Besides overseeing all state waterways on the far sides of the mountains, Whippo was tasked with locating a railroad from the Allegheny River at Freeport through Butler and New Castle.⁷⁷ Enthusiasm for railroads collapsed once this action became known. Early backers decided it would be a mistake to spend their own funds if the state planned on opening a competing route. All plans for the Erie and Northumberland were put on hold until the state made its intentions clear.⁷⁸

⁷⁵ Erie Gazette, March 31, 1836: p3c1.

⁷⁶ Burgess, Pennsylvania Railroad, 25.

⁷⁷ Report of the Canal Commissioners, 1836-1837: 19.

⁷⁸ Erie Gazette, June 23, 1836: p3c1.

Proponents of finishing the canal in Northwest Pennsylvania were stunned by the support railroads had garnered, and seized this lull to restore their waning influence in shaping state policies. Residents of Meadville opened 1837 with a convention to consider the merits of railroads and canals, but quickly gave away their real intentions. Plans were drawn up for a railroad between French Creek and the canal basin at Erie, but added this was only necessary if the state continued work on the Erie Extension. All in attendance agreed that a canal was sufficient for their needs if it was carried up French Creek, and Venango County was called to make common cause with them.

Up at Erie, citizens were growing worried at how the momentum for improvements had fallen off. Excitement over railroads had not fully collapsed with the Erie and Northumberland project, so promoters drew up another line between Sunbury and Williamsport. Petitions asking for charter privileges were carried to Harrisburg on January 4, 1837, where they received a lukewarm response. Elected officials from counties all along the Main Line made the charter conditional on finishing the Erie Extension, and Pittsburgh interests demanded that any major railroad should pass near the Three Rivers.⁷⁹ Backers at Erie had saw no reason they should fund

⁷⁹ Meadville Courier, January 17, 1837: p3c2.

improvements for Pittsburgh and had this part stricken from the bill, killing it.⁸⁰

Representatives from Southwest Pennsylvania had foreseen this outcome when they worked the offending clause into the bill. Pittsburgh merchants claimed that rail building in Pennsylvania was marked by failures, and characterized the line through Philadelphia as "impractical and useless." Critics of railroads next mused if the first city of Pennsylvania could not build an effective railroad, it would surely prove wasteful to push a line through "the wild lands of our Northern and northwestern counties." Since the ultimate aim was to break into the Great Lakes, their solution was to form an alliance with Cleveland and disrupt relations between the governments in New York and Ohio.⁸¹ Delegates from Venango County heartily agreed, and added his thoughts that a railroad from Pittsburgh to Cleveland might swing up near the mouth of French Creek.⁸²

Wrangling over charters and routes dashed any hopes for starting work that summer, leading potential investors to seek out other projects. Philadelphia merchants shifted their focus and expressed

⁸⁰ Erie Gazette, March 9, 1837: p3c1.

⁸¹ Erie Gazette, April 6, 1837: p3c2.

⁸² Erie Gazette, March 2, 1837: p2c6.

interest in a continuous railroad running from the banks of the Delaware all the way to New Orleans. Promoters observed that a series of short lines was already in place over parts of the route, and these could be joined together without any great expense or resorting to inclined planes.⁸³

State leaders finally acted to preserve the Main Line and keep money from flowing across state boundaries. After a short recess, delegates in Harrisburg crafted their first comprehensive railroad bill and sent it on to the governor on April 3, 1837. Key provisions of the bill incorporated the Sunbury and Erie Railroad with stops in Williamsport and Northumberland; a branch line was slated to run through Warren, Franklin, Mercer, and New Castle down to the borough of Beaver on the Ohio River. This act also directed "The Pittsburgh and Susquehanna Railroad Company" to proceed up the Allegheny River to join the sunbury and Erie on the West Branch of the Susquehanna. Finishing this network could more than answer the

⁸³ Erie Gazette, April 6, 1837: p2c4. Lines viewed as part of this system included the Philadelphia and Columbia Railroad in Pennsylvania; leading into the Cumberland Valley Railroad of western Maryland; Franklin Railroad to Harpers Ferry, Virginia; the Potomac and Staunton Railroad through the Staunton and Lynchburg, in Virginia; and then Lynchburg and Tennessee Railroad leading into the Nashville and New Orleans line. Parts of this corridor follow the traditional paths south and westward from Philadelphia described in Rouse's, Great Wagon Road.

needs expressed for canals.⁸⁴

News that the bill was signed into law sparked celebrations at Erie on April 18, 1837. Morning broke with a salutes from cannon, small arms, ringing bells, and "other usual demonstrations of joy." A public feast followed, with speeches and toasts that honored "State Improvements: long delayed by a system of log rolling, which would be much more honored in the breech than observance."⁸⁵ Problems with funding the lines and getting work started were overlooked in the euphoria of the moment. When weeks and months passed with no action, communities began discussing their alternatives again.

Citizens of Butler and surrounding communities called on the greater area to consider "the subject of constructing a National Macadamized Turnpike Road from some convenient point on the present National Road (leading from Cumberland, MD, to Wheeling, Va.) to the harbor at Erie." For once Meadville wholeheartedly agreed and called on Crawford County to join this effort, since the route passed through the town.⁸⁶ Calls for delegates eventually drew

⁸⁴ Burgess, Pennsylvania Railroad, 147-149.

⁸⁵ Erie Gazette, April 20, 1837: p3c1.

⁸⁶ Meadville Courier, July 25, 1837: p3c2; August 1, 1837: p2c4.

responses from Butler, Crawford, Mercer and Erie. Since none of the southwestern counties showed any interest, the convention was held at Erie on August 16, 1837. Those in attendance reviewed the general lack of progress in Northwest Pennsylvania and blamed it on sectional rivalries that held back the canal. Local politicians and merchants at the meeting saw their fortunes slipping away, and agreed to accept a new highway as a cheap substitute. A few voiced support for bringing the road up through Brownsville and Pittsburgh, expressing hopes this might restore good relations with the absent southwestern counties.⁸⁷

Legislators sitting in Harrisburg looked at the political chaos their policies had unleashed in Northwest Pennsylvania and fell back on their usual solution. The Board of Canal Commissioners was instructed to resume work on the canal toward Lake Erie, while the state assembly reviewed the needs of that area. Inhabitants of the region then took their turn in typical fashion, praising the administration for its "foresight" in tackling this matter; newspapers advised readers that the "croaking anticipation of the enemies of the [state] system are not likely to be realized."⁸⁸ Contractors soon called for "any number" of hands and promised

⁸⁷ Erie Gazette, August 24, 1837: p3c2-3.

⁸⁸ Western Argus, August 30, 1837: p2c4.

regular wages and high work, but warned they could not say how long the good times might last. State leaders were notorious for withholding funds and interrupting work schedules. Prospective workers were warned that any long term commitments hinged on elections scheduled for the following year.

Public improvements and the election of 1838

After years of disappointment and repeated delays, 1838 loomed as a critical year for the public works. Rising costs and the wholesale suspension of new lines in 1837 forced taxpayers across the commonwealth to reconsider their commitment to canals. Elections scheduled for 1838 were viewed across the state as a moratorium on the fate of the public works.

Inhabitants at Erie and other points along the proposed routes of the canal were in agony waiting for the outcome of the election. Talk of building railroads and finishing the canal had fostered another building boom at Erie, and several substantial warehouses were going up with a local branch of the federal national bank.⁸⁹

Goods began moving across Pennsylvania for the year on April 2, 1838 well before New York opened the Erie Canal. Wharves and warehouses that were already opened at Erie had presented an

⁸⁹ Erie Gazette, May 17, 1838: p2c5.

"animated scene" of workers scampering to move the freight and produce of the West over local roads toward the Pennsylvania Main Line Canal and outlets to the Atlantic shores. Citizens at Erie boasted that the state works were "honorable in the highest degree both to the state and to the administration" and could only be improved with the extension to Lake Erie.⁹⁰ Any difficulties in trade were attributed to envious feelings in other parts of the state and rival lake ports.⁹¹ Cleveland was subjected to bitter denunciations after boasting about its own buildings, shipping facilities and "spirited inhabitants."⁹²

Trade relations between Pittsburgh and Cleveland had already fostered work on the Mahoning Canal, and Erie fell victim to rumors that there was a plot between these two business centers to halt work on the Erie Extension canal. Citizens took offense at any slight and complained when Erie was described as a "sleepy borough" in Cleveland and Pittsburgh.⁹³ Newspaper editors at Erie commonly warned readers that Cleveland already manipulated the Pittsburgh

⁹⁰ Pittsburgh Daily Gazette, May 4, 1838: p2c3.

⁹¹ Erie Gazette, April 5, 1838: p3c1; Pittsburgh Daily Gazette, May 4, 1838: p2c3.

⁹² Erie Gazette, January 25, 1838: p3c1.

⁹³ Erie Gazette, January 25, 1838: p3c1.

media.⁹⁴ An anonymous letter favoring Cleveland in a Philadelphia newspaper brought paranoid charges that Cleveland interests had extended their reach.⁹⁵ When a Buffalo publication erroneously reported the steamer "Robert Fulton" had difficulty clearing the harbor at Erie, there was talk of a conspiracy between neighboring states.⁹⁶ Pennsylvania legislators only added to the hysteria by hedging on expenses as the costs relaying to the Main Line continued to rise.

Support for an appropriations bill collapsed in the General Assembly in April, 1838 when members reported the true costs of maintaining the public works. Taxpayers from Crawford County and Erie County were cheered that funding for the Mahoning Canal was stricken from the appropriations bill, but every individual segment of the state works was cut from twenty to fifty percent. Almost a quarter of a million dollars was allowed for paying off parts of the Erie Extension Canal that were already finished, but only half that sum was allotted for new contracts. Engineers and the divisional officers serving on the Erie Extension Canal were instructed they should not issue contracts for more than thirty

⁹⁴ Erie Gazette, April 5, 1838: p3c1.

⁹⁵ Erie Gazette, January 25, 1838: p3c1.

⁹⁶ Erie Gazette, April 19, 1838: p3c1.

additional miles of the canal, perhaps indicating renewed favor for a connection with French Creek.⁹⁷ If this was their intention, the canal commissioners reversed themselves soon after.

Legislators sitting in the Pennsylvania House of Representatives adopted the revised appropriations bill on May 3, 1838; Charles Whippo followed with an announcement that work was going to resume on the Western Route of the Erie Extension Canal. Once the Shenango Line reached its terminus at Conneaut Lake, a continuation called the Conneaut Division was projected due north and overland toward the lake shore and the harbor at Erie. Surveyors and engineers in the state service were instructed to begin locating this line from Conneaut Lake as quickly as possible.⁹⁸

Most residents of Erie paused in relief after suffering so many alarms over the years. One group of men decided that some sort of celebration was required and began firing a cannon in the public square. A popular physician named Dr. Roberts decided to add to the fun and brought four pounds of rifle powder that was packed into the barrel and fired; the force of this explosion shattered the cannon and injured several onlookers including Roberts, who died on the spot after his right arm and part of his skull was torn

⁹⁷ Erie Gazette, April 19, 1832: p3c1.

⁹⁸ Erie Gazette, April 19, 1838: p3c2.

off. Spectators drifted home after this tragedy and hoped it did not presage further disasters.⁹⁹

Whippo had already started work by then and even declined to attend a public dinner that was held at Erie in his honor, but reports from the field were not encouraging. His surveyors were pushed to their limits, but only completed sixteen miles by the middle of May. This represented just one third of the distance between Conneaut Lake and Erie, but the slow rate of progress was attributed to bad weather and especially harsh terrain. Whippo assured his fearful public that the work would be ready for the contractors by the end of June.¹⁰⁰

Confidence in the undertaking was restored by the end of the month when the engineers were reported in the area of Elk Creek. During an earlier visit to New Castle, the canal commissioners determined to put as much of the line under contract as permitted by law. Bids for that part of the line from Greenville to Conneaut Lake were opened at Meadville through June 19, 1838 with the remainder going at Erie until the following July 11. Plans for every part of the work were slated for public exhibit for ten days before the actual letting. Awarding these bids was viewed as such

⁹⁹ Erie Gazette, May 3, 1838: p3c2.

¹⁰⁰ Erie Gazette, May 17, 1838: p2c5.

a momentous coup for the administration, that the canal commissioners planned to attend the proceedings.¹⁰¹

Engineers working on the line reached Erie on June 13, 1838 and unexpected good weather allowed them to finish ahead of the most optimistic schedule.¹⁰² Residents and laborers across the northwestern counties were briefly hurled into panic by news the contracts would not be let on time, but state authorities explained the delay was a courtesy to the contractors. Some of them had asked for a postponement so they could prepare an accurate bid on difficult sections. Bids were then accepted at Meadville through July 2, 1838 and at Erie through July 11, 1838.¹⁰³

After their failure to bring railroads to Erie, local merchants and public officials hoped to get work started at the canal again as quick as possible. There was still a chance that the canal program might collapse in the face of mounting costs. After suffering under Ritner and his Anti-Masonry coalition, Democrats nominated David Porter of Huntingdon County for governor with promises to reduce patronage and trim state spending.¹⁰⁴

¹⁰¹ Erie Gazette, May 31, 1838: p3c2; June 7, 1838; p3c5.

¹⁰² Erie Gazette, June 14, 1838: p3c2.

¹⁰³ Crawford Democrat, June 26, 1838: p3c2.

¹⁰⁴ Snyder, Jacksonian Heritage, 123. Porter was named because of his background that appealed to wide interest groups.

Plans for a state constitutional convention during the summer added a sense of urgency to the campaign. State government in Pennsylvania had survived forty-eight years under the Constitution of 1790, despite several challenges to reform it. Critics were not so angered by the principles of rule as the mechanics. Under the terms of this form of government, the governor was vested with outlandish powers of patronage reaching into every corner of public life. Chief executives in Pennsylvania had the power to name a wide range of public officials including the state attorney general, auditor general, surveyor general, state judges, justices of the peace, notaries public, sheriffs, county coroners, clerks of courts, public inspectors, licensed auctioneers, and still later all positions on the state works.¹⁰⁵

Anti-Masons had inherited this system in 1835, and adroitly used it to further their faltering party. Democratic office holders

According to Snyder: "His business and political experience was varied. He studied law, but was never admitted to the bar. A venture into ironmaking ended in bankruptcy during the panic of 1819, but he was a successful farm owner and a noted breeder of horses and cattle. He held numerous local offices and served two terms in the House during the early 1820s. In the election of 1835 he voted for Wolf but took no active part in the campaign. During his two years in the Senate he was identified as an Improvement Man, but he supported party measures including the Independent Treasury. Bank men regarded him as safe."

¹⁰⁵ Wallace, Pennsylvania, 177.

were released from their duties, and contracts on new works were bartered for votes. Both sides therefore prepared for the upcoming round of elections with hopes of using the public works and a new constitution for their own purposes.

Ritner proposed an expansion of the state canals and railroads that was clearly designed with voters in mind. One part of the plan called for opening a direct link between the Western Division of the Main Line Canal at Pittsburgh and the Beaver Division. Since work in the northwestern counties had lagged, this was sure to be taken as a nod to the stockholders in the Mahoning Canal Company at Philadelphia and Pittsburgh, but a supporting line known as the Allegheny Feeder Canal or the Kittaning Feeder could be used to mute this criticism.¹⁰⁶

Navigation on the Main Line extension depended on waters from the Allegheny River. Ritner therefore approved building a feeder canal to take in waters from the Allegheny River near Kittaning and carry it fourteen miles downstream to the Main Line Canal near Freeport. While this was necessary for extending the Main Line Canal westward, it could be presented to Northwest Pennsylvania as the start of a new line leading up the Allegheny River to the

¹⁰⁶ "Report of the Canal Commissioners," JHR 1838, appendix, 23.

Franklin Line.¹⁰⁷

Contractors on the public payroll campaigned for Governor Ritner in hopes of winning new work, and fears that a change in the administration or even a poor showing might threaten their current funding. One series of 44 new contracts went to Ritner men with just 4 or 5 exceptions, and even a few of these were somehow connected to the governor. Critics charged that some of the most experienced contractors were denied work.¹⁰⁸

Published reports held that this policy formed at the highest levels of state government, and contractors complained they were forced to campaign for Ritner or risk losing work.¹⁰⁹ Fully two thousand hands working on parts of the Main Line were reportedly polled, and those against Ritner were summarily dismissed.¹¹⁰ Some

¹⁰⁷. "Allegheny Feeder-report of W. Morris, Engineer," JS 1840, volume III: 168-169; "Report of A. Morris, Superintendent," JS 1840, vol. III: 169-172. The Allegheny Feeder (or Kittaning Feeder) was projected as a fully navigable canal roughly 14 miles in length from an upper termination "somewhere near Kittaning" and joining the Pennsylvania Main Line near Freeport. Work on the different sections was placed under contract in August, 1838. Little was done beyond clearing and grubbing when state leaders failed to provide additional funding in February, 1839. Only one section length of the Allegheny Feeder Canal (no. 29) was ever completed out of 44 segments.

¹⁰⁸ Democrat and Courier, September 4, 1838: p3c4.

¹⁰⁹ Democrat and Courier, September 4, 1838: p3c4.

¹¹⁰ Democrat and Courier, September 25, 1838: p2c1-3.

of these men had brought their families more than one hundred miles in search of work and were left penniless.¹¹¹ One section chief on the Erie Extension Canal protested that "I was told by Mr. Reed, Superintendent, not to make any distinction in employing hands, whether for Porter or Ritner, and consequently never made enquiry how an applicant would vote, until Mr. Stevens [of the Board of Canal Commissioners] came along the line about the first of July."¹¹²

Stevens visited workers on the Gettysburg Railroad a month later and found that a large number of hands favored Porter in the election. All of the workers were then assembled and warned of work stoppages if Ritner lost, and a considerable number were let go as an example to the others even though the railroad directly benefitted an ironworks that Stevens owned. An newspaper at Meadville that favored Porter got wind of this incident and warned: "Since then the turning off process has commenced, and will, no doubt, be carried on with a vengeance. Some of the most active and valuable men have been discharged."¹¹³

Men were not thrown off the Erie Extension in large numbers

¹¹¹ Democrat and Courier, September 25, 1838: p2c2-3.

¹¹² Democrat and Courier, September 25, 1838: p2c2.

¹¹³ Democrat and Courier, September 25, 1838: p2c3.

since a majority in western Crawford County already favored Ritner, but the engineers and other officials on the Erie Extension still bombarded workers with slanderous accounts of Porter in an attempt to arrest any defections.¹¹⁴ Some of the officials took to making bets with the workers, ensuring they would vote for Ritner by linking their pay to the outcome of the election. Democrats vainly protested that buying "foreign and illegal votes" could only "elicit nothing but disgust in the minds of the free and independent."¹¹⁵

Early returns from the election on October 9, 1838 showed Porter with a safe majority, but there were questions over majorities in the House and Senate. Results from some of the Philadelphia districts were thrown aside by "The Friends of Joseph Ritner," who ordered an investigation into how voting was conducted in these localities. Ritner proposed staying in office until the matter was

¹¹⁴ Democrat and Courier, August 28, 1838: p3c3; September 4, 1838: p3c2. Workers were also spared oppressive tactics and firing because so many full time hands had left Northwest Pennsylvania that many who remained on the line were locals working part-time to supplement their incomes. They were less prone to threats. A surviving check roll covering August through December, 1838 shows men paid at a day rate or fraction of that amount based on hours worked; some men were only logging a quarter of a day. "Erie Extension Pennsylvania Canal, check Roll # 2," Archives, vertical file, Erie County Historical Society.

¹¹⁵ Democrat and Courier, October 16, 1838: p3c2; September 4, 1838: p3c2.

decided, tossing aside Porter and the new constitution.¹¹⁶

State senators assembled in Harrisburg to debate the matter on December 4, 1838, but mobs broke up the proceedings. Some of the leading members of the administration were forced to flee out a back window of the meeting hall, and units of the state militia were called to restore order "with thirteen rounds of buckshot cartridges" apiece. Spectators on the streets showed little sympathy for the politicians who were trying to drag out the proceedings; public pressure forced defections from the Ritner camp and the opposition to Porter collapsed. Final counts from the polling stations provided Democrats with majorities in both houses of the General Assembly and Ritner and his cronies were then banned from all public functions. Porter marched in procession to his inauguration in January, 1839 while Ritner was left waiting in the House of Representatives with a small group of friends to witness his "mortification."¹¹⁷

Conclusion

Inhabitants of the northwestern counties who had supported Ritner expected retaliation on a grand scale, and feared the canals

¹¹⁶ Snyder, Jacksonian Heritage, 131-132.

¹¹⁷ Ibid, 135.

might provide a tempting target. Porter faced an immediate interest payment of \$600,000 and an empty treasury, while tolls on the state works lagged far behind costs. In spite of the political and financial risks involved, Porter authorized additional work on the canals to curry favor with the Improvement Men of his party. Starting construction on more sections of the canal presented additional opportunities for dispensing favors to loyal voters. Work slowly crept up the Shenango River from the Beaver Division as a result, and bidding was opened on isolated parts of the Conneaut Division near Erie.

Porter and his closest advisors did not see that they had any real choices in this matter. They had restored Democratic rule in Pennsylvania by promising to finish the branch canals in spite of rising costs and repeated delays in construction. Northwest Pennsylvania voted heavily for Porter and possibly gave him the election because of this pledge.

Tax payers from Northwest Pennsylvania had grown tired of waiting for their elected officials to finish the canals after 1835 and looked at toll roads and railroads as alternatives. State leaders might have overlooked these rumblings from rural farmers and small towns in Northwest Pennsylvania except that other sections of Pennsylvania and neighboring states echoed their call.

Pennsylvania merchants had lost considerable advantages over their commercial rivals when state leaders dallied on building canals twenty years before and wanted to make sure this did not happen again. Philadelphia opened negotiations with Erie about building a railroad to compete with lines in New York and called on public figures for support.

Pennsylvania state leaders considered the benefits of roads and railroads again, but ultimately they decided not to fund any alternatives to the canal. Rather than alienate taxpayers and voters with an admission the canal program had failed to meet expectations, state leaders resumed work on the branch lines in hopes of increasing toll revenues. Plans for building railroads collapsed in Northwest Pennsylvania without state aid, and citizens of the area fell back on the public works as their only hope for tapping new markets and making lasting changes in the local economy. Their desires for improvements of any sort drew the attention of Democrats and Antimasons seeking state office in 1838.

After committing the state to further spending on canals, both parties made it a central theme of their campaign platform in Northwest Pennsylvania. David Porter and his supporters found an edge in citing the repeated failures to finish the Erie Extension Canal since the last election three years earlier. Northwest

Pennsylvania voted heavily for Porter as a result, and handed him the election based on his promise to finally finish the work.

Chapter 6:

GOING PRIVATE: COMPLETING THE ERIE EXTENSION CANAL, 1839-1844

In spite of their campaign promises to continue work on the branch lines, state office holders in Pennsylvania were growing cautious over promoting canals after the elections of 1838. Sparse revenues from the Main Line Canal had failed to reduce the public debt, and majorities of voters in the southern tier of counties (including Philadelphia and Pittsburgh) opposed spending any more money on a failed enterprise. Governor Andrew Porter pushed the work ahead to satisfy his campaign promises, but it was clear that he could not continue this course indefinitely.

A small army of laborers was posted up and down the Erie Extension Canal and the French Creek Feeder in a bid to finish all of the remaining work quickly, but the effort sputtered. The enthusiasm for finishing the canals in high state offices did not percolate down to contractors in the field, and the work suffered from the kinds of mismanagement and improper use of funds that had plagued the work all along.

Contractors and state officials connected with the Erie Extension Canal pleaded for additional time and funding, but in 1842 state authorities decided that tax payers had suffered enough.

Governor Porter and his aides finally admitted defeat in spite of the political risks and halted public spending on canals. All of the public works were then offered for sale beginning with the unfinished lines in Northwest Pennsylvania.

Inhabitants of Northwest Pennsylvania had viewed each mile of the canal that was finished as a visible measure of progress and a harbinger of prosperity. Towns and businesses located along the Pennsylvania Main Line Canal had reaped fortunes from that work (even if the state government faced mounting deficits to keep it running), and a handful of powerful businessmen at Erie reasoned they could replicate this kind of local success. They organized the Erie Canal Company of Pennsylvania in 1843 with plans to finish the work and restore public confidence in canals across Pennsylvania.

Work commences on the Erie Extension

Contracts had already been signed for the remaining parts of the Shenango Division when Porter was voted into office, but there was scant evidence of progress by the end of the year. Many of the contractors were slow getting started, and then they spent the building season and scarce funds erecting shanties for their

workers and procuring supplies.¹ There was wild speculation that Porter was slowing down the work to get revenge on those parts of Northwest Pennsylvania that had voted for Ritner.

Farmers living on French Creek found these rumors all too believable. They had griped for years about the wretched condition of the Franklin Line, and the canal commissioners had finally agreed to try and rebuild some of the worst obstructions to navigation; W. Milnor Roberts was named chief engineer of the French Creek Division on March 5, 1839 with orders to get the works in shape.² However, laborers had scarcely started making repairs before Roberts was instructed to scale back his operations.

Water was let into parts of the Mahoning Canal near the end of April, 1839 right after work resumed on French Creek, and Governor Porter and his aides felt compelled to respond. Merchants from Cleveland to Pittsburgh cheerfully predicted the remaining stretches of the Mahoning Canal would open in just four to six weeks.³ Porter and his aides felt compelled to respond and shifted

¹ JHR 1838, volume III: 100.

² "Report of W. Milnor Roberts," JS 1840, volume III: 237. The French Creek Division combined the French Creek Feeder Canal with the Franklin Line for administrative and funding purposes. State authorities had often seen the two as a single unit in the past and they shifted resources between them accordingly.

³ Pittsburgh Daily Gazette, April 26, 1839: p2c2.

all of their resources and energies into finishing the Erie Extension Canal and creating a real alternative inside Pennsylvania. The Franklin Line was sacrificed toward this end.

State leaders added up every penny they saved from making this decision, but there was still not enough money to finish the Erie Extension Canal; further cuts were needed, and so the Allegheny Feeder Canal and the western extension of the Main Line Canal that Ritner had proposed were also stricken from the budget. After giving up on the Franklin Line, Porter and the canal commissioners were afraid that work on these lines would be viewed as a favor to stockholders of the Mahoning Canal Company in Philadelphia and Pittsburgh.⁴ Pennsylvania was heading into a deep financial crisis and the administration needed to maintain the support of loyal voters.

Porter had already dispatched his aides to sound out bankers in Philadelphia about making a major loan after taking office, but

⁴ "Allegheny Feeder-report of W. Morris, Engineer," JS 1840, volume III: 168-169; "Report of A. Morris, Superintendent," JS 1840, vol. III: 169-172. The Allegheny Feeder (or Kittaning Feeder) was projected as a fully navigable canal roughly 14 miles in length from an upper termination "somewhere near Kittaning" and joining the Pennsylvania Main Line near Freeport. Work on the different sections was placed under contract in August, 1838. Little was done beyond clearing and grubbing when state leaders failed to provide additional funding in February, 1839. Only one section length of the Allegheny Feeder Canal (no. 29) was ever completed out of 44 segments.

weeks of negotiations did not produce an agreement. Porter reported this failure to the legislature and helped negotiate a small loan for their immediate use. This money allowed state offices to function during talks for additional sums, but it fell far short of the amounts needed to sustain the public works. Porter therefore reduced his ambitions and arranged a loan for two million dollars in June, 1839 by making concessions to the banking industry.⁵ Contractors and their hands were ordered to resume construction on the Erie Extension Canal, but the orders halting work on the Allegheny River and French Creek were not rescinded.

An entire building season had been lost while state authorities arranged a loan, and some contractors complained they had been ruined waiting for work. State authorities invited them to visit Erie and submit bids for new work on the Erie Extension by October 21, 1839.⁶ However, most had not even submitted their final bid for new work when the market collapsed again.

State leaders borrowed enough money to cover their operating expenses and prior debts, but they failed to make any changes in how they collected taxes or patterns of public spending. Jittery bankers in Philadelphia started to worry that nothing would ever

⁵ Snyder, Jacksonian Heritage, 137.

⁶ Erie Gazette, September 19, 1839: p2c5.

change and they suspended specie payments for the second time on October 9, 1839.

Porter urged the citizens of Pennsylvania to treat this crisis with "forbearance and moderation" while he expressed confidence the banks would "meet all their obligations."⁷ Public officials were instructed to press ahead with their duties, including work on the different lines of canals and railroads. Contractors hesitantly resumed work on the Erie Extension Canal after state officers promised to make good on any debts; however, several dozen contracts for sections, locks and other structures were abandoned because the contractors faced bankruptcy waiting for payment. Those who kept on explained that they had no choice since quitting meant they would lose all rights for what they had already finished.

Construction on the Erie Extension Canal was concentrated on the Shenango Division between New Castle and Greenville during this latest crisis. Chief Engineer Roberts explained to his superiors that finishing this part of the line would extend the productive use of the Beaver Division and open up the riches of the Shenango Valley where "thousands of acres of farm land remain to this day uncultivated, and would so have stood for many years longer, but

⁷ Snyder, Jacksonian Heritage, 138.

for this or some similar improvement."⁸ Roberts added that this plan offered the best hope of reaping any benefits from the canal since the work above Greenville represented some of the most difficult jobs on the whole line.

The remaining parts of the Shenango Division included 14.5 miles from the mouth of Crooked Creek to the end of the feeder canal at Conneaut Lake and included difficult stretches through the Pymatuning Swamp and over the Beaver Dam Summit. From this point, the Conneaut Division continued northward and east for 45.4 miles to the harbor at Erie. This carried the canal over the summit separating the Ohio River drainage from the Great Lakes system and required no less than 18 additional locks on the Shenango Division and 71 locks on the Conneaut Division, along with all of the necessary weirs, bridges and lock houses; plans for the Conneaut Division also called for several culverts and two aqueducts to span chasms near the lake shore.

Building specifications for many of these structures were revised to allow the use of cheap materials. Locks on the Conneaut Division (except the outlet locks at Erie) were built with wood in place of stone, and a combined plan mixing stone with wood was used

⁸ "Report of W. Milnor Roberts," Annual Report of the Canal Commissioners, 1840: 195-196.

on the upper end of the Shenango Division. Using inferior materials tacitly acknowledged the limits of public funding and a desperate need to show progress.⁹

Contractors and their hands helped ease the state through this predicament by working during the winter months to make up for wages they had lost during the budget crisis.¹⁰ Water was finally let into the canal between New Castle and Greenville on April 23, 1840. A large crowd of citizens turned out to celebrate the event, although this was just a test to see if the work would hold up; boats were not permitted to use the line pending further notice.¹¹ Any excitement generated by this event quickly soured when the people living north of Greenville realized the canal was not going to be carried through any time soon.

⁹ Building locks out of wood was a common response to inadequate funding. Wooden locks were installed on the Potomac Canal and the Mohawk Canal in the late eighteenth century, and several canals in the United States and Canada in the following years. Wooden locks were always viewed by canal builders as a temporary measure and replaced with stone whenever possible. Certain parts of the Erie Canal in New York were temporarily fitted with wooden locks to get that waterway open and producing revenues. See Richard J. Dent "On the Archaeology of Early Canals," Historical Archaeology, XX (1986) and Historical Research Limited, Archaeological Excavation of Lock 24, First Welland Canal (London, Ontario: 1988) for the evolution of wooden locks in North America.

¹⁰ Report of the Select Committee, 135.

¹¹ Crawford Democrat, July 28, 1840: p3c3.

Reports from Meadville held that the work was seventy percent finished between Greenville and Conneaut Lake, but unlikely to move along because the state was refusing further assistance. Merchants and farmers who provided goods and provisions to contractors were getting promises and receipts instead of cash; canal workers were not getting paid either, and many were reduced to trading their labor for meals.¹² One contractor claimed he only kept his men on the payroll "to save them from suffering, and keep their families from suffering, and felt morally bound to keep them whether they earned their money or not." None worked more than seventeen days in a month, and all survived on a spartan diet of bread and potatoes. Hired men on some neighboring sections were simply turned loose when the state failed to make scheduled payment.¹³ Local newspapers reported that everyone connected with the canal in any way was reduced to a state of despair. One editor at Meadville reflected that the "the shade of Stephen Girard must be sometimes seen among the Conneaut marshes, crying aloud" for all of his legacy wasted on the canals.¹⁴

¹² Crawford Democrat, May 5, 1840: p2c1-2. Some contractors paid their workers in scrip that could be used as promissory notes; see Sargent, Pioneer Sketches, 284.

¹³ Report of the Select Committee, 136.

¹⁴ Crawford Democrat, May 5, 1840: p2c1-2.

Some of the criticism was muted when state authorities finally permitted boats to enter the canal at Greenville in July, 1840. Several packets were enlisted to ferry citizens along the line, and officials announced that the remaining work up to Conneaut Lake was in a "forward state" and would open soon.¹⁵ Months then passed without any noticeable progress, and there was talk that the state might finally give up before releasing any additional money for new work. Contractors were finally notified on October 31, 1840 that funding for the year was exhausted, and any additional work after this date "would not be considered as incurring a debt against the commonwealth."¹⁶

A fair number of contractors had seen this coming and already scaled back their efforts. Hired hands faced the bleak choices of finding work away from the canal or stocking up on provisions and supplies to see them through the winter. Felix Reville Brunot gave up his position as an assistant engineer on the Erie Extension Canal, and sought other vocations in the belief that little would change.¹⁷ A great deal of hard work remained unfinished between the

¹⁵ Erie Gazette, July 23, 1840: p3c2.

¹⁶ "Report of John Mitchell, Superintendent of the Conneaut Line, Erie Extension," JHR 1841, volume III: 317.

¹⁷ Slattey, Felix Reville Brunot, 27. Brunot was a cousin to W. Milnor Roberts and used this connection with the chief

Shenango Division and the French Creek Feeder Canal, while the Conneaut Division was barely "one-half finished."¹⁸ The canal commissioners started to doubt the canal would ever be finished and suggested that a railroad "could be carried by the canal route surveyed in 1826, by the engineers employed in the state service, from the mouth of the Kiskiminetas to Waterford, by the Allegheny river and French creek."¹⁹

Folks living along the path of the Erie Extension traded rumors that the canal would be abandoned for several weeks and then called public meetings to consider their response. A meeting at the Baptist church in Conneautville during February, 1841 sparked calls to reorganize local government. Speakers proposed that the western ends of Crawford County and Erie County might be served better by joining their common interests, and petitions were drawn up on behalf of a new county named for the canal.²⁰ Public confidence in

engineer to find employment. Brunot stayed on the line a year and a half before giving up in despair.

¹⁸ "Report of W. Milnor Roberts, Engineer of the Beaver Division," JHR 1841, volume III: 208.

¹⁹ "Second Report of Charles L. Schaltter, Principal Engineer in the service of the State of Pennsylvania, to the Canal Commissioners, relative to the continuous Railroad from Harrisburg to Pittsburg," JHR 1841, volume III: 296.

²⁰ Erie Gazette, February 25, 1841: p3c4. State authorities subsequently declined to pursue the matter and Canal County did not enter the public record.

their elected officials was further shaken by charges of corruption in the public works program.

State law required the canal commissioners or their agents to accept the lowest reasonable bid for any work that was paid with public funds. Contracts were at first released by divisional supervisors, but this function was increasingly taken over by bureaucrats sitting hundreds of miles away in the state capital. Contracts were consequently given out as political favors with little regard for the actual building requirements or local market conditions.

Contractors who had submitted bids for work on the Erie Extension by the deadline on October 21, 1839 were shocked when all of the bids were bundled up and sent to Harrisburg for further review. One group of contractors waited over a month for word on their bids, and then visited Harrisburg in search of answers. After hearing their complaints, the canal commissioners asserted that it was their right to "revise, condemn or approve" the decisions made by supervisors and engineers in the different field stations.²¹ Opponents of the administration responded with serious charges of bribery and influence peddling in awarding contracts.

Mounting protests and complaints against the canal commissioners

²¹ Erie Gazette, November 14, 1839: p2c6.

finally forced the administration to investigate numerous charges of malfeasance. An investigative panel was empowered to gather evidence "of the manner in which the present Board of Canal Commissioners, and some of their officers had let out the public work in 1840, and of certain allotments of the previous board in the latter part of 1839."²² Testimony elicited at public hearings from dozens of witnesses painted a picture of corruption at high levels in the state government.

Contracts had been disbursed to party favorites without any pretense of real ability. One contractor on the Conneaut Division "was not on his work much of the time, but about the taverns of Girard," and was not widely considered by other contractors as "a man in any way qualified to manage a canal contract."²³ Several job seekers complained how the firm of Lauman and Bailey was given a choice contract for the outlet locks at Erie, without ever holding "a job in that section of the country."²⁴ Others received work for laughably low bids with an understanding the state would provide a supplemental appropriation to cover all extra costs. Dozens of these contracts were later abandoned when the state refused to make

²² Report of the Select Committee, 3.

²³ Report of the Select Committee, 131.

²⁴ Report of the Select Committee, 37.

an adjustment.

Some contractors took work on locks and other structures along the line without any knowledge of local building materials or conditions. Jacob Drum was forced to haul stone about a mile and a half to lock no. 5 on the Shenango Division, and five mile to the next lock.²⁵ William M. King was fortunate to have only a mile and a half to two miles distance between his supplier and lock nos. 20 and 21 on the Conneaut Division near Conneautville.²⁶

One string of sixteen locks dropping down through Hall's Run on the Conneaut Division averaged four miles from the closest quarries.²⁷ Several contractors with multiple jobs opened tram railways to distant quarries, but found the costs of opening a railroad destroyed any hopes of showing a profit.²⁸ Laumann and Bailey planned to ship stone across the lake from Sandusky, and haul it from a landing near Erie.²⁹ When these costs could not be recovered in any other way, contractors substituted inferior

²⁵ Report of the Select Committee, 137.

²⁶ Report of the Select Committee, 132.

²⁷ *Ibid*, 73.

²⁸ "Report of W. Milnor Roberts, Engineer on the Erie Extension," JHR 1841, volume III: 206-207.

²⁹ *Ibid*, 154.

materials and began cutting wages. Workers who had suffered several winters in shacks along the unfinished ditches had seen enough, and quit. Some of the work on the Erie Extension Canal and its allied lines had gone through three or four contracts and still begged completion by the time the investigative committee wrapped up its proceedings.³⁰

Contractors were businessmen instead of engineers, and they could seldom appreciate the fuss made over minor deviations in contract specifications. While serving as an assistant engineer on the Conneaut Division, Felix Brunot had discovered one crew covering a huge tree stump they had rolled into the towpath rather than hauling dirt. Contractors were strictly warned against covering stumps and other debris in the canal, but there was not much chance of catching cheaters. Brunot spied his unlucky crew through a telescope during a casual inspection of the line.³¹ Low wages and infrequent payments aggravated even the most honest contractors.

After several weeks of hearing testimony, the members of the investigative committee drew up a report that was read in the state

³⁰ "Report of Charles T. Whippo, Erie Extension," JHR 1838, appendix: 39.

³¹ Jordan, The National Road, 84-85; Slattery, Felix Reville Brunot, 26-27.

House of Representatives on April 16, 1841. Friends of the administration dismissed all of the charges against the canal commissioners and pointedly decreed that "the office of Canal Commissioner is arduous; [and] the duties are as various as the responsibilities are important." Most of the testimony was belittled as the work of disgruntled job seekers "whose wishes cannot be gratified," and the investigation was characterized as political grandstanding that was wasteful to state coffers.³²

These attempts to shift blame hardly dulled awareness that the administration was facing a financial catastrophe over the public works. One estimate held that "the Commonwealth has sustained a loss on the several portions of the public works [examined by the investigative committee], of 169,200 dollars."³³ Inhabitants of the northwestern counties were fortunate that the investigative committee had only looked at the upper end of the Erie Extension, or the entire program might have been suspended immediately.

State authorities had celebrated when the Shenango Division reached Greenville, but the poor condition of the canal on either end threatened to isolate the work. Locks, dams and parts of the towpath were crumbling on the Beaver Division, while the battered

³² Report of the Select Committee, 77.

³³ *Ibid*, 75.

remnants of the feeder canal and the Franklin Line persistently hindered navigation on French Creek.

Calls for retrenchment

Pennsylvania state authorities were especially concerned with the failing circumstances of the Beaver Division. One official connected with this segment of the public works admitted that it had been "a source of continual expenditure, without corresponding returns" for some years, and "a yearly drain upon the purse of the Commonwealth."³⁴ Opening the Mahoning Canal had increased revenues somewhat, but this was not sufficient to balance the costs of constant repairs. Much of the wood sheeting on the locks and dams needed replaced again, gravel had clogged several navigation channels, and at least two locks were near collapse. Inadequate appropriations over several years had prompted shoddy repairs and put any new work or major rebuilding efforts on hold. Nearly a third of the funding earmarked for labor and materials in 1840 was used to settle debts with contractors for work that had been done three years earlier.³⁵

³⁴ "Report of W. Milnor Roberts, Engineer of the Beaver Division," JHR 1841, volume III: 184.

³⁵ "Report of W. Milnor Roberts, Engineer of the Beaver Division," JHR 1841, volume III: 187; "Beaver Division. Annual

The canal commissioners had barely started discussions how to tackle this problem in 1841 when "greater than ordinary" floods came crashing down the valley with disastrous results. Almost all of the lower half of Dam no. 2 was torn away, along with three towpath bridges and one of the abutments from another bridge. Long stretches of the towpath were heavily damaged and massive sand bars formed below Dam no. 2 at the at the mouth of Connequenessing Creek.³⁶ The engineers who had designed the Beaver Division had improperly placed this particular dam so that flood waters crossed at an oblique angle, battering the wood sheeting of the dam and throwing gravel against the towpath with destructive force. As a result, "Owing to the shape of the stream and the peculiar location of the lock, dam and channel at this point, it has been exceedingly difficult and expensive to keep the latter free from bars."³⁷

Poor planning was even more conspicuous in the condition of the French Creek works. State records revealed that over \$300,000 had been spent on the French Creek Feeder Canal with no end in sight, and the line was still not finished. Milnor Roberts reported that

Report of W. Milnor Roberts, Engineer," JS 1842, volume III: 145-146.

³⁶ "Annual Report of W. Milnor Roberts, Engineer," JS 1842, volume III: 143.

³⁷ Ibid, 145.

"owing to the breaking of the dam at Bemus' Mills in 1837, it was rendered useless."³⁸ Funding was continually turned over to saving what was left of the old work instead of extending the canal toward useful outlets.³⁹

Only a small force of workers had been employed on the line in 1840 and most of their days were spent clearing bars from the bottom of the canal.⁴⁰ Long stretches of the line were commonly clogged with silt owing to a serpentine course that ran through gullies and hugged the lower slopes of the neighboring heights. One observer suggested there was not a sufficient channel to send a "full volume" of water through the French Creek Feeder Canal in 1839 without a "great and injurious charge."⁴¹ Besides clearing a new channel, parts of the feeder near Meadville had to be straightened in order to permit navigation by canal boats drawn off the Main Line.⁴²

³⁸ "Report of W. Milnor Roberts, Principal Engineer of the French Creek Division," JHR 1841, volume III: 190.

³⁹ Crawford Democrat, May 5, 1840: p2c1-2.

⁴⁰ "Report of W. Milnor Roberts, Principal Engineer of the French Creek Division," JHR 1841, volume III: 189.

⁴¹ *Ibid*, 99.

⁴² "Report of W. Milnor Roberts, Principal Engineer, French Creek Division," JS 1840, volume III: 236; "French Creek Division; Report of W. Milnor Roberts, Engineer," JS 1842, volume III: 151.

Plans for the opposite end of the feeder canal had initially called for raising Conneaut Lake eight feet above its natural level for use as a reservoir. New calculations showed that the lake would have to be raised an additional three feet to carry the Erie Extension Canal across the highlands of northwestern Pennsylvania. This meant the existing towpath had to be raised around the southern end of Conneaut Lake and gradually dropped down to the aqueduct over French Creek some twelve miles away.⁴³ Getting water across the aqueduct raised another set of problems.

Even if the ditch was fixed, state engineers could not provide a sufficient flow of water; all seven waste weirs on the feeder canal and the locks at either end of the line had been built of wood and needed replacement, and both of the aqueducts over French Creek and Watsons run required major renovations and modifications.⁴⁴ There was also the matter of the feeder dam above Meadville, which was marked by broken timbers and piles of rubble

⁴³ "Report of Charles T. Whippo, Erie Extension," JHR 1838, appendix, 99-100; "Report of W. Milnor Roberts, Principal Engineer, French Creek Division," JS 1840, volume III: 238, 240-241; "French Creek Division. Report of W. Milnor Roberts, Engineer," JS 1842, volume III: 150-151.

⁴⁴ "Report of W. Milnor Roberts, Principal Engineer, French Creek Division," JS 1840, volume III: 190-191, 239; "Report of W. Milnor Roberts, Principal Engineer of the French Creek Division," JHR 1841, volume III: 190.

since floods tore through in 1837. The entire French Creek Feeder Canal was useless unless a new and permanent structure was built. Most of the canal had not been watered since the dam broke and other sections were fouled by stagnant puddles.

Engineers working on the French Creek Division had determined that the dam was improperly placed in the stream, and it was suffering the same effects as those dams that were improperly placed on the Beaver Division. Floodwaters crashing down French Creek had broken through the dam in several places and then torn away about three hundred yards of protective embankment on the east side. A portion of the remaining dam was taken down after the flood to restore the normal stream pattern.⁴⁵

Charles Whippo had favored a new site just over a mile upstream at McGuffins Falls when he served as the chief engineer on the line, but the canal commissioners balked at the added costs for moving the dam. Whippo mocked their decision by noting "The only thing to be gained by this [new] location is safety to the dam, and the works connected with it."⁴⁶ Nearly three years passed while state authorities argued whether the dam should be moved or rebuilt

⁴⁵ "Report of W. Milnor Roberts, Principal Engineer, French Creek Division," JS 1840, volume III: 238-239.

⁴⁶ "Report of Charles T. Whippo, Erie Extension," JHR 1838, volume III: 113.

in place.

A contract to rebuild the dam in place was finally awarded to the firm of Cullum and Barlow near the end of 1840. Hired hands had just started when their efforts revealed "so much shattered" to make rebuilding a waste of time and money. Standing parts of the dam were taken down to the low water mark and the entire structure was almost completely rebuilt.⁴⁷

Passing down French Creek below the aqueduct gave further evidence of ruin and wasted opportunities. Plans to restore all of the locks and dams on the Franklin Line after the floods in 1835 had steadily dwindled until a "system of patching" was in place six years later. Tolls on the Franklin Line had dropped to just \$500.00 in 1840 and hardly justified any new expenditures. Surveys of the surviving portions of this canal counted just 19 locks, 9 dams, 13 towing path bridges and 3 road bridges. The remains of Dam No. 4 had not been rebuilt after the spring flood in 1835 and were almost entirely swept away, and another had been dismantled; the first dam up at Little Sugar Creek was taken down for

⁴⁷ "Annual Report of the Canal Commissioners," JHR 1840, volume II: 33; "Report of W. Milnor Roberts, Principal Engineer, French Creek Division," JHR 1840, volume II: 172; "French Creek Division. Report of W. Milnor Roberts, Engineer," JS 1842, volume III: 150.

rebuilding in 1839, but nothing was ever done.⁴⁸ Most locks connected with the dams were in fairly decent shape "with the exception of natural decay incident to such works," but they were of little practical use and the lower end of French Creek was broken into a series of isolated pools. The costs for restoring the old works or opening new chutes around them were placed in excess of \$54,000.⁴⁹

Navigation had nearly ceased on French Creek outside of the seasonal rises when flatboats came down in large numbers. One eyewitness noted that these vessels "laden with the produce of the upper country" tried to "avoid passing through the locks whenever it is possible to float around the dams in safety."⁵⁰ State officers protested that the works were secure, but agreed that "The Franklin Line has been so long overlooked or neglected in the annual legislative appropriations, as to have become almost a bye-

⁴⁸ "Report of W. Milnor Roberts, Principal Engineer of the French Creek Division," JHR 1841, volume. III: 192; "French Creek Division. Report of W. Milnor Roberts, Engineer," JS 1842, volume III: 153.

⁴⁹ "French Creek Division. Report of W. Milnor Roberts, Engineer," JS 1842, volume III: 153.

⁵⁰ "French Creek Division. Report of W. Milnor Roberts, Engineer," JS 1842, volume III: 153-154.

word and a reproach."⁵¹

After considering reports on the different lines, the canal commissioners were not eager to sink additional funds into the the northwestern counties. Roberts suggested carrying the Shenango Line through the French Creek Feeder Canal to Meadville, and "leaving but thirty-seven miles of land carriage over the best parts of the Pittsburg and Erie turnpike."⁵² Contracts were eventually released on each segment of the canals in Northwest Pennsylvania.

Canal enthusiasts have maintained that work on the Erie Extension Canal reached record levels in 1840 and 1841 from looking at the number of contracts. Public records indicate that state authorities were actually uncertain how to proceed, and simply scattered funds from the Ohio River to Lake Erie in order to mute public criticism. Work on the different lines was continued with a simple faith that something might be gained from all of the previous expenditures. Much of the activity was given over to saving those works already finished from ruin, and contractors were engaged with little hope of paying them. Roberts exceded his

⁵¹ "French Creek Division. Report of W. Milnor Roberts, Engineer," JS 1842, volume III: 156.

⁵² "Beaver division. Annual Report of W. Milnor Roberts, Engineer," JS 1842, volume III: 148.

authority as chief engineer and reported that the supervisor on the Erie Extension had just \$178,434.12 against debts of \$511,397.88 to begin the work year.

Gangs of laborers on the Conneaut Line were put to work hauling materials and preparing the ground in March and April, 1841 so that a favorable estimate of payment could be arranged for the year. When the engineers viewed the work around the first of May, 1841 these efforts had already surpassed the appropriation for that particular line. Further activity on the great aqueducts over Walnut Creek and Elk Creek was immediately halted, along with many of the smaller jobs.⁵³

State law required that each segment of the public canals should maintain separate ledgers, and did not permit transferring funds from one to another. Divisional officers scrambled to find funds, with the result that excess materials and even whole structures were discarded for cash. Work on the feeder canal was continued during the year by eliminating a string of costly bridges.

These structures were already a special concern for state officers, since a majority were falling apart and presented immediate threats to public safety. Wooden abutments had been

⁵³ "Erie Extension. Annual Report of W. Milnor Roberts, Engineer," JS 1842, volume III: 168-169.

installed in place of stone supports to get the work on the line started, but not one had been replaced on schedule. Most of the wooden abutments were now rotted and near collapse.

After reviewing the mounting financial crisis, chief engineer Roberts recommended a modest plan to maintain a crossing for the Mercer Turnpike and just a few other bridges near Meadville. Several dozen farm bridges could be abandoned after arranging settlements with the property owners for "trifling sums," and Roberts urged this approach to release money for more pressing needs. Higher state authorities embraced this suggestion, and no special appropriation was set aside for the French Creek Feeder in 1841. Only a small force of workers was employed on the line during the summer as a result, and their duties were restricted to clearing bars out of the bottom of the canal and protecting other work already done.⁵⁴ Remnants of the Franklin Line were quietly left to their fate, and the canal commissioners decided to roll back their commitments to the other northwestern lines in spite of the potential risks.

In June, 1841 Roberts was directed to reduce his engineering staff while maintaining operational control over the Erie Extension and its related lines. Robert S. Rodgers was released from his

⁵⁴ Ibid, 189.

position as the principal assistant on the Beaver Division, despite his "gentlemanly deportment and uniform excellence as an efficient officer." Andrew Porter was serving in the same capacity on the Erie Extension Canal and was directed to lend his assistance "when he could be spared from more pressing engagements on the main line."⁵⁵

One last hope that the Beaver Division and the operating parts of the Shenango Division might rescue state finances had been dashed by bad luck. An unusually dry end to the winter had dropped water levels on both lines and forced navigation to cease, with a corresponding reduction in collections. The Beaver River was reportedly "lower than at any preceding time within the recollection of the oldest inhabitants" during the summer, with the result that "the full depth of four feet could not be maintained" in the canal.⁵⁶

Workmen were diverted to the Beaver Division in a desperate bid to shore up the works and plug myriad leaks. By the end of the working season, the Shenango Division had progressed just another three miles northward toward Conneaut Lake. Much of the additional

⁵⁵ "Beaver division. Annual Report of W. Milnor Roberts, Engineer," JS 1842, volume III: 143.

⁵⁶ "Annual Report of W. Milnor Roberts, Engineer," JS 1842, volume III: 144.

work was on the most difficult sections, and voters in that area seethed over the apparent lack of progress. When John Dick of Meadville announced intentions to run for the state senate, members of the Crawford County Democratic Committee questioned him extensively about his views on canal building. Dick was given their sanction when he promised to work for the completion of the Erie Extension.⁵⁷

Taxpayers who did not live near the path of the canal showed much less enthusiasm than in years gone by. Calls for citizens to rally at Meadville in support of the canal with the new year garnered an indifferent response. Promoters carried the assembly over to February 17, 1842, in hope of a better turnout, and the editor of one local newspaper warned his readers to respond in a spirited manner or suffer the consequences of their apathy.⁵⁸

A few heeded the warning, but without the fire that had carried earlier meetings. Those attending proceedings at the court house tamely followed a well worn script. After appointing officers, the assembly recited a familiar litany of complaints, and forwarded petitions bearing their tired old message to the state legislature. Higher authorities were warned the northwestern counties would not

⁵⁷ Crawford Democrat, September 28, 1841: p2c4.

⁵⁸ Crawford Democrat, February 15, 1842: p3c1.

broker any attempts to abandon the canal, and that contractors and local men were suffering and near ruin from a failed financial policy.⁵⁹

Elected officials in Harrisburg hardly took notice of these kinds of documents anymore, and threats of retaliation from the northwestern counties did not carry much weight these days. The canal commissioners were under orders to reduce expenses, and they had already instituted cuts when the packet from Meadville arrived. Every division of the public works suffered a reduction in personnel, and the engineers were hit especially hard. Press accounts held that the Erie Extension Canal was going to be pushed toward Lake Erie in hopes of redeeming past expenses, but without guidance from the chief engineer on the line.⁶⁰

The canal commissioners declared that Roberts was released to save his salary, but fiscal responsibility was not their only concern. Roberts had increasingly adopted the Erie Extension Canal as a personal venture. He badgered the canal commissioners with letters and petitions every time they made a decision about the canal that he did not like, and these complaints frequently appeared in the local press. Word of his dismissal raised fears

⁵⁹ Crawford Democrat, March 8, 1842: p2c1-2.

⁶⁰ Crawford Democrat, March 1, 1842: p2c3.

that the board was secretly trying to scrap the project, and inevitably led to another public meeting at Meadville.⁶¹

However, calls to reinstate Roberts as chief engineer were tempered by threats that the canal commissioners might just as well quit the project and leave the contractors and workers to ruin. A new round of petitions meekly asked for an additional appropriation to pay off current debts and finish the line in an orderly fashion.⁶² State authorities barely noticed this latest appeal, and local citizens were left fearing the worst. The financial crisis haunting state finances appeared more serious in January, 1842 than at any point since the panic started five years earlier. A rally that was held in Philadelphia to shore up support for Porter on December 30, 1841, provided his opponents with a forum to attack his administration. Dissidents at that forum declared that the state debt was unconstitutional, and no citizen was obliged "to bear any burden of taxation or make any sacrifice of personal comfort to keep it unbroken." One proposal urged legislators to sell the public works and put the proceeds toward the debt.⁶³

Loyal newspaper editors protested this action across the state,

⁶¹ Crawford Democrat, March 1, 1843: p2c3.

⁶² Crawford Democrat, March 8, 1842: p2c1-2.

⁶³ Snyder, Jacksonian Heritage, 161.

and Porter affirmed his commitment to the public works several days later in his annual message. Friends of the public works were calmed, although there was always a threat of further action if the most powerful city in the state turned away. Fearful investors heightened the crisis by starting a run on the banks around Philadelphia during the last week of January, 1842.

Legislators across party lines agreed that something had to be done to restore faith, and decided to curtail spending. One of the measures that passed specifically halted all work on the French Creek Feeder, and spelled out absurd terms for outstanding debt payments on the public works. Contractors were required to take payment in depreciated Pennsylvania bonds worth half their face value, or get nothing. Representatives from the northwestern counties argued against the measure and were shocked at their defeat "by a larger vote than we ever imagined could be raised against our public works."⁶⁴

Funding for the feeder canal was eventually restored, once it was made clear that the Erie Extension was useless without an outside source of water. W. Milnor Roberts was brought back on the public rolls owing to his familiarity with the works. Getting the French Creek Feeder underway was of paramount importance to

⁶⁴ Crawford Democrat, April 5, 1842: p3c1.

demonstrate progress before legislators changed their minds. Roberts had already proposed a plan to extend navigation to Meadville before he was dismissed from the public service, and resumed the work with a marked determination.

One source of delay on the northern end of the line was constant leaking on the Beaver Division. Roberts was forced to address this matter on several occasions, and blamed some of the leaks on "gross neglect" by the divisional officers. There was talk of creating a new county from those parts of Beaver County and Mercer County around New Castle, and this matter increasingly interfered with operations on the canal. Roberts fumed that the supervisor and most of his staff on the Beaver Division were too busy with politics and "the dismemberment of the county" to attend to the duties for which they were being paid.⁶⁵

Inhabitants of the far northwestern communities had nearly given up their hopes for the canal, when they were electrified by the news that water had been let into the feeder again after seven years of waiting. One boat was launched down the canal on the initial rush of water by W.A.V. Magaw, with help from James Worall and Andrew Porter of the divisional engineering staff. The boat reportedly reached Conneaut Lake so fast that it must have been

⁶⁵ Western Argus, February 9, 1842: p2c5.

dragged through the head of the surging waters.⁶⁶

By the middle of May, 1842 the Shenango Line was completely opened and a couple of boats had come up from Beaver drifted into Conneaut Lake. Plans for pressing ahead to Meadville were interrupted by a break in the embankments of the feeder. Repair crews were hurriedly dispatched to the break from the divisional offices Meadville, while the boats rested along the southern shore of Conneaut Lake at Evansburg.⁶⁷

After waiting more than fifteen years for canal traffic, inhabitants of Meadville were stunned to hear a boatman's horn. Citizens flocked to the edge of the canal as the "Hudson" and "Pilot" came into view heading into the downtown basin. Reports of progress on the repair work had not been forwarded ahead of the boats, and no celebration was planned. Community leaders dashed around town during the rest of the day, making arrangements for a proper reception.

According to the customary format, the following day saw crowds of citizens gathering around the basin, where the canal boats took on passengers. Both of the boats were loaded to the bursting point, while hundreds of spectators who were unable to secure a

⁶⁶ Erie Gazette, August 25, 1842: p3c3.

⁶⁷ Crawford Democrat, May 23, 1843: p3c1.

seat on the vessels lined the banks. Members of the Meadville city band had crowded aboard one of the vessels and provided a musical background for the festivities. Once crewmen settled everyone in place and pushed the boats away from the banks of the basin, the drovers started their mules northward toward the dam at the head of the feeder. An artillery piece mounted on the Chestnut Street bridge and manned by the local militia thundered an announcement that the proceedings had begun.

After reaching the pool behind the dam, the boats turned and came back to town where one of the local news editors swore he "never saw a party better enjoy themselves."⁶⁸ The events concluded with the feasting and speeches, accompanied with the obligatory toasts to success.

Several arrivals over the next few weeks appeared to validate the expenses and all of the dreams placed on the canal in local minds. Boatmen and merchants talked of starting regular service between Beaver and Meadville, with the trip taking 43 hours. Wagons might grind along local roads at the same speed, but at profoundly higher costs. One estimate held that canals might drop freight shipping charges by two thirds of the going rate for

⁶⁸ Crawford Democrat, May 30, 1843: p3c2.

wagons.⁶⁹ Two boats pulled into the basin at Meadville near the end of June, packed with iron, nails, and glass from Pittsburgh.⁷⁰ Boats passing along the feeder stirred enthusiasm and civic pride for a few weeks leading into the summer season. Newspaper editors at Meadville conscientiously recorded every new arrival, and the novelty of canal travel repeatedly drew crowds of spectators to the towpath. Every blast of a boatman's horn coming into Meadville threw the school house at Shaw's Landing into a riot, with the children crowding the windows and spilling outside for a better look.

Officials connected with the different lines in Northwestern Pennsylvania had hoped that this kind of reaction would generate support for finishing the canals. They were shocked that communities along unfinished parts of the Erie Extension complained of favoritism toward Meadville, instead of seeing benefits for the entire area. Opponents of the administration in Harrisburg and across the state appropriated this discontent for their own uses, and wondered aloud if the local benefits from the canal justified additional expenditures of common funds.

Getting the French Creek Feeder in order had already exhausted

⁶⁹ Crawford Democrat, May 30, 1843: p3c4.

⁷⁰ Erie Gazette, July 6, 1842: p3c2.

the miserly appropriation set aside for Northwestern Pennsylvania in 1842. Contractors laboring on the Erie Extension were haunted by another fiscal crisis cutting back on their efforts as a result, barely a month after opening navigation to Meadville. Construction had nearly ground to a halt by June 23, 1842, when W. Milnor Roberts penned an ardent plea to the canal commissioners begging for supplementary funds.

Bridging Elk Creek and Walnut Creek with aqueducts loomed as the last major expense. The outlet locks at Erie were nearly done, and more than three quarters of the lesser locks on the line were reportedly finished and ready for use. Roberts added that only a handful of isolated spots along the Erie Extension had not progressed at a favorable rate, adding up to about three miles in total length. With another \$250,000 in hand, the contractors could presumably push navigation from the canal into Lake Erie.⁷¹

Added expenses for lockhouses, weirs, and some other minor works were not included in this calculation.⁷² By trimming his estimates in this manner, Roberts hoped to show progress and make the costs more palatable to taxpayers across the commonwealth.

⁷¹ Erie Gazette, July 14, 1842: p3c3; Western Argus, May 31, 1843: p2c5.

⁷² Erie Gazette, July 14, 1842: p3c3.

State offices in Harrisburg were deluged with complaints that the canals had failed to provide reasonable returns, while the costs of competing with neighboring works were growing by leaps and bounds.

New York and Ohio had operated their canals for decades, and had funded major improvements with toll receipts. The British government in Canada had recently purchased the rights to the Welland Canal and planned to overhaul that work to admit vessels bearing up to 500 tons of cargo. Estimates of the total cost came in at around two million dollars and spokesmen for the provincial government claimed they would willingly spend three times that amount.⁷³

Improvement Men in the Pennsylvania legislature repeated these estimates and timidly explained that the Erie Extension Canal only required a fraction of this amount.⁷⁴ However, their opponents were not swayed and correctly demonstrated that this would only bring the canal up to the prevailing standards of prior decades. Almost everyone outside of the northwestern counties agreed that Pennsylvania could never raise the kind of money that was needed to make the state works competitive. Wild spending on public improvements had already forced Michigan and Indiana into

⁷³ Erie Gazette, July 14, 1842: p3c3.

⁷⁴ Erie Gazette, July 14, 1842: p3c3.

bankruptcy, and Pennsylvania was trailing close behind. All payments for damage claims along any of the Pennsylvania canals were suspended in a desperate bid to stave off disaster while state authorities considered their options.⁷⁵ Reviewing the records from the Erie Extension gave the inhabitants of Northwest Pennsylvania little cause for hope.

Whether by accident or design, W. Milnor Roberts had grossly understated the condition of the line. Almost forty thousand dollars was needed on the Shenango Division, although that work had been reported as finished. More than one million dollars was required to settle outstanding debts and pursue completion of the Conneaut Division. Costs for the "work to be done" were placed at \$536,142.46, doubling prior estimates.⁷⁶ Roberts was nonplussed by the controversy, and urged completion at any cost. Complaints against the line were dismissed out of hand as the product "an illiberal and selfish opposition, excited by prejudices founded

⁷⁵ JHR 1845, volume II: 266.

⁷⁶ Corkan, The Beaver and Lake Erie Canal, 59-60. The first five sections of the Conneaut Division, for instance, were found to pass through beds of quicksand. A wooden trough more than two miles long was laid to keep water from seeping out, but hoilding the frame in place required driving supports up to 24 feet deep. This was slow and expensive, using a large frame pile driver. See Huidekoper, "Incidents in the Early history of Crawford County," in Memoirs of the Historical Society of Pennsylvania Volume IV, Part II: 140.

upon ignorance of the subject."⁷⁷

Inhabitants living along the unfinished part of the line added desperate appeals for funding. A newspaper editor from Erie tried to shame state figures by asking if "Pennsylvania after running a strong race, through a period of sixteen years, with the goal in full view and nearly within reach, [shall] permit herself to sink in despair."⁷⁸

These increasingly despondent rumblings out of the northwest counties barely caused a stir across the rest of Pennsylvania. State authorities were unable to make the interest payments on the public debt that fell due on July 1, 1842.⁷⁹ One solution that was proposed for dealing with this crisis called for getting rid of the public works and the ceaseless spending on them. A majority of Pennsylvania tax payers rallied behind a proposal, and state leaders fashioned a compromise to sell the least productive parts of the system at auction and apply the proceeds to the state debt. Boosters of the state works went along with this arrangement believing the Main Line might become productive again without the financial burden of the branch lines.

⁷⁷ "General Trade," JS 1842, volume I: 432.

⁷⁸ Erie Gazette, July 14, 1842: p3c3.

⁷⁹ McFarlane, "The Pennsylvania Canals," WPHM 22(1), 42-43.

Governor David Porter was dismayed to learn that the first canals scheduled for sale included unfinished lines in the upper Susquehanna basin and the Erie Extension Canal. Porter had linked his political fortunes with canals since taking office, and strenuously objected to the measure out of concern for the votes he was sure to lose in the next election. However, powerful shipping firms based in Philadelphia decided the issue when they threatened to move their business from the Columbia and Philadelphia Railroad to Baltimore if the bill did not pass.⁸⁰

The canal commissioners responded by confirming their decision to dispose of the works; as a further concession to the Philadelphia interest, they reduced toll rates and released funds to purchase of eighteen additional trucks for moving section boats over the rail sections of the Main Line.⁸¹ Members of the state House and Senate voiced their agreement on July 27, 1842 when they directed the governor to advertise for bids on the northwestern lines through the newspapers in Philadelphia and Pittsburgh.

The Erie Canal Company

Canal building again took hold of state politics with the

⁸⁰ Western Argus, June 7, 1843: p1c3.

⁸¹ Reiser, Pittsburgh's Commercial Development, 95-96.

passage of this measure. Influential citizens of Philadelphia gathered in the suburban community of Millbury to plan a political strategy for the remainder of the year, just a month after the vote to sell parts of the public works. Only those candidates in favor of the sale were given a nod for the fall slate.⁸² No realistic bids had been entertained over the last month, and Philadelphians wanted to make sure the legislature did not reverse course and resume spending on the unfinished works.

This apparent lack of outside interest in the canals was taken as a godsend in the northwestern corner of the state. With no other buyers at hand, the merchant community in Erie drew up plans to acquire their end of the work on the best possible terms. A petition was then introduced in the Pennsylvania Senate on January 12, 1843 requesting a partial sale of the most westerly divisions of the canal.⁸³ Merchants from Southwest Pennsylvania objected out of fears the line might disrupt their own trading patterns if it was finished, and they moved to block the measure. A newspaper from Beaver blasted the plan to sell the unfinished works as a scheme conceived by Philadelphia and New York interests to the

⁸² Erie Gazette, August 25, 1842: p3c3.

⁸³ Erie Gazette, January 26, 1842: p3c1.

obvious detriment of Pittsburgh and Cleveland.⁸⁴ By this point, the inhabitants of Beaver County had severed all associations with Northwest Pennsylvania.

Several weeks were lost in negotiating a settlement between the different parties, but the Erie Canal Company was finally incorporated to finish the Erie Extension Canal on March 7, 1843. Representatives for the state had granted the firm exceptionally liberal terms in order to get the lines off of the public rolls.

Under the terms of the company charter, the Erie Canal Company was vested with the rights to "all estate real and personal, surplus waterpower, toll houses, implements, etc." on the main line from the Ohio River to Lake Erie, and along the French Creek Feeder. Company officials were given three years to commence work, after raising stock subscriptions to fund all related costs. State authorities made it clear there would not be a supplemental appropriation if the company got into financial trouble, and the Beaver Division and French Creek Feeder were kept in the public domain as insurance. These segments of the state works would be released to the canal once the Erie Extension was finished, and a

⁸⁴ Western Argus, May 31, 1843: p2c5.

boat had fully passed between the Ohio River and Lake Erie.⁸⁵

By the start of the summer, the Erie Canal Company had sold sufficient stock to gain the state charter. William Watts left for Harrisburg during the last week of May to seek an audience with the governor. Editors of the "Erie Weekly Gazette" reported his departure, and added that boats might be running by the end of the summer.⁸⁶

Most observers did not expect any problem in getting state approval. Pennsylvania was clearly overwhelmed by its canal experience and mounting costs that showed no sign of letting up any time soon. The Jefferson County "Backwoodsman" reported that sixty people from the Buffalo Valley had set out for Illinois, citing "a multiplicity of taxes & c." in Pennsylvania. Other families were reported in flight from Crawford County for the same reasons, heading for the wharf at Erie and boats "West."⁸⁷

Correspondents in the Beaver Valley believed that selling

⁸⁵ "Statement of the Receipts and Expenditures of the Erie Canal Company," JS 1844, volume II: 34-35; Corkan, Beaver and Lake Erie Canal, 61.

⁸⁶ Erie Gazette, June 1, 1843: p2c1.

⁸⁷ Crawford Democrat, June 13, 1843: p2c4. Westward flight to avoid taxes was not limited to Pennsylvania. This same news item recorded refugees from Chatauqua County in New York trying to escape the crippling costs of the Erie Canal.

unproductive assets was the only way to rescue the state from debt, and wondered why it had not been done sooner. Local newsmen warned that tolls had better be lowered if the state intended to keep control over any part of the public works.⁸⁸

Private firms willfully tackled the state works with discounted prices and improved service. Owners of the Philadelphia and Baltimore Railroad were drawing traffic from the Columbia Railroad of the Main Line by offering the free use of their motive power and reduced rates. Work on the Baltimore and Ohio Railroad had stalled in the mountains, but was likely to strike the western end of the Main Line in the near future with similar results.⁸⁹ State officials could plainly see that boating on the public works in Pennsylvania was coming to an end and eagerly granted a charter to the Erie Canal Company on June 15, 1843. Everyone concerned with this transaction believed they were getting the better part of the bargain.

Even though the feeder canal had been opened for traffic in 1842, boats were having trouble getting beyond Conneaut Lake because of low water. Innumerable leaks drained some parts of the canal, and other sections were blocked with sand bars. Some of the

⁸⁸ Western Argus, June 7, 1843: p1c3.

⁸⁹ Western Argus, June 7, 1843: p1c3.

farmers living along the line discovered an easy means to irrigate their fields in dry weather, and citizens were warned that tampering with safety gates and locks on the canal was a crime.⁹⁰

The dilapidated condition of bridges over the canal in Meadville left folks wondering how no one had been killed. In June, 1843, a child crossing the Walnut Street bridge had slipped through a hole in the planking and nearly drowned before being pulled to safety.⁹¹ Further down French Creek, the ruined condition of the Franklin Line sparked a riot. Farmers and boatmen who had started downstream with the spring rise discovered the lower locks were near collapsing. A small fleet was trapped for several days leading to April 24, 1843, when a mob of boatmen armed with picks, axes and crowbars tried to break through. Local authorities put an end to the matter. Several boatmen were arrested, although local sympathies supported the riots. State officials were warned of further actions if they did not clear the obstructions.⁹²

Public confidence in the canal was eroded with every incident. Soon after the "Warren" reached Meadville several weeks later, a breach opened below town and trapped the vessel for a few days.

⁹⁰ Crawford Democrat, July 18, 1843: p2c1.

⁹¹ Crawford Democrat, June 20, 1843: p3c1.

⁹² Crawford Democrat, May 2, 1843: p3c2.

The skipper and crew had to question their luck, since a break below New Castle had already closed the lower end of the line on their way up. Things had gotten so bad that certain merchants at Erie were reported shipping goods from Pittsburgh through Cleveland and the Mahoning Canal.⁹³ Carriers from Meadville bitterly condemned the practice, and offered to haul goods overland between the lake shore and canal. A disastrous flood on the Mahoning soon put the plan to a test.

Severe storms on June 4, 1843, raised the river to unprecedented levels and caused severe damages. Warehouses in the lower part of Youngstown were flooded with heavy losses of flour and salt cached there. A gristmill and sawmill were swept from their foundations, and a woman and six children were drowned when their home was crushed and borne away. Damages were placed at no less than \$20,000. Colonel Dodge of the Mahoning Canal Company believed the canal had weathered it pretty well, and hoped that \$2,500 would have it in order by the end of the month. Other reports cited more extensive damages and said it would take at least six weeks to have the canal in running order.⁹⁴ Residents at Meadville watched

⁹³ Crawford Democrat, June 20, 1843: p3c1.

⁹⁴ Crawford Democrat, June 13, 1843: p2c5; June 20, 1843: p3c3.

in anguish as an expected windfall from the federal government slipped away when the Mahoning Canal was opened on schedule.

An iron steamer that was being built and tested at Pittsburgh was intended for service on the Great Lakes. Word out of Erie suggested the vessel might travel up the canal to Meadville, and overland to the shore. Promoters added that an iron steamer on Conneaut Lake would create a local sensation, even in pieces. Meadville joined in chorus and pointed out freight was already coming up that way for Erie. Local teamsters were reported willing and ready to haul any weight on short notice, at favorable prices.⁹⁵ After waiting a month, a news editor at Meadville hoped the steamer would still come as a means to bring some cash to the area.⁹⁶

Workmen began taking the vessel apart for shipment four days later. While Erie was selected as the home port for launching, the heavier pieces would be shipped entirely by water through Cleveland.⁹⁷ The boats "Warren," "Enterprize" and "Ontario" arrived at Meadville soon after with passengers, merchandise, and the sorry news. Adding insult to injury, several stagecoaches passed through

⁹⁵ Crawford Democrat, May 30, 1843: p3c4; June 20, 1843: p3c3.

⁹⁶ Crawford Democrat, June 20, 1843: p3c3.

⁹⁷ Crawford Democrat, July 4, 1843: p3c2; Erie Gazette, July 20, 1843: p2c5.

town in July, packed with workmen going to Erie to put the vessel together.⁹⁸

Locals could not even gloat when some of the lighter parts were shipped through Meadville. One boat carrying parts of the steamer sank in the lower end of the canal, and held up traffic for several days.⁹⁹ While state officers struggled to restore order, stockholders of the canal company at Erie were called to assemble at the Reed House Hotel on July 22, 1843.¹⁰⁰ A board of directors was named two days later, with authority to begin active operations. After years of delay, the canal company seemed to move with feverish determination. A committee of the directors assumed control of their charter properties from the Board of Canal Commissioners on August 1, 1843, including the canal between New Castle and Greenville, with the French Creek Feeder and the outlet locks into French Creek. State authorities were empowered to keep control of the Beaver Division until the Erie Extension was finished in an acceptable manner.¹⁰¹

⁹⁸ Crawford Democrat, July 25, 1843: p3c2.

⁹⁹ Erie Gazette, July 20, 1842: p2c5.

¹⁰⁰ Erie Gazette, June 29, 1843: p3c1; Crawford Democrat, July 4, 1843: p3c4.

¹⁰¹ "Statement of the Receipts and Expenditures of the Erie Canal Company," JHR 1844, volume II: 118.

Membership in the higher ranks of the company reflected the areas of greatest geographical concerns. A majority of the managers were from Erie County, including Rufus Reed, Thomas G. Colt, William. A. Watts, Bethuel B. Vincent and John A. Tracy. Two final positions went to M.B. Lowry of Crawford County and James Power of Mercer County. Charles Reed and William Kelley of Erie County were then named treasurer and company secretary. Three days after they had been elected to these positions by the stockholders, the managers confirmed Rufus Reed as company president and elevated Charles Reed in his place as manager.¹⁰²

Besides naming local favorites to key positions, the company had also dispatched agents to seek funds from eastern capitalists on July 25, 1843. An engineer was directed to survey the line and determine the exact amount needed this same day. With preliminary contacts and a plan in hand, the committee set out to negotiate a loan on August 7, 1843.¹⁰³

The exhilarating rush of the past few weeks came to a crashing halt when investors in Philadelphia, New York and Boston turned them away empty-handed. On August 17, 1843, the directors decided

¹⁰² Crawford Democrat, July 25, 1843: p2c2; August 1, 1843: p3c1.

¹⁰³ "Statement of the Receipts and Expenditures of the Erie Canal Company," JHR 1844, volume II: 118.

to offer contracts against their credit in monthly bonds, and paying six percent interest in 1850.¹⁰⁴ Contractors were called to place their bids by September 1, 1843, at the company offices in Erie. Each proposal was to include the type of work desired as well as the method of payment expected, indicating if the bidder would accept stocks and bonds in the name of the Erie Canal Company.

Critics charged that the bidding was flawed, and gave every indication the company did not want competitive bidding. Advertisements were only placed in Erie newspapers, and many contractors missed the closing date by the time their home newspapers picked up the story. Company officials later claimed that a large number of contractors had placed bids, but charges of favoritism were reinforced when key contracts went to John A. Tracy, who was a member of the managing board. Only \$27,000 worth of work was let, and Tracy managed to capture the Walnut Creek Aqueduct for \$4,000 and several other jobs.¹⁰⁵

¹⁰⁴ "Statement of the Receipts and Expenditures of the Erie Canal Company," JHR 1844, volume II: 118.

¹⁰⁵ Crawford Democrat, August 28, 1843: p3c2; September 5, 1843: p3c1; December 30, 1843: p3c2. Sample agreements including terms for paying in scrip or bonds of the Erie Canal company are included in the papers of V.B. Vincent and David Himrod, Erie County Historical Society; also see the archives, vertical files, "Erie Extension of the Pennsylvania Canal."

This was a small part of the total needed, but represented some of the heaviest jobs and brought the work near completion. Public records indicated the state had already spent upwards of four million dollars, leaving just \$211,000 to finish the line to Erie. Spokesmen for the Erie Canal company hoped that navigation might be opened by September of the following year.¹⁰⁶

If there was any problem, it was an immediate shortage of laborers. Much of the early work had been done with local farmers during their slow season, and most of the regular canal hands had drifted elsewhere seeking steady employment. Officers on the Welland Canal near Niagara Falls had advertised for a large number of workers and intended to start work when navigation ceased for the year. Agents for that canal were already hiring workers at Buffalo, and storing provisions.¹⁰⁷

There was little to be done until the local farmers were freed for the season. A small force was engaged in keeping the Erie Extension in order from New Castle to the Summit, and on through

¹⁰⁶ Crawford Democrat, October 21, 1843: p1c2. Boats had to pass through the line by the end of 1844 or the Erie Canal Company stood to lose all rights to the work. See Albert C. Koch, Journey Through a Part of the United States of North America in the Years 1844 to 1846 (Carbondale, IL: Southern Illinois Press, 1972), 35; Koch was visiting relatives in Erie and expressed this particular detail as common knowledge.

¹⁰⁷ Crawford Democrat, December 19, 1843: p1c6.

the Feeder Canal. Agents for the company were buying materials and supplies for the winter. No special problems were foreseen, although the French Creek Aqueduct and a few farm bridges on the Feeder needed immediate attention.¹⁰⁸ Officials of the Erie Canal Company predicted speedy completion, in spite of rains lasting several weeks and "the complete destitution of the company, in the matter of funds or money."¹⁰⁹

In spite of the obvious difficulties ahead, preaching good news about the work began to have an effect down the line. Borough managers across the river from Pittsburgh in Allegheny City contracted for a new wharf to facilitate the transfer of cargoes from canal boats to river steamers. It was scheduled for opening by the end of the following summer, in time for the opening of the Erie Extension.¹¹⁰

Contractors who were hard pressed for laborers during the winter in Northwest Pennsylvania faced an unexpected glut with the coming of spring. Continued work on the Erie Extension coincided with the wholesale abandonment of canals in other parts of the country.

¹⁰⁸ "Statement of the Receipts and Expenditures of the Erie Canal Company," JHR 1844, volume 2: 118.

¹⁰⁹ Crawford Democrat, December 30, 1843: p3c2.

¹¹⁰ Erie Gazette, November 23, 1843: p2c6.

Unemployed canal hands flocked to Northwest Pennsylvania and brought down the price of labor, which greatly raised prospects for the Erie Canal Company. This allowed the Erie Canal Company to get more production for their money, but there was still doubt in some quarters whether the company was properly funded. Other localities had simply written off canals as a bad investment.

Residents at Meadville had not forgiven Erie for turning against them the previous summer, and had become enamored with road transport. Concerned citizens were called to a meeting at the court house on February 17, 1844 to consider a Macadamized Road in place of a canal. Butler county had already voiced its support for the project, planning a path from some unnamed point on the Cumberland (National) Road to Erie, by way of Pittsburgh and Meadville.¹¹¹

Local proponents of the road took a backside swipe at the canal by suggesting it represented the shortest path to the lakes and would prove relatively inexpensive compared to other projects. For insurance, they tied it to national defense and defined the route "from some point at the base of Laurel Hill, to the Arsenal at Pittsburgh, and through Butler, and Mercer, to the arsenal at

¹¹¹ Crawford Democrat, February 6, 1844; February 13, 1844: p3c3.

Meadville, and thence to the borough at Erie."¹¹²

Contractors on the canal hurried along in hopes of finishing the canal by the end of the summer, but they faced one problem after another. Navigation had only been open on the lower parts of the line for a few weeks when a break near the junction of the Beaver Division and the Mahoning Canal closed navigation for a few days.¹¹³ Workers and funds slated for the unfinished sections had to be diverted toward this emergency. When August passed and the canal was still not opened to traffic, the Board of Canal Commissioners stepped in and demanded action. A decree was issued on September 2, 1844, ordering the Erie Canal Company to let water into their new works by October 10, 1844 or face uncertain penalties. Water was subsequently let into the new Conneaut Division of the Erie Extension at the last possible moment.¹¹⁴

This satisfied state agencies, but pushed navigation back several weeks. Like all new works, the line needed time to settle. Letting water in prematurely tore holes into the banks and opened innumerable small leaks. A boat from the Ohio River was finally

¹¹² Crawford Democrat, February 13, 1844: p3c3.

¹¹³ Western Argus, May 29, 1844: p3c1.

¹¹⁴ JHR 1845, volume II: 230; Crawford Democrat, October 19, 1844: p2c2.

pushed above Conneaut Lake for Erie on November 23, 1844.¹¹⁵

In order to acquire title to the works, the Erie Canal Company was required to pass a boat entirely through the line from the Ohio River to Lake Erie. Company officials and citizens at Erie feared that plans to finish the line might go unanswered with the approaching winter. Navigation of the Main Line had already ended for the season, and boats were drawn off November 15, 1844.¹¹⁶

A coal freighter dubbed the "R.S. Reed" plowed ahead in a race against the gathering storm. Near Erie, the packet "Queen of the West" took to the waters started a race for the outlet locks and the honor of passing through first. Several breaks near Erie trapped the boats a few miles short of their goal, where winter caught them. Both were frozen in, with little hope of getting further along.

Crews aboard the boats were making plans for an uncomfortable stay when a sudden and unexpected thaw weakened the ice. Both boats went crashing down the canal with the "R.S. Reed" ahead. Couriers electrified the city with news the boats were coming, while the echoes of gunfire indicated their distance. Dignitaries and private citizens raced out the canal to board the "Queen of the

¹¹⁵ JHR 1845, volume II: 230.

¹¹⁶ Crawford Democrat, December 3, 1844: p2c4, p2c5.

West," and when that boat was full they bargained for deck space between coal piles on the freighter.¹¹⁷

Celebrations erupted in the streets of Erie when the boats passed through down into the basin on December 5, 1844. Crowds cheered against the booming welcome of cannon and small arms. Representatives of the city government and the Erie Canal Company offered the customary remarks, and the day closed with a grand ball at the Reed House. A committee of company managers then took possession of the Beaver Division from state authorities just two days later (in accordance with their charter agreement), and made arrangements to claim the French Creek Feeder. After the exchange was completed, the company men found they had been swindled. Routine maintenance had lapsed and no major repairs had been made for several months.¹¹⁸ Some of the stockholders and the directors of the firm raised charges that state authorities had willfully deceived them and demanded monetary compensation. Rather than suffering feelings of guilt, some legislators defiantly proposed that the state should resume control of the canal now that it was finished.

State figures who had embraced the partial or whole sale of the

¹¹⁷ Crawford Democrat, December 10, 1844: p1c5.

¹¹⁸ JHR 1845, volume II: 230.

public works started having second thoughts once the Erie Extension Canal was finally finished and opened for navigation. There was wild talk that merchants at Erie were out to punish the state government for past wrongs and leaving the works in local hands would be detrimental to the public interest. Rumor mongers in Harrisburg suddenly remembered longstanding ties between the northwestern counties and New York and raised the prospect of special treatment for out of state shippers. This action would divert traffic northward and destroy what little promise remained for the Main Line.

These rumors were given new life after a second attempt to dispose of the Pennsylvania Main Line proved an embarrassing failure. Bidders were invited to attend a public auction at Philadelphia on January 20, 1845, but the call aroused little interest. A few persons showed up, but they were clearly more interested in observing the proceedings than making serious bids. Merchants from Philadelphia and Pittsburgh were dumbstruck to find they were still saddled with the Main Line after giving away any control over the chief branch lines.¹¹⁹

Merchants and bankers holding stock in the Erie Canal Company expressed their willingness to make things right by restoring the

¹¹⁹ Erie Gazette, January 30, 1845: p3c2.

works to public authorities. They had expected that the legislature would take the works off their hands all along, and looked forward to a return of seven percent on their initial investment. Obliging friends in the state legislature introduced a bill allowing the canal commissioners to resume full responsibility for the Erie Extension Canal and its related lines, but the deal quickly fell apart.

Critics of the administration jumped on this issue of resumption as "a breach of good faith upon the part of the state, and a childish kind of legislation." Porter and his aides were charged with trying to take control of the canals in order to stem the growth of free trade across state boundaries and shield their failed record of managing the public works from view.¹²⁰ The entire Board of Canal Commissioners was dragged along with charges they had failed to appreciate the value of the works and misused the public trust. Resumption was painted as a favor for special interests over citizens of the Commonwealth at large, with this largesse directed toward merchants from Philadelphia and Pittsburgh, along with stockholders of the Mahoning Canal

¹²⁰ Western Argus, January 29, 1845: p2c5; Crawford Democrat, January 30, 1844: p3c1.

Company.¹²¹ The old Improvement Men in the Pennsylvania Democratic Party could not stem these criticism and the attacks escalated in their intensity and scope. Additional charges of political favoritism and corruption were tossed out to newspaper editors looking for a story, and the banking industry was assailed as an guilty partner in this mess for providing the funds and credit that supported the canal program.

Porter had served two full terms as governor and passed his duties on to Francis R. Shunk, and the idea of resumption quickly became a vote on how the outgoing administration had handled state affairs. The resumption question was brought up in the state senate on February 4, 1845 and narrowly defeated by a vote of 15 to 13, with one abstention and four other members not in attendance.¹²² Porter was upheld in selling the works, while the Improvement Men in the legislature accepted their defeat and advised Francis Shunk to adopt more progressive and conciliatory policies with factions in the Democratic Party. Continued spending on canals was fully discredited as a public investment in Pennsylvania.

Bidding for the Main Line system of canals and railroads was then continued through the following month. State authorities

¹²¹ Erie Gazette, February 13, 1845: p2c6.

¹²² Erie Gazette, February 13, 1845: p2c6.

meekly agreed to accept just twenty million dollars for all of the works, but few bids were tendered even at this bargain price. A sense of frustration swept through the state legislature at this turn of events, and former governor Andrew Porter and his associates were again assailed with charges their administration had "despoiled the people" of their confidence in free enterprise through decades of mismanagement.¹²³ Even though Porter had taken steps to end spending on canals, he was immutably linked with the lingering public debt because of his early support for the branch lines during his initial campaign for governor.

Conclusion

The public works program was clearly in trouble when Porter took office in 1839 with promises to finish the branch lines. Taxpayers all over Pennsylvania were frustrated with ceaseless spending that did little to reduce the public debt, and Porter was charged by voters to make the system profitable or at least stem further losses. Finishing the Erie Extension Canal was crucial for his administration.

Opening navigation on this line would at once repay voters in Northwest Pennsylvania for their support, while generating income

¹²³ Erie Gazette, February 6, 1845: p2c6.

for the entire state by drawing traffic and tolls from the Great Lakes to the Main Line Canal. Some parts of Northwest Pennsylvania were still fighting to shape the route of the Erie Extension Canal in 1839, but this was finally settled when water was let into the Mahoning Canal spanning the Pennsylvania and Ohio boundary near the head of the Beaver River. Practical business concerns demanded Pennsylvania open a competitive system close by or risk losing control over trade and commerce in that area (and maybe the Main Line system).

The Mahoning Canal was built using a mix of tax dollars and private funds from both sides of the state line. As a private stock firm, the Mahoning Canal Company was not bound by the rules governing public works and could set its own schedules and offer discounted rates. Pennsylvania hoped to counter preferential treatment with the convenience and speed of a shorter line between the Great Lakes and the Pennsylvania Main Line system of canals and railroads. Plans for building a far ranging network of canals across Northwest Pennsylvania were culled down to a single line running near the state boundary between Pennsylvania and Ohio. It was believed that placing a canal to the Great Lakes in this area might reduce the Mahoning Canal to a feeder.

Unfortunately for Porter and his loyal voters, this modest

undertaking was afflicted with difficulties. A financial crisis in 1839 complicated matters and caused additional delays in construction and shook public confidence in the undertaking. Contractors and public officials connected with the Erie Extension Canal were therefore pushed hard to finish the Erie Extension in 1840 and 1841, in a bid to draw trade back across the state line and northward. However, the results of their work were not impressive enough to stave off another financial crisis.

Pennsylvania state leaders finally decided that tax payers had suffered enough, and in 1842 they voted to disband the public works program. All of the state canals and railroads were subsequently offered for sale, starting with the unfinished Erie Extension Canal.

Businessmen and taxpayers at Erie had counted on the canal to make Erie competitive with other lake ports including Cleveland and Buffalo. Some of the chief business leaders consequently organized the Erie Canal Company of Pennsylvania to resume work and finish the canal. They were driven to this end by hopes of protecting their investments in properties and trading houses around Erie and the contiguous shoreline of Lake Erie.

State office holders could not offer much assistance, but did promise to grant the company full rights to the Beaver Division and

the French Creek Feeder Canal once the Erie Extension Canal was ready for business. Stockholders of the Erie Canal Company therefore guided the remaining work to completion in 1844, but they were frustrated by the response from public officials.

Stockholders in the Erie Canal Company had finished the Erie Extension Canal in the belief they could sell the canal back to the state at a modest profit. Canal building had always been a risky business and the stockholders they believed that finishing an outlet to the Great Lakes would revive flagging interest in the public works across Pennsylvania. Elected officials from other parts of Pennsylvania were hardly won over, and turned aside talk of resumption in the state legislature. Nobody seemed to want the responsibility or costs of maintaining the Beaver and Lake Erie Canal by the time it was finally finished and opened for navigation.

CONCLUSION

While the managers of the Erie Canal Company considered legal action against the Pennsylvania state government over resumption, they affirmed their good faith with stockholders by ordering immediate repairs to different lines. They promised that the Beaver Division would be in its best shape for several years past and announced work had already started toward rebuilding the French Creek Aqueduct and several rotted bridges near Meadville on the French Creek Feeder Canal. Additional effort was directed at the three locks leading from the feeder canal into French Creek at the head of the Franklin Line were scheduled for work.¹²⁴

Boats began gathering at the mouth of the Beaver near Rochester and Beaver Point just as soon as the danger from ice had passed. Shipping lines with headquarters at that point predicted an "auspicious" year ahead and advised merchants they could pick between the Beaver and Lake Erie line or the Mahoning Canal at equal advantage.¹²⁵ While shippers debated the merits of either

¹²⁴ "Annual Report of the Erie Canal Company," JHR 1845, volume II: 230.

¹²⁵ Beaver Argus, April 30, 1845: p2c6.

route, workmen finished repairs on the different sections of the canal and opened the guard locks. By the end of April, 1845 several boats had cleared Rochester with freight for Buffalo, and a passenger packet named the "Gen. Mercer" started for Erie right behind them under a Captain Reno.¹²⁶

High hopes for a successful season began to unravel over the following weeks when boat captains reported low waters in the canal. Complaints about the northern canal were circulating in Erie by May, 1845 when the first boats drifted into Lake Erie. Parts of the Conneaut Division had not properly settled before water was let in the previous year and frozen conditions had masked significant problems with leaks. Boats were scraping bottom through the "quicksand sections" near Conneaut Lake. Other parts of the canal had been exposed to the elements for four and five years without being tested, and the embankments had reportedly become so dry and porous they could scarcely hold water. Sections on the "Long level" above Conneautville were composed of a light, sandy soil and looked as if they might give way at any time.¹²⁷

Even some of the major constructions were falling apart. Several locks were in danger of collapsing down on the Shenango

¹²⁶ Beaver Argus, April 30, 1845: p2c6.

¹²⁷ Erie Observer, May 10, 1845: p3c6.

Division, and all of the lock gates on the Beaver Division were rotting and needed replaced. Inspectors sent out from the offices of the Erie Canal Company also discovered that state contractors had not finished a number of bridges on the Shenango Division that were reported done. Workmen were placed along the line to shore up the locks for the season, but water levels continued to drop. Feeder streams were falling below predictions that they could keep the canal supplied at full depth, and a recurrence of draught conditions only exacerbated the problem.¹²⁸

A fleet of thirteen boats backed up near Springboro in June, 1845, when a small breach drained the waterway. Spokesmen for the Erie Canal Company promised quick action and hoped to avoid future incidents, "as it has a tendency to destroy the confidence of commercial men in the utility of the work."¹²⁹ A set of stop gates was installed at the head of the quicksand pools near the Conneaut Summit during the early part of the summer and the reservoirs were returned to their full volume by September in time for shipping the fall harvest.¹³⁰

¹²⁸ "Annual Report of the Erie Canal Company," JHR 1845, volume II: 230.

¹²⁹ Erie Observer, June 21, 1845: p2c7.

¹³⁰ "Annual Report of the Erie Canal Company," JHR 1846, volume II: 234-236.

Shipping was usually slow during the summer under any circumstances once barns and warehouses were emptied of their winter stores and no one could count the season as a calamity. However, every delay of any cause and duration was insufferable on a system that was only open for a part of the year under ideal conditions. Merchants and shipping clerks were already calling called for more reliable and year round services by the time the Beaver and Lake Erie Canal was opened for business, and this demand clearly pointed to railroads.

These kinds of calls did not go unnoticed in Harrisburg, and state leaders announced the emergence of railroads in Pennsylvania when they tried to dispose of the state works. The terms drawn up for selling the Pennsylvania Main Line were designed to replace that system with a continuous railroad. Anyone bidding on the Pennsylvania Main Line was obliged to continue the standing operations and assume all current debt, with an added responsibility for eventually replacing watered sections with rails. Bidders backpedaled from any negotiations for the Pennsylvania Main Line when they fully understood these terms. Secondary lines including the Erie Extension Canal and the West Branch Canal on the Susquehanna River proved more attractive because state leaders just wanted to freeze spending on them and

end any further obligations for tax dollars; there was no requirement dictating how these works should proceed.

Failure to start work on a railroad gravely troubled business leaders in Philadelphia and Pittsburgh because workers on the Baltimore and Ohio Railroad were pushing rails over the Appalachian Mountains toward the Ohio River. Construction of a horse-drawn tram road was started near Baltimore in 1829, and locomotives were introduced while the tracks inched westward. Businessmen in Pennsylvania were not too concerned at this time because they had survived several threats from Baltimore since the turn of the century.

Progress on the National Road was checked by crafting an alliance between Philadelphia and Pittsburgh to open a comparable work in the Pittsburgh and Philadelphia Turnpike, and the Chesapeake and Ohio Canal was then matched with the Pennsylvania Main Line Canal. A handbill that circulated through Wheeling in 1835 admitted that the Pennsylvania Main Line had drawn off some of the trade that used to frequent New Orleans and Baltimore, but added that "We hope to see in two or three years, this western trade which Philadelphia is thus diverting, restored by the completion of the Baltimore and Ohio railroad, to its natural

channel."¹³¹

Politicians and businessmen in Pennsylvania doubted the railroad would ever get across the mountains and even gave the railroad permission to cross the common state boundary. However, crews laying the tracks for the Baltimore and Ohio Railroad reached Cumberland, Maryland, in 1842 and Western Pennsylvania seemed in reach. This raised new fears in Philadelphia that the western end of Pennsylvania might revive economic relations with Baltimore, and revive the sectional conflict of earlier days. Public meetings were held in Pittsburgh, Uniontown and Greensburg in 1845 in support of extending the railroad into Pennsylvania.¹³²

Commercial interests in Philadelphia could not withstand defections at this level, and the state works would certainly collapse if the volume of trade fell further; state authorities could barely keep up with operating expenses. The western counties of Pennsylvania were aware of these costs and expressed a willingness to make an arrangement with the eastern end of the state. A newspaper editor from Indiana County suggested "Philadelphians must open their purses as the Bostonians and New Yorkers are now doing." A publisher from Philadelphia agreed "If

¹³¹ Ambler, Transportation in the Ohio Valley, 150.

¹³² Burgess, Pennsylvania Railroad, 36.

the merchants and other capitalists of Philadelphia who are deeply interested in this measure would subscribe with proportionate liberality compared with their donations for political purposes, there would be not the slightest difficulty in immediately commencing and rapidly progressing the work."¹³³

These are the same charges raised twenty years earlier during the sectional debates over building statewide turnpikes and canals; back then they had sparked imitative works, and this was the result again. Philadelphia merchants hosted meetings and rallied support for their own line to counter the Baltimore and Ohio Railroad. Railroads dominated every discussion when the state legislature assembled on January 6, 1845. After two and a half months of hearings, the House of Representatives passed the Pennsylvania Railroad bill on March 19, 1845. Members of the Senate adopted a similar measure one week later.

Officials of that firm (or subsidiary companies) were charged with carrying a continuous railroad from Philadelphia to Pittsburgh and then extending a branch line toward the Great Lakes. This design replicated the canals of the Pennsylvania Main Line system and the Erie Canal Company with a line of continuous railroads. As in the early days of the state canal program, there was a rush to

¹³³ Cited in Burgess, Pennsylvania Railroad, 36.

get started and ground was broken for the railroad at Harrisburg on July 7, 1847. Politicians and private citizens from Philadelphia had subscribed nearly \$4 million at this point to see the work through.

With the excitement of building railroads in the air, the directors of the Erie Canal Company were hard pressed to raise funds for improving their works in Northwest Pennsylvania. Repairs and routine maintenance fell behind schedule, and shoddy materials were used to cut costs. In a bid to raise profits, the directors of the Erie Canal Company adopted a tiered policy that gave discounts to boats passing over the full length of the waterway from the Ohio River to Lake Erie.¹³⁴ This policy increasingly pushed small farmers and boat owners off the line in favor of big, company boats hauling coal northward for steamers on the Great Lakes and bringing back ores for the furnaces and foundries at Pittsburgh.¹³⁵ Merchants at Erie and the stockholders of the Canal Company distanced themselves from small farmers living along the

¹³⁴ Crawford Democrat, February 11, 1851: p2c1.

¹³⁵ Early watercraft are described in Corkan, Beaver and Lake Erie Canal, 64. For descriptions of the larger vessels see Martin H. Aubel, "Memories of the Beaver and Lake Erie Canal," manuscript, Mercer County historical Society; Thomas Bannon Metheny, "Local Man Relates Interesting History of the Old Erie and Pittsburgh Canal From Rochester to the Lake Erie Points," manuscript, Mercer County Historical Society.

waterway as a result, and forged new ties with business and community leaders in Pittsburgh, Philadelphia and even Buffalo and Cleveland.

Resentment against the Erie Canal Company erupted in rural communities along the waterway, where farmers and small shippers started seeing every problem with the canal as evidence they had been deceived by monied interests. Grumbling flared into open hostility in localities that were plagued by fever and ague, and the village of Hartstown at the southern end of the Pymatuning Reservoir emerged as a hotbed of radical discontent.

Garbage and vegetable matter accumulated in the canal behind dams and across slackwater pools where the current dissipated over a wide expanse. Rules for using the Pennsylvania canals declared that "No carcass, putrid substance, dung or litter shall be thrown into the canal or into any basin or feeder connected therewith." Violators faced a ten dollar fine, but lax enforcement encouraged violations. Popular opinion linked the stench with sickness. Merely smelling this "miasma" was deemed sufficient to spark an epidemic and early guidebooks warned travellers to stay away from the western rivers during the hottest months of summer.¹³⁶

Early signs of trouble appeared in Northwest Pennsylvania even

¹³⁶ Baldwin, Keelboat Age on Western Waters, 136.

before the canal was finished. Evansburg (later Conneaut Lake, Pennsylvania) was nearly abandoned in 1841 after the canal was fed into the Conneaut Lake and sickness broke out. Later on, lands lying on the western side of the Beaver and Lake Erie Canal commanded a premium since prevailing winds were said to carry the stench and its allied diseases eastward. Inhabitants of Hartstown took matters into their own hands when rumors of another epidemic surfaced in 1846.

Hartstown was situated at the southern end of the Pymatuning Reservoir (and just a few miles southwest of Conneaut Lake). A drainage ditch that had been started on the west side of the reservoir near the village was never finished, backing up a floating mass of timber and decaying "vegetable matter."¹³⁷ Residents of Hartstown deduced that waters entering the canal from the Conneaut Reservoir were not flushing out the lower reservoir according to plans. An anonymous letter was then forwarded to the offices of the Erie Canal Company warning that firm to make improvements or "the dam or embankment [will] be demolished by the people of this district."¹³⁸

Murmuring and threats over "the alleged injurious effects upon

¹³⁷ Crawford Democrat, December 8, 1846: p2c2.

¹³⁸ Crawford Democrat, December 1, 1846: p2c3.

the health [of citizens] of the Erie Extension" erupted in action on the night of December 8, 1846. Unnamed parties attacked the embankment and ripped out a section measuring about thirty feet across. Water poured out of the reservoir into the adjoining swamp before officials of the Erie Canal Company discovered the problem and hurried work crews to the scene. A number of local men were arrested shortly afterwards and held for bail on charges of instigating and executing the raid.¹³⁹

This attack on the reservoir inaugurated a decade of conflict between local inhabitants and the Erie Canal Company. Newspapers periodically mention acts of vandalism against the canal properties, leading up to another effort to drain the Pymatuning Reservoir in May, 1857.¹⁴⁰ A group of masked conspirators disarmed a guard under the cover of darkness, and cut an eight foot gap in the embankment. Water was gushing out "with the force of a cataract" when the damage was reported to officials of the Erie Canal Company, and by dawn the break had widened to more than eighty feet. Citizens of Hartstown quickly joined repair crews to stem the flood before a disaster occurred. Prominent citizens of

¹³⁹ Crawford Democrat, December 15, 1846: p2c1.

¹⁴⁰ See Crawford Democrat, December 15, 1846: p2c1; March 13, 1849: p2c1; "Fourth Annual Report of the Erie Canal Company," JS 1848, volume II: 217.

the area condemned the "villains" responsible for risking a catastrophe, although rewards for information or evidence against them were never claimed.¹⁴¹

Local landholders came to see every disturbance at the reservoirs or attacks on the canal property as part of an ongoing feud with outsiders who represented monied urban interests. This development should not have surprised anyone, given the history of Northwest Pennsylvania. Settlement and economic development in the old Donation and Depreciation Lands had always been guided by outside interests looking after their own concerns.

Land speculators from Philadelphia and merchants at Pittsburgh had gained control over Northwest Pennsylvania before the end of the eighteenth century. They only relinquished their control of the area to free market forces when it proved too costly to maintain ownership. These same figures dominated the state government of Pennsylvania, and they subsequently ignored the area until they needed votes to fund the public works program.

Canal building was the single largest investment of public funds in Northwest Pennsylvania during the nineteenth century, but the local effort was always subordinate to the Main Line Canal serving

¹⁴¹ Venango Spectator, May 13, 1857: p2c4; May 20, 1857: p2c2.

Philadelphia and Pittsburgh. Politicians from these centers often used canal contracts and building funds for the local lines to sway voters in statewide elections. This produced uneven results and fragmented any sense of common purpose in Northwest Pennsylvania. Intense rivalries developed between communities trying to draw the canal and commerce in their direction.

Construction of a local network started on French Creek at Meadville in 1827 because it represented the most populated district in Northwest Pennsylvania. Work spread down French Creek from Meadville toward the Allegheny River after 1830, but this line was plagued by inadequate funding and poor management. At least some of these problems can be traced to opposition in Pittsburgh.

The civic and business leaders of Pittsburgh had struggled to raise support and funds for the Main Line Canal, and they demanded the canal pass through their city. Building a branch line on the Allegheny River would allow traffic to head for Lake Erie without visiting Pittsburgh. State leaders obliged by opening another canal on the Beaver River and drawing traffic off of the Ohio River 25 miles below Pittsburgh.

Inhabitants of the northwestern counties argued over how the canal should proceed to Lake Erie while the chief commercial centers of Pennsylvania looked at cutting costs. The solution for

Philadelphia and Pittsburgh was carrying the Pennsylvania Main Line westward through the Beaver Division and into Ohio. Plans for a widespread network of canals spanning northwest Pennsylvania started to fall apart because of the costs and the manner in which this emerging pattern satisfied Philadelphia and Pittsburgh. Parts of Northwest Pennsylvania resting on the Ohio River and the Beaver River began to identify with these major centers instead of the rural farmlands lying toward Lake Erie.

Inhabitants of Meadville and Erie pressured state leaders to continue work on the canal, but they were divided over a specific route. Proponents of a canal debated the merits of opening an extension from French Creek or building the Erie Extension Canal from the head of the Beaver River canal to Lake Erie. When surveys finally placed the main stem of the canal outside of Meadville in 1838, the inhabitants of that borough began promoting roads and railroads as an alternative.

Inhabitants of Erie repeatedly called on state leaders to fulfill their obligations to Northwest Pennsylvania and the canal slowly crept forward. However, political support and funding gave out in 1843 and the work was abandoned as a public enterprise. State authorities offered the unfinished sections to private developers and threw in the completed lines to seal the

arrangement. Business promoters at Erie organized the Erie Canal Company to pick up the work with a belief they could restore public confidence in the state program. However, other parts of the state turned away from canals and left the Erie Canal Company holding dated improvements that nobody else seemed to want.

When boating commenced on the Beaver and Lake Erie Canal in 1845, the old boundaries of Northwest Pennsylvania included at least three divisions based on the Beaver River, French Creek and the harbor at Erie. In their bid to make the canal profitable, the officers and stockholders of the Erie Canal Company created another division by antagonizing the farmers living on the middle reaches of the waterway. Building canals had torn Northwest Pennsylvania apart and crafted new elites with loyalties shaped by outside interests. In this regard, Northwest Pennsylvania can be seen as an extension of the larger Appalachian Region.

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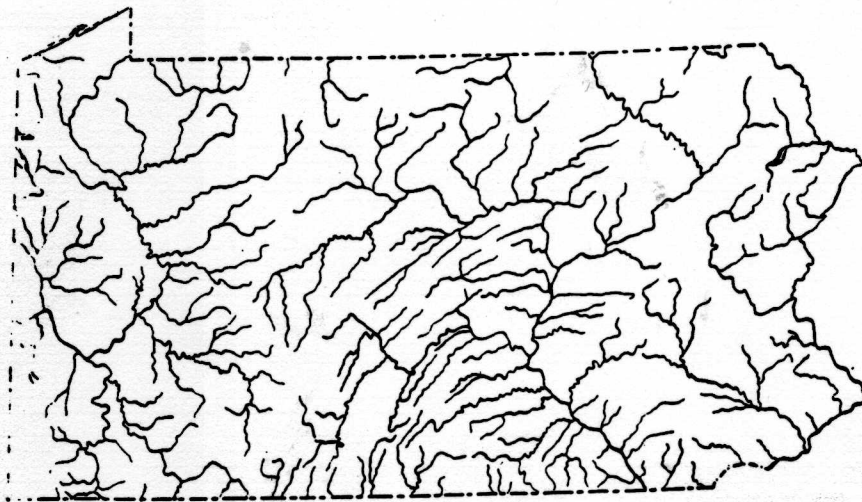
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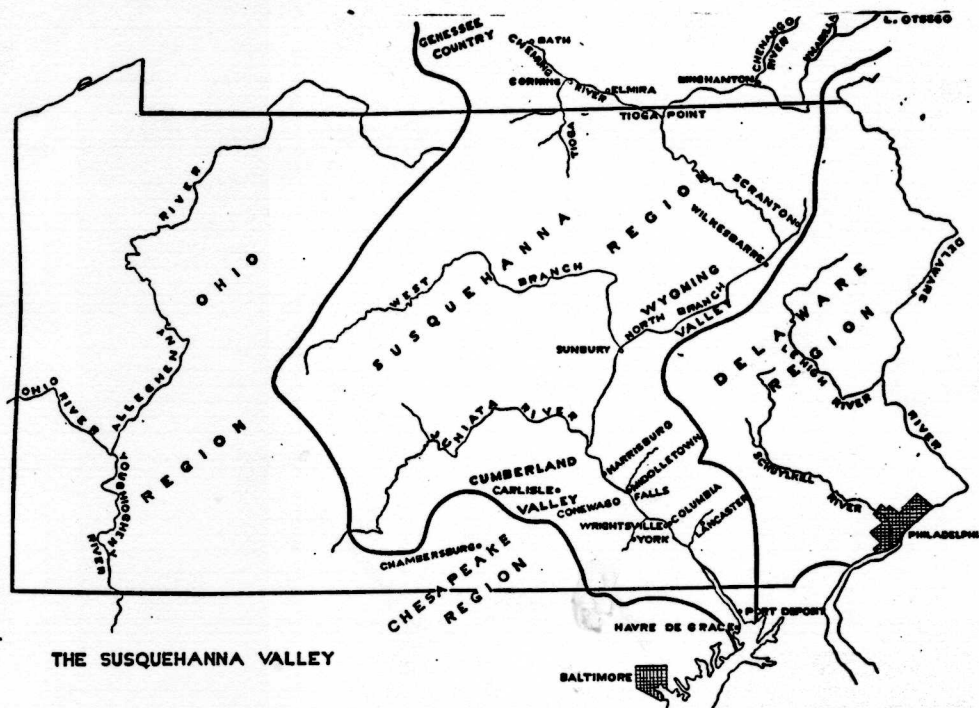
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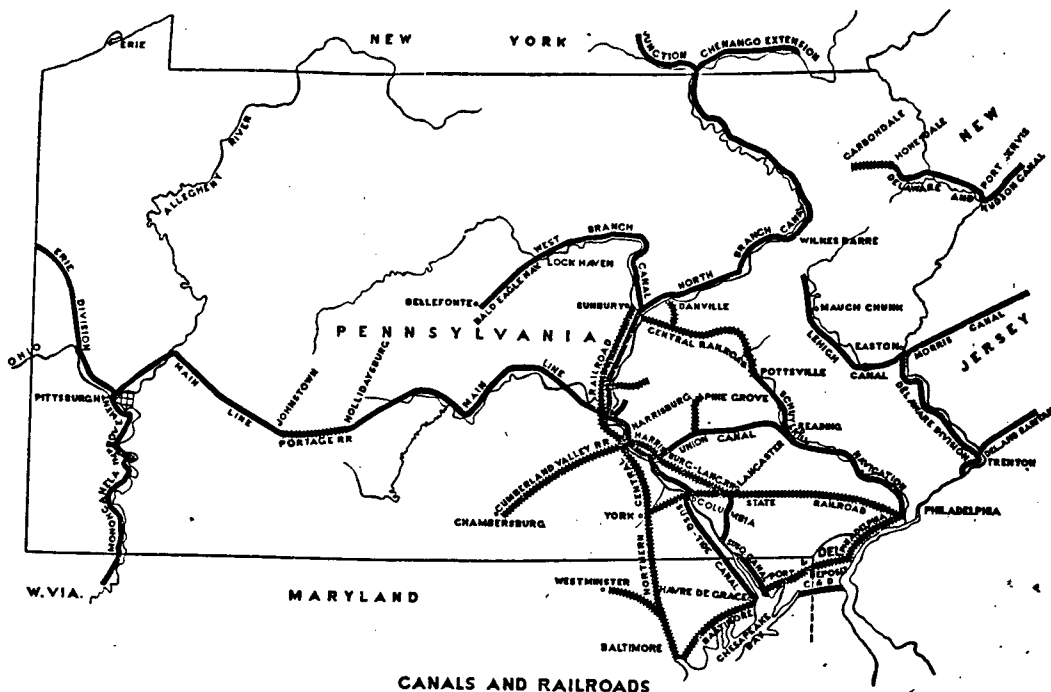
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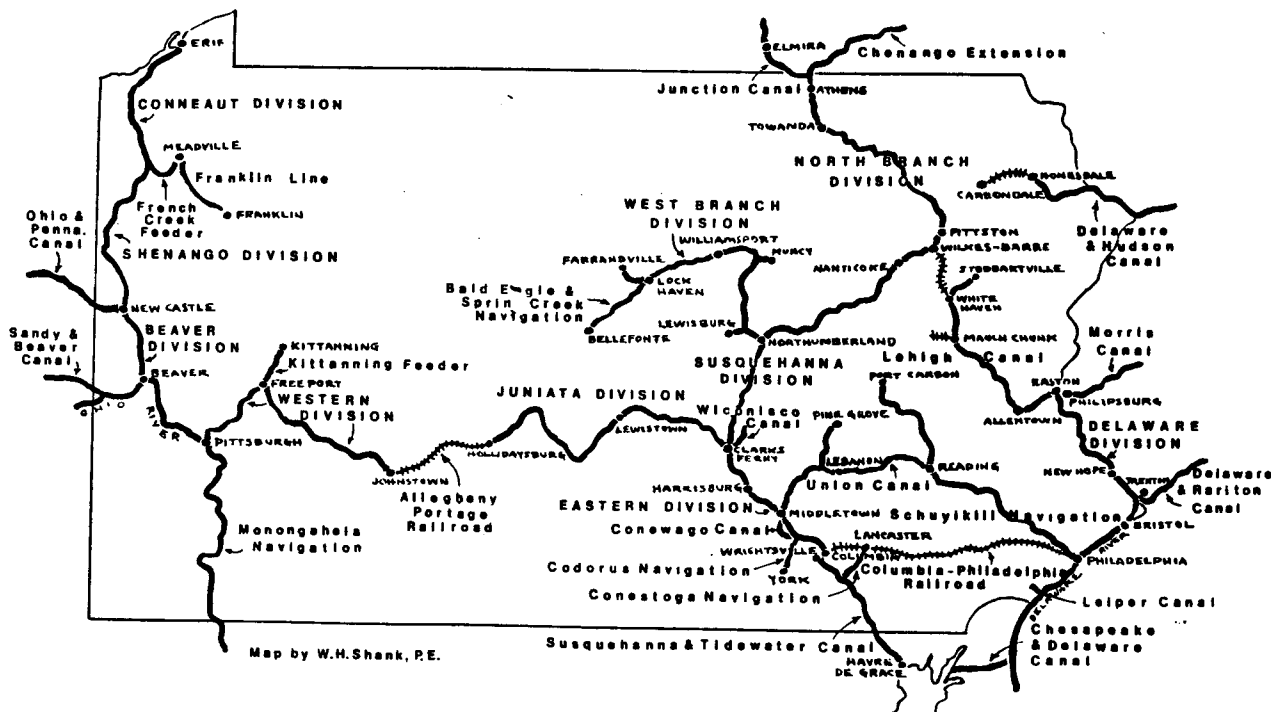
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Pennsylvania during the canal era. Taken from William H. Shank, The Amazing Pennsylvania Canals (York, PA: American Canal & Transportation Center, 1960), frontsheet.